

HARALD HØFFDING

MEMOIRS

Erindringer

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Preface

[6] It was not my intention from the first that the “Memoirs” which I wrote down in the winter of 1915–16, and continued later in 1922 and 1924, should appear before my death. Now, however, it has come to seem to me that conditions, not least in the field in which I have chiefly moved, have become so different from the time the book presupposes that no more time ought to pass if the book is to find understanding readers.

My wife, who was to have been the book’s editor, has come round to my view and is now helping me with the publication.

In the Introduction I have said enough about why I have written memoirs at all.

Carlsberg, 14 March 1928. Harald Høffding.

I

When I write down memories of my life, it is not because I think I have experienced anything that is remarkable in outward respects. But in every human life that is lived in earnest there will be events and experiences that may be of interest, even though the frame within which it is lived is limited. And in old age interest in this human element naturally comes forward, above all in its inner coherence. It is the time of memory, and there arises a wish to give oneself an account of the motives, the leading endeavors, that have carried one's life. Behind the traits and the fates the individual shares with so many others there may, after all, lie quite different individual motives, just as logic teaches that the same conclusion can be reached from quite different premises. That our real life is an inner life one learns in old age, if one had not learned it before. And with this the urge naturally joins to trace whether there has been an inner coherence in the life one can now look back on. I am fully aware that any attempt at a retrospect may bring with it many illusions. Memory may fail, both as regards the particular events and actions and as regards the leading motives. — I have myself, in my book on Rousseau, drawn attention to the difficulty of writing autobiography, and tried to show what different motives cross one another in a book such as Rousseau's *Confessions*. Where I can, I shall lean on letters and other documents that may be at my disposal, in order thereby to avoid mistakes [7] and illusory motivations. The letters I have are for the most part written to me. Apart from a few drafts, I have letters from myself only when the recipients are dead; they are therefore melancholy documents, but they throw light on many people and many things. Thus I could not have given a tolerably reliable account

of my development between my twenty-second and my twenty-seventh year had I not found the letters from the time of my engagement among the keepsakes of my late [first] wife.

When I look back on my childhood and youth, the time of those days and the way in which life was then lived seem to me utterly different from what now presents itself to an observer. I should very much like to give a description that would show this difference in vivid small touches. But I lack the gift of lively description of outward circumstances and events. The chief physician Nikolaj Holm, my schoolfellow in the infant school and later as a student, has given a lively and delightful description of life as it was lived in our childhood in well-to-do families of the middle class. What I remember of the daily life of that time agrees well with his description, and our outward circumstances were much the same. But I do not trust myself to tell it as well as he.

Holm's description stops with his student years, and it seems, unfortunately, that he will not continue it. If my memoirs are to have any value, that value will surely rest chiefly on whether I can give an accessible account of how my inner life, my faith and my outlook on life developed from my student days and on through the years. While I have the impression of a great difference, as regards outward things, between the time in which my childhood and youth fell and the present time, I nevertheless have, on thinking back, a still far stronger impression of the difference there is — in my own case at least — between then and now as regards the inner life. And yet it is step by step, through many nuances and [9] in part in zigzag, that I have come from my "then" to my "now." This point I shall try to make a main theme of my account. But this development in a purely personal respect is closely bound up with the course of my studies and with my philosophical endeavors. And I should like to take the opportunity to give an account, in as accessible a form as possible, of my development in the scientific respect as well.

The course of my life has brought me into contact with not a few remarkable people, some who have taken part in the life of the time, and through it in my own as well, others who in their narrow circle exercised a quieter, but not for

that reason less deep and memorable, influence — some who stood further from me, others whom I have loved dearly. Here is a host of memories which I shall try to let come into their own.

My parents were both of good, old Danish stock. They were first cousins, my mother's mother having been born a Høffding and a sister of my father's father. The Høffding family can be traced back to the seventeenth century. A merchant in Sorø in the seventeenth century, Anders Rasmussen, was married to a Høffding (as the name was spelled then), and from their son, who took up his mother's family name again, the line can be followed down to our own day. For several generations the Høffdings were clergymen, but later they turned to trade. My grandfather was a Chandler in Vestergade, and my father set up as a linen-draper on the corner of Gammel Torv and Nørregade. The house became my birthplace and is still (1916) owned by my family. My mother, whose maiden name was Gjellerup, was descended from a Jutland farmhand, Rasmus Gjellerup, who went to his studies and became a parson in Zealand. Her father was a farmer, tenant of Strandegaard by Præstø Bay. This farm my maternal uncle later took on lease, and after him my youngest brother, so that for nearly a hundred years it was lived in by my family. Some of my best holiday memories, from my childhood [10] up to later years, are bound up with this idyllic place.

My father was a handsome and stately man. I remember with what pride I saw him enter the examination room of the Metropolitan School when he came to hear me. Later, once during my student years, I learned in a comical way that others besides me considered him a handsome man. We were living in the country at Skodsborg and had our fixed bathing times in a bathing hut that was let for hire. One day, as I went to bathe, an elderly gentleman came and asked me whether he might not bathe with me, since there was no room for him elsewhere. I agreed to this, and we undressed, jumped in and swam. When we then stood drying ourselves, the man said: "Whose son are you, young man?" And when I told him, he exclaimed in surprise: "What? are you a son of that handsome man!" Fortunately I was not vain and could take the episode with humor.

Father was a keen man of business. I still see him before me in his gray work coat going about the shop, the office and the warehouse. The shop trade gradually turned into wholesale trade, especially when after 1848 Copenhagen conquered Jutland from Hamburg in the field of trade. The office was enlarged and moved up to the ground floor, and the shop premises were let out. He was highly respected in the commercial world, a member of the Maritime and Commercial Court in some of its first years. From his young days he was an officer in the Civic Guard, at last a colonel. He looked well in uniform and on horseback and was very popular among his fellow citizens, who sometimes after the end of the drills followed him home to Nørregade and cheered him. During the two Schleswig wars the Civic Guard manned the various guardrooms in the town, and at fires they cordoned off the street so that the fire brigade could work undisturbed. Often Father was called up at night, when the shrill watchmen's whistles announced that there was a fire.

[11] He worked hard to get on and to support his large family. We were seven brothers and sisters, of whom, however, only six reached grown age. From his childhood Father was used to frugality, and our home always had a frugal stamp, even after a certain prosperity had been reached. We always lived in a relatively small flat. Father never bought himself a country house, but rented modest houses for the summer. In his later years, however, he took much part in social life and himself gave splendid gentlemen's dinners.

As he stands before me, he was a man who filled his frame entirely. I have often applied to him Hamlet's words about his father: "Take him for all in all, — he was a man!" Self-assured and yet with a clear understanding of his limitation, hard-working and content with little, with a fresh and independent view of life and with a sense for the good things it could bring — so he stands before me. It was so safe to know that he was there, and so splendid to see his manly figure as the center of the home. We children felt ourselves at a distance from him, which made us all the gladder at a kindly smile or an encouraging word. There could be something reserved about him. He found it hard to speak of himself, and he needed one to come to meet him. Often hypochondria got the better

of him. This brings me to think of one of the proudest moments of my life. It was in the last year I lived at home before my marriage that he said to me one evening: “Harald, you must go out with me for a little; I am so heavy at heart and do not know why.” So we walked about the streets in the dark winter evening until the heavy cloud had lifted. When his sons had grown up, the relationship between them and him became free and cordial, although the element of distance was always there. The straightness of his character made him stand as a model for his children. Often in difficult situations I have asked myself: “What would Father do here?” — or: “Would he like what you are doing?” Although he was [12] conservative in both church and civic matters, he nevertheless understood that the young generation must in many respects see things differently from what he was used to. And I think I may say that he had such trust in his sons that even when they went ways that were strange to him, or even were against him, he could still believe that for them these were the right ways.

A beautiful and precious memory of him I keep, from childhood on right up to the night (25 March 1873) when I closed his eyes.

When I now come to speak of my mother, I am led to think of what a young student once wrote to me, that he found it hard to get a clear memory-image of those nearest to him: “I cannot picture my mother.” I understand this very well, although it does not wholly hold in my case. Only, with every memory-image of her that comes up, I have the distinct feeling that it is not adequate. My memory-images of Father, on the other hand, are clear and definite. In part this is explained by Mother’s features having been more irregular. But it surely has to do also with the relationship to Mother having been more intimate; she stands almost before me as a part of myself. I was equally fond of them both; but toward Father the element of distance was always present. My memories of situations in which Mother was the chief person are clearer than any definite and particular memory-image of her alone. I remember an evening from my fifth or sixth year. Mother had put me and my two younger brothers to bed and was sitting reading Andersen’s fairy tales to us. We were indeed absorbed in what we heard; but the main thing was the feeling of safety and homeliness, the feeling that the one we

loved so dearly sat there watching over us, while the content of the tale slowly passed over into the content of the first dreams.

[13] Mother was fair and rosy-cheeked. It is from her that I have the Socratic face I have often heard of. She had a gentle and a bright disposition, which exercised a calming influence on Father's choleric temperament and frequent hypochondria. When I once complained of my helplessness in the face of dark and sluggish states, she said gently and quietly: "You don't have that from yourself." How she loved Father and looked up to him! He had been the dream of her youth, and she stood faithfully at his side throughout life, until at his death she suffered the greatest sorrow of her life. — Much work was demanded of her. There were many children, and the household comprised, besides the family itself, the whole staff of the merchant's business, clerks, shop assistants, warehousemen, hired men and coachmen. And all this she managed in such a way that she stood as a mother to the whole staff. Many years later still I have met former members of the staff who spoke with kindness of the old Mistress, or of Madam, as she was called in earlier times, for before Father had become a captain in the Civic Guard she was, in the usage of the time, only Madam. At this rung lay the boundary at that time between Mistress and Madam. At the Theater all married actresses were called Madam, with the exception of Mrs. Heiberg, whose husband had a rank.

When the business went over to wholesale, the people were put on board wages, and Mother now had only the family to provide for.

We children came to Mother with everything, confided everything to her. And she understood us, saw through us too when we wanted to make ourselves out to be more than we were. Once I came home from school having been in a fight with some schoolfellows and got a proper thrashing. I then said to Mother (I remember the scene clearly: I took off my satchel and sat down, somewhat overcome, on a chair): "I beat some boys today!" But at the same moment the tears came on account of pain and indignation, and Mother said with a peculiar smile: "Did you, my boy?" Her tone made me ashamed, because I felt myself seen through. She did not mock me, but knew how to soften what was vexing,

here as so many times later.

She had a poetic disposition, easily kindled and moved, and without being well read in poetic literature herself, she did undoubtedly much to give me a sense of and interest in that direction. In her old age, when she had been left alone, all the young ones having flown from the nest, one would usually find her in her armchair with a book and her knitting, and she was always much absorbed in what she was reading, even if in her last years she quickly forgot what she had read.

Like Father she kept to the Church. They often went to divine service, especially in winter. They kept to the Church of Our Lady and followed, without noticing the differences, the line of deans from the rationalist H. G. Clausen through the speculative Tryde to the rhetorical Paulli and the kindly Rothe. My parents never talked about religious subjects and hardly had any grasp of dogmatic questions. When on the day I had taken the theological degree examination I confessed to Father, not without apprehension, that I did not want to be a parson, he said: "I have never set any store by that parson business." He evidently took what he could use and left the rest alone. In Mother's last days the opposition between believers and freethinkers came more and more strongly forward, and she took a decided stand among the former. But when I said that she must then really believe in a devil too, she declared most decidedly that she would have none of it.

Mother lived to be 83 and died quite suddenly after a few days' illness (11 November 1896).

To whom should I now go to tell what had befallen me of joy or sorrow? I have felt the emptiness above all when I came back from a journey. I was used to coming to her first of all and giving an account. Only then did I have the feeling that I had really come home.

In her last years she stood as the ancestress (mother, grandmother, great- [15] grandmother) of a family that looked up to her as the gentle and venerable matriarch. Her 70th and 80th birthdays were celebrated in a cordial and festive way in my eldest brother's house. On her 80th birthday children, children-in-law and

grandchildren danced a minuet they had rehearsed, in her honor. It went so beautifully that it really was an honor.

From a song I wrote for her 70th birthday I set down here a verse which in my opinion characterizes her quite well.

On this day a host of memories will rise
of what life brought to you, the dark and bright, —
of every time in sorrow you must tremble,
each time you shouted joy on gladness' shore.
But through all tones it will be sounding,
the soul's pure and deep harmony,
that ennobles life, even the quiet, humble.
It made your foot light and your pathway bright!

I was born on 11 March 1843. From my first years, before my schooldays, I remember very little. Only a few events and situations stand fairly clearly before me. One of the first shows me a little newborn brother lying in the cradle and the object of my wonder and my rejoicing. I was probably four years old at the time. Another picture is not so pleasant. For I am receiving a bodily chastisement (the details of which I shall not describe more closely) because I have not yet acquired the sense of cleanliness that every good citizen of the world ought to possess. This scene stands especially clearly before me, and I could point out the room and the place in the room where it took place. Just as clearly I remember seeing the railway to Roskilde celebrate its birthday; I stood outside the farmhouse in Valby where we were staying in the country, and saw the flower-wreathed locomotive come. Next I remember the evening when the body of Christian the Eighth was taken to Roskilde. The procession passed over Gammeltorv, and we [16] saw it from our windows in the house on Nørregade next to the corner house. The event gained a special interest from Father's taking part as an officer of the Civic Guard, in the uniform then in use: white trousers, red coat with blue breast and shako with a long plume. I was very proud of this sight. Dimly I remember the people's procession to Christiansborg in March; I see before me the many

people marching past in close ranks. The same spring, I believe, I went with my parents on a journey by carriage to Strandegaard and saw soldiers who were on their way to the war resting at a village inn; the signal to march off I remember clearly. From the first year of the war I remember besides that my big brother came home from town with a new song that everyone went about singing in the street; it was “den tapre Landsoldat”. Deeply imprinted from the year after is the disaster at Eckernførde, for it was then I first saw my parents weep; it was through their grief that it dawned on me that one can love, rejoice and grieve over something that lies beyond the family circle. The same autumn my eldest brother Emil died, and of a single episode on the night of his death I have a memory-image of how, from the bed I shared with my younger brother, I saw the commotion and the weeping when the moment of death had come.

A few more small touches come up from our summer stays in Valby. Every summer we used to make an outing to Alleenberg to ride on the merry-go-round. Once I was very tired on the way home. I was very smart, with a green velvet blouse and white trousers. And on the way home through the willow avenue I wondered greatly that the white legs down there could keep on walking like that, although I “myself” was so tired. I was held by each hand by a grown-up and could thus act as observer. Still, after the lapse of so many years, I see the white legs move on undaunted, as if they had not belonged to me at all. Otherwise I remember nothing of the whole outing.

A sight that always made an impression on me was the train disappearing [17] out toward Glostrup, when it had passed the level crossing near our lodging at the farmhouse. The train gradually became a dark dot, above which the white smoke rose toward the afternoon sun. I had no thought of where it was going; it was far, far away, out into the distance. It was the first dawning of an idea of something infinite. The memory-image has often come back to me as a symbol; from the first I was sure that “out there” everything must dwell that was glorious.

When I had turned six, I began school. My entry upon the path of learning took place in tears. It did not help that I had been given a new winter coat, which

had been made over for me from Father's cast-off gray shop coat. I howled as Father walked with me by the hand to Larsbjørnstræde, where an old student, Mr. Fenger, kept a highly regarded infant school. The first day at school did not turn out wholly dismal, however. In the last lesson the oldest boys had recitation, and one of them recited Oehlenschläger's "In olden days, long vanished time, there was a lovely maiden." I thought I had never heard anything so beautiful. And so poetry consoled me after the sorry beginning of my schooling.

Mr. Fenger was an old student who in his younger days had probably cultivated billiards more than learning, and now kept a little school of about 30 boys aged from 6 to 10. He prepared boys especially for the Metropolitan School. We were taught in two rooms and were instructed by him in all subjects (only for French a special teacher came once a week). While Fenger was reading with one group, the other age classes had arithmetic, writing or composition. We learned well, and the school gave a good preparation for further schooling. Fenger could be strict, and it did not feel good to be struck with a ruler on the flat of the [18] hand, an episode that usually ended with a stay in the corner. But he was fond of children and liked us to visit him on certain days in the holidays, when a variety of toys stood ready for our pleasant use. Like Nicolaj Holm, who was my schoolfellow at Fenger's school, I remember clearly the long-drawn "G'mornin'," with which we entered the outer schoolroom in the morning; it was answered by him from the inner room with an equally long-drawn "G'mornin'." Our greeting had of course arisen by imitation of his.

When the weather was fine in summer, he walked with us to Frederiksberg Garden, where we usually settled on the parade ground, which was then open to all. We played on the grass while Mr. Fenger rested under a tree. We set great store by these outings, which gave school time an unexpected use. On such days Vestergade stood in a festive glow for us. Through the swarm of farm carts and wheelbarrows the road now led out into the open.

Mr. Fenger ended his days in the nursing home, where some of the families whose children he had taught had found him a place. As a memento of him I keep a silver cup with his name on it, which I bought from a woman who as a

child had helped her mother to keep his rooms in order. She had been given it by him, and when, on the occasion of my 70th birthday, she had heard that I had been one of Fenger's pupils, she offered it to me for the value of the silver.

When I was nine and a half I was examined for the Metropolitan School, but was too young and had to wait a year. In the year 1853 (the cholera year) I was admitted and now began the eight years of school in the old school on Frueplads. Shortly before I began to write down these memoirs I had the honor of speaking at a commemoration of the Metropolitan School's 700 years of existence. I have been fond of my old school and owe it much, above all a good linguistic, historical and mathematical foundation for my later studies. And then on the school bench I won some of my best friends, laid the foundation of friendships that have lasted [19] throughout life. It is very strange to think that if I had been admitted the first time I was examined, these friendships would not have come about. Thus our most intimate relations to people are sometimes conditioned by quite particular events. Yet one can also see this in such a way that in apparently indifferent circumstances, as here the postponement of admission to the school, there may lie conditions for rich future possibilities. In my old age I have pondered much on how here in life the greatest is often bound up with the least — how perhaps that which for us gives life its real value may be dependent on something we are inclined to call "accidental."

Because of the cholera, school began late that summer. What I remember best from the first period in the new school is that every day after school I went to the police station, where it was posted up how many sick and dead there had been in the past twenty-four hours. I quickly grew used to the new school and went through it class by class, alternating as No. 1 and No. 2. For many years it was the later Supreme Court judge Grüner and I who relieved each other at the top of the class. What distinguished the school above all was the good order there was in everything. In the first 4–5 years the teaching was predominantly elementary. From these years I remember best the teaching in natural history. Our teacher, Carl Johan Fogh, was the born schoolmaster. He had in his whole

personality something that meant that as a matter of course there was quiet and stillness in the class. With his eyes he could reward and punish without needing stronger means. The strongest means he used was a stern word he whispered to a sinner; the others did not hear it, but the effect was at once visible. The main thing, however, was that his spirited description and characterization of [20] botanical, zoological and geographical phenomena awakened the interest of most of us. He could not help it that we did not often enough get to see the natural history collection. There was no special room for it, but the objects were placed in cupboards in various places. Our old headmaster, B. Borgen, we were very fond of, which did not, however, prevent us from often reporting a sudden headache in order to be excused from the dull lessons in the cold and dusty gymnasium. I believe it has harmed me that I did not get good and rational instruction in gymnastics in my young days, so that I might have come to want to continue with bodily exercise. We sat still too much and did not come to know the attractions of open-air life, as a later generation of young people has. My mother demanded that every afternoon I should walk around three miles on the old ramparts, which still in my schooldays stretched from Amagerbro to the Citadel. To walk the whole way round the ramparts would be regarded as a regular walking tour. Frederik the Seventh liked to ride along the whole of the ramparts with his train of adjutants, Horse Guards and lackeys. But few pedestrians thought of walking the whole round.

Copenhagen had at that time, not least by lying behind its ramparts, a different character from now. It was smaller, and the difference between town and country began just outside the gate. People stayed in the country in Frederiksberg Allé and in Valby, moved out in the spring and in again in the autumn. The gates were indeed no longer closed at night as in the time of Frederik the Sixth. But there was a customs inspection outside every gate. When in summer we boys drove to school on the farm's milk cart, with "Fløderikke" as driver, we experienced various curious things. One, which rather bored us, but which in our naïveté we did not think about, was that Fløderikke (I still see her with a black patch over one eye) got down somewhere on Vesterbro and took all her milk

cans with her into a house. We thought that this was just how it had to be, and did not consider that there must have been a good pump inside that house. But when we were then just outside the town gate, the customs officers came with their iron rods and poked into the straw of the cart to see whether there might [21] be an attempt at smuggling. The quality of the contents of the milk cans nobody examined. The town gate itself was so narrow that only one carriage could drive through at a time; it could be a long business when there were also carriages going the opposite way. Pedestrians had to watch their chance to slip in at the side when there were carriages. When a load of straw had got stuck in the gate, one could neither get in nor out. Once, when our uncle and aunt from Strandegaard had been on a visit to Copenhagen and were to travel home by train, they had to turn back and wait for another occasion, because the gate was blocked by a load of straw.

The stay in the country at Valby from May to October every year came to mean a great deal to us boys by making us familiar with country life and farming. We rode horses in the fields, drove the dung carts (where the brisk ride home without the evil-smelling load was the main thing) and took part in the harvest work, or tried to. Valby was then a complete farming village; there were only a few country houses. Now there is one five-story building beside the other, and on its fields a whole factory town rises. This change had taken place when, in my old age, I came to live on Valbybakke.

Before and after the stay at Valby the ramparts and the Cherry Walk, lying between the ramparts and the moat, were places where we could play and stroll. The bastion of the Cherry Walk sloped with its bush-clad sides down toward the reeds of the moat. Here were good hiding places, and here was opportunity to acquire a sense for the idylls of nature. Merely to lie in the tall grass between bush and reed was a glory. Now all this has vanished; only the Ørstedspark and Østre Anlæg recall the former time.

If one had acquaintances out in the suburbs, where there were still large old gardens that stretched freely out into the country, one could also move about in the open there. In one of these large gardens or parks was the haunt of an “order [22]

of knights,” formed by boys from various schools, under the leadership, naturally, of a Grand Master with his High Steward and Marshal, and otherwise consisting of knights and squires. My brother Valdemar, who was some years older than I, was a knight; it was chiefly his schoolfellows from “Efterslægten” who formed the army. I served as a squire and remember with what mixture of a sense of duty and self-esteem I, armed with my cutlass, stood on guard at the entrance to a fortified camp that had been laid out on the edge of a large garden out on Vesterbro, and whose entrenchment consisted of osiers woven into a wickerwork from tree to tree. Here the order of knights withstood a siege by the Valby boys, whose strength lay in their artillery, since they bombarded us with stones that had to be parried with the cutlasses.

Some years later I occupied a more exalted place in an order of knights formed by Metropolitan boys and pupils from another school. I was Marshal, and in this capacity came to lead in a great battle that was fought out in Søndermarken on the hill that slopes from the large wooden pavilion down toward Valby Bog. Our opponents consisted of pupils from some modern schools. Our army marched out along Vesterbro one Sunday morning and halted at the foot of Frederiksberg Hill. From here I sent outposts up onto the hill to see whether the enemy was there, and it was not long before the scouts came rushing down the hill shouting that “they were there.” We then advanced in good order up the hill, but whether it was the imposing sight of our host (we were twenty-odd), or whether it was deeper strategic plans that came into play — the enemy withdrew into Søndermarken and took up position at the foot of the slope just mentioned. They were probably as strong as we and better armed, since they all had cutlasses, while many of our men had only foils. We drew up in battle order at the top of the hill; both [23] armies marched forward, and the clash came halfway down the hill. We were hard pressed and had to fall back up the hill; some — and among them the Grand Master — fled very soon. I have never had so many blows as that day. I struck out fiercely enough with my cutlass and guarded my right side; but my foil-armed guard could not support me, and in my left side I was sore for a whole week after. We must, however, have made an impression on the enemy, for most of

his men proposed an alliance to us afterwards, and the battles were continued between new armies on a following Sunday; but I was not in that one. Then the whole thing was forbidden both by the police and by the schools. It could, after all, easily become a dangerous game. — Poul Andræ, my classmate at the time, has published, in the notes to his mother's journals, a fragment of his diary of the time, where he tells of these battles (though confusing the two battles). There I am given an honor which I really believe I deserved. First some are named who fled, and then it continues, making use of some newly learned Greek words: "ἀλλὰ [but] Høffding, the chieftain in facto, fought as befits a στρατηγός [commander]."

But my military exploits have led me away from the school. — Through Krebs's thorough teaching in Latin I had a good foundation laid for later language studies. The strict systematics into which we were initiated through Madvig's Grammar has in many respects been of benefit to me in my later career. It gave, alongside mathematics, a good formal schooling. Yet at that time one probably went the wrong way in beginning with grammar and practice examples, instead of leading as quickly as possible into connected reading, through which the grammatical system could gradually come to stand as a natural necessity. Krebs could be strict and, like many schoolmasters of the older time, become vehement and deliver long reprimands. But he was on the whole well [24] liked, although as inspector of the school he often had to set himself against the pupils' desires and wishes.

In my fifth year at the Metropolitan School came the confirmation classes. — At home we children got no direct religious influence. We saw our parents go to church and sometimes went with them; but religion was more a constant presupposition than something that asserted itself as that which made its own peculiar demands. Nevertheless it lay, as it were, in the air, from the moment it was decided that I should go to the Metropolitan School (my brothers all went to "Efterslægten"), that I should be a parson. I have been told that as a little boy I wavered between becoming an officer and becoming a parson; common to both

was that one had to shout loudly, and that, I suppose, I was (then!) very fond of. The main reason why I went to the Metropolitan School was, however, that I was very fond of reading — and the parson's calling then lay nearest. Later on in my schooldays I wavered between philology and theology. But in the year of my confirmation I really entered into a religious life of thought and feeling, and then the thought of going the way of the Church became alive. The elder Paulli had just then come from the Palace Church to the Church of Our Lady and was a much sought-after preacher. He was Bishop Mynster's son-in-law, and his sermons recalled those of this great churchman, but were not so full of spirit. For me there was too much rhetoric in them, and after I had become a student I stopped being one of his hearers. In the confirmation classes he often had an effect through the inwardness with which he could speak of religious subjects. But very often his teaching was purely a matter of school.

What had been founded here, however, only came to its unfolding when in my student years I immersed myself in Kierkegaard's writings. Then came a being-seized which at one and the same time led me deeper into religious life and away from theology, and which thereby became decisive for my subsequent [25] development. But for the time being my religious standpoint was rather idyllic and rather closely bound up with the prospect of a life in a parsonage in a beautiful countryside, where I could live in quiet among my books. When on a walking tour I passed a parsonage, I imagined myself into the life there. (There was, however, no Juliane in the game, as in "Øjeblikket".) Then at a certain point in time I was torn violently out of this idyll. —

At school classical languages and history were my favorite subjects. On my own I studied the history of Denmark to as great an extent as I could. The school's history teaching was of importance above all in impressing on us a firm chronological frame, within which the various phases of development in cultural respects could find their definite place. With much joy I used, in the last school years, the knowledge of Greek I had gained to read the Gospel of John in the original language. This Gospel stood for a long time from that time on as the most perfect expression of Christianity for me. Later I have come to a wholly

different view of its position in the earliest Christian literature. — Of the last school years and their importance for me I shall speak in a moment. I must first mention three friends whom I won in the years of transition, friends for life, as it turned out.

From the age of fifteen I was the classmate of Hans Skovgaard¹⁾ and Julius Petersen²⁾. In these years, when so much begins to stir in soul and body — when the school offers chiefly elements whose significance one only later learns to understand — when there is an urge to exercise the bodily and spiritual powers — and when, then, in the midst of this chaos religious ideas come in as guests from a wholly different country — in these years a refuge with a good friend is of the greatest importance. Toward parents and brothers and sisters a shyness often stirs that prevents communication of what is most inward. Later in life I have [26] in my work as a university teacher time and again found that young people will sooner confide in a stranger in whom for one reason or another they have come to trust than in those nearest them, and this has often laid a great responsibility on me and given me difficult tasks. For me there was at that time, outside my family, no older person I could go to. Perhaps I might have been able to confide in an elder sister, if I had had one. My sister was the youngest of us brothers and sisters and at this time still a child. She has since been the light of my eyes and the joy of my heart, and through her gentle look and kind smile I have, especially after Mother's death, often won peace and rest of mind. What I did not find in older people I found in the two schoolfellows to whom I now most closely attached myself, only in another way. If they were a great help to me, it was not really through what they said, or what they did for me, but through the fact that, of the same age as I and in the same circumstances, they nevertheless each took life in his own peculiar way, which I did not always understand, but which precisely thereby contained a challenge to me to let whatever peculiarity I might possess come to expression. We were often very much at odds, and both

¹⁾B. 1844, d. 1920. — Cand. theol. 1866, assistant master at Nykøbing F., later parson (last at Kettinge on Lolland).

²⁾B. 1840, d. 1912. — Cand. med. 1865, general practitioner, later professor of the history of medicine at the University.

in the young years and later things could get heated between us. But behind what could bring us into opposition to each other there lay in both of them a heartfelt sympathy, by which I felt myself enfolded again and again. I have not been understood by other men as by them. On so many occasions their fellow feeling and their understanding have helped me, besides which their criticism was a constant spur. They both had a remarkable ability to characterize, to find and to express what was peculiar to particular people. Skovgaard, who has not appeared as an author, displayed this ability as a letter writer, the best letter writer I have known. With people who did not know him, the ability and the desire he had to find what was characteristic in people could often lead to his [27] being regarded as an ironist, as a purely critical nature. Yet there lay behind it not only a great psychological interest, but also a great seriousness, an energetic striving to develop his personality and to find the content of life that was meant for it. Julius Petersen showed his gift for characterization later in life in the excellent biographies of physicians of recent and older times to which his studies in the history of medicine gave occasion.

As far as I remember, a serious illness that Hans Skovgaard went through about a year before we became students was the outward occasion for the three of us joining together so closely. Julius Petersen and I often went together out to Bjerregaard on Valby Bakke to look in on our sick schoolfellow, and thus the alliance was founded. Skovgaard's father was a well-to-do farm owner from North Schleswig, from one of the parishes that later came to the Kingdom. He had sold his farm over there and bought Bjerregaard, a home farm on whose lands a whole villa quarter and also the side of the Western Cemetery were built. My friend thus came of the sturdy South Jutland farming stock. Many good memories I have of the pleasant farm, where at that time there were open fields all around, and where one could feel oneself wholly in the country.

Julius Petersen's father had been a watchmaker in Rønne, but settled in Copenhagen when he had become a member of the Folketing. Julius had perhaps something of the Bornholmers' combative, choleric nature, but alongside it an inwardness and an urge to give himself, an immediate sympathy, above all with

the suffering and the oppressed, which later made him a beloved physician, not least out in the poor quarters of Nørrebro. His mind was subject to strong swings, alternating between enthusiasm and dejection. It was not always easy to get on with him. Suddenly he could collapse as if in despair, and then he could snarl at every attempt to cheer him up or merely draw him into conversation. And just as suddenly such dark hours could give way to a craving for festivity. And so it went with his work too. At certain times he worked with feverish zeal, but [28] then there could come times of complete idling. The teachers regarded him as an eccentric they did not know what to do with. Sometimes he disappeared for weeks; then he had taken himself off on a trip to Bornholm. Already in his school years he was in love with his future wife, who lived at Nexø on Bornholm, and he used every opportunity the smallest holiday offered for an excursion over there, as a rule with one of the small sloops that carried the freight between Bornholm and Copenhagen. Often, especially in winter, he had rough crossings. Our old headmaster, who at bottom rather liked him, and who, as long as it was at all possible, took him with humor, often exacted the solemn promise from him that he would not use a short holiday to travel to Bornholm: “Will you now promise me, Petersen — I say: *promise* me! — that you will not go to Bornholm? Will you give me your hand on it?” And Petersen promised and gave his hand, but in the afternoon he went down behind the Exchange all the same and looked for a pear boat for the passage over the Baltic. It must have been after such a trip that he once turned up in the middle of a lesson. The headmaster received him with a quotation from Schiller’s Piccolomini:

Spät kommt Ihr — doch Ihr kommt! der weite Weg,
Graf Isolan, entschuldigt Euer Säumen.

Toward the leaving examination he had just such a period of slackness, but he pulled himself together in the last months and passed with distinction. The restlessness of mind never left him.

The third of the friends I alluded to above I made the acquaintance of at Bjerregaard. It was the later famous physicist Christian Christiansen. (At this

time he was called Christian Madsen, because he was a son of the farmer Mads Christiansen at Holmsland near Ringkøbing. But then came the regulation that [29] surnames in the country too were to be fixed, and so he got the name Christiansen; for a long time, though, it was a standing joke to add: née Madsen.) He was living with the Skovgaards at Bjerregaard and reading privately for the student examination. Him too I came, especially in later years, to be close to, and here too a peculiar nature came to meet me, a young power that early found its definite field of work, but at the same time a mind that suffered from heaviness and needed an absolute refuge in the faith he had grown up in, yet with an open sense seeking out the human in all forms and at all times. He had the Jutlander's peculiar indirect way of stating his opinion, and there were those who could not quite make out where they really had him. All the greater was the effect when he really opened up and spoke out with warmth about a cause or a person, or perhaps gave inward expression to his friendship.

Among my classmates was Peter Jerndorff, with whom in my old age I have come into a closer relationship. In our student years he sometimes came to my parents' house, but later our ways parted. He studied medicine and afterwards went on the stage. When much later I came into a closer relationship with him (a kind of brother-in-law-cousinship), I saw how splendidly he had kept the bright look and the elastic step, in good keeping with the freshness and youthfulness that constantly show themselves in his art. At school he was much liked, and he was admired for his singing and his dramatic talent; but at that time I did not belong to his circle.

One more schoolfellow is to be named, and one who became a prominent figure in our political life, Viggo Hørup. He was somewhat older than the rest of us and, as the son of a village schoolmaster, felt somewhat a stranger among us, which later gave rise to the legend that we, as true sons of the bourgeoisie, looked down on him as a man of the common people. There was no question of [30] anything of the kind. And if he himself has said anything that could support this legend, his suspiciousness must bear the blame. In reality we admired his gifts. They showed themselves at school, as later in life, predominantly as criticism.

He could direct sharp attacks on acknowledged great figures in history and in literature. I remember a debate in which he attacked and I defended Luther. It was probably on this occasion that in my heat I called him a Thersites, which I often had to hear about later. At bottom I rather liked him, and behind his criticism and his love of opposition there lay a comradely feeling that never wholly denied itself. There was not a little phlegm in his character, something that is very often the case with critical talents, which is easily understood, for they are not set in motion when no object for criticism presents itself. But with this there was joined in turn a bent for daydreaming, fed by dissatisfaction with what actual circumstances offered. He was in a certain sense the most mature of us all, the one who looked most independently at what had been handed down, even if he could not always, or did not care to (“gad”), shape his opposition in definite thoughts. Later he threw himself into politics, and then we both met and parted.

The last two years at school were very important for me. A main point in this was the reading of Greek, which was conducted with energy by Carl Berg, later headmaster of Frederiksborg School. He was not a man of much spirit, and his translations were not tasteful; besides, his Jutland-Copenhagen pronunciation stood in a strange contrast to the Greek content. But he was tireless, and he got us to work for ourselves. He had us prepare lectures on subjects from Greek and Latin culture. He lent us works to get into the material. He afterwards had the lectures bound and deposited in the drawer of the class’s teacher’s desk. I gave two lectures, one on the Gracchi (we read Plutarch’s *Lives* of them) and one on Socrates. This last was prepared on the basis of a volume of Grote’s history [31] of Greece, which he had lent me in German translation. It became a two-hour lecture and was given to both divisions of the top class. With that the foundation was laid for my concern with one of the greatest figures of the human life of the spirit, a concern that has followed me throughout my whole life up to the most recent years, and which has been of the greatest importance to me both as a philosopher and as a human being. We read a whole series of important Greek works in the last two school years, from Homer, Herodotus and Plutarch, from

the Anthology, Sophocles' King Oedipus and Plato's Symposium. This last work above all captivated me and led me into philosophical reflection. In my student years I continued the reading of Greek authors, and thus a good foundation had been laid for my studies of Greek philosophy. This whole occupation became of great importance to me, since it allowed the thought of a purely human way of taking life, a belief in the possibility of an independent life of personality on a human foundation, to arise in me. But it was only very slowly that this thought and this belief grew strong in me. For the time being, as already mentioned, positive religious ideas prevailed in me, and these were not only confirmed but also sharpened in the course of my student years, as will appear in what follows.

Besides the Greek teaching there was in the last two school years another teaching that became of very great importance to me. In these years we had the poet and literary historian Kristian Arentzen as our teacher in Danish. He was a greater poet in mind and mood than in his printed poems. With heartfelt admiration for what was great and for the great, he constantly had to struggle with words to express what he felt. It was often only in single aphorisms that he could speak of Shakespeare and Goethe, of Lessing and Hegel, of Oehlenschläger and Baggesen. But these aphorisms stuck in the memory, by reason of the zeal with [32] which they were delivered, and the enthusiasm from which they sprang. He also had something provoking and teasing in his nature, which perhaps wounded some, but had a spurring effect on others. He was the first who made me suspect that much that was current and settled could be seen and taken in a wholly different way. On Saturday evenings we of the top class could visit him and his wife in their little home by Peblingesøen, and I remember how here, together with some schoolfellows, I fought a whole night through for Oehlenschläger's rank as a poet against Arentzen, who already then, as later in his extensive work on Oehlenschläger and Baggesen, was inclined to take Baggesen's side. It was the first time I really felt what a spiritual tournament means. In many other questions too he awakened, directly and indirectly, the critical faculty in me. And yet at heart he was a romantic, if you will an epigone of the Golden Age of our literature. But with romanticism as background, and with the security that sprang

from a heartfelt assurance that “the Idea” (as it was called then) or “Spirit” was the innermost thing in existence, the true reality, he let his criticism play freely. Criticism and romanticism did not enter into a real union in him. But it was perhaps precisely for that reason that he could mean so much to a whole circle of young people. Of my class it was, besides me, above all Julius Petersen and Viggo Hørup who came to be close to him, and those two stood closer to him, I believe, than I.

Arentzen had a quite special effect through his readings aloud, above all of Shakespeare, into whom most of us were thereby introduced for the first time. Like several of my old schoolfellows I always remember particular ones of his Shakespeare readings as especially captivating, and I can still hear his voice. A good reader in the modern, technical sense he certainly was not. But his enthusiasm communicated itself to us. And here too, with the introduction to Shakespeare’s poetic world, there opened a spring that right up into my old age has refreshed me time and again.

The last year at school was, alongside what, as just mentioned, could lift one [33] up and point forward, a hard year. Six hours of school and five or six hours of homework could well tell on one’s strength. I noticed already then what I have really noticed throughout my whole life, that my body was not suited to sitting still. My physician and friend Julius Petersen once said to me later: “Your constitution would be excellent if you were to thresh or chop firewood instead of studying.” With bodily heaviness hypochondria was joined, and both bred unsociability.

Now the end of the eight years of schooling at the Metropolitan School drew near. The last month formed a transition, in which we did the final revision on our own. I remember this month with a certain pleasure. It was like a foretaste of connected study, without division into lessons, and an inner coherence came between many things that had not hitherto been seen in their connection. One already felt oneself a student, could divide one’s time as one wished, and in the evening drink a glass of beer in the open air. And far off the holiday excursion then came into view. There was talk of a walking tour in Jutland together with

Hans Skovgaard. In the midst of being absorbed in trigonometry or in Livy, a glimpse of a forest road or of a path over the heath could appear as in a vision.

The examination itself went like a sport. It happened so luckily that the subject for the Danish composition was: “To develop the significance of the Socratic ‘Know thyself!’”¹⁾ This subject I was well prepared to answer, and it did in fact earn me the top mark. In the Latin composition there was a subjunctive I got wrong, and I was much put out when I came home and discovered the mistake in my draft. But fortunately there lay waiting for me a new installment of Lembcke’s Shakespeare translation, which had just then begun to appear, and that quenched the sorrow. — On 15 July 1861 I became a student with distinction.

[34] I cannot believe otherwise than that the feeling with which one left school in those days was of a somewhat different nature from that which stirs in the young students of our time. Conditions were smaller then. The school was more isolated from life than now. Nowadays one takes up at school in advance so many ideas, views and facts that in those days one had to work one’s way toward laboriously only after one’s schooldays. And besides, there were not as many students as now, only a seventh of what there are now. It meant more to become a student than now, and Hostrup’s and Ploug’s student songs could still be sung with a full heart, even if misgivings were already showing over the proclamation of lordship in the realm of spirits.

For the time being it was the freedom won that was enjoyed. We schoolfellows had a delightful outing to the woods some days after the end. It was before there were railways in North Zealand, and so we hired a “coffee mill,” i.e. a five-seated carriage, which went with us the whole day, through Dyrehaven to Ny Holte, and from there to the Eremitage. It was the first fresh breath after the strict time of study. Then came the Jutland tour.

It was as if it were a foreign country I was going to. It stood quite like a fairy tale before me, as I knew it from Steen Blicher and Carit Etlar. I had been about a good deal in Zealand, partly on foot. The summer holidays I usually spent with my maternal uncle at Strandegaard; glorious times, by the way, which still stand

¹⁾As everyone read Greek at that time, the assignment had γνώθι σεαυτόν.

in radiance before me! From there I had once made a walking tour with a cousin to Møen. But now it was a matter of a greater excursion.

So Skovgaard and I went by railway to Korsør and from there by steamer to Vejle. For reasons of economy we went on that same evening and spent the night in a village inn a mile or so north of the town. The landlord here regarded us with some suspicion. We discovered in the night that we were locked into our room, which caused some inconvenience, since the bedroom furnishings could by no means be said to be complete. Perhaps the suspicion came from our having, in [35] the evening, as we stood talking with him outside the inn, unfolded our astronomical knowledge to him, but met with absolute disbelief. He thought that all the astronomers said about the stars was fiction and lies. How could they know anything about the stars up there? — The next morning we walked to Greisdalen, where we rested in the midday hour. I had here an inkling of what panic terror was. We had camped in the wood, and my companion had fallen asleep. While I now sat alone, a strange feeling of loneliness came over me, and at the same time I had a sensation as if I had intruded on a place where I was not allowed to be, and as if at any moment demonic beings might come out of the bushes. It was surely not only classical reminiscences that were at work, but also the contrast between the solitude of the wood in the still midday hour and the busy life of the town I had recently left. Even after the lapse of so many years I can still see the scene clearly before me and call back something of the mood. When a couple of years ago I visited Greisdalen again, I searched in vain for the place where Pan had threatened to show himself to me. — In the evening we came to Uldum, and here we celebrated the memory of Poul Møller, whose birthplace it is. The next day the road went to Skanderborg. It was a long day's march, 5½ miles, and we were very tired when in the evening we saw the town before us and thought we had reached our goal. Unfortunately it was an illusion, since the road made a great bend around the Skanderborg lakes. Our feet almost refused their service. But then we got into a heated dispute, I think it was about the relation between poetry and religion. It was surely one of Skovgaard's paradoxes that had irritated me. During the discussion the last stretch of road was covered without our

noticing it, and the next day we took a well-deserved rest. There is something
[36] Epicurean about a day of rest on a walking tour. One enjoys the rest as never otherwise, because one feels one has deserved it. The desert can here, after all, be determined by the length of the road (when this is not all too small in relation to the time spent). Unfortunately it is not always possible to settle desert in that way.

From Skanderborg we went to Himmelbjerget, a splendid walk along Mossø. Up there we met our excellent natural history teacher Fogh and had a pleasant evening together with him. Telegraph Director Peter Faber (the author of “Dengang jeg drog afsted”) also came up there with his assistants; they were on a tour of inspection. While we lay up on “Kollen” (where fortunately no tower had yet been raised), a mighty thunderstorm came up. I can still hear Fogh say that it was surely not worth exposing ourselves to a thunderstorm on the most exposed spot in the Kingdom. So we all set off for Ry Inn; there was at that time no hotel on Himmelbjerget. We were soaked to the skin and had to be fitted out by the innkeeper before supper. Faber amused himself at table by telegraphing to his assistants by imitating the sound of an apparatus with his wooden shoes, and made telegraphic fun of us before our very eyes. It was a merry evening. We did not, to be sure, experience anything as interesting as the hero in Steen Blicher’s “Himmelbjerget”; but it was still a little episode on the walking tour. In the following days we lived at a farm near Himmelbjerget and roamed from there about the glorious countryside. By way of Silkeborg we then walked to Hald and from there to Viborg, where we parted, Skovgaard going to visit relatives up near Skive, while I stayed some days with relatives in Viborg. Viborg’s old and gloomy cathedral had a strong effect on me then. It made a more characteristic impression than on my next visit, when it had been restored in theoretical-Romanesque style. From Viborg I walked out to a farm a mile or so away, where I visited a family to whom we were distantly related. The youngest daughter, Emma Pape,
[37] I knew from her visits to Copenhagen, and a couple of months before I had had her as my partner at table at my eldest brother’s wedding. She was alone at home with two brothers. I stayed there for some days. Little did I suspect that it was

my future wife I was visiting, although I was much taken with my young hostess.

A rough steamer trip with violent seasickness from Hobro to Copenhagen ended this glorious tour, which awakened a love of Jutland that has never since vanished. The last part of this unique summer holiday I spent partly in the Sorø district with some acquaintances of my parents, partly with my maternal uncle at Strandegaard. — And then began my student years —

II

[38] When as a young student I went up the stairs of the University, it was not the first time I had gone to lectures at the University. In my last years at school I attended for several semesters Carsten Hauch's lectures on aesthetics. One semester he lectured on the folk ballads, another on Ewald's Adam og Eva, a third on a tragedy by Shakespeare. His inquiries did not go very deep, but when he became inspired he could say excellent things, and his figure then became as if transfigured, as the noble upper part of the face won the victory over the somewhat drooping lower part. I keep a vivid memory of the mood of these lectures. — In my last year at school I also attended the lectures of the later Bishop Fog on the study of theology. They did not give me much orientation as a future theologian. I remember only an image that was meant to illustrate the coldness of strict science in contrast to the warmth of faith: Athena is a lofty and noble goddess, but she did not spring from any mother's womb and has not been suckled at any mother's breast. This image pursued me for a long time, until I discovered that it did not fit, because strict science itself is an expression of the human spirit, conceived and nourished by it. It has its mother in a human need that is bound up with what is innermost in the personality. But it cost much labor before I could see the matter in this way. For the time being philosophy and theology stood as two poles between which I felt myself stretched. Neither [39] of them could I let go; but how could they exist together! Must there not, after all, in the end be a single expression for the life of the personality? —

It was Rasmus Nielsen and Sibbern who became my first teachers in philosophy. Rasmus Nielsen was at that time at his height. He was still seeking,

captivated by Kierkegaard and occupied with mathematical and scientific studies, striving to find a way by which these different worlds of thought could be united. His propaedeutic lectures in my year consisted partly of a review of Kierkegaard's "Stadier", on the basis of a small selection he had had printed, partly of a short outline of the theory of knowledge. He spoke with life and force, often with spirit and wit, and I owe these lectures an extraordinary amount. They set in motion a multitude of thoughts in me that had not stirred before. Yet it went with that course of lectures as it so often went with his books: the plan was too large and comprehensive, or else he worked out its first parts so diffusely that there was not time enough for the later parts. Of the "Stadier" he thus got through only the first, the "aesthetic". At every possible opportunity he polemicized against theology as a science, distinguishing sharply between faith and theology. This polemic at first provoked my opposition. I had come with great expectations of what the study of theology would bring; I hoped that the isolation in which the religious had so far stood in my mental life would, with the help of theology, give way to a harmony between the different spheres. I hoped to be led into a union of the life of thought and the life of feeling, such that they supplemented each other; I hoped that Athena and the Madonna could be united into one. In a diary I kept in my first years as a student I accordingly complained about those who would not acknowledge that there is a Christian science. — That was soon to change.

While Rasmus Nielsen lectured on philosophical propaedeutics, Sibbern lectured on psychology and logic. (The philosophical course at that time took up [40] ten hours a week. That was perhaps too much. But one has gone too far in limiting it to four hours, even if, now that printed textbooks are used, not so little can be accomplished in that time. In my opinion six hours would be suitable.) If propaedeutics was separated from psychology and logic, it was because it was meant chiefly to give the theory of knowledge or a general theory of science. Rasmus Nielsen, by the way, gave much else besides the theory of knowledge under the heading of propaedeutics; thus, in my year, the survey of the Kierkegaardian stages. There was a third professor, Hans Brøchner; he doubled by turns for Sib-

bern and Nielsen; and in my year he lectured on Sibbern's subject. I had chosen Sibbern, since I wished to hear him before he retired, and since I expected much of the author of "Gabrielis". He was then 77 years old. It was a disappointment. There did come, to be sure, flashes of genius now and then, fine thoughts and priceless remarks; but his delivery was flat and mechanical, and his dulled senses let him neither hear how he himself rattled his keys while he talked, nor notice the restlessness of his listeners and their chatter. His naïveté and his oddity could be priceless, as when he named his "Gabrielis" among "good poetic works", or when he explained to us at length why the four clocks of the Church of Our Lady did not keep the same time. But when, because he was too warm on the lectern, he first took off his skullcap and, when that did not help, his wig, one could not demand that young people should take it with devotion. He had outlived himself as a teacher, though his inner life still stirred with freshness. His books were tough to learn, all the more so since he preferred to have his own words back. — Only much later, when I had myself become independent in philosophy, did I properly learn to appreciate him, and it has been a great joy to me to bring his memory forward and characterize him¹⁾, and to help make his thoughts known abroad as well.

- [41] In my first year as a student I also began my theological studies, especially exegesis and church history. The exegetical study is probably what I have had most benefit from within theology. It accustomed one to analysis of what one read, to exact and thorough understanding, and it gave occasion for interesting comparisons between the New Testament writers. And to become at home in so great a work of the spirit as the New Testament, to be able to wander through it crisscross and feel the connection of the thoughts with the linguistic form, was already a great gain, and it is above all this that has made me never regret having studied theology, however far I have come away from theological ways of thinking. Certainly the diffuse German commentaries we studied were no pleasure to get sense out of. One ploughed through a whole series of interpretations which in the author's eyes were wrong, and then at last reached the author's own read-

¹⁾See "Mindre Arbejder", First Series, and "Danske Filosofer".

ing, which of course was the highest wisdom. There was a pedantry in this that could give one a distaste for the study. And when one really reflected that the words which were the object of so much learning aimed at setting those who read them before life's greatest question, the question of spiritual life or spiritual death, then one could often be indignant at the whole manner of treatment, all the more when one had just read a book like Kierkegaard's "Til Selvprøvelse". Several times I have flung the commentaries across the floor — but afterwards I went and picked them up. I meant, after all, to finish what I had begun. —

Through all this I nevertheless lived for the time being as a cheerful student and had many enjoyable evenings in the old Students' Union building in Boldhusgade in spite of its unsavoriness. On Saturday evenings there was often "carousing in the hall". One sat with one's pipe by the punch bowl; the songbook with Ploug's and Hostrup's songs was opened, and between the songs more or less emotional or witty speeches were made. Debates were not held, except at general meetings, where there was fighting to overthrow or uphold the senior- [42] rate. In the mornings, too, one could expect to meet comrades up there, and I had much use of the good library.

Since there were not as many students as now, and since they had more lectures in common, there was much occasion to make acquaintances. I quickly came to know the students from the Aalborg school, several of whom became my good friends. Not many days had passed after the lectures began before I was on intimate terms with Andreas Faartoft¹⁾, quite a type of the young student of that time, open and cheerful and with great zest for life. He had a fine singing voice, which was often a joy in my home, where he soon became a welcome guest. Another man from Aalborg, Søren Svendsen²⁾, I also quickly made the acquaintance of, and he and his violoncello also soon became welcome guests in my home. My two young comrades were regarded by my parents and brothers and sisters as belonging at home with us whenever there was to be an enjoyable and cozy evening. I owe them much, not least in the following years, when I was no enlivening element in my home, and when I myself nevertheless needed enliven-

¹⁾Later district medical officer in Nykøbing paa Mors.

²⁾Later head of the navigation school on Bogø.

ing. Faartoft later became a respected physician in his native town, Nykøbing paa Mors, and Svendsen, who had studied physics, became head of the navigation school on Bogø. — A third man from Aalborg, Poul Kierkegaard³⁾, I came into a closer relation with somewhat later, and in another connection I will tell about him and his fate. —

On the same day I had sat the philosophicum, Norwegian and Swedish students arrived. It was the last Scandinavian students' meeting to be held in Copenhagen (1862). There was great enthusiasm in the town and among the students, [43] and happy and enjoyable days followed, days that I still think of as festive memories, although dark shadows soon fell over the hopes that formed the basis of the festive mood. I remember particularly the excursion in North Zealand, when, after spending the night in Hillerød, we walked the next morning along the glorious road from Hillerød to Fredensborg. Here there was opportunity for conversation and exchange of thoughts with the Scandinavian brothers, and one could get information about the conditions of study at the other Nordic universities. Already on the first day I was quite taken with a young Swede whose name was Svartling, and with whom I corresponded for several years. Many years later I heard him described as a distinguished dean. At Fredensborg we filed past through the domed hall of the palace, from whose gallery Frederik the Seventh, surrounded by Countess Danner, ministers and courtiers, received our homage. We marched down into the Nordmandsdal, where a luncheon had been laid out. But hardly had we begun to help ourselves to the dishes before a violent thunderstorm broke loose. We ducked down under the tables, taking with us what we could lay hold of in the way of food and drink, especially the latter. No wonder the mood was high when the sun came out again and we emerged once more. A little later the King came, and in his genial way he said that he hoped we had become just as wet inside as outside. The excursion then continued to Helsingør.

That summer my family lived in a house on Krogerup Allé, from which there was a glorious view over the fields to the Sound and to Helsingborg. It is one of the best summer holidays I have had¹⁾. We roamed about in that glorious coun-

³⁾Son of Bishop P. Chr. Kierkegaard.

¹⁾I see from my letters to Hans Skovgaard from the summer holiday of 1862 that I occupied

tryside, now on horseback and now on foot. The tenant farmer at Krogerup had [44] two Icelandic horses, which he let my younger brother and me have, and so we could get far about in an enjoyable way. — One day we drove to Danstrup Hegn near Fredensborg and there saw Frederik the Seventh at the head of his Horse Guards receive Karl the Fifteenth of Sweden, who came driving from Helsingør and now mounted his horse, whereupon both kings at the head of a brilliant retinue rode to Fredensborg. This meeting of kings was thought, like the students' meeting before it, to herald a new time for the North. Alas, they were soap bubbles, and heavy and dark years came for our youthful ideals.

There now came a heavy and dark time in my inner life as well. I immersed myself in Kierkegaard's writings, and after a hard struggle I had to grant that he was right in his conception of Christianity. Christianity no longer stood as the mild, comforting way of truth that could take up into itself all human ways of life — family life, art, science, social life — and lead them toward perfection. The idyll was shattered. The ideal of the otherworldly came to stand in its whole unconditional severity. Only one thing was, in the literal sense of the word, needful: to enter into relation with the great paradox, the miracle of God becoming man, which made all that is human grow pale and set only one task, that of giving up all in order to have a share in the divine powers which, in one single place in the world and at one single point in time, had broken through the connection of nature and of human life and let the light of eternity shine into the darkness. Sayings in the New Testament that I had hitherto pushed aside or interpreted mildly and harmonizingly now came to stand in their whole and absolute ideality. It was not the intention of Christianity to complete what human culture had begun, but to break off and to set aside all human relations as indifferent, insofar as they were not hindrances to reaching the great goal. It was as if scales

myself much with Aristophanes (in Danish translation), particularly in order to get clear about the relation between him and Socrates. My interest already turned on Socrates from my school days. Besides this I read Plato's "Gorgias" (partly in Greek, partly in Danish), Röscher's "Aristophanes und sein Zeitalter", Goethe's "Aus meinem Leben" and Kierkegaard's religious discourses. It was the combination of these occupations with excursions in that glorious countryside that made the holidays in Humlebæk unforgettable.

[45] fell from my eyes when I now took up the New Testament again. And it became clear to me that what was proclaimed there was the highest. I cannot point to any definite moment of conversion. It was after hard resistance that I gave up the harmonious and idyllic faith of my early youth. That Christianity was and would be comfort, the eternal comfort, was true; but this comfort was bound to one condition: full devotion to the one thing needful, full renunciation of the human purposes of life. Only now did I really discover that neither art nor science nor civic activity is mentioned in the New Testament, and that there is a warning in severe words against marriage. It was Christian ethics that now appeared to me in an entirely new light. With dogmatics there was for the time being nothing wrong.

How was life now to be led, after the ideal had thus proved to lie higher than I had thought? The time that now came brought me, it is true, moments of heartfelt enthusiasm, but above all it brought me doubt, unrest and homelessness. I was at my wits' end. The master, the prophet, had after all passed away, after he had said that the Christianity of the New Testament did not exist, if indeed it had ever existed beyond the very first period. It was vain to speculate about what position he would have taken had he not been carried off so early. And besides, he himself had taught me that each individual must solve the problem of life in his own way, — that one fundamentally cannot learn from others.

And now my theological studies! I worked with zeal in the various theological subjects, but continued my philosophical studies too, attended Rasmus Nielsen's evening lectures regularly, and now also Brøchner's on the history of philosophy. I took part in a privatissimum Brøchner held on Kant's *Kritik der Urtheilskraft*. But from the purely philosophical side it was more and more maintained that a scientific harmony between faith and knowledge was impossible, — that there was fundamentally no theological science. So I went back and forth [46] between theology and philosophy — also literally speaking, since they had their lecture rooms each at its own end of the long University corridor upstairs. There made itself felt in me a constant intellectual discord, besides the personal one called forth by the new conception of Christianity.

They were the heaviest and darkest years of my life. I shut myself up with my doubts and became unsociable and closed toward those nearest me. However much I loved them, I was not a good member of the family. Life in my room and life in the living room came to stand for me as two worlds, and I managed only all too poorly to make the transition between them. The bright and harmonious way in which they downstairs took everything irritated me. Just in those years increased prosperity came into the house, and people enjoyed in their way what it could now open access to. I was dismissive and cold. I have many sins on my conscience from those years, and only later have I understood to how great a degree people had to bear with me. My parents were, as I have later learned, worried about me and asked my friends for advice.

Through all this there also worked a tendency to hypochondria, which is bound up with my bodily constitution and has followed me through life, right up into old age. Only those nearest me have had occasion to notice this tendency, which in the presence of strangers I as a rule find it easy to suppress. In my book “Den store Humor” the piece that deals with hypochondria (*acedia*) is one of the sections built most on my own experience. Heaviness and darkness could, without demonstrable cause, spread over the mind and give everything a dull and misty look. For a long time a feeling often came up as if I were hanging by a hair that might snap at any moment. Dissatisfied with myself, and that I accomplished nothing in the world, I often thought that all was hopeless for me. This tendency naturally had all the easier a time getting the upper hand as the mind stood doubting and uneasy before the greatest questions. What the [47] balance of strength was between the two currents, the one that came from bodily heaviness and the other that came from the heaviness of the intellectual and personal problems, I naturally cannot disentangle, and could do so even less at that time.

But naturally it was not the case that I constantly went about like one lost. My studies occupied me greatly. Besides the study of my own subject, the interest in Hebrew that had already been awakened at school led me to read Arabic with Professor van Mehren. I got so far that I read a couple of tales from “Tusind og

een Nat” in the original language, and for a while I even thought of becoming an Orientalist, which would no doubt have had the effect of diverting me from my absorption in philosophical and religious problems. I still read a good deal of philosophy; in particular I followed the development from Kant to Hegel, a period that especially at that time stood with a peculiar luster. For not only had Kierkegaard been strongly influenced by Hegel, but both Rasmus Nielsen and Brøchner represented shades of Hegelianism. I also read some dialogues of Plato in the original language. In short, my time was well occupied.

Systematic theology I read together with Hans Skovgaard, as a rule out at his home on Valby Bakke. Our reading often stretched far into the night, and I then had a walk before me in pitch darkness from the hill down through the narrow lane that led from Langgade to Rahbeks Allé, and straight down to Vesterbrogade, where civilization with its lamps began. The way was not without danger, since assaults often occurred outside the town, and since at the country house just opposite Pilealleen (now the main building of Ny Carlsberg) some big dogs went loose, which rushed out at the nocturnal wanderer without his being able to see them. But it was a refreshing walk I had out there in the afternoon. I remember a summer afternoon when as usual I came to read through an agreed section. I found Skovgaard’s second-youngest sister in the garden room, and she [48] — who was always amiable — showed me that day a quite special kindness and got me involved in a long and lively conversation. Afterwards it came to light that she was acting by arrangement with her brother, who had not finished his assigned reading. She often had to hear about the comedy she had played. She was a healthy and cheerful young girl, and I often think of her when I walk past the old Bjerregaard. Some years ago I had her granddaughter, who very much resembled her, among my listeners at the University. — It was both enjoyable and instructive to read together with Hans Skovgaard. He was very interested, but also very skeptical and contrary. At that time I was fundamentally a more eager theologian than he; later it has become the other way round. In particular he was not as eager as I to find meaning in Professor I. A. Bornemann’s often obscure words. In my experience it is something that cannot be sufficiently

recommended to young students, to read together with comrades. Independent thinking and criticism are developed thereby more than by reading with a crammer, which, when the crammer is not especially gifted as a teacher, easily takes on a mechanical character.

Besides Valby there was another place to which I often walked out, and where I found rest and understanding. An old uncle of mine lived in a country house in Frederiksberg Smallegade, and his house was kept by a distant relation of my parents, Sofie Pape, sister of the young girl I had visited toward the end of my journey in Jutland¹⁾. In her I found an older sister, such as I had often wished for. She understood my interest in Kierkegaard, though she kept essentially to his religious discourses. And now in the winter of 1863–64 her younger sister Emma came on a visit to her. We three came to form a little clique. But it was soon for the younger one's sake that I came there. We read together and we walked together. And I now thought that I had gained a sister of my own age. That it [49] was a feeling of another kind that stirred in me only became clear to me after her departure. For the time being I pushed back everything that stirred in that direction, under the influence of the strict religious discipline I had put myself under. And yet, far more than I would admit to myself, the thought of her was in those dark years a gleam of light that kept courage and hope up. There lay here besides the germ of something that later worked to bring me into a living relation to life again.

The winter of 63–64 was dark and heavy for my fatherland. People followed with suspense the events as they unfolded after the death of Frederik the Seventh, the threatening federal execution, the rising in Holstein and the intervention of Prussia and Austria. Then in February the battles at the Dannevirke and the army's sudden retreat. Grief and indignation seized everyone, and after the fall of Dybbøl defeat stood as inevitable. Those were bitter and dark times. But I am ashamed to think how much, through all this, I nevertheless was absorbed in my inner struggles and broodings and let myself be ruled by the feeling of powerlessness that was their consequence, without the misfortune of the country

¹⁾The two sisters were daughters of the landowner H. C. Pape of the farm Heiselt in Vendsyssel. For a time he also had a tenancy near Viborg. (See above p. 36).

being able to rouse me to action. In early summer, however, I decided, together with my friend Skovgaard, to report for conscription. For some time it thus stood before me that now everything was to be laid aside, and it was then also clear to me that if I came back from the war I would not return to theology. — Since no more soldiers were accepted, however, I went back to my study.

I had not given up Christianity, but I made to myself the admission that Kierkegaard (in “*Indøvelse i Kristendom*”) had demanded of the representatives of the Church. I acknowledged that I did not live under the ethics that primitive Christianity presupposes or entails. I recognized my distance from the ideal of primitive Christianity, although I held fast that it was the ideal. I felt like a [50] Catholic who does not enter a monastery, although he admits that it is the ideal. I thought that on these terms I had a right to regard myself as a Christian, although I could not think of becoming a priest.

The Church as Church could — this I have since understood — not make the admission Kierkegaard demanded. It would have been the same as admitting that it represented a quite different religion from that of primitive Christianity, if a religion and its ethics are acknowledged at all to belong so closely together that they stand and fall with one another. But the individual who makes the admission also, after all, really avows — this too I did not see clearly at that time — that he does not have the religion the Church claimed to represent. It signified in reality a break with the Church by virtue of one’s own experience of life and thinking, and I thereby placed myself under the principle of personality. The reach of this dawned on me only late and slowly, in connection with my continued experience of life and my continued studies. At this point Kierkegaard himself, by virtue of the principle that subjectivity is the truth, points far beyond himself. My love for Kierkegaard and my admiration for him have therefore been able to follow me long after I had come away from all dogmas. It has nevertheless been said of me in German, on the occasion of my book on Kierkegaard, by a lightweight theologian, that I lack love for Kierkegaard and depth of study of him. But the fact is that there are people who do not understand a love and an admiration that do not vent themselves in sentimental expressions, but in taking up a problem

that has been set and working at it faithfully in the way that accords with the individual's personality. Kierkegaard's problem has followed me from my youth, determined the direction of my life, again and again led me to a more inward conception of manifold relations, to a stricter testing of myself, to a shyness of what does not have personal truth. And while theologians and half-theologians, in the centenary of his birth, whitewashed the prophet's tomb, I held to the great principle of subjectivity as truth and sought to apply it in the way that accorded with my personality and my studies. [51]

Purely philosophically, the study of Kierkegaard has led me to a thought that my later philosophical study led me to deepen and apply in detail, namely the thought that the formal peculiarity of spiritual life lies in the unity, the concentration, with which the content of life is gathered together, and that the measure of the value of a spiritual life lies in the relation between the fullness of the content and the energy of the concentration. This thought, which has come forward in the history of philosophy before Kierkegaard, underlies Kierkegaard's philosophical characterization of the different stages or types of life. This point, naturally, was not clear to me either. It dawned on me only through a critical study of English philosophy and through the preparatory work for my psychology.

There was another point of view from which I was in those years also not yet able to judge Kierkegaard's conception of primitive Christianity. The theologians are accustomed to regard the thought that carries the whole ethics of primitive Christianity, namely the expectation of the imminent coming of "the kingdom of heaven," as an inessential illusion of the earliest congregation, or they explain away the passages where it is spoken of with particular force. And to my great astonishment I saw, when Kierkegaard's posthumous papers were printed, that he himself regarded the expectation as an illusion — only that he turned the relation around: in his opinion one could not live by an ethics like that of primitive Christianity without that illusion: "It is to such a degree agonizing to be the true Christian that it would not be bearable if one did not constantly expect Christ's return just now." (*Efterladte Papirer*. 1849, p. 248). By calling the expectation an illusion Kierkegaard places himself in complete opposition to primitive Chris-

tianity. From a historical standpoint the expectation is a fact and is the constant
[52] positive presupposition without which the ethics of the New Testament is not understood. That I saw clearly when later I began my reading of the New Testament over again. Yet I had already earlier had an inkling of this connection, since already in my student years I felt sympathy for Irvingism, which tried precisely to build on the actual expectation ("just now"). From the history of religion I have since learned to see the place of the New Testament expectation in a whole series of apocalypses or prophecies within the Jewish world. — But I return to my position in the autumn of 1864.

Besides the reason given above why I would not be a priest, there was also another reason, which now, when I look back, stands before me as fully as essential. I could not imagine having to stand up at a fixed day and hour (Sunday at 10 o'clock!) and speak about what was to me the most inward and the highest of all. The moments in which something of that kind stirred in me came as gifts I could not count on beforehand and could not call forth at will. Nor was I master of my hypochondriac states, in which what had stood clear and true in the good times suddenly darkened and seemed to be nothing. To this came a shyness, I might well say a chastity, which made (and makes) me not like to talk about what moves me most inwardly. I have also since then all too often experienced that what moved me most strongly in a quiet hour of preparation made no impression when I came out with it at a lectern.

Whatever the reason, my decision stood firm. But since nothing was to come of service in the Church, I decided to complete my theological studies in the course of a year.

It was a hard year. It still stands before me in darkness. Yet I had the experience I had already had in reading for the university entrance examination, that
[53] there is satisfaction in reaching the collectedness and coherence that becomes possible by going through in a short time the whole material that has been studied step by step. Now, too, given the relation in which I had now personally placed myself to theology, its whole content stood more objectively before me.

My own course of thought and my own life of mood unfolded now on their own. I had got from theology what it could bring me, and in quiet I looked about for new possibilities.

Among my theological teachers I owe most, especially as regards this year, to Hermansen. It had long since dawned on me that his hyperorthodox interpretation of the Old Testament was untenable, and that his attempts to repel what he called “the encroachments of the newer criticism” had failed. But I was still interested in reading the Old Testament in the original language. I myself taught Hebrew and had, as already mentioned, also read a little Arabic. And as regards the last year of study, I owe Hermansen much for his learned and thorough review of the essays we wrote for the exercises he held. It was the theology of the seventeenth century that furnished the presuppositions for his expositions concerning the topics we treated; but precisely for that reason there was a firmness and a consistency in the line of thought that modern theologians of Clausen’s and Martensen’s school did not offer. And then it did one good to work out something oneself, to be a little active after so much receptivity. I still think with a certain pleasure of those Saturday afternoons when I sat in Lecture Room No. 6 and worked out my exercise essays. Hermansen himself was a solid Jutlander, naïve and dryly humorous, kind and helpful.

Toward spring brighter moods came up. I felt myself fairly master of the material and looked forward to the end with confidence. My way of life underwent at this time a change. Whereas before I had regarded walks as a luxury, I now began my day with a walk in Frederiksberg Garden, and the broad path to the left of the entrance I seldom walk through without thinking of the spring mood I fell into on these morning walks when its splendid trees arched over me. — One morning the walk brought me a special joy. From a comrade I met I learned that it was Carsten Hauch’s seventy-fifth birthday, and that a number of older and younger students would on that occasion pay him homage at his residence in Frederiksberg Palace. I joined them, and we then went in procession into the palace courtyard, where a song was sung, and Ploug then made a speech to the old poet, who appeared at his window and with emotion thanked [54]

us for our homage. I have always loved Hauch as a poet. Some of his “Digte og Romancer” belong to my favorite poetry, and his sense for the great and lofty, his noble enthusiasm for his art, have made his figure dear to me.

From this spring dates a reform in my habits of no small importance. I had been completely addicted to tobacco. It was impossible for me to read a book without having a pipe in my mouth, and if I went out the cigar replaced the pipe. But now I began to feel disgust at it. It was probably a slight nicotine poisoning that was on its way. From that time on the craving for tobacco gradually fell away. From time to time it could come back; but I, who had hitherto been able to tolerate the strongest tobacco and liked to take it, could now not tolerate tobacco at all. A small reaction came when cigarettes appeared; but it lasted only a short while. Whereas formerly anyone who came into my room could have difficulty finding me because of the tobacco smoke, I now had clean, good air in my study. It was really no victory over a drive that I can report here, for the drive fell away when it turned out again and again that its satisfaction produced discomfort. It died of lack of nourishment. I have not needed to apply the self-discipline which a German friend and colleague, Friedrich Paulsen, has told me was necessary in [55] his case. He set a bundle of cigars on his table and decided that they should be the last he smoked. This last pleasure he then put off day by day, and in the course of a year the craving had then disappeared. —

The examination period went by like sport, and on 19 June 1865 I walked down the University stairs as *candidatus theologiæ*. In the afternoon I had the previously mentioned conversation with my father about my future. My wish was to take up school work and to continue my studies. Even before I had gone out to my family, who were staying in the country at Skodsborg, I received an offer of lessons at “Mariboes Skole” (by Frederiksholms Kanal) in history and Danish, which I had particularly thought of as my teaching subjects. At this school I worked as a teacher for 17 years, right until I became professor, and I have many good memories from that time. For the time being I took a holiday in Skodsborg, and later in the summer I made a journey to Stockholm, from where I returned home by the canal route via Gothenburg.

They were difficult problems that I took with me from the period of my life that had now closed. I had kept my personal faith, with the reservation I have described before. But in what relation should and could this faith now stand to whatever else occupied me in life? That was the main question that followed me. And to answer it, philosophical thinking was necessary. Philosophy, which had hitherto been a subsidiary subject for me, now became a main subject. For the answer to that question demanded an investigation of what human knowledge is and is capable of, and in what relation it stands to personal life. I had to learn what the human life of the spirit is able to reach on its own, so as then to be able to see whether a connection between it and religious faith was possible, and on what terms. That was the problem the Kierkegaard studies had set before me but had not solved. I had to pursue this question further. My future I pictured to myself for the time being in such a way that teaching would be my outward [56] work, and that to it would be joined the studies it required, — but that I would then strive to have a private chamber where what lay close to my heart personally could be cultivated. That my philosophizing could have any significance whatever for others did not occur to me.

And so after the summer holidays I began my work as a teacher. I had been interested in historical reading ever since my school days, and now I planned a study of the most important historical works, from Herodotus and Thucydides to Macaulay and Ranke. I also thought for a moment of answering a prize essay question the University had set on a topic from the Danish Middle Ages; but nothing came of it. Philosophy pressed on, and as a contrast to all the theology I had gone through, I felt a need to immerse myself in Greek philosophy. As I wrote some years later in my doctoral vita: “Classical antiquity came forward for me in a fresher and clearer light precisely by contrast with the scholastic period I seemed to myself to have lived through; I truly rejoiced in reading its historians, its poets, and soon especially also its philosophers. I thereby gained a deep conviction of the independent significance of science and of humane life.” Here too Kierkegaard’s guidance was constantly at work. He had clearly held up the Socratic-Platonic conception of thought and life as a spiritual power one

must give oneself an account of before one could, with full right and with clear consciousness, come to a stage that was really higher. I now read the Greek philosophical works consecutively, and in the following years that became my main study. In my teaching some years later I exchanged history and Danish for Latin (in the middle forms) and Greek (in the top forms), and there thus came a certain connection between my life at the school and in my study. Besides at "Maribos Skole" I also taught at the "Lyceum" and for a short time at "Bohrs [57] Skole". I was very fond of teaching, especially in the top forms, and have won friends there who even after their school years have shown me faithful devotion.

In the autumn of 1865 the young girl Emma Pape, who a year before had gone away as my "sister", came to town again to spend the winter there. As soon as I heard that she was coming, it was clear to me that a decision must now come, since she was in reality something other and more to me than a sister. I was afraid of a decision, not only as every young man no doubt is when he sees an Either-Or approaching, but also for reasons connected with my religious position. I had for my part made the "admission" Kierkegaard demanded, and which prevented me from becoming a priest. But this admission did not exclude unrest over the question whether full participation in the interests and tasks of natural human life was compatible with a strictly Christian conduct of life. The strong passages in the New Testament concerning marriage, and against marriage, I could not get away from. And there now took place, called forth by the Either-Or that was approaching, a last struggle within me. The seventh chapter of First Corinthians confronted me in all its might, and Kierkegaard's "Øjeblikke" lay on my desk. I was not "seeking" in the same sense as Kierkegaard's "cand. theol. Ludvig From", but I sought, quite personally, to make clear to myself what the consequence was of what I held fast to as the highest. It was the most decisive turning point of my life at which I stood. The natural, human need won, and with that the foundation was in reality laid for my whole later way of taking life. As I had earlier flung the theological commentaries across the floor, so I now flung Kierkegaard's "Øjeblikke". These too I picked up again, but from now on my occupation with

Kierkegaard aimed at finding the psychological and historical presuppositions [58] of his appearance, and at drawing purely human strengthening for my life by drawing the consequence of the truth that subjectivity is the truth. —

And so it was one afternoon in the autumn, while I stood bent over my Thucydides, that it came to stand before me: now or never. Without giving myself time to close the book I hurried out to my uncle's country house in Frederiksberg, and here, on that starry October evening, the covenant was made which began the short domestic happiness that was to fall to my lot [in my young days].

My fiancée stayed the winter over in Copenhagen. In the following five years that passed before we could marry, she was in Copenhagen about every other year, now in my parents' house; the other years I spent my holidays either at her uncle's, Dean Wulff's, parsonage in Gunderup near Aalborg, or with her parents on their farm in Vendsyssel.

Only on reading again, many years after her death, her letters from the time of our engagement, did it properly dawn on me how unfortunately placed she was in those years when she was not in Copenhagen. Her uncle and aunt in Gunderup were good and well-meaning people. But the dean's wife was of the old school. The whole day was taken up with housework and needlework. Walks were a luxury, and so was reading or writing letters. At home with her parents Emma had more freedom to write, read and walk; but her mother was very difficult to get along with, and there were many painful times. Several times Emma wished to take a position as a young lady in a stranger's house, but I was always against it. I did not at that time really bring home to myself how difficult her situation was. Good times we did have, however, partly in Copenhagen, partly in summer holidays on her parents' farm in a characteristic Vendsyssel countryside, with a wide view over the vigorous and hilly surroundings.

In the winter of 1865–66 a discussion was carried on in the press about Ras- [59] mus Nielsen's doctrine of faith and knowledge as two entirely different principles, which precisely because of their difference were supposed to be practically and personally compatible. I had been led to share this view through my own personal development in religious respects, as well as through my philosophical

studies. The latter needs a short explanation.

In this country Hegel's philosophy was still regarded around 1860 as a summit of thought. There a magnificent attempt had been made to show that, just as in the human mind one thought is understood only by its relation to other thoughts, so in nature, in history, in the world of experience as a whole, no phenomenon, no event is isolated, but everything is connected with everything else in the most intimate way. As one thought proceeds from another, so one phenomenon of experience proceeds from another. And Hegel thought it was possible to develop the mutual connection among thoughts in such a way that it would at the same time come to express the connection among things. From this sprang his great confidence in pure speculation. The human thought could not be something unique in the world; its laws must be the laws of the world.

In this country this doctrine had been the object of searching criticism by Sibbern and Kierkegaard. The hints these thinkers gave of a more critical and empirical philosophy were not heeded. For the time being it now stood thus, that both science and religion, each on its own, laid claim to giving an absolute solution to the riddles of existence. For Hegel the matter stood thus, that the religious representations contained in the form of the image the same thing that philosophy presented in the pure form of thought. Trusting in this view, many Hegelians believed themselves to be in good agreement with the doctrine of the Church, and Rasmus Nielsen for a time belonged to their number. But there [60] came a great reversal in his view under the influence of Kierkegaard's writings. He broke with his former associates, notably Martensen, and now maintained the absolute independence of religion over against science. They now came to stand as two different worlds, and man had to live in both of them. This view was attacked from two sides. Theology still demanded to be science and saw a danger in religion being relegated to the world of the purely personal and subjective. From the opposite side Georg Brandes in particular came forward in various newspaper articles and later in a small work "Dualismen i vor nyeste Filosofi". I took part in the dispute in a very awkwardly shaped work "Filosofi og Teologi" (1866), which in the main was an account of the discussion that, af-

ter the appearance of Martensen's *Dogmatics* (1849), had been carried on about the relation between philosophy and theology. My relation to the whole matter I expressed some years later in my doctoral *vita* thus: "I have always taken this view [Rasmus Nielsen's conception of faith and knowledge] more from the skeptical and negative side, more as a means to a personal solution of the difficulties, than as a positive doctrine in its own right." That is to say, I was more a Kierkegaardian than a Nielsenian. Brøchner later expressly drew attention to the opposition between Kierkegaard's and Nielsen's standpoints. And this opposition became (as I have shown in "*Danske Filosofer*") more and more pronounced in the course of Nielsen's continued development of his thoughts, until at last (in his work "*Om Aandsdannelse*" 1877) he entirely disowned Kierkegaard and fundamentally granted that the latter's theological opponents were right.

As far as I was concerned, the case was that I was on the way away from theology, and that the question now was what conception of science and of a personal view of life I could arrive at. A new period of apprenticeship now began for me. It was a matter of getting a foundation for my further development both in scientific and in purely personal respects. Of this I was naturally not conscious at that time, but when I look back I find an involuntary striving for a [61] foothold. About eight years passed before such a foothold was reached. I had to come to know the peculiar character of the different main problems and thereby understand both their connection and their independence. In a short draft for a course of lectures in the autumn of 1874 on "*Indledning til Filosofien*" were contained the main features of everything I have later set forth more or less fully.

But I anticipate. — My studies of Greek philosophy concentrated, at the point in time I am now at, more and more on a definite task, which I treated in a work "*Den antike Opfattelse af den menneskelige Villie*", which in the year 1870 I defended for the philosophical doctorate. Some years before I had answered the University's philosophical prize question (for 1867–68) and won the gold medal. This question too concerned the human will, since it called for an investigation of the dispute over the freedom of the will that was carried on at one time (1824 ff.) in our literature between the forensic physician Howitz, Sibbern, A. S. Ørsted and

others. I am not satisfied with the solution I suggested, and the essay had, in the judgment of the examiners (Nielsen and Brøchner), its essential significance in its thorough characterization of the different standpoints that had made themselves felt, of which Howitz's and Sibbern's had particularly interested me.

From this time on I came into a closer relation with Brøchner. When I had won the gold medal he advised me to travel abroad, and my father then made me a present of a journey. I wavered somewhat as to where I should go. Alongside my other work I had sought to orient myself regarding the development of philosophy after Hegel's time in Germany, and here the Göttingen philosopher Hermann Lotze had particularly attracted my attention. I thought of the possibility of studying with him in Göttingen. But I judged that I could come to know [62] this subtle thinker and witty author just as well through his books as through his lectures, and a stay in a small German university town would not be able to enrich me in other areas than the purely scientific. I thought that I would have a more many-sided gain from spending a winter in Paris, where one could not only study, but where art and literature and a pulsing metropolitan life offered possibilities for a more many-sided education. I spent a very eventful winter in Paris (1868–69), attended lectures (among others by Taine), wrote on my dissertation, was a constant visitor at museums and in theaters, and used my eyes to observe life in this center of the world. Here I came to know other directions of thought than those that stemmed from Germany and that had hitherto had the greatest influence on those who at home occupied themselves with philosophy. I became particularly aware of the positivist tendency, represented partly by the great figure of Comte, beside, and in opposition to, Hegel the greatest systematic thinker of the nineteenth century, partly by Herbert Spencer's bold but magnificent generalization of the concept of evolution. It was some time, however, before this tendency gained a more decisive significance for me. I have always been slow in turning. Thoughts had to ripen quietly in me before I could work with them.

So far in this autobiography I have relied essentially on my memory. But in

order to give a more immediate and documentary impression of the period of my life that is in question in this section, I will insert some fragments of letters to my fiancée in the years 1866 to 1870, letters I found among her keepsakes after her death, and which — together with the letters from her that I had kept — have now, in my seventy-fourth year, made it possible for me to put myself back into my inner and outer circumstances in those days. I pass over family matters and other things that are of no interest for the task I have set myself in this work. [63] The passages from the letters are given in chronological order.

30 Sept. 1866. — If one tries to keep life going on idyllic, contemplative harmony, one will surely run up against reality and learn that the reconciliation was only in thought or in fancy ... That is why I have become a disciple of Rasmus Nielsen, because he so strongly emphasizes the opposition between faith and knowledge. They are, after all, two entirely different states of the soul. Faith is an “unchanged mind”, but knowledge belongs to the realm of contemplation.

25 Nov. 1866. — How mildly and calmly life does not spread out before us when we think of those to whose lot the great struggles and temptations fell ... “All who live godly in Christ Jesus shall be persecuted.” (Second Epistle to Timothy) ... For the conditions of our life to be the truth of our life, we must surely understand ourselves before the great exemplars and not, in unclarity, pretend that the holy sepulcher was well guarded. What is required is humility and sincerity ... Then restoration and inward self-affirmation will not fail to come.

1866 (the date is missing). If I seldom go to church, it is partly because I know of no priest who is sincere toward real Christianity. There are passages in the New Testament that one never hears any priest speak about. It is by no means because I believe I can be sufficient to myself that I never go to church.

9 Dec. 1866. — You said recently that I seldom mentioned them at home. That does not come from my not having lived with them, I mean not merely in outward contact, but in real, inward living together. On the contrary, I have always felt a heartfelt joy in them, and I believe I understand them far better than before. A couple of years ago things were really a little constrained for me

in that respect, as you surely know and no doubt saw yourself. I often felt so
[64] isolated and forsaken, so different from the others. But now I am sure that the fault must have lain with me. That there is a difference is certain enough; but what does that really matter either, when only the right eye is there to see it? — I could have become a bad one if I had been allowed to go on the way I did a couple of years ago. But there was one who prevented it, who made my nature more open and gentle and drove away the coldness that for long periods could rest so heavily upon me. It is to you I owe it that I can again go about with a free and glad mind here at home among parents and brothers and sisters, for whom it must often have been a torment to look at such a killjoy as I was then. I do not mean at all that I am quite discharged from the hospital, — that I will probably never be, and that is probably as it should be; but certain it is that I become afraid of myself when I think of how I was three years ago ...

This autumn I have come to know Marie (my sister). The fact is probably that I have needed her more since I did not have you. What a genuine, unadulterated, childlike soul she is! There is gold in her, and it will stand its test. And the test will perhaps be hard; she knows, after all, only prosperity — but that too is a kind of test.

1 March 1867. — You said once at Christmas that I never wrote anything about my studies ... So far as I can come to clarity with myself, I am convinced that it is the one right thing I am doing when I strive for a more comprehensive and deeper-going knowledge and understanding in philosophical respects. It *must* lead to a goal that for me personally will be of great importance; I feel so surely that my life would become without bearing and wavering if I rejected these questions and let them stand in an indefinite mist. In that respect I harbor no doubt, although the goal naturally often seems to hide itself from me, and I seem to myself so powerless and so wretched. It is another question, on the other hand, whether I shall succeed in arriving at such a result that it would also have some significance outwardly. One cannot get further than one's ability reaches.
[65] But do you not agree with me that the first consideration is the most important? (Then the practical prospects were mentioned; I think of taking the doctorate,

working as a teacher at a school, and one day taking over one of the private Latin schools here in town.) To become a University teacher is something that in our small country is, after all, a sheer piece of luck, quite apart from the demands it makes on talent and personality.

7 April 1867. — Now I am to lose Skovgaard. You can believe it will be a great loss to me. He is to be private tutor with a Count Juel-Vind-Frijs on Lolland ... Then I shall not hear his vigorous step on the stairs and loud banging on the door, which now for so many years has announced a dear visit to me. It is no small benefit to have someone one can rightly call one's friend in the full meaning of the word, with whom one can speak from the heart and feel that one is quite understood.

16 June 1867. — You call me "true". I believe that this truthfulness in me can turn into a timidity that perhaps slackens me not a little ... True I would indeed be above all. This truthfulness, which is one with inwardness, is after all the only condition for our really being able to call anything our own ... Untruth in particular is so hard to get at when it hides behind an inspiring resolve.

8 Sept. 1867. — Sometimes I have a feeling that I am on a right way — that is to say, on a way that can lead me to what I believe I ought primarily to attain.

15 Sept. 1867. — Daily life has its high points and its great falls in respect of ideality. If one could only hold fast to the conviction that it is by the high points one should judge, and that the gleam that falls from them over life is the true light in which life is to be seen.

22 Sept. 1867. — (About Julius Petersen). What I have often admired as energy and strength of will in him, I believe is really more a restless striving, which is capable of much when the goal seems to lie near at hand, but which collapses [66] in on itself when patient endurance is called for. (Because of disappointment at being passed over in the appointment to a post as assistant physician, he thought of giving up continuing his studies and of settling in the provinces.) It would be painful for me to see someone in whom I have had as much confidence as I have had in him give way to the pressure and obstacles of life.

13 Oct. 1867. — What I strive for, what more and more becomes for me a

matter of spiritual welfare, is to work my way forward to a firm world-view. On that one must of course work throughout one's whole life, but I would nevertheless like in my youth to have carried through such a scientific work that I could have a good foundation in it ... That is what stands before me as the work of *my* life.

27 Oct. 1867. — I always believe that it is an idyll that is to be performed in life, and that is why things often go so badly for me.

7 Nov. 1867. — It may perhaps interest you to hear in what direction my reading mainly goes. Since the question of faith and knowledge, which tormented me when I studied theology, and which has since constantly presented itself to me anew, led me to a closer occupation with the history of philosophy, I gradually became convinced that without having grasped Greek thought in its characteristic main forms, one would not have the right idea of what it is really about. For the Greeks had reached the highest perfection of spiritual development that could be reached under purely human conditions. With Christianity faith came into the world, and new forces were set in motion, but everything we have of human *forms of culture*, points in its main features back to the Greeks. I have therefore already for half a year been occupied with Plato and Aristotle, and if I succeed in carrying out my plan, I will one day use a topic from there for a doctoral dissertation. Alongside this I am busy with history and Icelandic, which I need for my teaching.

14 Nov. 1867. — Lately I have read a good deal aloud from Shakespeare, especially on Sunday evenings, and also — which is a great pleasure — heard Poul Kierkegaard read. About a fortnight ago he, Troels Lund and I sat here one evening reading Shakespeare until the clock was almost one, without our being aware of it.

24 Nov. 1867. — A change that has taken place in me this autumn consists in my no longer being able to agree with Rasmus Nielsen, to whom, as you know, I had before on the whole attached myself. Partly a wavering in him himself, partly a telling criticism by Professor Brøchner, partly and above all a renewed testing of the matter itself (not least in conversations with Poul Kierkegaard) has

shown me the untenability of his view. Yet I have not thereby been led closer to the ecclesiastical ... On the contrary, it has at the same time dawned on me that on several points I held opinions that had no true root in me, but clung on as something external and handed down. Christianity will — of this I am fully and firmly convinced — always be to me the highest truth, the one in which alone I can find the riddles of life solved. But only what I can personally experience and appropriate can be truth for me; and I have come to the conviction that whatever one thinks one possesses that goes beyond that rests on unconscious hypocrisy. The view whose untenability I have now come to see has naturally not been without significance; it was a stage of development that had to be gone through.

18 January 1868. — Almost the whole of the new year I have been so listless and hypochondriac that I have often been at my wits' end ... It is never something outside me that I need in those states; it is collectedness and clearing, and above all strength to keep myself under the proper discipline, that is lacking.

(From the year 1868 there are not many letters, since we were together in [68] Copenhagen from March on, until at the beginning of December I went abroad.)

19 June 1869. — (About “the period that lies before my engagement and even partly extended into it”). I have sometimes called this period my sentimental period, and with a certain right, but more correctly, I believe, it is designated by calling it the ascetic period. Happiness and joy then stood before me as unentitled or at least suspicious guests at the table of life. Penance and renunciation were the main thoughts on which my view of life rested. I do not say that at that time I lived in every respect as an ascetic; but the corresponding anxiety was present nonetheless ... Had I lived in a Catholic country, then I would, at any rate at certain times, not have been far from the monastery ... If I have become more free, unprejudiced and independent, I have also become more humble than I was then.

11 July 1869. — This day has been good to me. I have truly experienced what a joy it is to busy oneself with a piece of work that lays claim to one's interest. It is a spiritual necessity of life. However modest what one accomplishes may be, there still come moments when one can have the consciousness: I too have felt

the great thoughts on which existence rests, and by which it is carried forward toward its goal. Even if I am not among those to whom it is given to grasp these thoughts and set them forth in a new and awakening form, my enthusiasm has nonetheless not been less. O, if one could only once truly collect oneself, truly concentrate all one's powers and push every hampering power aside! Perhaps there might after all be a stone that it could fall to my lot to add to the great building.

18 August 1869. — We have both, each in our own way, worked our way forward to greater clarity and firmness ... I have often noticed with astonishment how you saw things in the same way as I, and I am thinking then especially of the freer religious views that gain more and more significance and truth for me.

[69] 26 June 1870. — We now stand at the end of our engagement. How much has not been experienced and lived through in that time. I really believe it is only now that I have become properly independent and so a real man ... Independence consists in things no longer unrolling themselves before thought like a panorama, but in one's taking a hand oneself to bring forth what is true and eternal.

In keeping with my plan of going into school work I applied again and again for posts as an assistant master, and it was a disappointment to me that I did not succeed in getting such a position, since I now wished to set up house. Yet it would probably then have turned out that I had had to give up continuing my studies on the scale I had intended. And after I had defended my dissertation for the doctorate in February 1870, I applied for and received the Smith Scholarship, which I could expect to keep for some years if I continued my studies. On that, and on the income from my school teaching, together with an allowance from my father, I married in the autumn of 1870.

In the spring semester of 1871 I began to lecture as a privatdocent at the University. My effort to orient myself within the philosophy of the day led to the publication of two books, "Filosofien i Tyskland efter Hegel" (1872) and "Den engelske Filosofi i vore Dage" (1874). Through a critical examination of English philosophy, especially as it was represented by Mill and Spencer, I was led to

see the significance of a thought that had lain behind Kierkegaard's philosophizing and had been consciously brought forward still earlier by Kant, namely the thought of the unifying and unity-seeking character of human conscious life. Later I drew from this the hypothesis I made the basis of my psychology. In the autumn of 1874 I gave a course of lectures on "Introduction to Philosophy," in which, from the standpoint thus won, I characterized the various philosophical problems. From this time on it became gradually clear to me that the chief task [70] of philosophy is to show how that fundamental peculiarity of human mental life manifests itself in the various domains of human thinking. My philosophy, if I may use that word, became a doctrine of problems, that is to say, of tasks that are determined by the interaction between the manifold of observations and the unity-seeking need and power. A closed system could not come out of this. On the contrary, through new observations and new energy of thought it must constantly set itself new tasks. The point is only to show that everything that becomes a problem for the human spirit bears its stamp and is determined by its nature, whether or not the problem can be solved once and for all. For me this has been a fruitful working hypothesis, and for over 40 years I have sought to apply it to a series of questions. I have found that it was not only in intellectual respects that this standpoint was satisfactory (though people have sometimes found it too skeptical or too subjective), but that here there was also the possibility of the harmony between science and personality that I had sought so long. For in purely personal matters too the point is, after all, to bring a whole out of the manifold of experiences, impulses, and thoughts that makes up the content of our inner life. The sharp opposition between science and personality thereby falls away. Science is itself a personal labor, sprung from the innermost need of personality. And on the other hand there is nothing in personal life that could not be made an object of scientific consideration, at any rate of historical and psychological inquiry.

Given this relation between science and personality it becomes both unnecessary and impossible to harbor fear that science should lead to results harmful to personal life. And just as little is there reason for lyrical proclamations that

there is nothing above and nothing beside science. Science does not let itself be
[71] frightened, but it is too serious a matter to be the object of a lyricism that is not backed, point for point, by work.

For my part it became from this time on more and more clear that what was to support me in life could not be something outside me, but had to be something that made itself known in me, in the very best and clearest thoughts I could win, in the very best and purest striving that could lay claim to me. The point was not a sight but an eye that could see, — a central power within me, built on experience of life and testing in thought, — an inner home, a chapel, built up of everything that could give life value. The standard of truth and of value had to be drawn from our own innermost being, and it is in reality from there that science draws it, without always being conscious of it. Every image, every form, every concept by whose help we are able to interpret this innermost, which is at the same time the highest, and by which we try to make it an object for us, can have only symbolic significance, and here lies the boundary between scientific thinking and poetic analogizing.

In the summer of 1872 my wife and our little son traveled up to her home in Vendsyssel, and I was to follow as soon as the school holidays had begun. While I was thus in my solitude, a catastrophe befell one of my friends, to whom in younger days I had looked with great expectation.

Poul Kierkegaard, son of Bishop Kierkegaard and nephew of Søren Kierkegaard, has been mentioned a few times in the foregoing. We had matriculated in the same year, and our theological studies also brought us together, especially after I had begun to frequent the house of his uncle, Troels Lund's father. He was quite certainly unusually gifted, even if it would be difficult to say in what direction his gift really lay. In a letter from the spring of 1867 I write to my fiancée about
[72] him that his development is advancing with vigorous and sure steps, and that he evidently has the makings of a great thinker. He was living at that time with his parents in Aalborg, and the letters I received from him show independence and originality. He himself thinks, however, that it would come more naturally

to him to develop his ideas in poetic form. But I think he has more mood and reflection full of mood than imagination.

Alas, it was to go quite otherwise than I had thought. — Poul Kierkegaard had been strictly brought up. His mother's nervous debility and his father's heavy temper made his childhood joyless and cowed. In his student years he was strongly stirred in spirit, partly religiously, partly poetically, and at the same time his reflection was sharp and penetrating. It was very rewarding to associate with him, and I owe him much from that time. The fable that it was his uncle's fame that weighed on him I can firmly reject. The chief reason for his ruin as a human being I find partly in the violent reaction with which the craving for freedom, sensuality, and passion forced their way out after the constraint of his childhood years, partly in what I have already hinted at in the letter of 1867 quoted above, namely the indeterminate in his gift. He could not settle into patient labor of thought, and he did not have imagination enough to become a poet. He was thrown back and forth, did not get into a work that could become a spiritual home for him. He would have been best suited to be a clergyman, for he had a rhetorical sense and interest. He loved to declaim, and Virgil, who was one of his favorite poets, he could read aloud with enthusiasm in long passages. But a clergyman he unfortunately could not become, since his views became more and more heretical, and other use for rhetoric there is, after all, none under our conditions, apart from politics and the practice of law.

He took his theological degree the year after me, and at his father's wish he then went home to Aalborg. Here I visited him several times when in the holidays I came to Gunderup Parsonage, two Danish miles from Aalborg, or to my parents-in-law's farm in Vendsyssel. In the old Bishop's Residence one lived as [73] in a cloister. The bishop's wife never came out of her rooms and only sent down her greetings, accompanied by bouquets, to the guest. All day long one heard the old bishop walking with heavy steps up and down in his room. At meals he liked to tell and hear witticisms and droll stories. This breaking loose covered over the deep melancholy and the Old Testament cast of mind that prevailed in him. Between father and son a distance arose as soon as the son's heresies, and

probably also his want of self-control, began to show themselves. The bishop declared to me that he could have nothing to do with a person who lacked self-control to such a degree. For a long time I was then the go-between between father and son, no easy matter between two such natures. I imagine, moreover, that the bishop thought he saw in his son's apostasy the effect of the curse that, according to his and his brother's belief, rested on their family. It became a misfortune for the son, for he loved and admired his father, and had the father been able to open himself to Poul and show him the love that in spite of everything lived in the father's heart, perhaps much would have turned out otherwise.

I remember a summer day when Poul and I were sitting down by the Limfjord, a little outside the town. Then he asked me whether I would advise him to propose to a young lady in Aalborg who, he believed, cared for him. I naturally answered him that the very fact that he asked my advice showed that he was not himself sure of his feeling. Whether he saw in her the possibility of a rescue for himself, I do not know. But from what I knew of his nature and tendencies, I did not dare take on myself the responsibility of intervening here. Those nearest him saw a means of rescue in the young girl. Once, after Poul had gone away on a little excursion, it was arranged that I should take her in to dinner at a party at the Bishop's Residence, so that I might form an opinion of her. She was fresh [74] and healthy, childlike and cheerful, and I thought excellently of her. But I saw the great contrast in temper and in need, and I could give no advice. A year or so later, when Poul was living in Copenhagen and had fallen into all manner of dissipation, the young girl came with her parents to Copenhagen. She had, according to what was written to me by a lady in the bishop's house, traveled over in glad expectation, but came back disappointed and grieved. — A few years ago she was still living, unmarried, in Aalborg.

Against his father's wish Poul went over to Copenhagen and meant to make a living there by teaching. Some time later he got into Borch's College. In the first years we saw a great deal of each other. He, Troels Lund, and I read Plato together, and our sessions usually ended with Poul reading Shakespeare to us; he was especially fond of the Falstaff scenes. He could be brilliant and full of wit

when he was really in form. But soon his time went mostly in carousing and revelry. He used up his money at the beginning of the month and then starved for the rest. He would come with a wolf's hunger to my parents' supper table, or later to my own home, and then it was masses of food and drink he could put away. My wife liked him, and she thought it a pity when I wanted to set a limit to the toddies she might give him. He could also be magnificent in wit and humor when, with long strides, he paced up and down the floor, puffing with all his might at his cigar (and at the same time constantly tapping the cigar, so that fine ash was strewn over the whole room). But he was on an inclined plane. One summer Sunday in 1872 he came up in the forenoon home to Borch's College without a hat, after having been away a whole day and night. The Inspector of the College stepped in. The doctor declared that he must go to a lunatic asylum, and a couple of days later I accompanied him down to Oringe. It was a dismal moment when we drove in through the hospital gate and Poul exclaimed: "Ye who enter, abandon all hope!" The chief physician declared that he had long been expecting him, after what he had heard of his conduct, which pointed to [75] acute dementia. I believe it comforted Poul that he could be regarded as ill. He stayed at Oringe a couple of years. After that he vegetated in Aalborg. He had some small occupations, but real work he never took up. In his old age he was cared for with touching solicitude by a lady who had kept his father's house in the latter's last years. The last times I visited him he had had strokes, but was nevertheless fully clear in mind and could remember many a thing from old days. There was a sadness about him, as there was sadness in the old friend who stood by his bed. With him the male line of that remarkable family, which reached so deeply into Danish intellectual life, died out. — Poor Poul! —

I return to the summer of 1872. When I had come back from Oringe, I set out on a journey to Jutland to join my family there. I wished to use the occasion to see the part of North Jutland I did not yet know. I sailed to Aalborg and from there went down the fjord to Aggersund, and from here began a little walking tour. I walked through Hanherred up to the North Sea. I drove part of the way

with a man who had fetched some children from the steamer. The young horses that were in harness took fright at the rattling chains on some harvest wagons and broke into a gallop across the embankment the road ran along, and down into a potato field, where all of us passengers were scattered among the potato plants. It happened in an instant, and when I came to myself and got up, I saw the various children and grown-ups crawling up all round the field. Fortunately no one had come to harm, nor the horses and the wagon either, and we continued the drive a little further, until our ways parted. I stopped to rest at Fjerritslev Inn and, while I rested, read in Spinoza's letters, which I had with me in a pocket edition. Again and again I had immersed myself in that profound thinker; but it [76] was only now that the whole, as it were, crystallized for me. Of course I have not become a Spinozist in the literal sense; one cannot be that nowadays; but from that time on I have often repeated Lessing's words about Spinoza: if I am to name myself after anyone, then I name myself after him! — To enjoy a walking tour properly also requires being able to let thought or imagination dwell on significant subjects. For many years I carried a little book with me, in which I had copied out reflections and poems I was especially fond of. But concentrated reading of a page or two in a profound book is also a good use of part of the time spent resting. Then later, when the march has begun again, one lets the countryside, with its cornfields, woods, and hills, and with the clouds above, work on one with all the more life and freshness. My way led up toward Bulbjerg and Skarreklit, which I reached in the early evening. The North Sea was throwing its waves up against the solitary rock out there, and behind the silk-blue, foaming sea the sun was sinking toward its setting. I continued my walk along the coast to Torup Strand, where I enjoyed hospitality and got a night's lodging with the beach bailiff. It was still in the time when one could take refuge in the hospitality of strangers in these lonely regions. The next day I set off at 6 o'clock and walked the whole day along Jammerbugten, in splendid sunshine and a strong wind, which made the waves beat high over the wrecks that stood at the water's edge. The whole day through one and the same illusion of the senses repeated itself: a piece of wreckage sticking up out of the sand I constantly took for a human

being, although I saw again and again that it was a mistake. I have used this example in my psychology. In the evening I came, tired and hungry, to Blokhus, after having made a detour on the way into the lovely Fokkedal, whose shade and luxuriant green growth formed a contrast to the sunlit beach I had walked along the whole day. Never has a supper and a night's sleep done me so much good. The next day I rested, and in the afternoon I got a one-horse carriage to drive me to Brønderslev, where I spent the night, so as to walk the next day to [77] my parents-in-law's farm, where I found wife and child in the best of health.

Every such walking tour I have made has let me live myself more inwardly into the nature of our country, feel myself one with it, on its sandy coasts, in its luxuriant woods, and among its hills. Before and after the time I am speaking of here, I have walked through North, South, and West Zealand, Møen, Bornholm, southern Funen, and great stretches of Jutland. The nature of Jutland especially, as I have already said, I love, and a summer holiday does not seem normal to me if I have not renewed my acquaintance with it. Vendsyssel with its wide views, its hills, meadows, and streams, Mid-Jutland with heaths and woods, heather and bogs, West Jutland with dunes and roaring surf, East Jutland with the glories of Aarhus Bay and Vejle Fjord — all this not only gladdens me while I go about there, but images in memory from these regions often come back in my fancies. In Steen Blicher's short stories it is not least his splendid descriptions of nature that have made him one of my favorite poets.

When, after this Jutland excursion, I return to my life in Copenhagen, there is one figure who stands out for me in my memory of the years around 1870. It is Hans Brøchner. I had come into contact with him in the summer of 1867, when, after hearing me speak as opponent at a doctoral disputation, he sent me a kind and encouraging greeting. From that time on I visited him often. I received advice from him regarding my study of the history of philosophy, and when I had written a critical review of one of his books, he sent me his rejoinders and asked me to come one evening and discuss them with him. In the following years, until his death (1875), I visited him regularly once a month in his lonely

[78] home, where he lived as a widower with his two children. He associated with none of his contemporaries, with the exception of the friend of his youth, Privy Councillor Vedel. Of younger men only Georg Brandes came to him besides me, after his closest disciple, the amiable and gifted Kristian Møller, had died. When one visited him, it was as a rule not philosophical subjects that came up. In his solitude he felt a wish to hear news from the academic world and from the rest of the world. I still see him sitting in his rocking chair or pacing up and down the floor with his characteristic long and decided strides. His unusually handsome face could then shine with goodwill and interest. Often he told of his travels or of his young wife, who had died early. Of Costanza, the young Italian woman he had been in love with in his youth, he never spoke to me; it was only when I published his letters that I came to know this episode of his life. In the letters it appears, as he describes it, as a romance full of mood. It seems to have been a father confessor's intervention that prevented him from bringing Costanza up to the North. It would surely also have been a hazardous venture. — When one stood up and wished to take one's leave, he became especially lively and had many things to ask and talk about; it was as if he was loath to let go of the few links that connected him with the world around him.

He was a philosophical hermit. The circle of thoughts he had made his own was his spiritual home. He did not have much ability to communicate himself in free form, varying his expressions according to situations and personalities, and he had once and for all summed up his ideas in definite, very abstract forms. But both in lectures and in conversation there could come a quivering in voice and expression, a sign of the deep feeling that lay behind and bore witness to the connection of thought with the whole personality. He was a knight of thought, the last representative among us of the idealism that, in confidence that the innermost of existence could find and had found expression in the form of thought, also found in this form expression for the highest longing of personal life. For those who followed after him in the field of philosophy the problems have become more complex and manifold. In one of his last lectures Brøchner declared himself an adherent of "the idealistic philosophy that Germany has the honor

[79]

of having produced,” and there can hardly have been many in whom the chief thinker of this philosophy penetrated and ennobled the personality to such a degree as in him. The image of “the quiet professor,” as he has been called, has followed me on my way and reminded me what value the life of thought can have, even beyond the purely intellectual domain, when there is earnestness in the work of thought. His friendship was to me an honor and an encouragement, and it was with deep emotion that I took leave of him on his deathbed. It was the day before he died that I saw him for the last time. He spoke with complete calm of his departure, and arranged with me the settling of various matters. When he bade me farewell and thanked me for my friendship, I was more overcome than he. His housekeeper related later that he had said quite calmly, when I had gone: “Take that glass away, for Dr. Høffding’s tears are in it.”

A little myth formed, after he had died, about his last moments. He died on 17 December (1875) toward afternoon, that is, in the darkest time of year. Among the last things he said was: “We must have light in here.” In the time just after his death I heard from several quarters that he was supposed to have cried out for light, and there were those who added that it was no wonder that that man cried out for light! — The myth, however, seems to have died a natural death. For a time it got some nourishment from what happened at his funeral. At that time no purely civil funeral was possible. He had wished to be buried from the University, and that a colleague should speak; but if that could not be done, he had named a particular clergyman, who had spoken over his young friend Kristian Møller and [80] had shown great tact on that occasion. But the clergyman in question seems to have misunderstood the situation and read more into the deceased’s very conditional wish than was justified. I thought of correcting the misunderstanding, but gave it up when Brøchner’s oldest friend, Privy Councillor Vedel, firmly advised against it.

In the preface to my edition of the correspondence of Brøchner and Molbech and in “Danske Filosofer” I have given a characterization of Brøchner as a personality and as a thinker, and my work “Den nyere Filosofis Historie” I have dedicated “To the memory of my teacher and friend.”

If I were to try to describe my home life after I had set up house, I would face the same difficulty I have mentioned earlier with regard to forming a clear picture of those nearest to one. The few years in which this home life lasted stand for me as an enclave in relation to the rest of my life. Not as if it was a pure idyll. Looking back, I call myself to account for many an hour when despondency and low spirits, which did not always have deep-lying causes, fell on the one I least of all wished to grieve. But I was borne with, here as in my old home. And we developed side by side, as had already begun in the years of our engagement. My wife was naturally not at home in what occupied me. But when I succeeded in finding an expression for the human and personal side of the subjects my studies concerned, it was taken up with joy and understanding. I have always found it comic when wives simply took on their husbands' opinions, especially when they, as is not seldom seen, come forward more dogmatically and didactically than their male halves. And I dare say that my wife had such a sense for what is genuine and self-acquired, and at the same time such tact, that she went along only with what she could make her own by the way of her own experience and [81] reflection. And in the land of poetry we could meet as in a common world. I read Homer and Plato to her or with her, Shakespeare and Molière, besides the authors of the day, in the first place Bjørnson and Ibsen. I remember especially how taken she was with Homer. Many an evening, when the question was what we should take up, she said: "Let us have something about the godlike heroes!" Our family devotions now became poetry. In the years of our engagement it had been the Bible in its capacity as dogmatic authority. Hand in hand we had wandered over from the land of dogmas to the land of symbols and poetry. Now too we read the Bible, but as great poetry of life.

Glorious summer journeys we made together, to Møen, to Aarhus and the Silkeborg country, or we met at her parents' farm in Vendsyssel, she traveling ahead and I usually making a little excursion, partly on foot, and ending up with her and her family. I have mentioned the walk along Jammerbugten. Another time I went to Skagen. That was in the summer of 1875. Skagen had then just

been discovered by Drachmann. No hotels and villas yet waged war on free nature. One drove by mail coach from Frederikshavn, partly right along the water's edge, and from the post station one had to wade through deep sand to the thatched inn. Here I stayed almost as the only guest; a man of the Inner Mission was staying there too. So I could go about undisturbed in the world of sand and sea. The return journey I made by carriage to Frederikshavn, and from there I walked the glorious road along the shore, with the Bangsbo hills on my right hand, toward Sæby. That bright summer afternoon still stands clearly in my memory, and not least the moment when, a little outside Sæby, I met my wife, who had driven out to meet me. —

In Copenhagen we associated first and foremost with Julius Petersen and his wife Oliva, née Munch. He was now practicing in Nørrebro and quickly got a large practice, not least in the poor quarters. He was restlessly active, and already now began his studies in the history of medicine. When he came home from sick calls in poor homes, he could be indignant at the luxury he thought he saw in their very meager homes, and he could sit sunk in low spirits and discontent. But then suddenly quite another mood could come up, and often, when we thought the barometer stood low, an invitation could come to take part in a little gathering. Against his restlessness and his many fluctuations Oliva's levelheadedness, clear understanding, and firm will were of good use. As the flock of children grew quickly, there was enough for her to do. And always she kept her house running well, so that it even became a gathering place for his friends. Here we met with Kristian Arentzen, Viggo Hørup, and Holger Drachmann and their wives, and in many and long speeches at the festive supper table the many questions of the time were discussed. — Troels Lund I had made the acquaintance of in my student years. From philology he had gone over to theology, and after his examination he took up, as I did, studies of Greek philosophy and defended (1871) an interesting dissertation on Socrates. Later he went over to historical studies, occasioned by an appointment in the Rigsarkiv (the Geheimearchiv, as it was then called). Troels Lund's fine, harmonious personality was a pleasure to associate with, and his lively wife, together with him, made their home a place [82]

where we liked to come. And in those days one could also have the pleasure of being surprised by a visit; it was so pleasant when Lund and his wife came and settled in for the evening, making do with what the house could offer. — To Heegaard's home too many good memories point back. At my doctoral disputation he was opponent, and from that time on we came to be close to each other. After breaking with Rasmus Nielsen he was in a searching state, taken up with eager study of Kant and the more recent English philosophers; he also occupied himself a great deal with mathematics. As his financial circumstances were straitened, he had to take on wearing extra work. Among other things he wrote anonymously a series of novels, in which he was strongly influenced by Dickens.

[83] For some years they found a fairly large readership. He also took on office work at a publishing house for a time. Heegaard was, in his vigorous period, open and jovial, full of mockery of all manner of dogmatists; the clergy he liked to call bonzes. He declaimed perhaps a little too much against dogmatism instead of immersing himself, by his own activity, in positive work. But it was fruitful and encouraging to associate with him. And in his home his wife had a refreshing effect through her clear and cheerful bearing in the most varied circumstances.

Outside this narrower, personal circle of friends, the collegial life among the teachers at Mariboe's School played a large part for me in these years. The headmaster, old Neve, as he was usually called, was a man of what was then called the old school. He was a man of feeling, and a patriarchal relation prevailed between him and his teachers, which was not dissolved even when the radical taste for discussion of the time also found voice at our teachers' meetings. A young radical thus raised in all seriousness the question why one should really arrive punctually for one's lessons. When the person in question kept on making difficulties and objections, Neve said afterwards to one of the teachers: "N. N. is surely under some pressure; if it is money he needs, I will gladly help him; but won't you question him — if I do it myself, he will be offended." He often gathered his teachers in his home for pleasant get-togethers. He was fond of a good glass, and there was a festive mood on such occasions, as also when we teachers held a party at shared cost and invited him. It was a new student life I

enjoyed in these years. Among the teaching staff were Schandorph, Otto Borchsenius, Carl Michelsen, Kaper (later senior master at the Metropolitan School), Frederik Nielsen (later professor and bishop), Archivist Feilberg, and others. The questions of the restless time could give rise at our teachers' meetings to violent clashes. I especially remember a meeting that Neve had called to talk with us about how the teachers should stand toward the religious and social questions [84] that had come up so strongly at the beginning of the seventies. It was maintained on the side of the orthodox (Fr. Nielsen and Kaper) that a teacher's faith or unbelief must show itself in his teaching, even if this concerned writing or German grammar. That was to give the rest of us the choice between hypocrisy and agitation. The orthodox believed they had old Neve on their side, because he maintained that the Christian spirit should pervade the school. But when from the other side a closer explanation was asked of what the Christian spirit was, he answered that he was thinking chiefly of monotheism and morality — whereby he also answered the question of how the school should stand toward the Jews, who made up about a third of the school's pupils. The orthodox pulled rather long faces at this explanation. For the rest, the whole question found its natural settlement in the simple pedagogical rule, which was surely followed by all of us, that one should not in school bring forward problems that there is not yet maturity to deal with. There is, moreover, occasion enough in the school subjects themselves to dwell on the purely human and its significance; then it must be left to the later personal development of the young whether they can get through life by keeping to that, or whether they need something that claims to go beyond it.

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The circle I moved in at Maribo's School coincided in part with the one that gathered around Kr. Arentzen. The subjects of discussion in Arentzen's circle, — to which, besides Julius Petersen, Hørup, and me, also Schandorph, Borchsenius, Carl Michelsen, Drachmann, and Schwanenflügel belonged, — were connected directly or indirectly with Arentzen's own personality, since they turned on the relation between romanticism and criticism, to which now also was added the relation between romanticism and realism. Arentzen had worked so strongly on

us partly by his provocative criticism, partly by the background of something
[85] great and infinite that seemed to stand behind him. It was this union that conditioned his awakening influence. When in the year 1872 he was to travel abroad to be away for a year, we held a farewell party for him that stands as a shining memory for me. Drachmann had written a splendid song and read a beautiful poem aloud. We vied with one another in expressing our thanks for all that we owed the guest of honor. Kaalund, Arentzen's old friend, was present and read an excellent poem, which is printed in his collection of poems "En Eftervaar" under the title "Ved en Vens Afrejse til Udlandet," and in which he aptly characterizes Arentzen, especially in the following lines:

The homage I bring you here today
is a debt I have owed you so long.
So long — yes, since the youthful years —
I think since our first meeting,
for no one so well as you knows how
to help others to give birth.

We know it, who know your bright spirit:
on the banner that you have raised,
that from youth you have boldly held in your hand,
there stands "Excelsior" written:
Upward and onward and always up! —
Your aim is as high as the goal!
It beckons you like an Alpine peak
above the fog and the bawling of the day!

Arentzen had grown tired of school life and used the occasion that the closing of some classes offered to take his retirement on a waiting allowance, and after that he and his wife went away to spend a year or so in southern Germany. Before that an attempt had been made to bring him into contact with Georg Brandes, around whom, after his return from a long journey abroad, a circle had begun to gather. The attempt failed. At a gathering that was arranged, Arentzen made a

speech that was somewhat long-winded; — making speeches was on the whole not his forte. He impressed on them that, even if one struck out on new paths, one must not give up piety toward the old, still less mock it. The speech was [86] unfortunate in its form and met only with mockery from the other side. One had to know Arentzen well to understand his conduct, and it was in itself not strange that people were ill pleased at being admonished to consideration when on so many occasions such inconsiderate methods were used by those who came forward on behalf of the old.

When Arentzen came home from abroad, it was more and more a romantic conservatism that gained the upper hand in him. And he was vexed that so many of his younger friends were so taken up with Georg Brandes. Altogether it seemed as if he could not get used to the thought that those who had been his pupils and had benefited so much from his comprehensive literary knowledge as well as from his enthusiasm now came forward more or less independently and went other ways than his, perhaps even directed criticism against him himself. In their younger days he had so often driven them to the wall in discussion, and now there were those who tried the same with him. Increasing deafness did its part to isolate him and often led him to misunderstand what was said. His later years he spent, true to his old love of the great and the great ones, reading Homer and Dante in the original languages. Unfortunately his suspicion and his ill will toward the new movements led several of his younger friends (Drachmann, Schandorph, and others) to break with him outright. I do not believe the wrong was wholly on their side. I have had the opportunity to read Drachmann's letters to Arentzen right up to the break, and these letters do Drachmann honor by their warmth and sincerity, and by the attempt to hold on, in spite of everything, to the connection with his older friend. For my own part I could well notice an ill feeling in him. Every time I met him, I usually got some sarcasm. But it was only long afterwards that I learned that the reason was something I had said one evening at the Schandorphs' during one of the usual discussions about old [87] and new. Arentzen, as usual, went violently at the younger men. I had then said that when he rejected the new gods they believed in, it was at any rate not be-

cause he himself believed in the old gods. The remark must have been reported to him in distorted form; for it said only what was true, and what in earlier days he would have acknowledged himself. But now his romanticism, which earlier could unroll a background full of intimations for a younger man, led him to defend orthodoxy and reaction. It pained me, as it did the others, to be estranged from him. In all of us, however, the good memories have continued to prevail. In the last year Drachmann lived, he and I had the plan of publishing a portrait of him with contributions from a series of his former friends. Drachmann was to write a long introductory poem. The plan proved for various reasons impracticable. I must content myself with expressing in these memoirs my great gratitude toward the teacher of my youth and the friend of my manhood. —

In literary and poetic respects my youth fell between a period that can be described as the end of the Golden Age and a new period whose signature I am not able to give in brief. When I think back on literary events that made an impression on me during my school years, it is “Hjortens Flugt,” Bjørnson’s short stories, and Kaalund’s “Et Foraar” that especially come up for me. “Hjortens Flugt” came as a fresh greeting from the land of poetry, taught us that poetry was not something merely handed down from the past, but that it can constantly open new springs. It took on a special interest for me because from my childhood on I had gone about in the part of South Zealand where the action took place. I could fill in its fresh pictures of nature with my memories, and conversely an increased [88] poetic luster came over the summer stays down there when I could people the countryside with the figures and events of the poem. It made a melancholy impression on me when some years later I met Christian Winther in Paris during my stay there. He was old and decrepit, and at the Café de la Régence the waiters amused themselves over him when he came shuffling in and asked for his sugar water. It was probably not of his own good will that he made this journey to Paris; it was his wife and daughter who wanted to go out and enjoy themselves. Life and enthusiasm came over him only when he told of how he had been on

the point of going blind, but had been saved by an operation, and how now the world's glory in colors and forms had again become accessible to him. As my journey home drew near, I promised to see to something for him in Copenhagen and therefore went up to the house where he lived. Outside his and his family's rooms there was an open entrance hall, and when I came into it, I heard, before I knocked, his voice inside. He was speaking with much emotion to a person in there, and I heard him say: "I think that when I now show you that I have confidence in you, then" A family scene was evidently going on in there, and I would rather have slipped away. But I had asked for them from the porter's wife, so it could easily be learned that someone had been at the door. I then took a few firm steps and knocked. A little later he came out in dressing gown and slippers and with tears in his eyes and led me over into a room on the other side of the corridor, where we talked together and where I was told what I was to do for him. — Poor Folmer Sanger had had his wings clipped and could not now himself follow the advice he had given to "him who has sorrow in his heart." —

Kaalund's "Foraar" I borrowed in my last school year from Kr. Arentzen and copied out many of the poems. I used at that time to copy out poems I was fond of, and thereby often learned them by heart. It amused me on walks to test whether I could bring them back. Kaalund's nature poems I was especially fond of and still read with pleasure. Him I came to know through Arentzen and Schandorph. More than the cheerful and fresh, what stood out in his personality was the enthusiastic, the pathetic, in part the sentimental. I have had good conversations with him and was glad of a visit he and his wife paid me one summer day in Øverrød. Here he made an attempt to convert me to his religion, which was a poetic theism; but he did not get the better of my Spinozism. It was at the time when he was having his poetic tournament with Schandorph, and I do not forget a day I met him as he came straight from the railway station and was on his way to the printer's with a new contribution. His tall, lean figure with a face that could recall Don Quixote could not but attract attention, apart from the great cloak he was wearing. He embraced me on the spot, led me into a café, ordered two glasses of port, and now declaimed to me (and the whole pub-

lic) with much pathos his new poem, while the cloak flapped under his violent movements of the arms. — Better than his poems to Schandorph, I think, is his poem to Drachmann.

With greater poetic gift than Arentzen, he lacked the latter's fullness of knowledge and critical sharpness. But like Arentzen he marks a stage where romanticism lived on in the mind after its time of flowering was over, and where a polemical attitude often asserted itself toward the new that would take the place of the old. —

Bjørnson I came to know personally only at a later time and therefore postpone speaking of my relation to him.

Of my relation to what is usually called "the Movement of the Seventies" I have had occasion to speak in a "Tilbageblik" I wrote in "Tilskueren" (1913) on the occasion of my 70th birthday. I have nothing essential to add to that statement. I still maintain that "the Movement" was predominantly literary, — [90] that scientifically and philosophically seen it was very superficial, — and that it had more eye for what had to fall before criticism than for what keeps its significance, and for the new possibilities of positive value. For my part the main thing was that I had enough to do in getting firm ground under my feet in the domain where I was personally to work. In the middle of the '70s I had arrived at what one could call a critical positivism (and what I have somewhere, from another standpoint, called a critical monism). It constantly set me new tasks that I had not been able to see beforehand, but that gave me constant work. I had, as I have said in the "Tilbageblik," a thread to spin further on, whether the current of the time went in one direction or the other. The fluctuations of literature, which modern literary historians believe they can follow from decade to decade, so that each decade gets its characterization, I have not gone along with, and I have not really been able to trace these rhythms in the young generation I have had to do with either. But then I am probably not fine enough in my senses.

Georg Brandes and I had been opponents in the controversy over faith and knowledge. Later we often met in Troels Lund's father's house. When, together

with his brother, he had founded the journal “*det nittende Aarhundrede*,” I became a contributor and thereby came into a closer connection with him, very beneficial for me.

He invited me one evening after he had married, and he and his wife also visited my home. I have always followed him with admiration in his works of literary criticism. For me, as for so many others, he has opened new poetic and literary worlds, and by his power of searching characterization and analysis he has thrown light on so many of the great figures of literature. I felt myself very different from him in temperament. I took everything more heavily and more awkwardly, and I lacked the self-confidence that is the condition of bold action. What I have been able to accomplish is owed to long and unflagging work, and [91] my tasks lay further from the great public. Moreover, I have generally held the view that what there is to change or get rid of in the world of thought or of society can only be recognized when the right thing is found. It is difficult to find the right thing, but when it is found, it becomes clear what the false is. And the forms in which men’s need for support and footing in life finds rest can be changed only when this need itself changes; but such change takes place very slowly if it is to be thorough. Here too it is truth that shows what is false, the positive that grounds the negative. As Spinoza says: truth bears witness both to itself and to untruth (*verum est index sui et falsi*). And Comte maintained that one only displaces what one replaces. This way of looking at things meant that I stood differently from Brandes toward religious and moral polemics. But his criticism has in many ways benefited my work, since in many it awakened a need for further orientation in the domain of thought. I have, to be sure, seen in not a few cases how the view arose that it was enough to have bold and brash opinions, without one’s needing to care that philosophy demanded a penetrating inquiry.

What I am not least grateful to Brandes for from the time I am speaking of here, the seventies, is the advice he gave me in connection with the contributions I sent to his journal. Thus he wrote to me on 7 June 1875: “Allow me, not so much as editor as in the capacity of a sympathetic fellow striver, to put a cou-

ple of questions to you. Have you ever made the experiment of reading what you give to the press aloud to some man or other who has not been to a grammar school? Have you read it aloud to a lady who was not especially trained in philosophy? Have you put a mark at the places he or she did not understand, [92] and tried to rewrite them in other words? I dare say that you have not made this attempt. But why not?" And thereupon he complains in particular about a passage in an article I had submitted to the journal, and which was undeniably expressed in a very unpopular way. I found the complaint just; unfortunately it probably also hits much of what I have written since, although I really set myself to write as accessibly as possible. But there is, after all, a difference between philosophy and literary history, and besides, it has been my lot to develop slowly and to come late to clarity. I could have waited to write until everything could be expressed clearly (if not for those who have no prerequisites at all); it might not have harmed literature. But I have always myself learned much by trying to set forth my thoughts and the knowledge I had so far acquired. And in Brøchner I had an example of what it can lead to to wait too long to write; he often regretted that he had wanted to wait with his writings until he had completely worked through all his subjects, and when that time seemed to him to have come, he was nearly fifty, and he had grown wholly into the abstract expressions handed down from the Hegelian philosophy, and which in themselves could have done good service as short formulas during his solitary thinking. — I have, however, often been surprised later on at how wide the circles are that many of my books have reached.

When in the year 1876 I had published my little book "Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik," to which I shall return in another connection, Brandes wrote to me (24 Oct. 1876): "You are, although on another basis, the 'transfigured' Brøchner, and it would certainly have been a great joy to Brøchner if he had lived to see this book of yours. I also congratulate you on the form of your book. You have gained extraordinarily here in freedom and mobility. You once said a despondent word to me about the dryness of your style, in which you were far too severe on [93] yourself There is in my opinion still too little temperament in your style;

you do not yet write sufficiently with your whole personality, the whole human being. But you are on the way to doing so.” — Brandes, by the way, recalls in this letter the inscription on the papers of the Committee of Public Safety: “Liberté, Egalité, Fraternité, ou la mort!” — and he thinks that I have hardly ever been so young that I could have said this. In that he is quite right. Yet it grated a little on my ears when he added: “You must have been born to a certain degree old.” Of himself he then says: “I am afraid that I was once very young.” —

The relation in which I had come to stand to Brandes was to me a source of much joy and encouragement. After Brøchner’s death I felt lonely, and since Brandes combined with his great artistic sense an understanding of philosophical inquiries, his letters were always welcome to me. Some years later he wrote to me from Berlin: “I am very glad to be on such friendly terms with you; there is nothing I would rather do than live in brotherly understanding with all my contemporaries in the North who inquire honestly.” What was here expressed so warmly found a full echo on my side. And this feeling did not disappear in me even when it was put to the test some years later by a serious and sharp opposition between our views on an essential point.

III

- [94] In the autumn of 1874 I gave a lecture on “Introduction to Philosophy”, in which I set out in brief the view of the philosophical problems and of the relation between them that had now become settled in me. And after that my authorship proper began, as I now set myself the task of treating the individual problems each by itself. The short program I had given in the lecture mentioned naturally had to undergo many changes when it was worked out in detail, and there was great work to do in the individual fields. I can divide my work in the following 40 years into three periods. From 1875 to 1887 it turned on psychology and ethics in the first place, from 1887–1895 on the history of philosophy, and after 1895 it is philosophy of religion and theory of knowledge that have especially laid claim on me. As the position of philosophy still stands, it is of some importance that these different fields, which in so many ways overlap one another, can be treated by the same person. It is not certain that this will always be possible, and the problems of philosophy would then present themselves in more difficult forms. We must at all times take up our work as the questions present themselves to us; we must only not forget that questions as well as answers can take on a different character at different times. Yet I cannot conceive of philosophy without a striving to gather human thought under certain general points of view. And this striving is prepared within the individual sciences, the more these themselves
- [95] seek to become conscious of their guiding ideas. There is then always a task for philosophy as a comparative science.

The first tasks that presented themselves to me were: to write an ethics on purely human presuppositions, and to work out a psychology by which the study

of human mental life, which had not been cultivated here at home since Sibbern's time, could be taken up again. From this time on I felt my work more and more as a continuation of Sibbern's, or rather, I wished that it could be regarded so. However much I owed Rasmus Nielsen and Brøchner, I saw nevertheless that one had to go other ways, ways that "old Sibbern" had traveled over long stretches, although a romantic-speculative background had at many points determined the light in which he saw the questions.

In the autumn of 1876 I published a little work "Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik". I sought here to show that there is a purely human foundation for the conduct of life, which is given with the possibility that man can bow to a law that points beyond the individual moments and beyond the individual persons. Although I believe that I got some way forward in clarity with that work, and that the analysis of the concept of authority in particular may still have some interest, there remained an indefiniteness, connected with the fact that I did not yet distinguish between the motive that leads us to call actions good or evil, and which I have later called the motive of valuation, and the motive that in the individual special cases gets us to satisfy the demand of the motive of valuation, and which I have later called the motive of action. When I became fully clear about this distinction, which is so often overlooked, I could proceed to the working out of a full ethics. But that happened only several years later.

For the time being I became absorbed in psychological studies, and from the autumn of 1876 on I treated every year one section or another of psychology in my lectures as privatdocent. Gradually a considerable circle of listeners gathered around these lectures, so that from the little room in which I had begun I had to [96] move to the larger, and at last to the largest rooms at the University. Now and then, for variety, I lectured on subjects from the history of philosophy, thus on Spinoza, on the occasion of the bicentenary of his death. This lecture I worked up into a little popular work, which came out in the autumn of 1877.

I remember the winter of 1876–77 as an especially good time for work. But there is sadness bound up with this memory, for it was the last winter my wife lived. Traces of the chlorosis of her young days came out again and again, and

there appeared, as the doctor, my friend Julius Petersen, later told me, symptoms of anemia. I believe that already in the autumn she had had forebodings of what lay ahead. One fine October day we had gone out to Øverød to rent a little summer apartment for the next summer. After that was seen to, we walked in Geel Skov, and the expression on her face when, sitting on a tree stump, she looked down over Søllerød Sø toward the little house we were to live in, later stood for me as the sign of a sad thought that she perhaps would not come to live there. It is above all this remembered image that I have kept from her later years, the one I most return to. At New Year she gave birth to a son, and after that came a bad phlebitis, which was however healed, so that she had a good time in the early spring. But then the decline began, with increasing weakness and exhaustion. And then came the day when the doctor told me that there was no hope. A pernicious anemia had developed.

We lived in a little house by St. Jørgens Sø. In front of the house there was a little garden; then came an embankment, over which one saw the clear lake and in the background the towers of Copenhagen. The scene stands clearly before me in the glow of the light nights, with the wondrous contrast between the glorious nature outside and the struggle with death that was fought inside. Day [97] and night not only glided into one another out there, but also merged into one in there under the anxious strain. And in the same way, in the sick woman, clear consciousness alternated with sinking into unconsciousness. In one of the clear moments I came out with a hint that I was aware of what lay ahead, and it turned out that she too was clear about it. I tried to tell her all that she had been to me, and how poor a return I had made. She was not afraid to die — “but it is so early, though!” — I asked her whether she did not want to speak with a priest, but she would rather keep to what we had so often talked about, and what lay at the root of the poetry we had both set highest. She asked me to recite Paludan-Müller’s “Nattevagt”, one of our favorite poems, and I then whispered it into her ear. And then she slipped away, away from me and my two little boys. In the last days she lay in fantasies that did not seem to be distressing. One of her last exclamations was: “Lift me up into the boat!” — And the boat glided slowly away, out into the

great sea. Early one morning (12 June 1877) I closed her eyes. — —

Some days later I moved out to the little house by Søllerød Sø. The summer went in work on the psychology, a work that in the years now following was a great help to me. It is good in times such as those that had now come over me that there is always a piece of work lying and waiting. Otherwise emptiness threatens. Besides, it was a refreshment to me to roam about in Rude Skov, which only now I really came to know. Here I spent the afternoons. Often I walked to Hørsholm and had supper and then wandered home through the forest.

The support I had in my mother and my brothers and sisters made it possible for me to live with my two little boys without having any “lady in the house”, which I have always dreaded. It has perhaps not been good in all respects for the sons that the comfort only a woman can bring to a home was lacking. But it could not be otherwise.

In the following years I had special reason to appreciate my friends, and I [98] won new ones. Skovgaard had become an assistant master in Nykøbing paa Falster, and I liked to visit him once a year. Julius Petersen and his wife I was with even more than before. I have always, not least in times of sorrow, found a heartfelt sympathy with them, and have myself also taken part in their fortunes. It was not always easy to get along with Julius. Precisely because he was so fond of me, it was a sorrow to him, to which he could often give a violent and provocative expression, when there was disagreement between us, e.g. in literary or political questions. Perhaps it also irritated him that there was in my nature a striving for continuity and harmony that he did not understand, because he also did not understand how much it could cost me to keep this striving up in spite of heaviness and torpor. I believe that I understood him better than he understood me. His wife Oliva had been my wife’s friend, and it was a comfort to me to talk with her about the past. When, as could happen, a hitch came in the line between Julius and me, she stepped in as mediator. It could happen that I met her on her way to me when I myself was on my way to Julius after a little clash that might threaten to let grass grow on the path. She understood her husband as no one else did and held fast to him through all his swings, even the most violent.

Steady and faithful she was in her ways, and he always came back to her, always understanding better what she was for him. She saw clearly that besides his practice, which satisfied his humane mind but could often wear too hard on him, it was a vital necessity for him to work as a scholar and a writer, and it did him no good to resist; he always had to go back to the desk and continue his works on the history of medicine, works that led to his appointment in this subject at the University and gave him well-deserved standing. After Oliva's death he broke down.

[99] What these two people have been to me, I keep in grateful remembrance. And their children, a row of able and aspiring people, keep this memory alive in me in the finest way through the kindness they show on every occasion to their old Uncle, as they have called me since they were small.

With Troels Lund and with Heegaard too I had good support in these years, and to these two homes I often went when I needed a pleasant and interesting evening.

In remembering the years after my wife's death I also think with gratitude of how Herman and Anna Trier opened their home to me at this time. His steady and calm nature and his pedagogical interest, which also led him to interest in and understanding of philosophy, made association with him beneficial and strengthening. And Anna Trier's lively, enthusiastic, and faithful nature brought me a refreshment and an encouragement that I could well need in those years. She came from a Grundtvigian circle, but now entered with an open mind into circles where quite other thoughts prevailed than those she had grown up with, and she did not lose her originality and boldness. For her the only thing that mattered was that she felt herself before something truly human. Illness broke her strength early, and her sudden death (in the summer of 1888) was a heartfelt grief to me. Again something beautiful and bright had gone out of my world. —

My psychological studies went their way through all this. In the journal "Nær og Fjern" I published (February 1878) an essay "Om Erindring", in which some of the basic ideas of my Psychology, which came out later (1882), were expressed

in popular form. The view of human mental life to which my studies led me had partly come about through criticism of the presuppositions of English “association psychology”. This school has done psychology great service by demanding exact analysis of each single mental phenomenon and by rejecting the spiritualistic appeal to “the essence of the soul” at every difficult point. But it could not see the forest for the trees, and in particular did not see that in all memory an inner connection makes itself known, a belonging together of all mental elements with one another. I tried to follow this connection right from the simplest sensations to the highest thoughts and decisions. In addition there appears in the essay mentioned a main point of my psychological research, namely the way in which the study of morbid states throws light on the general nature of mental life, inasmuch as states of dissolution bear witness to the significance that collectedness and concentration can have for the persistence of mental life. [100]

In the same journal I published that same year a series of reviews, in which my ethical view was brought out through criticism of various works. First among these stands a critique of Bishop Martensen’s *Ethics* running through several numbers (July 1878). It was a settling of accounts with theological ethics, especially with the “modern Christianity” about which, after much inner work, I had come to clarity for my own part. Martensen was a characteristic representative of this modern Christianity, in that, with all his combination of speculation, aestheticizing, and edification, he nevertheless claimed to stand in continuous connection with original Christianity. Kierkegaard had protested against his attempt to set up Bishop Mynster as a Christian witness to the truth, an attempt that overlooked the opposition between primitive-Christian and modern-Christian ethics. Since one of my main tasks was to discuss the possibility of an ethics built on purely human ground, it was bound to be of interest to me that there was a spirited exposition from an opposite standpoint. Martensen’s attempt to work Christianity and humanity together appears in a characteristic way in his criticism of Augustine’s famous sentence about the virtues of the heathen as splendid vices. He instructs the old Church Father that the pagan virtues were not vices, but splendid fragments, which only through Christianity could be given a har- [101]

monious composition. Not only a Church Father, an apostle too is corrected by the Bishop. When Paul advises against marriage because the one thing needful is to live in expectation of Christ's return, he is now told that one should certainly hold fast to this expectation, but that one must not therefore give up living a healthy and abundant human life with enjoyment of all the goods of culture. The heavenly existence is only the conclusion of a great process of development. It is in reliance on this view that the author of the "kristelige Etik" goes through all human relations in society and state, in theater and school (e.g. orthography!) in order to arrange them under what is for him the fundamental Christian view. It follows of itself that he thereby goes far outside the domain that can be illuminated from the New Testament, whose ethics is borne throughout by the great expectation, whose fulfilment Martensen really could not wish to come too soon, since otherwise there would be no time for the cultural development that was to be crowned with the "Second Coming". — In spite of his defense of the heathen, Martensen nevertheless declares that when men like Kant, Lessing, and Schiller were not believing Christians, it came from ill will and loathing of the holy! — Here the old theological barbarism broke through.

This critique of Martensen won much approval round about. There were many older scholars, authors, and politicians who had been annoyed at the Bishop's attempt to let theological points of view dominate science and art, the life of the state and of society, and who now — in all quietness — expressed their sympathy. Among them were e.g. Madvig and Bille.

Some years later I again reviewed (in "Ude og Hjemme" 1882) a book by Martensen, his "Jacob Böhme". It was the subject that interested me. It amused me to demonstrate how little the profound and independent-minded mystic would [102] have put up with being shut up within the bounds the Bishop wanted to set between "Christian" and "pagan" thinking. — At that time I often met the historian Caspar Paludan-Müller at the University, as we lectured at the same hour. When at his wish I had sent him my review, he said in his peculiar decided way: "Well, your opinion is really that the whole book is nonsense. I hold to what my father said, that faith is a matter of the will and that one should not speculate about

it.” And a little later he added: “Besides, I would advise you against attacking Martensen so often; he could whisper something in the King’s ear, and then you will not become professor!” — This warning was not needed, since I had now got said what I wanted to say, and I was now wholly occupied with developing and grounding my own views. — In his “Levned” Martensen mentions that his later writings were attacked from the side of the “purely negative tendency”. I assume that I too have here come under the concept of “the purely negative”. I myself felt more and more positive, the more the human in its manifold types and forms dawned on me. —

But I have strayed from the year 1878. — In “Nær og Fjern” (August 1878) I wrote a review of Heegaard’s book “Om Intolerance”. This book, under evident and strong influence from Kierkegaard, set out to show that a faith or view of life can only appear in the form of personal conviction. Scientific decision of the highest questions is impossible, and it is no use appealing to authority, for faith in an authority is also subjective conviction. The differences between personalities make common formulas that should fit everyone impossible. All through life the individual has only himself to deal with. Social life concerns only external relations and stands as a coercive, hostile power. Regarding the religious questions, of which immortality especially lies close to the author’s heart, it is stated that we do not get beyond mere possibilities. We live on possibilities! And in the strict school of possibilities the very best in our nature can be developed: nobility [103] in ways of thinking, and conciliatoriness toward those who think otherwise.

Against this way of looking at things I maintained that if there is no common ground at all to build on, all negotiation between different views of life is impossible. And the common ground must in the end be science. We demand of every view of life that we are to respect that it agree with itself, display inner consistency. Already here, in pure logic, there is a common ground. But besides, we cannot have respect for a view of life when it does not bear witness to an honest endeavor to apply and think through the knowledge that is available. A view of life that cares nothing at all for natural science and historical criticism cannot gain significance beyond a quite definite circle. — I did not emphasize, as

I would now, that every view of life comes into being under definite inner and outer conditions and must therefore become an object of psychological and historical investigation. But I showed the impossibility, for one who would develop into a real personality, of isolating himself from society, and also from acting on society. "If the author," I said, "had only made clear to himself what kind of feeling it was that brought him to write down the fine and energetic statements in his book, he would know from personal experience that the ethical demand on the personality includes the endeavor for a higher and nobler development of life in society."

I set great store by my personal friendship with Heegaard. He was one of the few with whom I could then discuss philosophical subjects, and it was a pleasure to associate with him in the good working years he had after he had become professor. His horizon widened, and his sense for problems sharpened. The best he gave at the University was probably the course he held for the young students [104] at the end of the seventies. He treated here the concept of development and its history, and besides often gave himself in his lectures to personal statements on the significance and necessity of independent conviction. Many of his listeners from these years have kept a fine and distinctive memory of him. Unfortunately his good working years were not to last long. —

I wrote yet another review the same year and in the same journal ("Nær og Fjern". Sept. 1878). After Sibbern's death (1872) his moral philosophy had been published, and I then used the occasion to give a characterization of my old teacher, whom I had come to value highly over the years. This review was a preliminary study for a fuller characterization of Sibbern, which I wrote in "Tilskueren" (1885) on the occasion of the centenary of his birth, and which is reprinted in the first volume of my *Mindre Arbejder*.

When I have also mentioned an essay on philosophy in Sweden, in the form of a review of Axel Nyblæus' work "Den filosofiska Forskningen i Sverige" (*Nordisk Tidsskrift*, utg. af Letterstedske föreningen 1879), I have named the most important literary works from my hand at the end of the seventies. —

At the end of 1879, at the urging of Madvig and Heegaard, I submitted an

application for a lectureship, which was also recommended by the faculty. It was not only on this occasion that Madvig showed interest in me. I had first met him when, as inspector of education, he made a visitation at a school I taught in, and I have also had him as censor when I examined in Greek for the Artium. Madvig took a great interest in philosophy, and at a festive gathering on the occasion of his having been a member of the Royal Danish Academy of Sciences for 50 years, he gave a survey of his own philosophy, which, however, since I was not then a member myself, I know only through a summary written down by Fausbøll. His thoughts went generally in the direction of the critical philosophy, [105] concluding by way of analogy in an atmospheric “pantheism”, with a firm holding to the doctrine of causality, in the domain of the will too. He sympathized with the theory of evolution, and when I had (1874) given a talk in the Students’ Union on “Darwinismen og Filosofien” (printed in “Nær og Fjern”), he spoke very warmly of it and said that it seemed to him that the idea of an ascending development was far more appealing than the doctrine of a fall. He added with a sly smile: “But I dare not say it to my daughters!” These excellent ladies were in fact very orthodox, and the learned father was very considerate. Some years later I proposed to him that he be a co-sponsor of a collection of contributions to a statue of Spinoza in The Hague, on the occasion of the bicentenary of Spinoza’s death. Madvig at first had misgivings, also out of “consideration for his home”, but overcame them, and he raised a considerable sum, so that the contribution from Denmark to the international undertaking became relatively large. With my critique of Martensen’s Ethics he sympathized greatly, and he expressed to me in warm words his interest in the way I had illuminated theology’s attempt to dominate the whole of life. From these (and several other) different conversations with the great philologist I had formed an idea of his relation to religion and church. But when, many years after his death, his notes on philosophical and religious subjects were published, I was nevertheless surprised at the sharpness with which he expressed himself about the dogmas and the church. In the address given over him by Paulli the Younger in Frue Kirke he was honored as a constant churchgoer (“Sunday after Sunday he sat here in the church” etc.); but

in the hours of his quiet reflection he had written that the sermon with its obscurities and crooked conclusions spoiled for him the elevated mood that organ playing and singing had put him in! — His philosophical stray thoughts often
 [106] point in a direction I sympathize with. — In the year 1878 Madvig obtained for me two years' support from the newly founded Carlsberg Foundation for preliminary work on my Psychology. And it was under his auspices that I applied to have my privatdocentship replaced by a permanent lectureship. The Minister of Education (Kultusminister) Fischer tracked down an unused sum in his budget, and on 11 March 1880 I received my appointment as lecturer in philosophy.¹⁾ I now gave up most of my school hours and set to work in earnest on the writing of my Psychology. After I had once more gone through the subject in a series of lectures over two semesters, the book came out in the autumn of 1882.

The main idea around which it moves, or rather the hypothesis it seeks to ground and confirm, is this: that the fundamental law of mental life, or of the life of consciousness, in which its essence shows itself, is synthesis, combining activity. This hypothesis is grounded partly by investigating the passage of the life of consciousness into the unconscious, and conversely, its awakening out of it, partly by analysis of important mental phenomena and processes (memory, comparison, grief, doubt, decision). And the hypothesis is sought to be confirmed through investigation of the conditions of sensation, as Fechner and the experimental psychology founded by him illuminate them; further through investigation of the association of ideas, of the activity of imagination, of the main forms of the life of feeling, and of the stages of the life of the will. If the law named is the fundamental law of mental life, the will, in the widest sense of the
 [107] word, becomes its proper, central expression, since, as long as mental life lasts,

¹⁾In a letter to Hans Skovgaard of 17 April 1880 I say on the occasion of my appointment as lecturer: "I am of course very glad of the prospects I have thereby gained of continued work in the field where I most wish to work. But on the other hand the feeling of responsibility also came up, and still more the feeling of the inadequacy of my abilities in relation to what one ought to demand of a teacher of philosophy. Until now my striving has been private, personal It was from the start not at all my intention to want to be an official scholar. I only wanted to sit quite still and read what I was interested in knowing. And now step by step it has come to this. Whether I would not have become happier if I had entered a more practical occupation is a question I sometimes raise. Only at certain times ... do I answer it with no."

there is work to be done to hold together a more or less full content. The feelings are symptoms of this will, and knowledge is at first its servant, later perhaps its master. I thus attach myself most nearly to so-called voluntarism. This standpoint is carried through with greater consistency in the later editions, but lay decidedly and clearly at the base of the first edition. The usual threefold division (knowledge — feeling — will) is thus here first traced back to a unity, or rather to a whole.

That this book has become so widespread that I, if I wanted to boast, could well say that it is spread over the whole world, can be explained by several causes. Its guiding idea was, when the book came out, not a common one. One usually started from spiritualistic or materialistic hypotheses. With me it had, as I have indicated in the foregoing, developed step by step, right from the Kierkegaard studies of my early youth, through my Kant studies, to studies of the sick mental life in its relation to the healthy. To this came the fact that this main idea was sought to be illuminated by contributions from all the different sources of psychological knowledge (natural science, self-observation, history of culture and of literature). No single person can master all these sources; there are really many psychologies; all the more significance it can then have to begin with a well-grounded hypothesis and seek contributions from the various sides to illuminate it. Finally, it happens in a small country that a philosophical author is obliged to gather his thoughts in as easily accessible a form as possible, since the number of experts is small. Be that as it may, the book has been translated into many languages (German, French, English, Spanish, Italian, Polish, Russian, Finnish, Japanese) and it has brought me friendly approaches from the most varied people around the world. It was a special pleasure to me that the psychopathologist Pierre Janet wrote a preface to the French edition; precisely on account of the significance that a comparison between sick and healthy mental life had had for the development of the book's underlying hypothesis, it was interesting to me that it came out in a major language under the aegis of an eminent psychopathologist. [108]

I am myself aware of the book's shortcomings (although I probably do not know them all). Its time is perhaps now past. But I am sure that its main ideas

will in some form or other continue to assert themselves. There will probably arise a greater opposition between the different methods in psychology. One will be obliged not only, like most experimental psychologists (who often claim to be the only proper psychologists), to start from the relatively simple mental phenomena that can be produced by experiment, but also to start from observation, description, and analysis of the phenomena of complex mental life, and from there to seek back to the simpler and more easily unraveled ones. And sociological psychology, especially the psychology of culture and of literature, will also more and more mark out an independent direction. But efforts will always arise anew to find basic mental forms that satisfy all these points of view. Such efforts will probably be harder to carry through than it was when I worked out my *Psychology* in the years 1876–1882.

For my teaching at the University the psychological way of looking at things in which I had become practiced, and the psychological sense and interest I believe I possess, were of great importance. Here, in face of the intellectual movements of the time, was given a standpoint that could meet the different tendencies with intellectual sympathy, while it held open the concluding epistemological and ethical questions. My old teacher Sibbern has said that just as for the botanist there are no weeds, so for the psychologist there is nothing in the stirrings of the life of the spirit that cannot become an object of interest and observation. Before [109] we can judge the intellectual or moral value of a spiritual phenomenon, we must surely know it and understand it, preferably from within. All too often one goes the opposite way and stamps as stupidity or sin what has its natural root in the coherence of life and perhaps, if it were understood rightly and therefore taken rightly, could grow up into the world of truth and goodness.

The new tendency in literature that developed in the seventies collided more and more sharply with the representatives of the older tendency. The most violent clash was the so-called literary New Year feud of 1879–80, provoked by a powerful polemical poem against Ploug by Schandorph. The dispute soon came

to a standstill. I had no reason to take part in it, although I was indignant at seeing the conduct of the old champion of liberty Ploug toward the new tendencies in literature and in politics. Both these tendencies came for a time to run side by side, as the men of the new literature cherished sympathy for the political Left. Ploug then also christened the new literary tendency “the literary Left” and doubtless believed he was thereby dealing it a mighty blow. But the name was accepted, and for the time being collaboration came about in various ways between the two tendencies.

On the occasion of this alliance I carried on a correspondence with my friend Victor Pingel. It was partly at Arentzen’s, partly at Julius Petersen’s, that I had come into contact with this fine, pure, idealistic man. He lived like a hermit for his studies, which, apart from his proper field, classical philology, extended over various domains of nature, especially geology. He had been strongly taken with the new tendencies, which he understood from his ideal standpoint. What struck everyone who knew Pingel was the purity of his mind. Arentzen once said: “Pingel — he is like clean linen on a Sunday morning!” But behind his hermit ways there was a smoldering passion that broke out into flame, as indignation at the fanatical opposition the new tendencies met had an inflaming effect. Later, as is well known, he threw himself with passion into political life. For the time being he set himself a more theoretical task, namely to write a program that should gather the literary, scientific, and political strivings for freedom under common points of view. From a letter from Pingel from the beginning of 1880 I see that I criticized this program. Partly I feared that party combination would hamper individual development, and partly I thought that the diverse strivings could be brought under the same heading only in an artificial way. I was not glad to be enrolled and to take others’ sins upon me besides my own. I seemed to myself too unfinished in my own field to be able to come forward with proclamations. Only step by step could I work my way forward. [110]

Pingel replies (26 March 1880) that as a younger man he had been bent on complete isolation and had torn himself out of it only with great difficulty. He thought that since a general European movement had now reached us, had been

met with ill will by a political tendency that believed it could monopolize the whole of intellectual life, and since that movement had obtained a sort of alliance with this party's opponents, the nature of the new tendency must be stated unreservedly and in a generally understandable way. "I believe, dear Høffding, that both you and Lange and Heegaard and perhaps almost all our younger scholars overestimate the significance of individual independence and misjudge party cohesion as a necessary condition for development." — To my remark that Drachmann's and Schandorph's poems bear no particular trace of the world-view that Pingel had set up as the common foundation of the tendency, Pingel replies that this only shows that these poets have not gone into the depths, have not caught sight of "what underlies the age". —

[111] Although I thus did not think that the political, scientific, and poetic movement of the seventies could be brought under a common metaphysical formula, I had nevertheless followed the political struggle from the beginning of the seventies with keen interest. It presented two sides, a struggle on the part of democracy for influence on the government of the country, and a struggle over the defense question, especially the fortification of Copenhagen. I stood divided in this struggle, as my sympathy was more and more on the side of democracy as far as the purely political is concerned, while I was convinced, as I am to this day, that a vigorous, up-to-date, and proportionate development of the defense system is a condition of life for a people that would maintain its material and spiritual independence, — its honor. But it became clearer and clearer to me that a cause like the defense question could not be carried through except with the people's support through its lawful representation. In a state of emergency it can be defended to act against the law, because something is at stake that is more than the law, the very existence of the people. But no state of emergency was at hand, at most dangers and threatening possibilities. Experience would therefore not be able to prove the justification of a defense arrangement carried through in defiance of the expressed will of the people. One ought in any case to try whether responsibility would not lead the leading men of the Left to see the matter differently when the government was entrusted to them. When the Estrup ministry

in the spring of 1877 resorted to the desperate expedient of issuing a provisional finance law, this step, which at once offended my sense of justice and stood for me as a great stupidity, made me a man of the Left, and in the following years I voted and spoke for the opposition's candidates.

A friend I had won in these years did much for my increased interest in politics. One day in the winter of 1879–80 the banker Laurids Bing came up to see me. I had been his teacher in Maribo's School, and later I had met him in the "Nationaløkonomisk Forening", of which I was a member and had even helped to found. He came to propose that I give some popular lectures on philosophy [112] in his home for a small circle. He and his wife soon became my good friends, and since we lived near each other in Frederiksberg, I often went over to them for a good conversation, besides giving my little lectures for several winters on Wednesday evenings. Laurids Bing was an eager democrat and took a large part in the political stir. Together with him I took part in the winter of 1882–83 in some meetings held in the house of Christopher Hage, later a minister of the Left, by a circle that consisted of what were then called liberal men of the Right, and that sought understanding and collaboration with the Left. Among those present were Supreme Court Justice Nyholm, presiding judge Madvig, Professors Deuntzer and Falbe Hansen, the Supreme Court advocates Frederik Salomon and Octavius Hansen, and others. These meetings led to the formation of the Liberal Voters' Association in Frederiksberg, the first sign that the Right did not hold sole power in Copenhagen and its environs. Its candidate was Supreme Court Justice Nyholm. He was elected in the summer of 1884. On this occasion I was one of his speaking nominators, and soon after I became chairman of the Liberal Voters' Association in Frederiksberg, to which liberal men of the Right, men of the Left, and Social Democrats belonged in brotherly union. On this occasion I came to know several worthy and able workmen.

A politician I never became. There was always much that repelled me in politicians by trade. In their eager opposition to the Right, the Left also attacked the University, because they believed that all university teachers must be men of the Right. They had even wanted to deny men like Vilh. Thomsen, Zeuthen,

and Julius Lange appointment. I remember a conversation with Hørup in which he confided to me that he looked with irony on scholarly work, insofar as no politics could be got out of it: "Come down to the market, for that is where we do business!" He added, however, in his good nature, that I presumably also took [113] his political activity humorously. This, however, was by no means the case. Later on, when I had become professor, they wanted me to stand for the Folketing in Roskilde, and a deputation came to me from down there. I also had a meeting with Berg and Hørup in the former's chairman's room in Christiansborg Palace. Sitting between them, I was worked on for a good hour. But it did no good. On this occasion Hørup said, when I had spoken of my university work not leaving me time for political work, that once I had made my lecture I could find time enough. So: just turn the pile over! Besides, it was said that I need not always attend, so long as I attended for the vote! — These arguments had the opposite effect of the one intended.

In the political movement of the following period I took part, as will be mentioned later, really only within my own constituency and in the Students' Society. I often met Hørup at this time and had occasion to observe his remarkable union, or rather rhythmic alternation, of phlegm and skepticism on the one side, fanatical passion on the other. His political program really aimed at the possession of power, the power of government, as the most important thing; then one could talk afterward about what it should be used for. He took no interest in particular special social tasks. A brilliant journalist he was. Many of his articles were unsurpassable, at least when one had the whole definite, given situation present to mind. A masterly speech, and one characteristic of him, he gave at the Constitution Day festival on Frederiksberg Exerцерplads in 1884. His skepticism about the state's ability to solve social questions found expression here in an apt image: One year the forest would not come into leaf. A commission was then set up by the state to see what could be done. It inspected the forest, and when the first green leaves appeared, it said: "That color is good; we adopt it!" — When things [114] thus grow forth of themselves, there is surely, by the way, not even any reason to fight over power — the power to set up commissions! But a certain mystical

faith that there is something in the world that grows “of itself” Hørup did have. — I once said to him that in my opinion he was more journalist than politician. He answered: “Yes, you can believe it is fun to be in on things behind the scenes.”

Besides the literary and the political world there was around the year 1880 yet another world I came into contact with. One evening I was invited to a gathering at the wood engraver Hendriksen’s, where there was to be talk of founding an association that should consist of artists and authors. Taking part in the gathering were Georg and Edvard Brandes, Drachmann, Schandorph, Krøyer, Zahrtmann, Viggo Johansen, and others. It became an enjoyable evening, especially on account of Zahrtmann’s merriment and inexhaustible humor. Sometimes we lay back in our chairs with laughter. But we got our purpose achieved, an association of artists and authors who sympathized with the new tendencies in art and literature. The majority of the association’s members were painters, especially of the group that had been influenced by modern French art. There was to be a gathering every month in the winter, and there was the draconian rule that the meeting should be held each time in a new place. The result was that we sometimes came to taverns that would otherwise have remained unknown to most of us. But the association did not last so long that we needed to resort to repetitions. The meetings were to be arranged by the members in turn, two each time, in alphabetical order, and the association was therefore called “Bogstaveligheden”, which did not, however, imply that radical realism was to be the program. I think back with great pleasure on these gatherings. Among the painters a common love of art made itself felt, so that the whole circle rejoiced when one of the comrades had done something good. One cannot say the same of the authors, and it was indeed literary quarrels that caused the association to cease. It was refreshing to move in artists’ circles. Artists are certainly not as eloquent as authors; but through their short and quick remarks I got many a pointer toward a better understanding of what art is. I have followed this circle of artists with interest in their further development. Later tendencies I have not really been able

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to understand, and in the end I have quite stopped visiting exhibitions. Among the individual artists with whom I came into closer relations I will especially name Viggo Johansen, Valdemar Irminger, and August Jerndorff. With the last I later became related through my youngest son's marriage to his daughter. And the thought of this pure and fine human being, this enthusiastic artist's soul, this faithful friend, belongs to the best within my world of memories.

In "Bogstaveligheden" I met several times with J. P. Jacobsen, who now, after "Mogens", "Marie Grubbe", and "Niels Lyhne", was the most admired of the authors of the new age. Several years earlier (1870) I had been in contact with him. He had not then yet appeared as an author, but was known as an eager botanist. I met him one evening at Poul Kierkegaard's, who then lived in a boarding house in Studiestræde, and who had invited us so that we might make each other's acquaintance. And when a bottle of Swedish punch had then come onto the table, Kierkegaard declared that he liked us both so well that he wanted us to drink to brotherhood. That we naturally did, as in duty bound. Jacobsen read some poems aloud, which seemed to me somewhat stilted. He was very angry with Georg Brandes, who had advised against the printing of his poems. The evening went well. Jacobsen was then still fresh and strong and sparkled with wit. But it [116] turned out so unluckily that when some time later he came up to visit me (I was then still living with my parents), I had completely forgotten that we had drunk to brotherhood, and that presumably had the consequence that the visit was not repeated.

His books, especially Niels Lyhne, made on first reading a somewhat artificial impression through the many new words and turns of phrase. But it was striking how this fell away on repeated reading. His language had triumphed. It is still a delight to me to hear a piece of "Niels Lyhne" read aloud. Especially the chapters on Edele's death and on the mother's stay in Clarens are pearls so genuine that time does not touch them.

At one of the meetings of "Bogstaveligheden" Jacobsen read his masterly story "Pesten i Bergamo". This reading, which Erik Henningsen has rendered

in a drawing that is in the Frederiksborg Museum, became unforgettable for us all through the uncanny correspondence between story and reader. Jacobsen was now attacked by tuberculosis, and his face and voice, marked by death, suited in a strange way the subject he was presenting. —

In “Bogstaveligheden” Holger Drachmann was a constant guest. I knew him from Arentzen’s circle and had followed him with enthusiasm on his poet’s career. “Dæmpede Melodier” and “Sange ved Havet” still belong to my favorite poems. His unsettled course I followed at a distance, but did get the chance to give him a small helping hand once, when he was in an awkward situation. In the spring of 1878 I was visiting a friend in Lund and heard then that Drachmann was living there in hiding, after he had gone away from North Zealand with a married woman and her (and his) child. I sought him out, and I do not forget the expression of fright that came over him at someone asking for him. He did not forget me this visit, and when the next winter we met at a party in Copenhagen, he drew me into a side room, thanked me for having sought him out, and proposed brotherhood to me. The awkward situation he had been in had, by the way, a comic ending, when the lady fled from him with a Swedish doctor. — [117] This time I did not forget the brotherhood, which I also had frequent occasion to cultivate through our common circle.

Drachmann’s strength and limitation was the decidedly lyrical character of his gift. Neither as a novelist nor as a dramatist was he really in his element. “Der var engang” disappointed me greatly when I saw it; it was a series of poetic scenes, but no drama. I saw it, to be sure, only long after it first appeared, and after the excellent actors who had carried it at the first performances had passed away or had gone over to other kinds of parts. — Once Drachmann had received a state grant to make dramatic studies abroad. A good while afterward I met him at a party where Olaf Poulsen was also present. Olaf Poulsen teased him by asking when the new dramas would come for which the state had given him an advance. Drachmann snapped a little at first, but then it burst out of him: “Well, that I don’t know. But I promise you to cover the whole foyer of the Royal Theater with verse, if you wish it!”

Julius Lange did not belong to “Bogstaveligheden”. He refused to become a member, because he thought it was a party formation that was to take place. But I had already earlier become acquainted with him, especially after I had, at his request, written a review of his book “Om Kunstværdi” (“Nær og Fjern”. 1876). Later on he asked me several times to go through parts of the great book on the human figure in the history of art, particularly with regard to the psychological ideas he employed. This led, among other things, to a discussion between us, as Lange held that it was the task of art to give the typical, e.g. the typical in the human form at a given time, while I maintained that the representation of the individual and characteristic was art’s highest task. Lange appealed to Greek art, first and foremost to the Parthenon frieze. (See Lange’s letter to me of 24 January 1887). I held that the Parthenon frieze meant a great advance in individualization in relation to oriental (Asiatic) art, and that art had later (especially in modern art) gone further in the same direction. A main point for me was that only on this view does art itself appear as a characteristic form of spirit in relation to science. — It was a great joy to be Lange’s friend, to hear at first hand his original judgments and the outbursts of his humor, which did not fail him even when he was succumbing to a heart disease. —

In the first years after my wife’s death I lived in summer in the little house by Søllerød Sø, which we had been out to rent the last autumn she lived. After that I lived for a series of summers with a skipper on Vemmetofte Strand by Faxebugt. Here there were good walks, and I had only three quarters of a mile to my youngest brother, who had now succeeded my maternal uncle as tenant of Strandegaard. I now renewed the childhood memories of the glorious summer holidays I had once spent in this region.

One summer I made, with three young students, my former pupils, and two ladies, the one a sister of one of the students, the other her friend, a glorious sailing trip to Møen. We hired a brand-new fishing boat that lay at Faxe Ladeplads; it was manned by three skippers, of whom my host was one; my housekeeper supplied us with provisions. On a fine starry summer evening we sailed off be-

fore a brisk wind, and we had a splendid night passage. In the morning we were at the cliff, but since the wind was onshore we could not land there, but went south round the island and put in at Klintholm Havn, from where we drove to Liselund. After spending the day on the cliff, we went back to the harbor in the evening; the ladies, whose number was now four, two acquaintances having joined us at the cliff, got a room ashore, and the gentlemen lay on hay in the boat. The next day we sailed south of Møen, up through Grønsund and Ulfsund and [119] across Faxe Bugt to the Ladeplads. It was in the first days of August, when one can sing “Soon the time of the light nights is past”, and there was something of this song’s mood over our sailing. — It is said, by the way, to have caused some offense that we had thus sailed out with young ladies. And I was indeed told by a female relative that I must not imagine I was old enough to be a patriarch. I believe that such things are now looked at differently. —

This excursion is among the good memories of the summer of 1882. When I came into town after the holidays, I received an invitation to give a lecture in the newly founded “Students’ Society” on its first meeting evening. “The Society” had been founded in the spring, because Georg Brandes had been refused a discussion in the Students’ Union after a lecture he had given there by invitation. To “the Society” there now came the older and younger students who in literary, religious, and political respects felt themselves in opposition to the ruling authorities. The title of my lecture was “Om Realisme i Videnskab og Tro”; it is printed in the first series of my *Mindre Arbejder*. I sought to show how science laid weight more and more decidedly on the definite, factual conditions, in contrast to the idealistic interpretations of the Romantics, and that at the same time in theology one clung to the definite, factually given dogmas, in contrast to the symbolizing interpretations of speculative theology. — In the following years I spent many Saturday evenings in “the Society”, where in that politically stirring time one could meet like-minded people and talk about what one had on one’s heart. In the first years there were often lively and interesting discussions.

The following winter brought a change in my position at the University. Of the two professors of philosophy, the one, Heegaard, had been struck by a stroke

[120] a couple of years before, and he had not yet recovered from the after-effects, which, as I shall mention later, grew worse after a great sorrow. There was talk of my holding the philosophical course in his place in 1882–83; but Rasmus Nielsen declared himself ready to take it over, although he too had recently had a stroke. It soon turned out that he was too weak to carry it through to the end, and since the number of students had now risen greatly, a division became necessary, and Dr. Kroman and I were approached to lecture in the spring semester of 1883. When Rasmus Nielsen then retired, the faculty recommended me for the vacant professorship. Attempts are said to have been made with the minister to work against my appointment, particularly on account of my conduct in the Students' Society, perhaps also on account of my religious opinions. I have never been able to find out who the man was who, according to what I know from a reliable source, went on this matter to the then Minister of Education (Jacob Scavenius). Several of my friends were greatly concerned and doubted that I would be appointed. But on 2 February 1883 I received my appointment (reckoned from 1 Sept., since Nielsen's retirement was reckoned from that day).

I had long given lectures and exercises as privatdocent and as permanent lecturer. Now I also took over the philosophical course for the young students. My university activity consisted in the following years (until 1916) of three things. Besides the annual course for the young students, I held special exercises, intended for those who wished to take the master's examination in philosophy, or for students who wished to continue their occupation with philosophy after the first year, and finally I often gave evening lectures, which were intended for wider circles and which sometimes gathered a large number of listeners.

It was twelve years since I had begun to lecture as privatdocent, and since 1883 I have then worked as professor for 32 years. But this last section comprises different periods, each of which must have its chapter.

IV

It has been a great good fortune for me to be a university teacher. The constant [121] interplay between the study and the lecture hall, — the fact that little by little, facing the young, one could come to touch on or speak of everything that concerns one's chief interest in life, — indeed, the very fact of having to do with young people at the age when so much is laid down in them, — all this makes life rich. I have had very great difficulties to overcome both as a speaker and as a writer, and I know well that I have never entirely overcome them. And I have, especially in my earlier years, suffered from what one might call lectern fever. Just before a lecture or an address one easily gets a feeling of emptiness; what one has worked out stands there as uninteresting, and as something that in any case will not interest those one is to speak to; — and can one even bring out what one wants to say in the right way? — In time I have no doubt gained greater freedom and confidence. And in any case what I have been able to offer has been received and acknowledged in a way for which I must feel deeply grateful. —

Already during my years as privatdocent I had come into a personal relationship with some of my listeners, and as my circle of listeners widened, this took on a larger scope. One came to seek advice about his choice of studies, another to discuss a philosophical problem, a third to complain of his hypochondria, a fourth to get advice concerning difficult or problematic circumstances at home. And I also began to gather some of those who seemed to have a philosophical interest beyond the extent to which philosophy is required for the philosoph- [122] icum. At monthly gatherings various subjects within and outside philosophy were then discussed, most often in such a way that the students gave the intro-

duction in turn; yet I myself also sometimes gave the introductory talk. I valued these gatherings highly for the personal acquaintance they led to in many cases. It particularly pleased me to learn how the foundation was laid here for many friendships among the participants. Many took part in these gatherings year in and year out; but I sometimes had to drop the oldest age groups, so that they should not weigh down the younger ones. For me myself, too, friendships have grown out of such gatherings. Men like Valdemar Vedel, Georg Saxild and Niels Møller I have through them come into a personal relationship with that will surely last through life, since it has lasted so long. Among the dead I remember with sadness Knud Ipsen, whose posthumous work on Diderot I published with an account of his life and personality.

Among those who for a time took part in these gatherings were also two young men who later won fine names as poets, Johannes Jørgensen and Viggo Stuckenberg.

Johannes Jørgensen I remember as an eager young biologist who had gone over from the study of German to natural science. He gave a talk at my home on Weismann's biological theories. But biology could no more hold him fast than the study of the German language, and after he had for some time talked of studying philosophy, he devoted himself entirely to literature. I liked the young man with the beautiful eyes in the Mongolian face, but I cannot — according to his own autobiography — boast of having been anything to him. What, by his own account, interested him in philosophy was really only that it could not set up new authorities in place of the old ones, which he believed he had left once
 [123] and for all, and he then found it justified to give himself up to his bohemian life, just as he no doubt also later, after his conversion to Catholicism, finds it to have been the most consistent course. If there is no hell and no purgatory, why should one deny oneself anything at all? In his first books he depicts time after time the poor student from the provinces who comes to Copenhagen without having any foothold there and therefore knows only the life of the streets and ends in the gutter. I once wrote to him, when he had sent me a new book of the same content: "Dear Jørgensen, you once traveled from Svendborg to Copenhagen,

and you never forget that journey.” After he had left my circle, he attacked me from the various standpoints he later took up, lastly from the Catholic one. I nonetheless kept my interest in him and found in particular that the conversion to Catholicism not only gave him hold and support but also made his poetry truly unfold. Yet I confess that I prefer the old Catholic poets to the modern ones; in the latter, it seems to me, the poetry often stands in a somewhat external relation to the religious ideas that are professed. — On the occasion of my sixtieth birthday he wrote to me from Rome: “I believe I am connected with you on more than one point, and I think that the more the years go by, the more I shall come to recognize this. In any case I believe I can never come to be as far from you as I was in my negative period.” (9 March 1903). — I do not deny that after this I was both surprised and hurt by the cool and superior (forcedly superior) manner in which I am spoken of in his autobiography. On the one hand he has me teach a purely negative view, without heeding that I have always conceived and presented the human life of the spirit, its laws and its tasks, as a positive fullness that was able in itself to give life value, and that the negations I was led to aimed only at protecting this true and genuine positivity. A delight in mere criticism I have never felt. On the other hand he does not mention the purely human motives [124] that in my view could give strength for serious self-assertion and keep one from throwing oneself away to end in the gutter. — Had he written his autobiography in his “negative period” I could have understood it, but not after the statement in the letter. But perhaps the point was to set off in relief the conversion that a later part of the biography is to depict.

[That it is not only I who have received this impression of Jørgensen’s account of me in his biography, I see from a letter I received in January 1917 from a former listener who was personally quite unknown to me. He writes: “The way in which you and your life’s work are spoken of in Jørgensen’s memoirs cannot but outrage a person who has received some of his best impressions from your human personality. There is, to be sure, nothing directly disparaging about you in these books, but it is in a high degree dispiriting to see the complete blindness that has struck a spiritually stirred man and outstanding poet with regard to your

life's work ... You taught us respect for the significance of the life of the spirit. You always pointed to the human, which united us all." — I could not wish for any better summary judgment of what I strove for in my work as a teacher than the one which a listener of 1906, unknown to me, has expressed here, several years after his participation in my teaching. In my most confident moments I pass a similar judgment myself; but it does one good to see them come forth in a spontaneous outburst from another quarter]. —

Viggo Stuckenberg, too, took part for a time in the monthly gatherings on Amicivej. I see clearly before me his handsome face with the radiant eyes. When he had begun his work as an author with tales and short stories, he once asked me for a frank opinion on one of them. I found it slight and unclear, and in [125] keeping with the promise I had given him, I wrote this to him in words as kind as possible. From what I heard, my judgment nevertheless hurt him, and he thought of ceasing to take part in the meetings. Yet he overcame his misgivings, and a short time afterwards he read aloud at my home a fragment of a short story that was very successful. It depicted how a young student, who sits absorbed in reading in his room with Darwin's picture on his wall and Brandes' books on his table, receives a visit from an old uncle from the country, who is then appalled at what he gets to see and hear. — Stuckenberg's later production, from "Favre Ord" onward and through his deeply felt and finely wrought poems, I followed with interest and sympathy. I still admire the great poem about his mother and the even more profound poem "Bekendelse", in which he settles accounts with a friend (Johannes Jørgensen) who had changed his faith. After I had not seen him for a number of years, I met him one day up at "Nordisk Forlag" and took the opportunity to thank him for his books in a few kind words. He seemed a little embarrassed by this, but I thought no more about it. The same evening I received a letter from him, in which he thanked me in the most touching and childlike way for what I had said to him, and apologized for his confusion that morning. "There lies," he concludes, "a kind of curse on reverence; it always keeps a barrier lowered between the younger and the older. I would just not like to see that barrier too much gone. Conversations matter least in this world, most

the thoughts we go about with of one another. And I shall be glad if you, from your thoughts about me, will always be able to greet me as kindly as you met me this morning.” — The wish Stuckenberg expressed in these last words has been fulfilled, though I did not get the opportunity to tell him so. Of his struggle with grief and poverty I heard only after his death. His memory I have kept in admiration and sadness, and the letter I have mentioned I keep as one of the [126] finest memories of how young people I have come into contact with on my way could feel disposed toward me. —

After the laboratory instruction had become more organized, it was as a rule the participants in it whom I invited. I had grown somewhat tired of the more general subjects I discussed at the monthly gatherings. And the laboratory hours themselves, in which a major philosophical work was as a rule gone through (other works too, e.g. one of my own), gave occasion for closer acquaintance. I then gathered the participants for an evening at the end of the semester, and it was then as a rule a purely social gathering. In the years when I lived in the little apartment on Carl Bernhards Vej (1908–14), space could be tight; we sometimes had to go out for a walk while the table was being laid. At Carlsberg there was room enough, and it was a fine sight to see groups of young people moving about in the garden or in “Pompeji”. Perhaps it is on such evenings that I have especially had a festive feeling about “the Honorary Residence”.

In the autumn of 1883 Heegaard resumed his work at the University after the heavy blows of fate that had passed over him, and he lectured alongside me for the young students.

During the examinations in the summer of 1880 he had suffered a stroke, which for a time left him unable to work, and to regain his health he traveled to Italy. I received several letters from him that seemed to show that he was recovering. But in the spring of 1881 he had a new attack in Florence, and his wife and daughter then traveled down to him. The daughter, a fresh and cheerful young girl who was a great joy in the home, caught typhoid during the stay in

Florence and died after a couple of weeks' illness. After this sorrow Heegaard
 [127] never rose again. There now took place a great change in him. His former intellectual zeal, his absorption in independent and critical inquiry, was now replaced by a sinking into brooding. It was the thought of his daughter that occupied him. I remember conversations with him in Frederiksberg Garden, where he set out how the dead were not far from us; he could well imagine his daughter stepping forth under the trees there in front of us. Anyone who has lost someone he truly loved will know something of this feeling. But in Heegaard the brooding over it became more and more dominant. At the same time his attacks recurred, and he became more and more enfeebled. The energy for work was gone. The need for an absolute foothold in another world than the one that experience and reflection could open became stronger and stronger in him. And so there came the declaration (in the preface to the second edition of his *Pædagogik*) that he had returned to the old faith of the Church as the only thing that could hold him up. In a very fine way, and with the honesty that lay in his nature, he declared his changed faith, whose coming into being I had been able to follow step by step through our conversations. He himself believed that it was by an act of will at a particular moment that the change had taken place. But such "mutations" surely always have their prehistory, in the spiritual as in the material domain, and I had been able to follow this one in its main outlines. From the belief in immortality, which sprang from the need to feel himself near his beloved daughter, as a first beginning, his mind had been bent more and more toward what lies beyond experience, and when the need for definitely formed ideas of this beyond made itself felt, the content of his childhood faith lay nearest at hand.

There was something touching in the inwardness with which he spoke of his new position, and I felt the greatest reverence for what was stirring in him. All the more did it pain me that he sometimes harbored mistrust of me. We met
 [128] almost daily at the University in the autumn of 1883. But one day he did not come. The next day I said to him: "You were ill yesterday?" He answered: "Yes, I was ill." I thought no more about it; but a little after I had come home after the lecture the bell rang, and Heegaard came into my room deeply moved and

said: “I have come to tell you that I lied to you. I was not ill yesterday, but I was at communion, and I feared you would mock me for it.” To this I answered that it pained me that he could harbor such a belief about me, especially as he had to acknowledge that I had given him no occasion for it. It ended with both of us weeping, and we parted as good friends. — In the course of the autumn the strokes became more and more frequent. After the lecture I had to accompany him to the omnibus and often feared for how he would get home. Some way into the new year he passed away.

From the orthodox side a great deal was made of Heegaard’s conversion. His friends, who had known him in his good working years and seen his best and manliest qualities unfold in them, could not be in doubt as to where they should look for the real Sofus Heegaard. They saw him in the man who in his full strength let his thought work on the problems, even if the world of possibilities already then occupied his mind when it sought rest, — in the man who looked with irony on every kind of dogmatism, wherever it came from. Now he was weakened in mind and body. He had spent far too much of his strength in toil for a livelihood, and then the great sorrow came on top of it. The time of his vigorous unfolding of life was so short. But an honest man he was, wherever he stood. —

It is of course so that what we think and believe in our strong times must stand its test in the weak times, and precisely in them. But how many are put to such a test as Heegaard? And it holds of every faith that it can fail when it counts. I have on my way seen several cases where people who in good times were churchly believers, precisely when sorrow and misfortune came upon them, [129] had the experience that the faith they had held to until then did not help them. These are exceedingly deep-lying matters, hard to disentangle, that we face here. And however great a weight one may wish to lay on the times of weakness as decisive, they can still never be what one should take as one’s basis. A building can be firmly joined and have a deep foundation, even if it cannot withstand an earthquake. The measure of a life’s value we must take from the times when it unfolds freely and luxuriantly. The free man, says Spinoza, broods not over

death but over life.

Another friend took, at about this time, a significant step which, while it did not have the character of principle that Heegaard's conversion had, yet came as a surprise. Hans Skovgaard, my friend from my school years, had studied theology like me, and in our first student years I was probably more theological than he. After his theological examination he took to studying history and French and, after having been a teacher in Copenhagen (at the "Lyceum", where I also taught), became assistant master in Nykøbing on Falster. He had, for that matter, like me come into Greek studies and occupied himself closely with Plutarch's philosophical writings and with Stoicism. In Nykøbing, where he was much taken up with the school and with his boarders, he got up at 4½ in the morning to read Plutarch and Marcus Aurelius. One of his fellow teachers said of him that he still lived as a student, and that was right. It has also lasted into his older days. His religious views had hardly changed. But those closest to him had the impression that he was wholly absorbed in his school work and his studies. Then he wrote to me on 2 January 1884: "In the autumn I spent a great part of the time, in my room or [130] on solitary walks, debating pastor or not pastor, until one fine day, to a certain astonishment of my contemporaries — not least of my wife — I declared that I would become a pastor."

After he had been ordained, the same year, I wrote a letter to him whose content I do not remember, but whose character and direction appear from his reply (3 Nov. 1884), from which I quote a longer passage because it is characteristic of our relationship before and after: "Thank you for your kind letter. I had indeed expected a letter from you, and a real letter from a friend too, and that I have also received. So I have nothing to complain of, one would think — and yet I cannot deny that there was something that as it were hurt inside me when I read it. Were I properly a 'pastor', — yes, possibly I ought not to say 'pastor' in quotation marks, but simply a Christian pastor (possibly, I say, for I do not really know) — well, were I that, then I ought presumably to say that it pained me for your

sake. But that would not be the truth, not the full truth at least. Still less does it pain me for my own sake, — but for both our sakes, or for the sake of a breaking harmony. Your words sound to me as if they came from a far, far place and could reach me only faintly ringing and half broken; — there is something so melancholy in the echo of a farewell far away It is a mood that sounds in me, not only when I look back on your path and mine, how they have slowly and surely moved away from each other, so that we must now raise our voices to be heard, but also when I measure my own wayward paths against the King's highway on which I ought to walk." — In the following years he often comes back to the same subject. Thus in a letter written on my birthday in 1891: "We have indeed talked much together, and thought or dreamed together, and taken together that comes to: we have lived much together. And then it is so strange that we cannot live together like that and think and talk together as before. Sometimes I cannot get [131] it into my head: you are after all still the old Harald Høffding, and you have the same eyes when you go to the borderline and look out over the infinite, which is there, whatever kind of hoarfrost may cover it ... And when you go down into yourself to find the origin of yourself then I think you must see the same as I see At other times it whispers inside me: 'How far we have come away from each other ...' — In January 1894 he writes: "Strangely enough: although, especially in the evening, when I sit alone in my room after my usual bedtime, I not so rarely have little conversations with you (have you ever noticed it?), which are carried on without voice and could hardly be rendered in distinct words (so unborn are they — unripened moods) — yet I have never in them caught myself attempting to convert you — although I quite soberly think that you ought to do it. I suppose that we both (as far as I am concerned) are still 20 years old in such evening hours, and something in us is indeed so still."

I have visited Skovgaard in his various parsonages, — in Ørum near Vejle, in Lynge near Sorø, in Kettinge on Lolland. The friendship and the intimacy have lasted. We have indeed had a single clash on account of the opposition between pastor and philosopher; but it did no harm. There was and remained, moreover, something of a student in my old friend. I quote a passage from a letter of March

1909 which shows how the pastor and the student in him could work together: “I still live, then, as pastor in Kettinge-Bregninge. Of exploits in this my capacity it is, for good reasons, quite impossible for me to speak. The feelings that come up in me during the work — whether I sit at home at the table here trying to get hold of something that people may benefit from hearing, or am out on my parish rounds — can be of rather different kinds. Now I think that it is tough to
 [132] be a pastor, tougher than most other things, now again that no other work can be finer, so genuinely human — in both cases a unicum, which it certainly is, too. — Then I have got it into my head that it is not without danger for the pastor and the human being to grow old. And to avoid that danger as far as possible I read some strenuous book or other — one that lies so high up that I must stand on tiptoe to reach it — that is salutary, even at the risk of not understanding it. In that respect Boutroux: ‘*Sur la contingence des lois de la nature*’ fulfills all reasonable demands.” Of other books he is reading Amiel’s “*Journal intime*” and James’ “*Religiøse Erfaringer*.” From the fragments of letters I have quoted here, one may perhaps get a small idea of my friend’s gifts as a letter writer. But the main thing for me has been to show the fine way in which he conceived our relationship, all the while he was living himself more deeply into his churchly position. —

There was another parsonage I visited in the ’80s and ’90s besides Skovgaard’s. Through my cousin Karl Gjellerup I had made the acquaintance of his foster parents, the poet and pastor Johannes Fibiger and his wife Amalie, née Waage, — an acquaintance that soon passed into warm friendship, on both sides, I am sure. From 1880 on I spent a few days with them every year. At first it was in the summertime, and I remember some glorious summer days spent in the garden or in the surroundings of their snug parsonage. Fibiger was, when I came to know him, pastor in Valensved near Næstved, later in Ønslev on Falster. I have received from his nephew a picture Fibiger himself painted of the garden at Ønslev, and it awakens good and fine memories in me. Later it was mostly in the month of January that I went down to them. Precisely in the heart of winter I needed those two people, whose spirit was as deep as their hearts were warm.

The quiet days with them helped me through many a low time. Johannes Fibiger [133] was, as I said, both poet and pastor, and he himself admitted that he was not entirely clear where the one ended and the other began. Deeply religious he was in any case, though he did not think much of theology. We sometimes had long conversations about the relation between the figurative and the literal in people's faith. One winter evening I remember especially, when our conversation ran so lively, and at the same time so thoughtful, a course that I later said to Fru Amalie, who had been our interested and understanding listener, that she ought to have taken it down in shorthand; it could have become a philosophical dialogue. It was probably in the course of this conversation that I, when Fibiger had set out the content of his faith, said: "For me it is only poetry!" — whereupon he answered: "Do you say *only* poetry?" Since that time I have avoided saying "only" in that connection when what was in question was what I call the poetry of life. By the poetry of life I understand a poetry that is the symbolic expression of deeply affecting experiences and experiences of life, which the poetry of art is not always. — Often we seemed to draw closer in our verdicts, only then suddenly to see the opposition stand out sharply. Fibiger liked to bring his statements to a point, and he could then perhaps hold on a little too long to the artificial point. But his rich imagination and life of feeling and his thorough study of the history of religion gave conversation with him great interest when he was in good form. In his later years he could sometimes say with sadness that the calling of pastor had not really suited him, and that he would not choose it if he had to choose now. His sermons were not delivered to many listeners. His Bible readings, on the other hand, were well attended; here he could give himself more freely, and there he could put his spirited independent thinking and great wealth of knowledge to more use. Visits to the sick and the poor also suited him well.

Of his poetic work, special mention should be made of some Old Testament poems and the collection he called "Den evige Strid" and published under the name of Diodorus. But his best book is his autobiography, which appeared after his death and which gives an exceedingly interesting contribution to the understanding of the spiritual life of the forties. The greatest interest of the book,

however, lies in its depiction of the life of two lovable and spirited people.

When his wife was mentioned above as listener at our conversations, it was by no means because she could not give her own, independent contributions to a serious discussion. She was a finely cultivated lady who strove to see for herself and to find her own bearings in the great questions. When her foster son Karl Gjellerup, whom she loved dearly, began to move away from the churchly faith, she made it her concern to examine what the reasons for such a change might be. She studied the main works of critical theology; I often saw learned works of this kind lying on her table. Her great modesty and her great admiration for her husband meant that she as a rule held back in the presence of others. But in conversations alone with her I received the impression of a very considerable human being. There was a radiance over her utterances, because they came from a stirred mind and were the fruit of serious seeking. Perhaps she was quite as gifted as her husband. It was at bottom easier for me to talk with her than with him, and I was and am very proud of the openness with which she expressed herself to me. I cannot refrain here from inserting a passage from a letter of hers, although it contains exceedingly kind words about me. I believe it gives a true impression of the relationship between us. It is written on 7 May 1894.

“It was fine and kind of you to send me a letter for my birthday, and one so heartfelt and so full of content! It pleased me greatly, and I thank you for it. That we have been able to be so much to you, even I, could not but both please and surprise me; though one may hope for such a thing, it is still something one
[135] does not really know until one hears it from the person concerned. We have indeed both regarded you as a truly good friend, with whom we could speak freely and in confidence and from whom we could hope for understanding, in spite of much difference in development and opinions. Yes, it has often surprised me myself that I did not shrink, as you remark, from speaking to you about religious questions that lay close to my heart, and on which I knew you took a different view from mine. I, who otherwise find it hard to speak of such things and feared any rough or mocking touch upon this inner life of mine, have never had any such feeling with you; on the contrary, it interested me to speak to you

about it. On one single occasion I thought I offended you by it, but that this was not the case I now see, and it pleases me. When people trust each other, it works.”

—

After Fibiger had retired on account of infirmity, he and his wife moved to Copenhagen. He survived the move only a short time, however. Fru Amalie lived some ten years more after his death, and it was always a refreshment to me to visit the old lady. She for her part appreciated my visits in the most touching way. I once called her in a letter my motherly friend, and she gladly accepted this name. With her it was always easy to come onto subjects of interest. But just as I was looking forward to coming to live nearer to her (she lived on Kochs Vej, and I was to move out to Carl Bernhard's Vej), I received word of her death. For several years she had suffered from a heart ailment; her strength declined, and life had become a burden to her. Then came a stroke, after which she passed away. — But often, when I come along Kochs Vej, I still look up at the windows where I had so many times seen my motherly friend at her work, and from which I sometimes received her friendly greeting already down on the road.

Those two people stood for me as fine and noble representatives of the generation that went before mine. Through them I understood much of the time to [136] which they had belonged. But they represented for me first and foremost themselves. —

In the summer of 1884 I visited both Skovgaard, who still lived in Nykøbing, and the Fibigers in Ønslev. Julius Petersen came along to Nykøbing to visit a colleague there, and one day we three schoolfellows went out to Pumlénakke on the east coast of Falster. The day after I went out to Ønslev, and after some good summer days there I went on board the steamer to Rostock at Nykøbing. I had in fact decided on a little journey abroad — to get to know German philosophers and Swiss mountain scenery. In Berlin I stayed some weeks, visited the museums, where Rembrandt in particular and my special favorite Ruysdael absorbed me, and attended lectures at the University as a guest. The most famous

man I made the acquaintance of was old Eduard Zeller, author of the giant work “Die Philosophie der Griechen”, a neat and precise scholar whose pronounced Swabian dialect entered into an attractive union with his guileless and kindly words. I further came to know Friedrich Paulsen and thereby laid the foundation of a friendship that has been of much significance for me. Paulsen was a Frisian from South Schleswig and has given in his memoirs of youth a fine and interesting account of life in the lonely regions of southwest Schleswig. He was a broad, steady and solid scholar and teacher. The acquaintance was continued on my later visits to Berlin, and he has also visited me in Copenhagen. He could read Danish from his childhood, and it was owing to his urging and recommendation that my *Psykologi* came out in German, where it has then drawn my other books after it. A third philosopher I came to know in Berlin was the moral philosopher Georg v. Gizycki, an eager follower of Bentham and Mill. Gizycki was somewhat dry in thought and speech, but an enthusiastic adherent of utilitarianism [137] in its specifically English form. His thoughts went more and more in a socialist direction, and he was a great optimist, though he was a cripple. A nervous debility had paralyzed his legs, so that he had to be wheeled in a wheelchair up to the University and into the lecture hall, where a ramp had been laid up to the lectern. He told me that one evening his servant was out, and he (who was then unmarried) was alone at home. He wanted a book that stood at the other end of the room and dragged himself over there along the table, but was so unlucky as to fall. Get up he could not, but he lay there on the floor and read until the servant at long last came home. As a boy he had been able to walk, but run he had never been able to. In the afternoon he liked to sit over a mug of beer in the zoological garden, and there one could have a good conversation with him. And sometimes one Berlin colleague or another would join us, thus one day Gustav Schmoller, famous for his works in social history. — Besides these men’s lectures I heard Adolph Wagner on political economy and Scherer on Goethe’s poems.

From Berlin the journey went to Dresden, where it was of course the museums that laid claim to me. The Sistine Madonna struck me as a revelation. The little room where the picture hung had the character of a chapel, and the visi-

tors too felt seized with devotion, whether they were believing Catholics or not. The picture stands for me in a radiance that has become, if not more brilliant, then more inward and full of feeling on my later visits. It is the apotheosis of motherly love, of inwardness and of enthusiasm. The cult of the Madonna is the cult I understand best, especially since sociological studies have shown me the mother with the child as a psychological center for the development not only of the family's feelings but of all sympathetic feelings, the hearth of altruism in the history of the race. In later years Yrjö Hirn's fine work on the cult of the Madonna has deepened my understanding of this at once most exalted and most inward religious figure.

A devotion of another kind I held in Weimar, where I entered into Goethe's ^[138] daily round. The little garden house outside the town, by the river Ilm, reminded me of the young Goethe's enthusiasm for nature, when he took up his abode out there one spring evening and made his bed out in the open air, where he was woken by the birdsong. The Goethe Museum in the town called up the memory of the old Goethe, whose heart could yet still beat like a young man's, though resignation had to dampen its beat. I saw him sitting in his armchair in the plainly furnished study, while Eckermann, over by the table, was absorbed in the glorious Marienbad Elegy, the most beautiful and deepest of Goethe's poems of his old age.

Eisenach with the Wartburg turned my thoughts again to other regions. From the high castle Luther's eye has looked out over forests and mountain peaks. In the Thüringerwald I took glorious walks.

A little comic story from the table d'hôte in Eisenach I must tell. I happened to sit beside a gentleman and a lady who were speaking Danish, and when they came onto private matters, I made them aware that I understood them. They turned out to be a village pastor from Zealand and his wife. The pastor was coming from Carlsbad, where he had been taking a cure, and complained loudly about the high spa tax he had been assessed. This tax was set according to the person's position, and to give an impression of something very humble and lowly he had entered himself on the list as "Landpfarrer"; in his opinion that was to

mean a simple village pastor — but it was interpreted as a kind of bishop, a pastor over the clergy of a whole province, and his attempt to make himself as small as possible thus had an unfortunate outcome. At the hotel he must have made similar attempts, for the landlord whispered to me when we talked about them: “die Pfarrer können bisweilen sehr praktisch sein!”

[139] From Eisenach the journey went to Heidelberg, where I paid a visit to the well-known historian of philosophy Kuno Fischer and spent an evening with him. He was a stately man, felt himself a *Geheimerath-Excellenz* and spoke with sovereign contempt of other authors. His books had been of much use to me in my first attempts to find my bearings in the history of modern philosophy; later I saw how uncritical they were, in that they passed lightly over the difficult points. A spirited man he was, and his lectures were well attended. From Copenhagen I knew that in the autumn he was to marry a Danish lady, Fru Stilling, a very beautiful lady with radiant eyes and chalk-white hair. I had been a guest in her house and had learned to value her kind-hearted and lively nature. In the course of the conversation Fischer asked me, seemingly quite by chance: “Kennen Sie eine Frau Stilling in Kopenhagen?” It was a little sly; but even if I had not been prepared, I would still have had nothing but good to say of her. Later I sometimes saw Fischer and his wife in Copenhagen, where he also paid me a visit.

In Freiburg in Baden I stayed a couple of days and visited Aloys Riehl here, who was already then known for his work on “*Den filosofiske Kriticisme*”. Riehl was an energetic man, sharp in speech and thought. A very lively evening I spent at his home together with an English guest. From Kiel, where he later lived, he has visited me in Copenhagen. In his older days he is professor in Berlin, and I have been in touch with him there.

My travel plan as regards Switzerland had been laid by arrangement with a younger, much-traveled friend, the zoologist Nielsen, assistant master in Aalborg. I had met him at Brøchner’s, who thought highly of him, and I learned to do the same. He had decided scientific gifts, but was in despair over his isolation in Aalborg. An excellent teacher he was, but that did not wholly satisfy [140] him. He felt happy only on his journeys, for which he saved up the whole year.

Now we met in Schaffhausen and began our Swiss tour from there. Zurich was our first station. Here I looked up the philosopher Richard Avenarius, founder of the journal “Vierteljahrsschrift für wissenschaftliche Philosophie”, in which I had written the year before. He was an acute thinker whose main work, which came out some 8–9 years later under the title “Kritik der reinen Erfahrung”, has, despite its abstract form, an exceedingly interesting content; in my book “Moderne Philosophie” I have given an account of his theory and characterized it as the natural history of problems. The strenuous work later broke down his health; he sought relief, among other places, at Skodsborg, where in the summer of 1894 I was together with him several times and philosophized with him among the trees of the Dyrehave. Two years later he died. But in 1884 he was still healthy and active, and with him and his wife I spent a good evening in their snug home.

It was on the way from Schaffhausen to Zurich that I first caught sight of snow mountains (the Glarus Alps) and at first took them for white masses of cloud. I have used this experience in the preface to my *Etik*. We began our walking tours in Graubünden, from the little post station of Thusis. We walked over the Albula Pass to get to the Engadine. Up on the top of the pass we were snowed in, to the great joy of two German gentlemen who were staying up there to collect butterflies, but who had now begun to grow tired of each other. In any case the one, a tall and heavy man, had grown tired of the other, a small, thin fellow who undeniably did not seem to have much to say either. The big one expressed his joy that we had to stay there, — for, he said, “zwischen mir und diesem Herrn ist der Faden schon ausgesponnen”. The little one looked a little sheepish at that. The big one at once took it upon himself to arrange the meal and was altogether something between a steward and a *maître de plaisir* for us.

From the Albula Pass we walked the next day through Samaden to Ponte [141] Resina, where we settled down for some days and made excursions in the Engadine with its glorious lights and the lovely colors on lakes and fields. And then the air one breathed here; it was a pleasure merely to draw breath. When I later read Nietzsche, who got some of his best thoughts up here, I understood well that he valued living up here so highly. We saw the Alpine peaks glow in the

light of evening. It was cold in Ponte Resina; but in the mornings the sun lured the marmots out of their burrows on the mountain slopes; they sat in front of the burrows and licked up the sunshine, while a fine piping expressed their contentment. The small and the great alike here drew one's attention. We climbed Piz-Languard, 9000 feet high. The ascent was laborious but not dangerous, yet I became dizzy, especially when the Alpine choughs swished past me and suddenly shot downward. Our guide gave me moral support by taking off his trouser belt and letting me hold one end while he himself held the other. But the toil was well rewarded. When we got up, we saw many miles away snowy peak after snowy peak shining in the strong sunshine. It was a sight I have never forgotten.

In a return carriage we drove back to Chur, went from there to Göschenen and began here a new walking tour, over Andermatt and up over the Scheidegg, past the Jungfrau and the Mönch. It was 5 days' march, which ended in Lauterbrunnen, from where we drove to Interlaken to rest there before the journey home began. We were very weary after the 5 days' walking, but they had been glorious days; the mountain landscape showed itself to us in all its splendor under the radiant sunshine, which let every form stand out in its full particularity.

We traveled home through Germany and up through Jutland. Nielsen was going to Aalborg (which he did not at all look forward to seeing again), and I was to fetch my two boys in Vendsyssel, where they had spent the summer holidays with their relatives. —

[142] In the years 1884–85 the political tension grew. Copenhagen, which for so long had been undividedly National Liberal and Right, was now divided, as the formation of liberal voters' associations indicated. On Constitution Day the Opposition too now marched en masse in procession out to their festival ground. The mass was not large, however, at any rate the mass of those who were willing to prostitute themselves by taking part in the procession. At the festival in 1884 we gathered behind Tivoli and were then bold enough to march out along Vesterbro, a small but perhaps select band. But people laughed at us from the

windows, and our band had the stupidity or the malice to play “When I lay in the cradle — and was as big as that” — The festival otherwise went off excellently. There were good speakers, Hostrup, Hørup, Bojsen and others. There was a large assembly, for a great many of the like-minded had preferred to meet out there instead of taking part in the procession. On the platform, where I had a place as chairman of the meeting and as president of the Frederiksberg Liberal Voters’ Association, I talked with a journalist, an old schoolfellow, about how many people there were. I thought 10,000, he 8,000. The next day I saw that his paper, a Right paper, gave 4,000. But he then came out to me and explained that he had written 8,000, but that the editors had changed it without further ado. — It is hardly the only time such a thing has happened — on both sides.

Although the Opposition won the election in the summer of 1884, the Estrup ministry nevertheless continued its policy and from 1885 on governed without an appropriation act. The tension grew, and there was great unrest in people’s minds. It was a feeling of indignation and humiliation that made itself felt among those who belonged to the Opposition. The Danish people had not deserved such treatment.

Once in the course of the summer a political meeting was held in Holstebro, where Chr. Berg was to be the main speaker. The chief of police had on this occasion taken a seat on the platform; but Berg refused to speak as long as he was there, and two men (Noos and Nielsen) on the board of the voters’ association [143] then gently led the chief of police down from the platform in spite of his protest. The government made a great deal of this affair. The government sent a special commission over to judge those who were thought to have offended. Noos and Nielsen were arrested and treated as criminals. They were roughly addressed by the examining magistrate, and even their wives were treated insolently when they sought to obtain some easing of their husbands’ conditions in prison. This aroused general indignation. The agitation was great all over the country, especially of course in the district itself. There had even, according to what a man from the district told me shortly afterward, been talk of taking the two men out of prison by force and of disarming the soldiers in the Jutland garrisons, which

was thought not to be difficult once men from the soldiers' own home districts came forward. It was the local members of the Folketing who prevented the carrying out of this plan. The sentence was 6 months' imprisonment on ordinary prison fare for Berg and the two men from Holstebro. After the sentence Noos and Nielsen were set at liberty, since they, like Berg, appealed to the Supreme Court.

A short time afterward all three were invited to a gathering at the Students' Society. There was no special occasion for me to come that evening; but I remember that at dinner I said to my brother that I would go up there to shake some brave men's hands. I had taken the gathering to be private, but by an irony of fate it became the first evening at which everything was reported. My colleague Erslev and I were present and both spoke. It was the two men's treatment while in custody that had aroused our sympathy for them.

The next morning the Right papers raged and demanded that an example be made of Erslev and me for our "friendliness to criminals". Some weeks passed, and I was prepared to be dismissed. The tension rose when Estrup was shot at, though only a coat button was hit. The evening this had happened, two of my [144] colleagues who, like me, lived in Frederiksberg came to me and said that I must be prepared for a search of my house during the night, as president of the liberal voters' association, and that I should therefore get all dangerous papers out of the way. There were no such papers, and no guests came in the night either. On one of the following days I took part in a large meeting at the Kasino, which had been arranged beforehand, and sat, with members of the liberal voters' associations, on the stage while Hørup in a brilliant speech presented the Copenhagen Voters' Association with a new banner. Before the meeting there had been a dinner in common at the Hotel Kongen af Danmark, and as I made my way there, I noticed two well-known politicians of the Right who, each from his street corner, were taking note of who came to the meeting. In the following week there was a meeting of the Frederiksberg Voters' Association at "Sommerlyst", where I was to speak. Just before the meeting began, a stenographer from the Rigsdag came and told me that, from what he had heard, it was now to be dismissal for Erslev and

me. The fact that the decision seemed thus to have been made brought complete calm to my mind, and I gave my address with full composure and with quite as much force as I am otherwise able to put into it. It dealt with how powerless those in power would in the end prove to be in the face of what has developed by virtue of a people's nature and has become its will.

I now prepared myself for how I should arrange my life if I was dismissed. A main concern for me was how I should now gain time to complete my "Etik", which I had long been working on. I thought of resuming school teaching in some form or other. But then the decision came in a somewhat different form from the one expected, namely in the form of a severe reprimand, because we had taken part in celebrating "convicted lawbreakers" and had thereby made ourselves guilty of a "gross tactlessness" toward the respect owed to the courts, and it was intimated to us that a repetition of conduct of a similar kind would not be tolerated.

It was hard enough to receive such a rebuke. It had been sent to us in copy ^[145] through the Consistory; but when some time later a meeting of the teaching staff was held, the then rector (J. L. Ussing) considered it fitting to read it aloud there. By chance neither Erslev nor I was present. The Right papers had, moreover, printed the text at once. — It would of course have been tempting to refuse to accept the reprimand and thereby bring about a dismissal. I received letters from several of my friends who urgently advised against such a step, which I too thought of only for a single moment. Erslev and I valued our teaching at the University highly, and we also believed that we had the right to attach such significance to it that there was ample counterweight to what had now befallen us. Hørup had already said to me at the Kasino meeting: "Just stay, and don't venture too far forward. You do the cause the best service by staying where you are."

Some students, according to what I later heard, are said to have planned a demonstration for me at one of the following lectures, but that day I was prevented from lecturing by a dental abscess. Some time afterward I appeared as a speaker at a meeting in the Students' Union and was greeted here with demon-

strative applause as I mounted the rostrum. I did not take this as approval of my conduct in the Students' Society, but as an expression of the wish to see me remain at the University.

I believed that it was the reactionary government that had thought it necessary to take action against the "friendliness to criminals". But many years later I happened to learn that it was the commission judges who had felt offended by our conduct and had lodged a complaint about us. One of them (later Justitiarius N. Lassen) is said to have boasted that on this occasion he had upheld the dignity of the judiciary, and he drew from this the conclusion that a judge is grander than a professor. —

[146] As long as Estrup was in power, the country continued to be governed by provisional finance acts, no matter what the outcome of the elections. The Government issued several provisional laws besides the Finance Act, for instance a law establishing a gendarmerie to keep watch on the population. This law aroused particular indignation. It was offensive that when the Government, "in order to satisfy the requirements of the Constitution," laid the Gendarmerie Act before the Landsting, it was buried there in a committee, because it was known that the Folketing would reject it! That the sense of justice in the country did not weaken under these conditions, which recurred year after year, is a proof of the sound sense of our people.

Relations between those who belonged to different parties were often very strained. In my family, for example, politics could not be discussed at our gatherings. My eldest brother, the wholesale merchant Victor Høffding, and I belonged to the Opposition, but my younger brother, the tenant farmer Otto Høffding of Strandegaard, was a man of the Right (later a Free Conservative). Mother kept the peace with anxious caution; yet I do believe that she gradually became liberal. The present generation can hardly enter into the conditions of that time. In my case, the fact that I took part in electoral life in my own constituency, and that I had moreover once been "prostituted," was enough to brand me as a fanatic who thought of nothing but politics. It was believed that I agitated from the lecture chair. An excellent old colonel who was to meet me at his son's wedding is

said to have exclaimed: “What on earth am I to talk to that man about! He is a politician, after all.” By being a politician was meant voting with the Opposition. The doings of the Right were naturally not “politics.”

The autumn of 1886 brought me a new little clash. At a discussion meeting held jointly by the Students’ Union and the Students’ Society I had been asked to preside, since I was at the time a member of both associations. On the day the meeting was to be held, strong articles were written against me in various [147] papers of the Right. The evening itself passed quietly, until one of the Students’ Society’s speakers used an expression about Goos as a politician whose ambiguity I did not catch at the moment. That gave a man of the Right occasion to accuse the chairman in sharp words of partiality, because the expression had not been reproved. I rejected the accusation. But on looking more closely into what had happened after the meeting, it became clear to me that the remark ought to have been reproved, and I then wrote a statement to the papers, which I also sent to Goos personally. It was painful to me that a colleague from whom I had learned much, and who had shown me goodwill, should believe himself to have been publicly mocked without my having reproved it as chairman. There were men of the Left who disapproved of my having made this concession. But I have always found it best to make amends where I had been at fault.

A short time afterward a little incident occurred which the papers of the Right combined with my other offenses. In the Students’ Union a liberal party had formed, whose leader was the librarian Alfred Larsen. I was invited to a gathering of the party in the small hall of the Students’ Union, where plans were to be laid for the year’s meetings. We sat around a round table, I on one side of the chairman, one of my colleagues from the law faculty on the other side. The lists on which people were to sign up for the coming meetings were sent round by the chairman, one to each side, so that my colleague and I came to stand at the top, each on his own list. Whether it had been planned so in advance, I do not know. But “Dagbladet” (the real old Dagblad, before the merger with “Nationaltidende”) now carried a leading article headed “Professor and Agitator,” which dealt only with my humble self and accused me of letting myself be used as a decoy for the

young students. One of the following days I then gave a talk to the students at the University, in which I explained my view of the relation between them and me: in my participation in student life I proceeded, I said, on the assumption [148] that each of them thought for himself and took his side according to his best conviction, not because a professor had taken that side, and that was at bottom, I added, the presupposition on which my whole work as a teacher rested.

In spite of these experiences I became neither more nor less of a politician in the following years, as long as the political struggle lasted. Later on, after the “change of system,” my political interest has undeniably weakened, and I gradually became a political free-lance. I cast my vote according to the particular issue at hand. For the cause which the Right had abused and the Left misunderstood, the cause of defense, I have come forward in particular a few times.

I appeared as a speaker at the Left’s Constitution Day celebration in 1889, and in the same year I tried, together with the banker Gotfred Rubin, the colleague of my friend Laurids Bing, to mediate in a strike which the furniture joiners had started. We trudged from Rømersgade to the offices of the factory owners. I thereby gained an insight into the course of labor disputes and acquired besides a special knowledge of price lists for panels, moldings, window frames, etc., which unfortunately did not stay with me long. I met interesting people on both sides, for instance the later Mayor Jensen, who was then a journeyman painter and spokesman for the workers’ committee. Our mediation did not lead to the settlement, but it did prepare the way for a later mediation. — In the summer of 1890 I gave a political lecture at a meeting at Frederiksberg. Some Social Democrats also took part in the discussion after the lecture, and as a consequence they spent some time on the platform. Now I had again done something a professor must not do — been on a platform together with Social Democrats! In a dispatch from Copenhagen to “Hamburger Nachrichten” this dreadful event was reported, and it was added that this time I would certainly not get off as lightly as before. In Danish papers too there were hints of my dismissal, and the reprimand [149] of 1885 was reprinted. “Ugeblad for Danmarks Højreforeninger” discussed the matter and declared that it did not know whether the rumor of my impending

dismissal was true, but that it went without saying that an official who appeared together with Social Democrats could have no claim to keep his position! Some of my friends were very apprehensive. But nothing came of the matter. It turned out later that the Minister of Education (Kultusminister) himself, Scavenius, had trouble enough clearing himself (though on account of other things than me). He had to resign shortly afterward. — Many years later I came together with him, he being President and I Vice-President of the Association franco-danoise (an unsuccessful attempt to bring about a livelier interchange between France and Denmark). At a meeting for discussion with French guests, which was held in the chamber of the Landsting, I had a seat at the chairman's table beside him, and I said to him then: "I would never have believed, Chamberlain, that we two should meet *here*." He laughed. The former antagonisms were now forgotten. New ones had come in their place. —

— What I have related here are only small and insignificant features of the strange but painful time of the eighties. I have dwelt on them only because it is an autobiography I am writing, and I therefore naturally come to speak of how the events of the time reached into my personal existence. A good deal of vexation was caused me thereby, but then I did come to bear my share of the general pressure that lay upon life here at home in those days. Isolate myself from what was going on in my people I could not, and even if I tried, some occasion or other would come where I was held fast — at least by the coat-tails.

Through all this I had continued my philosophical work. After completing my *Psychology* I resumed my ethical studies. My concern was to gain clarity about how matters stand with the presuppositions on which every attempt at [150] a scientific ethics must build. This problem now presented itself to me more sharply than before. It is in general in this way that my books have come into being, — not because I thought that people now needed to learn this or that, but because tasks presented themselves to me which I, quite personally, had to have solved. Against the otherwise so kind account I receive in Vilhelm Andersen's

“Tider og Typer” (Goethe II), I have the objection to make, not an unimportant one in my eyes, that it looks as though I had from the very first laid out a course (thus from 1876 to 1910!), in which the appearance of each individual work was determined by “a pedagogical regard for the attention and receptivity of the participants.” No, the order of the works was determined by the difficulties and tasks that presented themselves to me myself, after I had become clear (as mentioned above, in the year 1874) about the essential standpoint from which I could treat the problems that might present themselves to me. If I have had any significance as a teacher, it is because I have had the need, and perhaps the ability, to learn myself.

In my little book of 1876 I had not posed the question of the presuppositions of ethics in a critical way. Now I asked: just as logic and mathematics rest on presuppositions that are universally human, and just as empirical science rests on the principle of causality, which all must acknowledge, are there likewise universally human presuppositions for ethics? I remember clearly the strenuous labor of thought which for several days on end (in January 1886) kept me almost without interruption at my desk, until I had seen that, when one makes duly strict demands of justification, there is no ethics that can rationally be imposed on all, as logical, mathematical and natural-scientific propositions can. Psychological observation and historical experience show that human actions are judged from [151] widely differing presuppositions. And since pronounced typical differences assert themselves in the ways of thinking of men, — since, besides, constant shifts and changes take place in human nature and in the conditions under which it develops, one could not expect anything else either. Ethical judgments are passed, and must be passed, from different standpoints, which, even if they agree in their results, do not always agree in their justification. By logical analysis we can get back to the presuppositions peculiar to a single standpoint, but these are bound up with psychological and historical conditions which do not assert themselves in the same way where other standpoints are concerned. In a lecture I gave in February 1886 in the Royal Danish Academy of Sciences, of which I had become a member two years before, I sought to point out the main types that appear

when we go back to the first presuppositions of ethical judgments, all the way from the standpoint of the moment through the standpoint of individuality, the clan or family stage and the stage of nationality, to the universal stage of humanity. Ethical judgments vary consistently with the stages or types, even if they can meet at many points. After the lecture two Excellencies, Madvig, the President of the Academy, and the Minister of Justice Nellemann, raised the objection that the different stages ought to have been derived from “the Idea of Man.” I answered that I did not consider such a derivation possible. We are here on the ground of psychological and historical experience, and moreover it is precisely “the Idea of Man” (man’s innermost being) that appears differently at the different stages. — Madvig, for that matter, is said to have liked the lecture very much. According to what Vilhelm Thomsen told me, he said that it was a long time since a lecture so good in both form and content had been given in the Academy.

I see the position of ethics as analogous to the position of astronomy before Newton. Then too several different systems were possible (the Ptolemaic, the Copernican and the Tychonic). Whether ethics will get its Newton, I do not [152] know; at any rate he has not come yet. Every ethical view proceeds from definite presuppositions, and it is of decisive importance to become conscious of this. Every attempt at ethics that is to have significance must itself point to the psychological and historical conditions on which it rests. Here, as so often in science, the point is to take as one’s basis the hypothesis one can best work with. For my part, the universal human feeling of sympathy or humanity, which broke through in the Greco-Roman world after the time of Alexander and, after the ecclesiastical authority of the Middle Ages had lost its absolute rule, manifested itself again in the eighteenth century’s assertion of the rights of man, stood as a significant foundation which it was worth deepening and trying to apply in detail. What can be justified from these presuppositions can then be compared with what can be developed from other standpoints (individual self-preservation, family, nation etc.). “The Idea of Man” does, after all, express itself through different types, partly simultaneous, partly successive. Here we have what Fichte called a *projectio irrationalis*. Even where people meet in their results, the justifi-

cation can be different, and in the end what matters in ethics is the fundamental motive, the fundamental value, that determines the particular valuations. One can set up a civic or social morality without asking about the motives. But the ethical is, after all, not merely action but the expression of a disposition. And as regards motive, one must — this I first saw clearly now — distinguish between the motive of valuation (fundamental value) and the motive of action, since they need not coincide. Thus love of mankind as the motive of valuation can give rise to special motives of action such as justice, courage, helpfulness etc. The motive of valuation need not be the constant motive of action. It leads, on the other hand, to a valuation of the various possible motives of action. What in one ethical system can be a motive of action is perhaps in another a motive of valuation, and conversely.¹⁾

Later I have more often sought to make this clear, thus in “*Etiske Undersøgelser*” (1891) and in “*Den menneskelige Tanke*” (1910). And I have found a similar way of regarding the position of ethics in various scholars who do not seem to have known my work, thus in Georg Simmel, Heinrich Maier, Henri Poincaré and Alexander Shand. In my eyes it is a remnant of dogmatism when one does not see the matter in this way. —

When I had thus gained clarity about the position of ethics with respect to the theory of knowledge, I proceeded to the final working out of my Ethics on the basis of psychological, historical and economic material that I had collected over the years. I went into the particular conditions of human life as far as was possible for me. Yet it was mostly my general conception of ethics that attracted the attention of my critics. As a rule they took the matter lightly and found it reprehensible in itself that I denied the possibility of a single rational ethics that alone brings salvation. Or my ethics was called a morality of feeling, without heed to the more precise determinations I gave, and had already given in my Psychology, of the relation between idea and feeling and of the dependence of the life of feeling on social and historical conditions. There is still so much dog-

¹⁾In an essay on my work as an author, reprinted in “*Religiøse Tanketyper*” (1927), I have made use of the above characterization of what I aimed at in my “*Etik*.” But I do not consider it unnecessary to let it stand here. [Later note.]

matism in the air that people thought they could make ethics rational merely by saying “Reason!” or “Society!” or perhaps, if one was especially learned: “Clan!” As if reason could not enter the service of the most widely differing standpoints, and as if there were not many clans and many societies which, as experiences of the most recent date prove, do not always get on well together! — In wider circles it was presumably above all the even and thoroughgoing treatment of the different spheres of life in the light of one leading idea that has won this book so [154] many readers here and abroad.

An ethics, even if it seeks to go the way of justification as far as is possible, is not merely a theoretical work. It acquires practical significance both by what it denies and by what it asserts. The account I had given denied that a supernatural confirmation or a metaphysical justification was necessary, since human nature itself, as we can come to know it from experience, furnishes motives both for acting and for judging the action. It was therefore regarded in certain quarters as an ungodly book, and I know of young people who were severely taken to task because it was found among their books. From another side too, people held to this negative aspect. There were those who said: here, after all, there is no sanction, no confirmation by a higher power; why then should we live by this ethics? Let us rather abandon ourselves to all our desires and not care a damn what the moral philosopher says! — Theologians and anti-theologians often agree like brothers on the conclusion that if the traditional dogmas do not hold, and if there is no supernatural sanction for ethics, — “then let us eat and drink, for tomorrow we shall die!” —

Unlike many other ethicists, I deny moreover that any proof can be given of the very foundation on which ethics is built. Here several starting points are possible. But the point then is to draw the full consequences of the starting point one acknowledges. The demand for serious intellectual work holds for every standpoint that is to be called ethical at all, whether it takes egoism or altruism as its basis. If someone then says that he will not work at all and does not care about being consistent either, all discussion ceases, and there can then be question only of education, — of education by human beings, or of education by life.

[155] In opposition to the current freethinking I pointed out that serious and positive work was precisely what was required, both in theory and in practice, when one had given up the old faith. Greater demands are made precisely both on using one's understanding and on exercising self-discipline when one no longer leads one's life under the guidance of authority. —

Nearly 30 years have now passed since my *Ethics* came out, and I still acknowledge its essential thoughts. On particular points I have made changes or additions in later editions. Possibly, if I were to write it now, I would lay it out differently. In an outline I prepared for lectures at the Folk University (1901) (reprinted in the third volume of my *Mindre Arbejder*), I have indicated a somewhat different turn in the exposition, a more analytical line of thought.

Bjørnstjerne Bjørnson was much taken with my *Ethics* and wrote a review of it in a Norwegian paper, which certainly did a great deal for its spread. I had several times met him at meetings and festive occasions here in town. I came to know him more closely through my eldest brother, in whose house I often saw him. His vigorous and fresh nature, his tremendous eloquence and his enthusiasm for everything human made it a refreshment to be with him, even if one came to feel his desire to rule and to have the last word. Of his works I value his poems most; among the dramatic works it seems to me that the first part of "Over Evne" stands highest. In his novels (especially "Det flager" and "Paa Guds Veje") I have found much that refreshed me, though the moralizing tendency came out rather strongly there. Norwegian and Danish intellectual life owes him an extraordinary amount through the fresh, bold manner in which he asserted his humanism. Without mockery and goading, also without learned

[156] theorizing, he let an independent human side of life find expression and become accessible to large circles in images full of feeling. Without the fresh breath he brought, narrowness and dogmatism would have ruled even more than they do.

A little clash between us came in the year 1893 on the occasion of my essay "Filosofi som Kunst" (printed in the first series of "Mindre Arbejder"). I came

there to speak of how little a purely theoretical formula is able to express the right relation between self-assertion and self-surrender, and how art in its images can express what theory cannot. On this occasion I referred to Ibsen's "Bygmester Solnes." There the ruthless self-assertion in Solnes's personality is depicted, and it is shown how this ruthlessness makes him powerless and barren, but also how through Hilde's intervention he feels young again, and now commands such strength that he can do justice, which he could not do before. As a counterpart, morbid self-surrender and sense of duty are depicted in Mrs. Solnes, and it is shown how she would have been able to be more for others, and better able to fulfill the duties she talked so much about, if the need for self-assertion had stirred more strongly in her. I had made the express reservation that I did not understand everything in this poetic work, and did not approve of everything either, but took what I could use. And I had expressly remarked that a poet as such cannot decide whether what he depicts is the rule or the exception. Bjørnson now wrote me a letter on the occasion of this essay (from Aulestad, 10 May 1893), in which he did find "many striking things" in it, but was indignant that I had praised Ibsen's psychology and in particular praised "Bygmester Solnes." One ought not to admire so irresponsible a person as the Master Builder! Nor Hilde, who brings her dirty linen with her and finds a touchstone of the Master Builder's greatness in whether he gets dizzy or not! The letter ends with the words: "Hvad fan har vi filosofer til, naar de gør tilværelsen ugrejere ved at gøre [157] de ugrejeste Digterbilleder til Love for os?" — and it was signed "Deres vrede ven Bjørnstjerne Bjørnson."

I did not feel touched by these objections, since I had expressly stated that a poetic image in and of itself can just as well be the exception as the rule. What had interested me was the contrast between the two characters. In my reply I tried to make clear what I had praised in Ibsen. But Bjørnson stuck to his own view. The same summer he was down here, and I met him at a festive gathering at Klampenborg. When I came into the hall, he was standing with a number of guests in the opposite corner and shouted, as soon as he saw me: "Yes, you are wrong!" I thought that we should have to have it out over that. But the discussion

was not continued. And it left no sting.

In the following years I met Bjørnson more often in Copenhagen. I remember once, at a party at the home of one of our politicians where Hørup was present, that the conversation at table came to turn on the folk high schools, and that Hørup spoke of them with scorn and indignation. As often on such occasions, he went quite white in the face with exasperation. Bjørnson shouted across to him: "You must look happy, Hørup, you must look happy!" — But it did no good all the same. —

When Bjørnson was working on his cantata intended for the University of Kristiania ("Lyset"), he asked my advice regarding the content, which was to be a depiction of the triumphal progress of thought and enlightenment. I lent him books and went through his first draft, and also got several things in it corrected. There were some lines that I did not understand. The darkness of the Middle Ages and the longing for light were depicted. Then it said: "*One* found a way, — the greatest means of light the world has known!" I did not know for certain who was meant. Bjørnson answered that it was Guttenberg; — but, he added, [158] there was after all one more who invented the art of printing at the same time, — should one not then write: "*Two* found a way" —? I advised against it, however, since it sounded comic. The cantata itself I found magnificent, and I wished that we had its like at our University.

Later I had points of contact with Bjørnson through his interest in the Danish cause in North Schleswig. —

His friendship was an honor to me, and I was very glad of a telegram from him on my 60th birthday, which ran as follows: "Thanks for faithful friendship, thanks for what you taught me." —

I must also mention that the only review of a poetic work that I had written up to then concerned Bjørnson's "Poul Lange og Thora Parsberg." This drama had caused a great stir in Kristiania immediately on its appearance, because Bjørnson was said to have made very detailed use of the character and fate of his late friend, Minister of State Richter, as a model. I then received, like others down here, a telegram from "Verdens Gang" asking me to write a review as quickly as possible,

so that it could be seen how the drama affected those standing further off. I wrote this review quite *con amore*, since the depiction of character interested me. (It is reprinted in the second series of “Mindre Arbejder”). — A rather interesting piece of information about Bjørnson’s relation to this drama came to me some years later. A rich American by the name of Young, living in Minneapolis, was assembling a large library consisting of works by authors from various countries. He paid for the works himself, but the author concerned was to write something at the front of each book. When Mr. Young now applied to me as well, he sent me a list of Nordic authors who were already represented in the library, citing what they had written about their books. Bjørnson had written at the front of “Poul Lange”: “Written in hours of emotion, in the presence, so to speak, of my late friend.” —

Henrik Ibsen I came into contact with only a few times. For a number of [159] years it was an event for me when Ibsen’s books came. As in families where things go regularly, they came every second year, and one knew then that one had to be prepared for problems that could put a knife to one’s throat. I remember especially the evening I read “Gengangere.” It was a few years after my wife’s death, and I was not yet quite used to solitude. The terrible eeriness of Oswald’s death scene, which on a first reading (as at the first performances) came to determine the main impression, I do not forget. The room grew clammy and cold for me. What occupied me on later readings, and especially in Mrs. Hennings’s performance of the role of Mrs. Alving, was the retrospective understanding of her own and her son’s fate that one gained through her conversation with Pastor Manders (one of Peter Jerndorff’s best roles). Several times I have had occasion to stress the great art with which Ibsen, through the conversations of his characters, opens the way to an understanding of their present through their past. One evening in the early days of the “Students’ Society” Brandes had succeeded in getting Ibsen up there. It had evidently been hard going, and it looked as though Brandes had to pull him into the hall. It was the first time I saw Ibsen. He looked

most like a boatswain; broad and heavy-limbed, brown in the face, he sat motionless and with half-closed eyes. I had been asked to say a few words, and I dwelt then precisely on Mrs. Alving's character and fate, developing how Ibsen, through the backward glance, is able to make his figures clear to us. I would have liked a little word from Ibsen as to whether I had understood him rightly. A little word did come. He held out his hand to me across the table and said "Thank you!" — Some ten years later I was together with him in Kristiania, where by invitation I gave a lecture in the "Students' Society." The figure I met when I (after [160] he had looked for me in vain at the hotel) visited him at his home seemed to me very different from the boatswain of former days. A dainty little gentleman with the ribbon of an order in his buttonhole showed me his elegant apartment and his fine paintings. In conversation between the two of us he was very talkative, only avoiding any mention of his writings. Yet it was surely on this occasion that he told me that he had been asked to write the history of his works and explain how they came into being. I answered that he should not do so, since his readers were best served by solving for themselves the riddles his works posed. My real opinion, though, was that his explanations would be somewhat artificial and keep especially to particular impressions and moods whose significance could be understood only if more information were available than he could or would give. Nor, I suppose, did he ever seriously think of it. — At a farewell dinner that was given for me he was present, and I had him on my right. Here too he was in very high spirits and communicative, and in the course of the evening I noticed that he was constantly in conversation with someone or other. At table I proposed a toast to Norway, making use of the scene in "Lille Eyolf" where the Norwegian flag is hoisted to full mast. Afterward I heard that Ibsen had liked the speech.

The last time I saw Ibsen was when he visited Copenhagen in 1898, where his 70th birthday was celebrated, after it had first been celebrated both in Kristiania and in Stockholm. He was childishly glad of the fuss that was made of him, not least of the Grand Cross of the Dannebrog which the King had presented to him. At the Students' Society's celebration I gave one of the speeches for him. He came from the "Kvindelig Læseforening" and was very pleased with the homage

of which he had been the object there. “And how they could speak!” he repeated several times. In my speech (which is printed in the second series of “Mindre Arbejder”) I dwelt on his threefold struggle: to satisfy the demands of art, — to look the problems of the time in the face, — and to overcome the resistance of the reader and the spectator. I made use of some lines of his poem about his visit [161] to Egypt (“Ballonbrev”), where he tells of temple ruins and overturned images of gods which jut up out of the sand like the skeletons of perished caravans, and says that this culture went under because it lacked personalities. On this understanding he builds a hope for the future:

Paa begravne Karavaner
bygger jeg vor Fremtids Baner!

It is one of the few places in Ibsen where a hope surfaces, and I would gladly have heard a word from him about it. But he only said: “Thank you, — you applied that well!” Whether I had also applied it “rightly,” I was not told. — After that Valdemar Vedel spoke, and it was now expected that Ibsen would take the floor. There was great suspense when he rose — but it was only to say: “Thank you for this evening!” And then he left. The mood in the overcrowded hall was somewhat flat. But Marcus Rubin broke the gloom by jumping up on a chair and saying:

It was but a feast!
before the black night;
He was but a guest —
and now he is gone!

A full-throated laugh let the evening end in a conciliatory mood. How, indeed, could one have expected that the great eccentric should have unburdened his heart to a whole assembly and solved riddles for us which he himself surely struggled with, — insofar as the main thing for him was not that these riddles gave him motifs for depictions of human characters and human destinies. Only through such depictions did he know how to speak.

When I was putting the last touches to my “Etik,” of which I have spoken [162] here, I suffered from stubborn attacks of gallstones, by which I had also been troubled now and then before. It got better for a while, though, and in the spring of 1887 I lived for a time with my sons in Tisvilde, which at that time did not have the fashionable stamp it has now. I went about daily in the splendid forest, which with its hills and valleys, its dunes and its ravines, reminded me of my dear Jutland. After that I had a strenuous examination and then went out to Jyderup, where there was also glorious Danish countryside to wander in. But out there the attacks came back, and they recurred when I came to town. Julius Petersen then insisted that I should take a cure at Carlsbad. So I set off, visited Friedrich Paulsen in Berlin and then steamed through Saxon Switzerland down into Bohemia. When we had crossed the border, the train became a local train (Bummelzug), and in the end I was left alone in the compartment with a pale, fat, sickly and despondent-looking gentleman. I myself did not feel well and had all sorts of forebodings of new attacks. After my fellow traveler had long sat staring at me, he said at last: “Haben Sie auch extravagiert?” In spite of my indisposition I chuckled inwardly at this “auch,” but I rejected his hypothesis with cold superiority, explaining to him that my case came from too much diligence and sitting still.

The cure at Carlsbad was not strict, but very dulling. In the end I was not able to read four lines in a newspaper, and I was horrified when I thought that in a month or so I was to lecture in Copenhagen. The cure did me good above all through the complete rest, the constant walks and the strict diet that was enjoined. I was not free of the attacks, however, until several years later. For many years I never traveled away to stay overnight without taking with me the morphine syringe that my doctor had entrusted to me. I felt no temptation to become a morphine addict. Only in a few cases did the injections call up beautiful dream visions before I fell asleep; and almost always there were very unpleasant after-effects.

In the eighties, besides my *Psychology*, psychological works by my colleagues [163] Kroman and Lehmann had appeared, and since rather considerable divergences between our views became apparent on various points, I set about in the winter of 1888–89 giving a fuller account of my psychological standpoint and meeting the objections that had been raised against it. The result was a treatise which in 1889 was printed in *Videnskabernes Selskabs Skrifter* under the title “*Psykologiske Undersøgelser*.” Here I have developed, more thoroughly than could be done in the “*Psykologi*,” the doctrine of the different kinds of recognition, of the association of ideas, of the different stages of the will and of the relation between mind and body. On several points this work also became a preparation for a work on the theory of knowledge which was completed only 20 years later, but whose foundations I had already begun to lay, at the same time as I was preparing a connected account of the history of modern philosophy.

The autumn of 1889 brought me into a polemical stance toward Georg Brandes, on the occasion of his unlimited and, in my eyes, uncritical praise of Nietzsche’s theories of the Overman and of the opposition between the great men and the great mob. Against his essay “*Aristokratisk Radikalisme*” (in “*Tilskueren*”) I wrote (likewise in “*Tilskueren*”) an essay which I called “*Demokratisk Radikalisme*.” I do not deny that there was something in Nietzsche’s views, as well as in the overvaluation of which they were the object, that aroused my indignation. If it could really be shown historically that the individual, scattered great men constituted the only thing that could give life and history value, then one would have to resign oneself to it. One cannot fight against a fact. Then “the great mob,” as Nietzsche said, would be only “copies, means or hindrances” in relation to them. But that we should admire this fact and find existence significant because of it, that was in my eyes just as absurd a demand as when it is demanded [164] from the theological side that we should admire the divine world order with its heaven and its hell. Now I denied first of all that the fact was there. Experience and history show us a whole series of degrees of independence and originality,

and in such a way that the difference of degree is often succeeded by a difference of quality. There are greatnesses of different kinds, and it will be difficult here to establish an order of rank. Independence is moreover required in order to understand and to acknowledge greatness. Without this understanding and acknowledgment greatness has no significance for development, nor for the development of the great ones of the future. The value of the great rests on their influence as founders, originators and models. One may well say with Schiller that noble natures signify something by what they are, not by what they do. But precisely by what they are, they act to strengthen, to advance and to give direction.

What not least repelled me in Nietzsche was the presupposition that an essential aspect of superiority and greatness should consist in a feeling of power conditioned by the distance at which one sees the others moving about below oneself. Nietzsche entangles himself here in a curious contradiction: if this feeling of distance is to be a necessary element, then the great become dependent on the small, since they must have someone to look down on. Nietzsche expressly ascribes to the mob the reactive feelings, that is to say, such feelings as are determined by the relation to others and exclude living one's life out of oneself alone. But his Overmen too, after all, become reactive.

The controversy was continued through a series of articles from both sides all winter long. A whole series of side questions (on the significance of science, on the principles of ethics, on the origin of morality) were discussed. The whole [165] thing came together for me, as I sought to establish in my "Epilog," in the question whether any human being can be said to be an end without at the same time being a means, or to be a means without at the same time being an end. It was Kant's old formula that I took up, after I had sought in my *Ethics* to give it a new justification. —

It was no small thing for me to come forward against Georg Brandes. In liberal circles his standing was overwhelming, and he was regarded as a symbol or a prophet who must not be touched, not criticized. In particular the circle in which I moved, apart from those closest to me, regarded him as sacred and invi-

olable. Marcus Rubin, when he heard of my intention to write against Brandes, wrote me a long letter in which he urgently begged me to refrain. He admitted that there was much to dissociate oneself from, but ended with the words: “Of Brandes I say: quand même!” I could not see that because Brandes was the object of much hateful, stupid and unjust criticism, he should therefore not be open to criticism at all. I began the article with a warm acknowledgment of his significance for Danish intellectual life: “I will not [begin my criticism] without first and foremost, and in all sincerity, stating what our literature and our intellectual life owe to this man’s brilliant gifts and great ability to awaken and inspire. I do not think that his significance can be expressed by saying that he has put problems up for debate; for he has never really wanted to be a thinker himself; — what has been his strength has been his great ability to point, with energy and warmth, or, to use an expression he seems to favor of late, with violence, to such intellectual and literary phenomena as he considers it worth occupying oneself with and letting oneself be influenced by. Even those who in their own field have learned nothing from him, and who in many respects have perhaps felt themselves at a distance from him, cannot but follow his activity with sympathy and be grateful to him for the life and the movement he has awakened. I here even leave aside the wonderful gift he possesses for evocative characterization, [166] which makes his works of literary history so attractive.”

It was, moreover, my sincere opinion that the ill treatment he had been subjected to here at home had not affected him so much that he could not well bear a criticism coming from an entirely different side from the one from which he had hitherto been attacked almost exclusively. Ardent Brandesians naturally could not see the matter in this way. In the coverage our controversy received in the press, there was not much engagement with the very question at issue, — in my eyes a testimony to how superficial a purely literary or aesthetic culture can be, even if for a time it has as its program “to put problems up for debate.” — Marcus Rubin wrote in “Politiken” a so-called account of the controversy, with many fine-sounding words, with the obligatory homage to Brandes and a benevolent pat on the shoulder for me, but without understanding of what it was about. And

this article was regarded by many as a word in season. I would rather he had attacked me, for Bacon is surely right that truth emerges sooner from error than from confusion.

The press of the Right naturally claimed me for its own, but when Brandes, in one of his later articles, in the heat of the controversy, reduced me to a mere nonentity, it turned around and used him against me, and we then came to stand as two zeros who had nevertheless got into a fight with each other as though they were real quantities.

It is correct, what Brandes says in his *Levned*, that the controversy was conducted "with unnecessary sharpness on both sides." It is no doubt also correct, what he adds, that for his part he let himself "be led into teasing mockery." And I admit that I felt hurt by several of his utterances. But I never failed to recognize his superior gifts and his flaming enthusiasm for a free intellectual life. It is not [167] easy to reckon up what we owe him. And as will be seen from the foregoing, I owe him much, also as regards the form of my exposition. The very controversy that I had now carried on with him became of significance for my development.

A couple of years later some of his friends and admirers wished to celebrate the 25th anniversary of his first book. I confess that I wavered a great deal as to whether I should take part or not. The issue was decided by the enthusiasm with which my sons followed his lectures on Shakespeare. I signed up, and then received a request from the festival committee to speak, which I promised, only I would not give the main speech of the evening. Once the decision had been taken, it came easily to me to bring out what for me was the main thing in Brandes's work, and even to look back on the controversy with humor. The speech, which is printed in the second series of my "*Mindre Arbejder*," fell on good ground. I was myself moved in giving it, and I saw Brandes shed tears while I spoke. Later in the evening he said to me, what he has repeated in his *Levned*, that I had heaped coals of fire on his head.

Shortly afterward he wrote to me: "Strange is what has become of the subject of our controversy. Since I first drew attention to Nietzsche in 1887, he has become the fashionable philosopher the world over." — It was indeed also the case

that the followers Nietzsche got, especially in Germany, were rather dependent imitators (“copies”); but that agreed precisely with his own theory.

In the year 1902 I went through Nietzsche’s philosophy in a series of public lectures on modern philosophers. By now his writings and drafts were available more completely, and his letters had begun to appear. I sought to show that what had been most striking from a purely literary point of view, the doctrine of master and slave morality and of social dualism, together with the contempt for the great mob, — that this was, in Nietzsche’s whole line of thought as one could now survey it, something derived, not something fundamental. His fundamental idea was the welfare of the species (not of individuals, not even of the great), and he thought — admittedly inconsistently — that social dualism was a condition for it. Brandes and I had agreed in regarding Nietzsche as an opponent of the morality of welfare, and now it turned out that it was his fundamental idea¹⁾. Nietzsche’s personality has interested me greatly, not through his sister’s at once idolatrous and self-satisfied account, but through the Swiss Bernouilli’s book on his relation to the two people who were probably closest to him, the Basel professor Overbeck and his wife. [168]

Through all this I had continued my studies, which now concerned especially the history of modern philosophy, on which I also gave public lectures for several years. After the completion of my *Psychology* and my *Ethics*, the next task I set myself was to give a reasonably full account of the history of philosophy in modern times. This task was naturally connected with the plan for an account of the main problems of philosophy in their mutual relation, a plan which, as mentioned earlier, dated from 1874, and which constantly occupied me.

The history of Greek philosophy I had lectured on in the winter of 1885–86. Later I went through Aristotle’s *Ethics* in special seminars, which were repeated

¹⁾I take the opportunity to correct a slip of memory. It is not (as is said in “*Moderne Filosofer*” p. 145) the “Midnight Song” (in Part 4 of *Zarathustra*) that Nietzsche calls “the loneliest song that has ever been written”; it is the “*Nachtlied*” (in Part 2) of which this is said. In the foreign editions of “*Moderne Filosofer*” I have had this error corrected.

when the Laboratory for the History of Philosophy was established. Here I have also repeatedly gone through Plato's "Republic." Greek thought has continued to be of great significance for me, as it already was at my first acquaintance with philosophy. I sometimes made forays on particular points, as will be seen from my "Mindre Arbejder." It is my conviction that for the study of philosophy an
[169] orientation in Greek thought is indispensable. It should always be the case that at least one of the University's teachers of philosophy is able to conduct a seminar on subjects from Greek philosophy in such a way that he himself relies on the original text, even if most of his hearers must use translations. That is something I have energetically stressed during the deliberations on filling vacant chairs of philosophy. Greek thought lies to such a degree at the root of all European philosophy that a many-sided and unprejudiced study of the latter must go back to it. There should always be forces at the University that are able to go back to it. Even if there are classical philologists who take an interest in this side of their subject, as I too have had the pleasure of experiencing, it is nevertheless only independent philosophical study that can say the decisive word here. For my own part, it was not for lack of desire that I gave up working out an account of the history of Greek philosophy, but because I had to limit myself, and the philosophy of the last three centuries was naturally of the greatest direct significance for the position of the problems in the present. But the limitation was not carried through without resignation.

In my treatment of the history of modern philosophy I laid more weight on problems than on systems and sought more to characterize than to report. Through the characterization the criticism then comes out of its own accord. To the characterization there belonged also an investigation of the relation between the philosopher's personality and his doctrine, and several of the small biographies I wrote *con amore*. Besides this, I laid great weight on the relation of philosophy to other sciences, especially natural science, and in my account Kopernikus, Galilei, Newton, Darwin and Robert Mayer therefore came to stand in prominent places, because, whether one will call them philosophers or not, through their research they gave the impulse to significant changes in the way philosophical

problems were posed. On particular points I first worked out monographs. To these belongs a treatise in Videnskabernes Selskabs Skrifter on “Kontinuiteten i Kant’s filosofiske Udviklingsgang.” My book on Kierkegaard, and the later book on Rousseau, also belong here. The writing of the work took place at various times, not in chronological order. The last part to be written, and perhaps the best shaped, is the section on the Renaissance. [170]

The book came out in parts in the years 1894 and 1895 and was soon afterward translated into German, French, English, Spanish and Italian. Next to my *Psychology*, it is the one of my books that has been most widely circulated. It amused me to hear various expert readers each single out a different section. Dilthey singled out, in a letter to me, the section on German philosophy from Kant to Hegel as testifying to thorough understanding. The Scottish philosopher Pringle-Pattison singled out the section on English philosophy in the 19th century as understanding and critical. The Italian ambassador in England, San Giuliano, to whom I was introduced in Cambridge in 1909, thanked me for the account of the Italian Renaissance, which he meant to make use of in a lecture he was to give in Oxford. — From the German accounts of the history of modern philosophy my book differs, among other things, by its detailed treatment of French and English philosophy in the 19th century. Even those Germans who do not adhere to the speculative school are inclined to regard the development in Germany as the main thing and to treat the philosophy of other countries in an appendix.

If the section on the Renaissance should be more successful than other sections, it is perhaps because I made the draft of it during an idyllic summer stay in Finland. The summer vacation of 1893 I spent, that is, with my second-youngest brother Theodor Høffding, who in the spring of 1869, as a young polytechnic graduate, had gone to Russia, where he worked first as a railway engineer, later as a factory manager and as a contractor. In the summer of 1893 he lived with his family at a country house in eastern Finland, near Wiborg, by a lake that was connected with the great Lake Saima. It was a glorious summer, which was spent on walks and sailing trips, on one occasion on a trip up through Lake Saima with its [171]

thousand islands to Wilmanstrand and Punkoharja, and from there to the Imatra Falls. Since I have never been able to take a summer vacation without work, I had Giordano Bruno's works with me over there and spent some hours each day with this enthusiastic thinker, who stands as the prophetic herald of the world-view of the modern age.

The visit to Finland, with which a few days' stay in Petrograd was combined, acquired a special value for me through the life I shared with my brother and his family. He had been my playmate in my childhood, but had now long lived away from his native place. He had become a Russian citizen, and his way of thinking had become entirely Russian. But just as on a later visit to him, and on his visit to me, when we had both passed 70, I felt the brotherly bond and experienced the understanding that can exist between close relatives, even if their work and their homes have come to lie in the most widely different regions.

Roughly from the time I have spoken of here, a beginning was made of some regular gatherings which I have had, and have, much joy of. The first occasion was that after the meetings in the Academy I often walked along with the physiologist Chr. Bohr, and that we then often continued the conversation at a café, where we had supper. I had already come into contact with Bohr earlier. When he heard, in his time, that I was working on a Psychology in which I wished to take as much account as possible of physiological viewpoints and results, he offered his help in going through the relevant sections. The evening visits thereby occasioned brought many later ones in their train, and in his and his wife's beautiful home in the stately residence of the professor of physiology I have spent many interesting and pleasant evenings. As a physiologist he belonged, being a disciple of the Leipzig researcher Ludwig, to the school that would carry through strictly the application of physico-chemical methods in physiology. Outside his laboratory he was an ardent devotee of Goethe. When he expressed himself on practical matters or on views of life, it was usually in the form of paradox and as a rule improvised. The conversation often took on new life through his intervention. At our café visits after meetings of the Academy the physicist Christiansen

[172]

soon became the third man. He and Bohr had many interests in common, since Bohr's physiological method led him to thorough studies in physics. I had, as told earlier, known Christiansen from his very young days, and our friendship had stood its test in spite of the different ways we went where the limits of scientific thought lie. He loved literature and biographies and is still, in his old age, an enthusiastic reader of Homer. Like Bohr he is fond of paradoxes, which he often holds on to with Jutland tenacity, and he likes to go against the current. He retired when he turned 69, on account of illness, and then spent a year abroad, especially on the Riviera. From this stay he came back with renewed interest in experimental work. In a letter to me from Italy he says that he wishes for a task in which he can be wholly absorbed. In this too he has succeeded, and he works steadily and eagerly some 4–5 hours a day. The rest of the time he reads Homer or some good biography or other. In general there are several examples of how one can, as professor emeritus, get just as much to do as before. New tasks come along besides the old ones one wants to put the last touches to, and there is still so much that one would after all like to become acquainted with before it is over. — But I must get back to our gatherings.

The trefoil that had formed grew tired of café life, and it was then arranged [173] that we took turns going home with one another on the Friday evenings when there was a meeting in the Academy. At the same time we now acquired a fourth man in the famous linguist Vilhelm Thomsen. I had made his acquaintance when we were for a time teachers together at Maribo School. Later I met him again when he taught my brother Theodor Russian before the latter's journey to Russia, and later again when we became colleagues at the University. A closer friendship began when for several winters we did gymnastics together at a school on Mynsters Vej. We usually walked together from there in pleasant morning conversations, and I soon began to be a guest in his home. And I have come to be deeply fond of him and feel closely bound to him. He is a quiet man, but he takes part gladly in all kinds of conversation, and his mild eyes and warm-hearted manner make one want to speak out. I once said in his home, on a festive occasion, that there was no place where I talked as much as in his

house. Of his own works he seldom speaks. Yet I remember that one Monday morning, as we walked from gymnastics, he said in his quiet way: "I rather think I made a discovery on Saturday evening." And then he explained to me how he had found the key to the alphabet in which an old inscription on the border between Siberia and China was written, and had thereby also discovered an Old Turkic dialect hitherto unknown. During our gatherings he was always eager to investigate every linguistic or historical detail that came up, provided he did not have the explanation ready to hand. His wife and daughter often joked about his eagerness to "look it up." The evenings in his home were not the least pleasant among the many good evenings I owe to the company of the three friends I have spoken of here.

When the Academy moved into its new premises in the splendid building in which the Carlsberg Foundation has given it meeting rooms and offices, it [174] became the custom that the members drank tea together after the meetings and spent an hour or so in conversation in the pleasant rooms. Our little club was then moved to the Friday evenings when no meetings were held. The gatherings are still held as I write this. But Bohr has passed away, and we miss him greatly. — A change has been introduced in the very last few years on my (somewhat egoistic) proposal, namely that the ladies also take part in the gatherings outside their homes, just as they had always given the gatherings in their own homes coziness and charm.

V

In the autumn of 1894 a change took place in my domestic arrangements. As [175] mentioned before, after my wife's death I had not wanted to have any "lady of the house". I wanted no intermediary between myself and my children, and I could not imagine anyone who, without being my wife, could take a mother's place. There was no lack, from time to time, of remonstrances from my family in that direction. They thought that I was doing my sons a wrong by letting them go without a real hearth, a center that would always be ready when they needed conversation or comfort. I was, after all, always taken up with work and was not so seldom out in the evening. Yet I believe that we often had a good time together. When hypochondria, or other, more agreeable guests, did not present themselves, we read together, especially Homer and Shakespeare, whom I know my sons learned from me to know and to love. And often dinner or supper went on long because of conversations that had got under way. But perhaps it was not often enough. I believe that my youngest son in particular felt a want here. He often spoke with enthusiasm of the comfort there was in the homes of his friends, where the mother at her lamp in the living room was always available to anyone who had something on his mind or simply wanted a little chat. A living room was lacking in my house. We each had our own room, and then a dining room. Only work and eating, no hearth, had their place.

My sister-in-law Elisabeth (married to my eldest brother, the wholesale merchant Victor Høffding) had often reproached me with this, and at the beginning [176] of 1894 she came with a regular declaration of war on the subject. Elisabeth was a remarkable personality, clear and all of a piece, finely cultivated and with many

interests. She lived in an exceedingly happy marriage. She and my brother were, even in their old age, like two young people engaged. They kept a fine and hospitable house, but at bottom they were happiest when they were alone. They enjoyed the evenings in their cozy and tasteful home, and the summer at their country house near Frederiksdal, and they got a great deal out of their travels. I always had great respect for her, even if I did not always understand her rightly. She was one of those who did not much need others, and therefore she believed that others did not need her either. There was therefore always a certain reserve in her manner. All the greater the impression made by a letter I received from her on 17 January 1894. She wrote that I lacked comfort in my home, but that in any case my sons, especially the youngest, did. "I think," she wrote further, "that one need not talk long with Hans before one notices what an undercurrent of longing runs through him for a cozy home ... To have in the house a kindly being who cares for one, who in an hour of dusk or in the evening, when one needs to rest a little, will listen to one's chat, to whom one can read aloud or show a little attention in some other way, is for the young a well-being that he consciously or unconsciously feels the need of. But tell me, where is Hans to go with his need? Emil is, after all, not like others; he seems to be sufficient unto himself, though one cannot really know. But Hans? When he comes home, you three have a meal, and whether it turns out lively or empty presumably depends on what humor you are in. Then he presumably sits down to read, and reads until evening, if a friend does not drop in on him, or he has to go out I do not know what your reasons may have been for so stubbornly refusing a woman to bring up your children; they may have been many and perhaps justified; but [177] I know that for a number of years I have looked up to you as the least egoistic person I knew; only here did I find egoism in you. I believe you have thought more of yourself than of your sons in this. If you do not now draw a line through it altogether, then let me, or your sister, or whomever you like, have leave to seek out someone. If there is one who seems to fit, you can always decide for or against. Only I think that if a change is to be made, the time is now, since it is your intention in the near future to part with your housekeeper, and the longer

time goes on, the harder it becomes for the young ones to grow used to living with a stranger.”

For many days and nights I thought over what had here been laid so urgently on my heart. I could not overcome my reluctance to take a stranger into my house, who would come to stand in a strange intermediate position between myself, my children and my servants. I know that other widowers have overcome this difficulty; but I could not. Nor would I be able to marry for my children’s sake; nor, to speak frankly, do I believe that any widower has done it, even if it was put down to the children’s account.

Then one night I had an idea, and it concerned another sister-in-law. — The same year that my wife died, my second eldest brother Valdemar had also passed away. He died suddenly of a heart attack. He had been a merchant captain, but after father’s death had entered the firm as cashier. His widow, Maria, née Bøving, now lived with two grown-up daughters, and it had now been settled that the elder of these should travel to America to marry her fiancé, the engineer Nissen, who a couple of years before had gone over there and had found himself a position there. My sister-in-law and her younger daughter were then thinking of moving into a smaller flat. My thought was that I would propose that we combine our households, so that she with her daughter and I with my two sons made up one household. The proposal was accepted, and in the four years the life [178] together lasted, my sons and I had a truly cozy home. We lived in Christianshavn, first in Brogade, later in Strandgade. My sister-in-law Maria was lively and quick, independent in her way of thinking and receptive to everything beautiful, careful and loving as mistress of the house. We got on well together. Daily life now took a less monotonous shape than before. The lamp burned in the living room as a sign of unity for old and young. We read together, and a pleasant young circle gathered around us. Now and then I could now see friends and colleagues at my home in a more festive way. More propriety and order came into my household, and this had its effects beyond the time the life together lasted. That it came to an end was due partly to my sister-in-law’s nervousness, which made the housekeeping weigh on her as a heavy burden, partly to the circumstance that

her elder daughter with husband and child was now returning from America, and that she would rather live with them. The younger daughter, Jenny, later married an Italian painter and died in Sicily of pneumonia.

In the year 1896, at the invitation of others, I took part in a holiday course in Zurich, at which lectures were given on ethics, pedagogy and political economy. I was to give lectures on the principles of ethics.

On the journey I spent some days in Berlin, where I renewed my acquaintance with the museums and visited Friedrich Paulsen in his villa in Steglitz. In Dresden too there was great art to renew my acquaintance with. From there I made an excursion down into Bohemia to visit Professor Friedrich Jodl, who was staying in the country there. I had come into contact with him through Gizycki, and he had written a very fine review of my *Ethics* in “*Deutsche Literaturzeitung*”, one of the reviews that have pleased me most. He had for some years been professor in Prague, but had now been appointed professor in Vienna. What was [179] interesting in this was that I too had been under discussion in the Vienna faculty, as Theodor Gomperz, the well-known author of “*Griechische Denker*”, had told me after the matter had been settled. Even if I had been asked, I would not have accepted the invitation. In the first place I could not imagine any sphere of work outside Denmark, and in the second place conditions in Vienna were very difficult because of the sharp national and religious antagonisms. Jodl was well suited to work under these conditions, and he had a significant career there right up to his death at a relatively young age. He is the author of a *Psychology* and of a *History of Ethics*, both very able works. I spent an interesting day with him and his wife at their summer residence. During our walks we discussed various problems, and there turned out to be great agreement between us as regards direction of thought and the way of posing problems. A somewhat different position we took toward the religious problem, as became apparent especially later. Jodl really did not recognize any problem here at all, but thought that Feuerbach had once and for all settled the matter. I always saw both a psychological and an ethical problem here, which it was important to get formulated in the right way.

From Dresden I went by way of Stuttgart to Switzerland. There were still a few weeks before the lectures were to begin, and so I went by Lucerne and Stanz up to Engelberg, where I stayed a couple of weeks. Around the old monastery, which was still inhabited by monks, a hotel town had grown up here, high up in a mountain valley, from which one could really enjoy the mountain air and take splendid walks. I here made the acquaintance of a lawyer, Alscher, from Königsberg and his wife, two lively and interesting people, with whom I often went walking and could talk about everything under the sun, right from Dante to the political questions of the present day. For several years afterward we kept up a correspondence. Now they are both dead, and I know from a daughter's letter [180] that they had not forgotten their Danish companion on the mountain walks. A small characteristic scene from the table d'hôte I must relate. I sat opposite a family from Dresden and often talked with a young lady who belonged to it. They were mostly joking remarks that passed between us. But one day she had found out that I was a professor, and asked with great interest how often I had fought duels. When I answered that I had never taken part in that, she exclaimed in the highest degree astonished: "Aber, mein Herr, sind Sie dann ein Streber gewesen?" ("Streber" means in German student language a swot who curries favor with the professor and thinks only of getting a good examination, for which reason he does not take part in student life.) I answered: "Nein, mein Fräulein, es gibt noch ein Drittes!" And I explained what the ideal of a student was with us, an ideal one could strive for without fighting duels. The people at the table were indignant with the young lady, and she looked very unhappy. Then I took my glass and said: "Nun, Fräulein, last uns anstossen und immerfort gute Freunde bleiben!" At that she became enthusiastic and cried: "Ja, mein Herr, die grossen Geister, sie begegnen doch immer wieder einander!" — This the old ladies found the height of impudence, and I had to defend my young friend, with whom I also had a pleasant time in the period that followed during the long table d'hôte hours. —

In Zurich I came to live in a boarding house up on the Zürichberg, where from my room I had a view over Lake Zurich and in clear weather could see the Bernese Alps. I gave up this room, however, after a few days to Tönnies,

whose acquaintance I made in Zurich, where he too was to give lectures. I knew him as the author of some excellent studies of Hobbes, and of a very interesting work “*Gemeinschaft und Gesellschaft*”, which I had reviewed in “*Tilskueren*”, and which gives an excellent characterization of the transition from the old “community”, built on family ties, custom and usage, to the modern “society”, which is built on the acquisitive drive, and where an external social mechanism takes the place of the natural bonds of connection. Later on, when the book came out in a second edition, he did me the honor of dedicating it to me. I had imagined Tönnies as a powerful Frisian (he came from the same district as Friedrich Paulsen), broad and solid, partly because of the energy of his style, partly because of his Marxist radicalism. But I saw before me a fine and slight man, soft-spoken and nervous, also weak in health. He was unhappy about the room he had been given; he could not sleep there because of the noise all around. So I let him have mine — but the next morning he complained again: “*Ich bin ein Pechvogel!*” For a gentleman had moved in that same evening into the room next door, and he snored abominably! — Tönnies and I became good friends and are still in touch. He has repeatedly visited me, and I have also visited him in Eutin, where he lives.

It was a very pleasant boarding house we lived in. The old lady, who had charge of the kitchen, one did not see much of during the day, but as I was up early, I usually saw her at morning coffee, and we had many a good chat. She said on that account: “*Ach, ich mag so gern mit dem Herrn Professor philosophieren!*” — Among the residents I became better acquainted with two married couples from Berlin who had come for the sake of the lectures, the lawyer Bieber and his wife and Medicinalrat Schwerin and his wife. Bieber was a liberal man in the best sense of the word, who had made a name for himself as defense counsel for Social Democrats at the time when the Prussian government was proceeding harshly against them. Of the ladies I came to set great store by Frau Jeanette Schwerin. This finely cultivated lady, who read her Dante in Italian and translated Leo Hebræo, took an eager part in philanthropic endeavors in Berlin. She [182] learned there time after time how difficult it was to help women who were treated brutally by their husbands, because they were without rights against them. And

that was the reason she became an ardent champion of woman's economic and social independence. She is one of the noblest and most gifted women I have met in my life. She died only three years later, so that I did not come to see her again. In the later editions of my *Ethics* I have mentioned her and her work.

A remarkable man I met in Zurich was the old Colonel Egidy, who had resigned his commission in order to work for a free and purely human religion. He was in decided opposition to many things in the German character. When one day at the boarding-house table, where he and several participants in the lecture work also ate, I remarked that I could not bring myself to address German ladies as "Gnädige Frau", because it was so servile, he rose in enthusiasm and came over to me and said: "Herrlicher Mann, lass mich Sie umarmen! Das ist ganz aus meinem Herzen gesprochen!" — Also speaking in Zurich was the well-known economist Werner Sombart, who in a brilliant series of lectures set forth the ideas of Marxism in a somewhat dogmatic way. In the discussions that were held after the close of each series of lectures, I came forward with a criticism of Marxism along the same lines as the one I have given in my *Ethics*. Later this gifted man has taken up a more critical standpoint. Both him and Tönnies I met some years later in America. — In the discussion that was held after my lecture, I had especially to defend my theory of the different, logically irreducible ethical types.

I had an enjoyable evening in Zurich on a visit to the Scandinavian workers' association. I turned up without further ado on a meeting night and was received very kindly. There were speeches and singing, and the young journeymen who were gathered had a bright and cheerful spirit. They were mainly journeyman painters who had work in Zurich, where in those years there was much building. [183] I gave a contribution to the association's funds and received an emblem with the Scandinavian colors. It was a Nordic evening in the midst of the German-speaking land. — The next New Year I received a telegraphed greeting from "the traveling journeymen in Zurich".

I had been happy in Zurich and had come to know worthy and interesting people, and it was with sadness that I left. According to what was later written

to me, several young people had turned up at the station to bring me a farewell greeting, but they had mistaken the time.

It was in the spring of 1898 that my sister-in-law, who now for four years had run my house and created its comfort, felt she was no longer strong enough for it. Besides, she now wanted to move to her elder daughter, who was returning home from America. It was a great disappointment to me, but I resolved to make use of the good running order she had brought my household into, and simply try to maintain it. She had engaged two capable maids who were glad to stay with me. And this led to the household order I have lived under since.

There had gradually formed a circle of young people who regularly visited us. They were mainly friends of my youngest son, but some young ladies also belonged to the circle. I now arranged it so that they came every Thursday to dinner, and that the afternoon and evening were spent in music, singing or reading. I had much joy from these evenings. I owe to them a closer acquaintance with music, with which I would otherwise not have become familiar. I took especial delight in Beethoven's Fifth Symphony, which two young people played for me as a piano duet. These Thursday gatherings continued until the little circle was scattered by the dispensations of life.

[184] For a number of years I had followed with interest the conditions in North Schleswig, where the Danish population with steady firmness worked to assert its language and its national culture, and I had often been glad to meet outstanding men from over there. In a lecture I gave in the autumn of 1898 in Kolding, later repeated in Copenhagen and had printed in "Tilskueren", I sought to show that much of what Fichte in his famous "Reden an die Deutsche Nation" emphasizes in order to strengthen his people's courage under oppression fits the struggle of the Danish Schleswigers nowadays. The lecture was attacked in German papers, and I answered the attacks in "Kieler Zeitung". Shortly before, I had written

some articles in “Frankfurter Zeitung” and in “Ethische Kultur” on the language situation in North Schleswig. On that occasion I received a letter from the well-known philosopher Rudolph Eucken in Jena, of which I quote a part, because it bears witness that there are excellent men in Germany who see clearly and courageously in this matter. It says in the letter (which is written 3 April 1898): “Auch ich empfinde solche Beeinträchtigung des natürlichen Rechtes einer Bildung in der Muttersprache peinlich und kann darin nur eine Überspannung der Nationalitätsprincipes erblicken. Wir ereifern uns heute über das ‘cujus regio, ejus religio’ der 16. u. 17. Jahrhunderts; — heute scheint man fast überall nach dem Grundsatz zu handeln, ‘cujus regio, ejus natio’, und darüber werden spätere Jahrhunderte kaum günstiger urtheilen”. Eucken finds an excuse in the fact that most Germans have no idea of the conditions in North Schleswig, and ends by saying: “Nach meiner Überzeugung wäre es im wahren Interesse Deutschlands, das Gebiet, dessen Grundstock anerkannterweise dänisch ist, Dänemark freiwillig abzutreten.” He thinks that from this would spring a cordial relation and a fruitful interaction between Denmark and Germany.

In political life, after I had moved from Frederiksberg, I took part only as a [185] nominator at Folketing elections. Slowly but steadily the old Højre party was dissolving; it wore out all its significant men in the hopeless struggle and by the hopeless means that were used in the struggle. Meanwhile conditions within the Opposition were not pleasant. It suffered from the long period of waiting, in which all objective interest threatened to fall away, and in which a brisk and teasing newspaper article stood as the only possible feat that could be spoken of. The alliance between the new literary movement and oppositional politics, which I had in my time been so much against, had indeed not quite answered to the great expectations some had cherished, but it was still at work through its consequences. The paper “Politiken” had in its time been founded precisely on this alliance. The consequence of this was that those who held to the paper as the Left’s chief organ also had to take its literary reviews as sound goods, or in any

case had to put a good face on the game, even if they found the game ever so bad. And the paper's literary articles now became more and more marked by a wantonness and a frivolity that could not but arouse both sorrow and indignation. It was especially Edvard Brandes who let himself go in a way that even made men who stood close to him say that he must be suffering from a monomania. I had on one single occasion protested against the tone of the paper, where it was directed at a man for whom I had reverence, however far from him I otherwise stood. It was a scandalous article about Bishop Kierkegaard that I objected to, naturally with the result that I was taken to task in an editorial postscript. I had not, however, broken off relations with the paper. Shortly before the episode I shall now speak of, I had written a review in it of my late friend Johannes Fibiger's autobiography. All the more was I indignant to read, in those same days, a literary review (of "Damen paa Natkaféen"), in which the height of frivolity was reached.

[186] At this point two men came up one day to me, the author Alfred Ipsen and the journalist Mads Jepsen, and appealed to the duties I had toward Danish youth to protest against this abuse by being one of the conveners of a public meeting at which there was to be a protest against the tone that had spread in the press, first and foremost in "Politiken", but also in other papers. The two gentlemen did not exactly inspire me with much confidence as regards impartiality and freedom from prejudice, and I was not much inclined toward that kind of meeting. But I had long been vexed, also at the fact that I myself did nothing, and I therefore gave my signature, thinking that I otherwise need have nothing to do with the meeting. That I signed was due in part to my being told that Valdemar Vedel, whose literary judgment I trusted more than my own, had given his support. It turned out afterward that Vedel's support had been obtained only on condition that I would take part. In a not entirely honest way two half assents had been made to count as two whole ones. The invitation to the meeting was signed by 15 men (the University teachers Vilhelm Thomsen, Gertz, Viggo Bentzon, Vilhelm Andersen, Vedel, the author Niels Møller, the painter Viggo Johansen and others). Several University teachers declared privately that they agreed with the judgment on the literary articles of "Politiken", but that for political reasons it

was indefensible to weaken the position of “Politiken”. Here the misfortune of the union of literature and politics really showed itself. I did not think further about the matter, but the day before the meeting Valdemar Vedel and Niels Møller came out to me and told me that some reactionary hotheads intended to give the meeting a very fanatical character, and they therefore begged me earnestly to chair it and thereby give the meeting the character it in our opinion ought to have. So I came to have a more prominent position than I had at first imagined. I then prepared to speak at the meeting as the opening speaker, though I was not happy about it, especially after I had heard more closely how the signatures had [187] been brought together.

On the morning of the day on which the meeting was to be held, Professor Viggo Bentzon came up to me and told me that the Minister of Justice was going to bring a case against Edvard Brandes as the author of the novel “Ungt Blod”, which had come out some time before. We now both agreed that the matter had taken on an entirely different character. In the first place we had been thinking chiefly of the tone of the newspapers, not of book literature. In the second place we did not want to meddle in a matter that was being taken up from a purely legal side. We therefore decided to have the meeting called off, and drove out to Valdemar Vedel and Alfred Ipsen to get their agreement to this. With some hesitation they consented, and I then drew up an announcement for Ritzau’s Bureau.

In fact the demonstration had its effect all the same. The scandalous articles did not appear again.

The same morning that the meeting had been called off, I went up to Hørup to explain the connection to him. I had expected that he would take the story with scorn and irony. But instead he began to explain to me why he had at the time had to take Edvard Brandes as literary editor of the paper. I interrupted him with the remark that he owed me no account of that, but that I simply wished to tell him both the reason why we had planned the meeting and the reason why we now gave it up. He was evidently much taken up with the whole affair. I have at any rate never seen him so defensive and so nervous. I believe in fact

that his whole way of thinking was very different from the one that had lately come forward in his paper's literary articles, and he must also have noticed that these articles were harming him and the paper politically. — He soon recovered himself, however, for in the following days it rained in the paper with taunts and distortions directed at the signatories. Some of these attacks were of so impudent [188] a character that I wrote to the editors and canceled my subscription, with the request that the cancellation take effect at once. — In another way too Hørup now took his revenge. In a letter to Bjørnson a short time after he gave a highly distorted account of the whole episode and on occasion represented Vedel and me as sneaks and hypocrites. This letter "Politiken" saw fit to publish some years later. I had by then begun again to take "Politiken", but now I canceled it again, and since then it is only occasionally that I see this paper, which with all its stylistic merits has done our country so much harm at home and abroad.

Bjørnson disclaimed in a letter to me any part in the letter's appearing. After Hørup's death he had sent all the letters he had from him to Edvard Brandes, whose hand was also evident in the lines that introduced the publication. That the letter came out was a return of an old favor (by the way not the only one). Edvard Brandes cannot forget. And it seems moreover to be — or to have been — a trait of his that he cannot imagine anything but selfish motives behind any action that goes against him. Several years after the episode spoken of here, the Supreme Court advocate Frederik Salomon told me that Edvard Brandes had complained that people on several sides were out to get him. "What have I, e.g., done to Professor Høffding?" he had asked. He has not been able to imagine that one could come out against him on objective grounds. It was in fact so far from my having anything against him personally that I actually liked him very much and had myself felt the winning and amiable quality in his nature that those who knew him at close quarters spoke of. I particularly remember that once, at the time we used to meet in "Bogstaveligheden", he believed that I had felt offended by some remarks of his at a larger gathering, and in the friendliest way gave me an explanation of his statement. His many-sided gifts I have admired. [189] After writing plays, some of which have artistic value, he has published fine

translations of Old Testament writings and in recent years has shown himself an able Minister of Finance and has, by all accounts, done his country great services by his influence on the policy that has been pursued during the war. —

My break with “Politiken” brought me into contact with “Socialdemokraten”. Since I would not write in the papers of the Right, I was journalistically homeless. But I made use of an occasion that was given by one of the serious and able literary articles (by C. E. Jensen) that appeared in those years in “Socialdemokraten”. The reviewer had said that the lewd literature came chiefly from circles that belonged to the pampered youth of the bourgeoisie. In a letter to the paper I agreed with him on this, saying that I thought the people of hard work did not look upon life so frivolously. — When I had thus come into contact with the paper, its editors invited me to write, in the number for 1 May (1899), an article on the eight-hour working day. This I did with pleasure; I had already expressed myself in that direction in my *Ethics*. — The offprint I was sent of the May number is the finest copy I have of any of my works, since it is printed on silk. — Otherwise my relation to “Socialdemokraten” had not always been so friendly. When in the autumn of 1883 I gave lectures on social ethics, the criticism I made of the existing economic order was greeted with joy in the paper, but it was added that if I did not draw socialism from this criticism as its consequence, it must be because with me, as with several of my colleagues, other motives than the purely scientific were at work. When I protested against this, the paper interpreted its statement to mean that it had merely meant that I, as coming from a bourgeois family, could not with the best will in the world see the matter with the workers’ eyes. The interpretation was somewhat forced.

My studies in these years, after the completion of “den nyere Filosofis Historie”, concerned the theory of knowledge and the philosophy of religion. One of the preliminary studies for a theory of knowledge is to be found in the treatise “Det psykologiske Grundlag for logiske Domme”, which was printed in the *Skrifter* of the Royal Danish Academy of Sciences (1898). As regards the religious

problem, there had been a long time when it did not interest me particularly, and when I did not expect to discuss it beyond the treatment it had received in my Psychology and in my Ethics, where, by the way, the view I later developed in detail is already hinted at. Reading biographies had more and more become my favorite reading, and I came by this route also to occupy myself with Augustine's "Confessions", which interested me greatly from a purely psychological and historical point of view. And when I came to the tenth book, where the great Father of the Church raises the question: "What is it that I love, when I love God?" (*Quid est quod amo, quum deum amo?*) — then it stood clear to me that an important source for the understanding of religious phenomena must be found in the self-testimony of personalities who, while they live wholly and fully in their religion, have the ability and the need to make clear to themselves, in the form of reflection, what they experience in a state of religious rapture. I then collected a series of similar utterances — from Indian literature, from the mysticism of the Middle Ages, from Luther and Pascal, from Pietism — and analyzed them psychologically. It naturally did not occur to me (as people have taken it on a superficial reading of my writings) that one could by this route learn anything about the origin of the positive religions, or about the first origin of all religion. But one could learn something about what it is that keeps religion up once it has come into being, and that is for the philosopher quite as important as the purely historical question of the origin of dogmas and forms of worship. And I saw besides clearly that the study of religion's subjective and individual side must be combined

[191]

with an objective study of the history of religion. Here I sought especially to trace what standard the historians of religion by profession apply when they call one religion higher, another lower. By both these routes I sought to form a hypothesis about what is the fundamental thing in religion in its various forms. And thereby I thought I could then find a basis for understanding religion's position in our day and for conjectures about its future. In a speech at a University celebration in the autumn of 1897 I gave a preliminary characterization of my standpoint.

It was my wish, before I proceeded to the final exposition of my thoughts on the philosophy of religion, to go through the problem in detail in lectures. And this gave occasion for a change in my University work which also later benefited me. Since I became professor, I had every year, alongside Professor Kroman, given a propaedeutic course for the young students, and besides that held laboratory exercises for a narrow circle and public lectures for larger circles. Since the preparation of a course of lectures on the philosophy of religion, intended for students of all faculties, would demand a great deal of work, I proposed to Dr. Wilkens, who had become professor extraordinarius, that he take over the propaedeutic course in my place. This proposal was accepted and was sanctioned by the authorities concerned, and it led to the arrangement that each of the three professors of philosophy every third year could have more time to give free lectures or to undertake new works.

To shed light on my standpoint in the philosophy of religion I shall use some statements in letters that were occasioned by it.¹⁾

From a certain quarter people saw in my philosophy of religion something that smacked of theology, or that the theologians could in any case could use. [192] I had on that account an exchange of letters with Dr. Anton Thomsen and set down here a couple of fragments of two letters from me to him from February 1906.

On 17 February 1906 ... “On several points, after all, the differences between our ways of seeing came out during our discussion the other evening. Such there will naturally be; I need only think of my own relation to Brøchner in my day. But I confess that it seems to me you suffer from an antitheological anxiety. What is antitheological is not therefore philosophical. We must look without bias at the possibilities that present themselves when we come to the boundary points. Precisely as positivists we can here go quite calmly and leave it to the prophets of the various parties to carry on. Perhaps I feel more secure because I have gone through the various stages and know that for me they are left behind.”

On 23 Feb. 1906 ... “By antitheological anxiety in my previous letter I meant

¹⁾A short characterization of my view in the philosophy of religion will be found in the essay on my work as an author, which is reprinted in “Religiøse Tanketyper” (1927). [Later note.]

precisely what you call political anxiety. I want us to philosophize without tactics. And according to my view of philosophy and its significance it is our duty to examine all possibilities when they really come forward with an attempt at justification.”

On 28 Feb. 1906 ... “A working principle is the proposition of the conservation of value, in that, at an essential change in the conditions of human life, it leads one to ask whether equivalents come in place of what has disappeared. So in particular at the transition from positive religion to free humanity — precisely the phenomenon that has led me to my hypothesis. I take a different attitude toward ‘free thinking’ when I am convinced that it will provide ample equivalents than when I am convinced of the opposite or at least have doubts about it. (I confess that I still belong among the doubters — that is, I doubt my own hypothesis!) And the hope of finding equivalents (which I will not give up) can lead to a labor of finding or producing them.” —

[193]

In the letters quoted here I sought to give an answer to objections from a quarter that thought it was speaking on behalf of science and was guided by fear of giving theology a little finger. From an entirely different quarter came an objection that I answered in the letter I shall now quote very nearly in its entirety. A couple of years after the “Religionsfilosofien” had come out, I received a letter from a man I did not know personally, but who was well known in the political and journalistic world. He wrote that he had read my book at once when it came out and had thought he could agree with its main ideas. But after a great sorrow (the loss of his wife) he had read the book again, and then things looked different, particularly as regards faith in a personal immortality. It was a very fine, serious and well thought-out letter. My reply to him (of 28 October 1903) ran as follows: “It must be my first word in reply to your letter to thank you for the confidence you have shown me by approaching me. I am glad that my book has placed me in such a light for you that you could and would write to me, the stranger, as openly and personally as you have done. Your letter has both moved me and interested me. As you will see from my book, I distinguish between the leading fundamental thought in all religions and religious views of life, and the special

form it takes among different peoples and at different times. It has been my interest as a philosopher to attempt a conceptual determination of religion. But in such a determination not all special features can be included. Belief in immortality, e.g., occupies a very different place and is motivated in very different ways in the different religions. What interests me as a philosopher is really only that *where* a decisive place is assigned to it, this happens through a motivation that leads in the direction of what I in my terminology call ‘the conservation of value’. And so it happens, too, in your letter. I myself personally could not maintain that the conservation of value necessarily requires the persistence of the individual [194] personality. I stand on the whole (a fruit of hard personal and theoretical struggles) skeptical toward any more specific working-out of the religious principle, fully convinced that such a working-out necessarily has the character of poetry, valuable for the mood that carries it, but not an adequate expression of objective truth. But I see clearly that here is a point where personal differences will make themselves felt until the end of days, and I have the deepest respect for every truly personal settling of life’s accounts on this point. Only I must object when one makes one’s personal need a standard for the emotional life of others. As, e.g., when someone would conclude that he who has lost a person he loved, and does not believe in immortality, must have loved the departed less than he who *believes* in immortality has loved the one *he* lost. That conclusion is inadmissible, and here I can set experience against experience. Yet — there is no use quarreling about this.” —

In “Forord og Efterskrift til min Religionsfilosofi” (printed in the second series of “Mindre Arbejder”) and in “Den store Humor” I have in several respects sought to shed light on my position on the religious problem as a philosopher and as a human being. As a philosopher I have to do with the general principles of science and of life; as a human being I have to do with the special shading and application of these principles to which my course of life and my personal experience have led me. But I believe that in my case the philosopher and the human being have drawn closer and closer to each other — I hope that it has not been to the detriment of either of them. — I would particularly refer to the

chapter “Tragik og Humor” in the book “Den store Humor” as the clearest and most deeply reaching expression I have been able to give of the domain where my philosophy and my personal experience of life meet. —

[195] My Philosophy of Religion came out in 1901 and was soon translated into various languages (German, French, English, Russian, Spanish, Japanese). The best and most understanding review of it I saw in “Literary Times” (24 August 1906). Under the heading “A Danish Thinker” an excellent résumé of the book’s line of thought is given here, something with which a philosophical author is as a rule not spoiled. It is emphasized that a thinker from a small country suffers from the fact that he writes in a little-known language, but that one will in return rather find in him freedom from prejudice and a universal outlook (a more unbiased cosmopolitan outlook). The book’s personal character alongside its investigative method is stressed, and it is remarked at the end that even if the book might seem to diminish the content of religious faith, — to say too little for fear of saying too much, — yet its strict honesty refreshes like a spring of cold water (its austere sincerity refreshes like a spring of cool water). I do not deny that I was very glad of this review, and that is why I have quoted it here.

On the last lecture day of the nineteenth century (19 December 1900) I gave at the University a speech which I published under the title “Ved Aarhundredskiftet”. I emphasized here some features in the characterization of the century just ended. The spiritual antagonisms, and in particular the national antagonisms, had become sharpened in the course of the century. In scientific respects the nineteenth century had to be described as the age of empirical confirmation and of historical research, whereas the greatest thoughts, the really fundamental ideas, had appeared in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. In the practical sphere it got its character from the mighty workers’ organizations and the class struggle conditioned by them, through which for the first time in history the worst-placed strata of the people, living in the meanest circumstances, themselves began to take an active part in the work that can lead to a progressive solution of the social questions.

In the autumn of 1901 I received from the University of Uppsala, through the [196] dean of its humanistic section, an invitation to come up there in the course of the winter and give lectures there for a month. I gladly accepted this invitation and so spent the month of February 1902 in the classic Swedish university town. For me it was above all Benjamin Höijer's and Erik Gustaf Geijer's town. These two Swedish thinkers I had come to take a great interest in, and especially Geijer's rich personality, his writing of history and his philosophical development (which forms an analogy to that of Sibbern and Kierkegaard among us) I occupied myself with then and later, in that I not only studied his works but also used the extensive literature in which the personality and development of this brilliant man are investigated and presented. From my lectern at Uppsala University I looked out on Geijer's statue and farther away, out over snow-covered fields and woods.

In preparation for these lectures I had, on the basis of many years' studies and notes on the main philosophical problems, worked out a short account of the present state of these problems, as I conceived it. As already in the introduction to "Den nyere Filosofis Historie" I distinguished four main problems — the psychological, the epistemological, the ethical-religious and the metaphysical. Or, as I have sometimes put it, philosophy discusses four main subjects: personality, science, the conduct of life and the world-view. I found in Uppsala a good and interested audience, which admittedly fell off when I came to the more abstract investigations, but grew again when toward the end I came back to more accessible questions. After my return home I worked through anew the content of these lectures and used it as the subject of the University program which it was my turn to write for the University celebration in the autumn of 1902. This program is regarded by some as the clearest and most concise account of my main philosophical ideas. It has not been published through the book trade, but [197] has been distributed on a large scale by the University and by myself. It has been translated into German, and as William James liked it so much, he had it, by arrangement with me, translated into English.

Besides the series of lectures mentioned, which extended through the whole month of February, I gave in Uppsala and in Stockholm popular lectures on Holberg and Kierkegaard, and on more recent epistemological points of view I spoke in Uppsala's natural science society and at Stockholms Högskola.

After the close of the lecture series I was honored by the Uppsala student choir, who turned out with banners, song and a speech in the entrance hall of the University. And on the journey home I was invited to a celebration in Lund, which a circle of students there gave for me. — I was glad and proud of the honor that was thus shown me in our neighboring country, and that I had been able to contribute my mite to the interaction between the universities of the North.

During my stay in Uppsala I lived in a hotel garni, but I was hospitably received by several colleagues and felt at home in their families. At the home of Professor Reinhold Geijer and his amiable wife I had several pleasant evenings. The famous linguist Noreen, the dean of the faculty, also opened his home to me, and I came and went at his house. His warmth of heart captivated me, and it was a particular honor to me that he brought me a fine farewell greeting on behalf of the faculty. All the more ashamed I am to remember that I could not recognize him when, 10 years later, I met him in the street in Stockholm and he very kindly came up to me. My two closest Swedish friends, both during the stay in Uppsala and later, were Frants and Hanna v. Schéele. Frants v. Schéele was a knowledgeable and enthusiastic philosopher who, since he obtained no University appointment, followed his interest in pedagogy and accepted an appointment as head of Stockholm's "elementary school system", a position that involves a great deal [198] of work, and to which he has devoted his best powers. Hanna v. Schéele was my faithful Swedish correspondent, whose letters gave me a vivid impression of Swedish moods, and whose sympathy and understanding have been and are of great value to me.

In the summer of 1902 I made a journey with my youngest son in Germany and Switzerland. In Berlin and Dresden we visited the glorious museums. We stayed for a time by Lake Lucerne and later on the Wengernalp.

In the autumn of 1902 I was elected Rector of the University for 1902–03, succeeding my dear friend Vilhelm Thomsen. The constitution of the University had shortly before been changed, in that the Teachers' Assembly got greater influence, and the Consistory was to be filled exclusively by election, whereas formerly most of the seats were seats by seniority, where seniority as professor was what decided. Since I had only become professor at the age of 40, and since I therefore stood far back in seniority behind several colleagues of the faculty, I had never got into that high assembly. I have always had an interest in the affairs of the University, and it had therefore grieved me that I had not belonged to the circle that made decisions about them; the Teachers' Assembly had before the constitutional change little influence. Some years before my election as Rector I had, however, been put up as a candidate for one of the few seats in the Consistory that under the older arrangement were filled by election. But my opponent was my friend Vilhelm Thomsen, and I found it natural that he should go before me. In his gentle way he said to me that if it had been anyone other than me who had been put up against him, he would have taken it amiss. On the very day the election was to take place, he lay in bed with one of his frequent attacks of illness. I visited him in the morning and asked for his authorization to give thanks for the election on his behalf if he were elected, which I did not doubt. It caused much merriment in the Teachers' Assembly when, after Thomsen had been elected by [199] a majority of ten votes, I stood up and gave thanks for the election on Professor Thomsen's behalf.

My rectorate was then remarkable in that it was the first time that a man was elected Rector who was not already a member of the Consistory and thereby familiar with its business. It was therefore, especially at the beginning, no easy matter to act as leader toward the men who "had sat in the Council for so many years". I believe, however, that I came off reasonably well, although it was not always easy to conduct the proceedings in the Consistory and especially in the Teachers' Assembly, in which certain members had a tendency to make long speeches out of season and to come forward with formalistic objections. I remember a meeting at which rules of procedure were to be adopted, and at which

at the last moment an objection was raised to the method of voting I had proposed. As I foresaw that this objection would give rise to a long discussion, and as the hour was late, I made use of the right the Rector had to adjourn a meeting and fix a new meeting a week later.

Besides signing the current documents and conducting the proceedings in the Consistory and the Teachers' Assembly, the Rector also has the task of representing the University to the outside world. In this respect the most interesting thing I came to attend was the festivities at the German Emperor's visit to Copenhagen at the beginning of April 1903. After having been present at the Emperor's landing at the Toldbod I took part in the evening in a great gala dinner. King Christian the Ninth proposed the Emperor's health in a German speech, which he read out with great dignity. The Emperor replied in a flowery speech, which ended with the wish that the King might for many years yet stand "am hohen Mast, von den Falten des alten Dannebrog umgeben". The speech was delivered in a powerful voice and without the help of paper. After the dinner the Majesties held a reception. The Emperor showed all evening the greatest deference to the old King.

[200] As soon as the latter approached, the Emperor stood at attention, like a young lieutenant before his colonel. With great liveliness and amiability he conversed with those present. Our democratic ministers were not all skilled in languages. I heard the Emperor put a question to the Minister of Agriculture of the time (O. Hansen), but when the latter only stammered: "I regret, — — I regret — —" the Emperor looked at him for a moment and then moved on. When I was presented to him, he asked in which faculty there were the most students, and when I answered that it was the medical one, he said: "Nun, das ist gut, denn es gibt in der Welt allzu viele Juristen." I permitted myself a little joke on the subject, whereupon the Emperor began to talk about the glorious student days, which he looked back on with pleasure, and which his sons were now enjoying. He spoke with much energy and with large, shining eyes, which for a while made one forget the stiff and dry appearance he could otherwise have.

Later in the evening Queen Alexandra, who was on a visit, came up to me and said that she had heard from her brother (the Crown Prince) that I had been

in touch with the Dowager Empress Friedrich of Germany (“my poor sister-in-law”, as she called her). The fact was that the Dowager Empress had read my *Ethics* and had sent me greetings both through the King and through the Crown Prince; I had also had to send her an autograph. Queen Alexandra talked with me for a long time and wished to have one of my books. Some time after I then sent her my *Ethics* with a letter to the effect that I was glad to present the book to the Queen of the country to whose literature and science I owed so much.

The next evening there was a *soirée* at the Crown Prince’s. Here a great crowd of people from various circles was gathered, who were arranged in groups in the various rooms. University, Academy of Fine Arts, administration, etc., stood ready, and the Emperor went around and addressed a few winged words to the various groups. I heard him talk with Krøyer about academies of art, which [201] Krøyer thought were an evil, and I heard him say, when Marcus Rubin was presented as a statistician: “Statistik — die schwierigste aller Wissenschaften!” (On the other hand I did not see that he got any more “lines” out of this difficult science’s Danish representative.) — That evening, besides the Rector, the deans too were present, and I then told them the Emperor’s remark about the lawyers from the previous evening. The dean of law then said that fun must always be made of the lawyers; but the physician thought that the doctors were usually the most roughly handled, and so each dean complained on his faculty’s behalf; only the theologian (Professor Jacobsen) stood silent until all had spoken, and then said: “The worst is after all what is said about theology, and it is only a single little word: *leider!* (in Goethe’s *Faust*).” —

About a month before the Emperor’s visit I had turned 60 (on 11 March). On that occasion I unexpectedly came to celebrate my first jubilee. I had probably always had a feeling that the students on the whole liked me; but I was surprised and overwhelmed by the devotion and goodwill that now surged toward me. Even if part of it was owing to the zeal for celebrating jubilees (even where the person celebrated does not himself think of it), still there was, of this I was and

am convinced, genuine feeling in what met me on this occasion and on various occasions in later years. I was heartily glad of the many proofs of sympathy I received from older and younger, although I often deep down had the feeling that I was being overrated. What I knew and know about myself is that I have taken life and my work — the work it has been my good fortune to carry on — seriously. I have been a diligent man, and my personal development and my intellectual work have gone hand in hand, although there are slack places in my personality which the intellectual work has not been able to master.

[202] The Students' Union and the Students' Society jointly invited me to a celebration, which was held on the evening after my birthday. It was a great joy to me that Professor Kroman took on the office of toastmaster on this occasion, — that Valdemar Vedel gave the main speech, — and that later Georg Brandes gave the brilliant speech which he has reprinted in his writings. Among the songs I am especially glad of Sofus Michaëlis's splendid poem. In addition, friends and listeners brought forth characterizations and words of tribute in prose and in verse. I especially keep in fond memory Saxild's characterization in "Tilskueren", and Niels Møller's poem in the same place.

When I was about to drive home late in the evening, a crowd of students unharnessed the horse from the cab and pulled me at a gallop the whole way from the Hotel "Kongen af Danmark", where the celebration had been held, over Knippelsbro to Strandgade, where I lived at that time. Several teams relieved one another during the drive; those who were not pulling ran alongside the carriage or behind it, and after the whole procession rode the cabman on his astonished horse. There was a police station in the building where I lived, and the constables came out to see what was going on. When I had got up to my room, I opened the window and gave one more word of thanks to my young friends, who answered with a hurrah that rang through the quiet street.

The next day I met the police assistant and asked him to excuse my having been the occasion of a disturbance in the street. He answered jokingly that the police so often caused a disturbance in the building by bringing drunken people to the station; — it might just even out! —

The summer of 1903 I spent in Jutland, partly in Ebeltoft, where my eldest son was then staying, partly in Viborg, with Archivist Saxild, partly at Tyborøn with Engineer Munch-Petersen. They were three genuinely Jutlandic regions.

The following winter an invitation came to me to give a lecture on the present position of psychology at a general scientific congress which was to be held in the late summer of 1904 in St. Louis in North America, on the occasion of its being a hundred years since Louisiana had been united with the North American free states. About a hundred European scholars of various disciplines were invited to this congress, besides a good many Americans. It was mostly the desire to see America that moved me to say yes; but a kind letter from William James with an invitation to visit him during my stay over there did much to strengthen me in my decision. Besides, I would meet many interesting people. The prospects for the journey became still more attractive when my friend and colleague Otto Jespersen came up to me one day and told me that he too had received an invitation. We then agreed to make the journey together. We two and the physicist Arrhenius were the only Scandinavians who were invited. [203]

Travel allowance and fee were so ample that I could make a plan for a stay in England and Holland on the return journey.

Among the preparations for the journey was also that of learning to speak English tolerably. I had not studied English at all at school, but had later taught myself to read it, and had also had a few lessons; but my pronunciation was very deficient. I had words enough for household use, especially for philosophical household use, but was not practiced in finding them in a hurry. It helped a good deal that I now took some lessons from a capable woman teacher; but it was only after some weeks' stay in America that I could really get my tongue going. Several Americans, among others William James and Morton Prince, declared my letters "quite idiomatic"; but my pronunciation was poor, and I have not succeeded in getting beyond this imperfection. When I once asked Jespersen what he thought of my English, he answered: "Well, you can manage to say everything you want to, and you can be understood; — but it is not English!" —

I was fairly well satisfied with this testimonial, although it would of course, if [204] I were to speak to an audience that was interested not only in the content but also in the form, be an essential shortcoming that my spoken language was not “idiomatic”. This was one of the reasons why I have twice declined invitations to come to Scotland and give the so-called Gifford Lectures. —

At the end of August, then, Otto Jespersen and I set out on our American journey on the “Hellig Olaf”. It was a lovely clear summer evening when we went up through the Sound, and the next morning we had a glorious sail up through the Kristianiafjord. The ship lay for a day at Kristiania, and we used the time for an excursion to Holmenkollen. After we had lain for some hours at Christianssand the following day, the voyage went across the North Sea, north of Scotland, out into the Atlantic. It was a strange thing, for some eight days, to come up in the morning and see sea around one on all sides. We did not meet many ships on our way. In the distance we often saw whales sending their spouts high into the air. Sometimes we were accompanied by shoals of dolphins that wanted to race the ship. It was an amusing sight when in their eagerness they leapt from wave crest to wave crest. But a sailor who stood beside me said: “Well, that is just plain stupidity. They want to get round the ship; but then they could just lie still until the ship has gone past!” This animal psychology was no doubt quite correct.

Of actual seasickness I had only, one evening up by the Orkneys, a slight attack, which Jespersen cured with a few drops. But for several days I felt best on deck in an easy deck chair, and there I was given my meals. Here I had as my neighbor a young, pretty German lady, with whom I had good conversations. My main reading during the voyage was Shakespeare (in the small, dainty English editions). Later on I could again take part in the social life on board. In the evening there was sometimes dancing, and I practiced the minuet with a young Danish woman student who was traveling to America on a visit. A couple of [205] years later she came up for the philosophicum with me, and when she came and sat down opposite me, I said: “Well, Miss, let it go as well now as on the Atlantic!” This riddle the audience evidently could not guess.

Otto Jespersen was a good, steady traveling companion. We shared a cabin and got on excellently with each other. In his younger days he had taken part in student gatherings at my home, introduced by his friend Knud Ipsen. He had a fine scholarly career; it was indeed a great honor to be invited to an English-speaking country to speak on the history of the English language. I teased him that he studied phonetics at night, not only by day, for when we sailed at night in fog, the ship's steam whistle sounded constantly: "Boom—boom—boom!" and I then heard Jespersen in the bunk above mine imitate it in a somewhat weaker key, just as he was in the habit of training his tongue in imitating foreign languages or dialects.

It was a joy to me to get to know Jespersen and to learn what life and what warmth there was behind his somewhat dry and awkward manner. An old politician who was on board, Commodore Bluhme, said to us: "Well, now you gentlemen are setting out as good friends and colleagues; but before the journey is over, you will be so sick and tired of each other that you cannot bear the sight of each other." He was presumably relying on his experience. But his prophecy did not come true. We had set out saying "De" to each other, but came home saying "du", and him and his charming wife, Fru Ane Marie, I still count among my good friends.

Besides Danes, our traveling company also included Americans. A doctor from New York traveled back and forth across the Atlantic in summer because there were no telephones there. An American lady with her daughters belonged to the sect that gathers around the so-called "Christian Science", whose main tenet is that there is no evil, no pain in the world. Her confession ran: "We are glad and happy, and why should we not proclaim that this is the meaning of the whole?" — For a couple of days, however, she had disappeared — on account of seasickness. Presumably she then had to admit that there were realities of another kind than the one she had proclaimed. But I did not get round to asking her about it. [206]

The Congress committee had sent us two tokens (badges), which we were to wear on landing. On arrival we were met by two envoys who wore similar

badges, and with their help we got quickly through customs. We were taken up into New York and had lunch at a restaurant. Then Jespersen left at once for Philadelphia to visit his wife's brother. He brought with him on a record his father-in-law's voice, which his brother-in-law had not heard for 20 years. I was put up in a hotel and introduced into a club which had its rooms on the 13th floor of the same building as the hotel. The next day I traveled via Boston up into New Hampshire to James's country place in a splendid wooded region by "the White Mountains". From that region, when the land sales in the West began, a whole emigration had taken place. One saw round about many abandoned farmsteads. It was such a farm that James had bought and made into a cozy summer home.

When I arrived at the farm, I found only Mrs. James, who sat on the veranda darning stockings. Her husband had rowed across the lake to the station to meet me, but had arrived too late. I was shown to a spacious room, and a little later the author Henry James, William's brother, came to bid me officially welcome in his sister-in-law's name. When I came over to the veranda again, a small man came along in knee breeches and shirtsleeves and with two oars over his shoulder. He had a fine, intelligent but nervous face with beautiful eyes. And so I stood face to face with a man of whom I had gained, through his writings, so fine and vivid an impression, one of the finest descriptive psychologists of the age. It has been said of the two brothers that Henry was the best psychologist among poets, William the best poet among psychologists. In the course of the [207] conversations we had in the following days, we discussed both the points where we met and those where there were divergences. The year before, I had given an account of my relation to James in a University program of 1903 (on some attempts in the philosophy of religion in recent times), which is reprinted in the second series of my "Mindre Arbejder". The portrait of James was later included in the foreign editions of "Moderne Filosofer", and I know that James valued this characterization. As regards his religious views, he thought he could call himself a Christian, but he belonged to no church (denomination) and did not like hearing sermons, whereas he often went into a chapel in the morning to hear hymn singing. There was in his way of taking up theoretical and practical

questions something original and personal that had a highly refreshing effect. He belonged to a type which many would not expect to meet in America, a quiet, gentle and inward spirit, with a sense for the inner life wherever it is found and whatever forms it may clothe itself in, a type that stands in curious contrast to the restless type, absorbed in the toil of business, which one often regards as the truly American one. James's nature suited the nature by "the White Mountains". One day, when the forest "stood still and was silent", not a wind stirring, and a wonderful calm and a deep mood rested over the landscape, James said: "This is an American day." Yes, such days there are in America, and in the circles in which I moved during my two months' stay in America, I often had occasion to experience such days and to meet the human type that corresponds to them.

James's gentleness and peace of mind were not simply a gift of nature. In an earlier period of his life he had suffered from violent attacks of neurasthenia accompanied by feelings of anxiety. Everything in life appeared uncertain and full of danger. He had to cling to the most exalted biblical words he knew so as not to go insane. He has himself described this case in his famous book "Varieties of Religious Experience". For the case he describes on p. 160 f. (in the Danish popular edition p. 86 f.) is in reality his own, which I did not know at the time, but which he has declared in a letter to a French friend, in which he also describes the case as "acute neurasthenic attack with phobia".¹⁾ Whether it was during this attack of illness that he made use of the so-called mind-cure, which consisted in what he regarded as telepathic influence, I do not know. He has described this cure in "Varieties" p. 123 ff. (not included in the Danish popular edition). [208]

James's previous history I did not know fully when I visited him. If a good and thorough biography of him should one day appear, it will be extraordinarily interesting to see what he has had to struggle with and how it has influenced his way of thinking. He himself belonged to what he calls "the sick souls". And it was his conviction, founded on experience, that such a sick soul has the right to seize upon whatever proves to have the power to hold it up in the moments of crisis. This explains both his deep religious disposition, borne by the need for peace

¹⁾See on this *Th. Flournoy: La Philosophie de William James* (1911), p. 149.

and for mastery over the inner darkness, and his great impartiality and freedom from every dogmatic formulation. His position toward the religious problem is that of a physician of the soul, who uses the means that experience points to, without systematic scruples. His “Varieties” is, although he does not conceal his own personal standpoint, one of the most undogmatic books there are.

He was never free of the neurasthenia. When I was with him, he was suffering from severe depression. Only for a few hours in the morning could he work. In the afternoon he liked to drive about in a small one-horse carriage.

After a stay of 4–5 days with James I traveled back to New York, where I [209] was invited to stay a couple of days with one of the gentlemen who had received us on landing, an Anglican clergyman, Mr. Carstensen, a Danish-born man, son of the founder of Tivoli. He was minister of a small church out in a pleasant residential district. He lived in a large and handsome house, and he and his wife showed me much kindness. This visit ended with Mr. Carstensen taking me to the express train by which I, together with a score of participants in the coming Congress, was to make a circular tour to various places before and after the Congress, under the direction of one of Cook’s agents. It was a mixed traveling company, Frenchmen, Germans and Italians. Among the participants were the mathematician Darboux, the archaeologist Enlart (who had a thorough knowledge of Danish medieval architecture and was particularly taken with the Marieklostret in Helsingør), the philosopher Dessoir (a German), the historian Ettore Pais and the linguist Pio Reina. With Pais I came into closer contact and have also heard from him several times in the following years. Our first station was Niagara. We arrived there toward evening, and I went at once — together with Jespersen, who joined us here — out to the Falls. We came out right at the edge over which the mighty masses of water plunge down like fiery horses that rush forward at a furious pace and hurl themselves into the abyss. The mass of water gliding evenly above suddenly turns into the violence of the fall, just as an overwhelming emotion can suddenly well up from the ground of a calm disposition, where nothing seemed to presage such a transition. When some years before I visited the waterfall at Imatra in Finland, where the great masses of wa-

ter from Lake Saimaa are pressed out through a narrow cleft in the rock, it was also the image of furious, onrushing horses that arose at the sight. — The next day we saw the Falls from below, as we, dressed in oilskins, came down by elevator to the foot of the cliff. Here it was a splashing and thundering world we entered; but the impression did not have the sublime character it had above.

Our next station was Chicago, where we spent a couple of days. A banquet [210] was given for us, paid for by some millionaires (who, however, were not themselves present). The various nationalities were toasted, and Jespersen replied in a brief, lively speech on behalf of the Scandinavians.

In St. Louis we were quartered in a new building that was to be used as a student residence, corresponding to our Regens. There were a great many small apartments, each for two students, with two bedrooms and between them a common sitting room. Jespersen and I came to live together, and as Arrhenius lived close by, we three took our breakfast together. Arrhenius was usually in radiant spirits, and his wit and liveliness gave us a cheerful start to the day. Tönnies, whom I met again here, was often a fourth, quieter participant.

The Congress lasted a week, with lectures and accompanying discussions both morning and afternoon. I spoke on general psychology, with James Ward from Cambridge in England as co-speaker. Of the discussion after our lectures I remember nothing. On the other hand I remember other discussions in which I took part, especially the one on pathological psychology, which was opened by Pierre Janet, whose acquaintance it was very interesting to me to make. He had written a preface to the French edition of my *Psychology*, and there was a certain kinship in our psychological points of view. — I also made the acquaintance of the chemist Ostwald, who now appeared as a philosopher with a classification of the sciences which, he had no idea, had already been set up by Comte. Personally I liked Ostwald; he was hearty and naive, — in his speculations, though, perhaps too naive.

When one took part in meetings both morning and afternoon, one's time was well taken up. I did not go to festivities, except to the great closing banquet. There I sat beside a very charming German colleague, Benno Erdmann of Bonn

(now in Berlin). He asked me whether a more conciliatory feeling was not now
[211] cherished in Denmark toward Germany. I answered that I believed the feeling would become good if new examples did not keep coming of how the Prussian government suppressed the language and national culture of our countrymen in Schleswig. To this he said that the State must after all have the same language and culture everywhere. I then said: "Ja, Herr Kollege, das ist eben die Nemesis der Eroberung. Man kann die Herzen und die Geister nicht bezwingen, und wenn man doch Einheit auch auf dem geistigen Gebiete haben will, muss man die rohe Gewalt anwenden." After I had explained the circumstances to him more fully, it was as though a light dawned on the honest man for the first time, and he answered: "Ja, ich sehe, man muss ja aus seiner Haut ausgehen, um diese Sache gerecht zu beurteilen."

After the close of the Congress we came again into Cook's care. We traveled first to Washington, where we stayed a couple of days. Here we were presented to President Roosevelt, who addressed a few words to each of us. When he heard that I was from Denmark, he asked whether I knew Jacob Riis, and when I said that I hoped to make his acquaintance in New York, he said: "I hope, You will do so, because he is one of our best American citizens, and at the same time still a good Danish patriot." To this I replied that I knew that from one of the President's own magazine articles, in which he had described his and Riis's work to reform New York's municipal affairs. Roosevelt made a very energetic impression. When he spoke, something of the beast of prey could come over him, or he looked as though he were about to charge in as a cavalryman.

During the stay in Washington we were one evening at a soirée given by the President of the St. Louis Congress. On this occasion there was nothing to be had but oranges and lemonade. That was not enough for Germans and Scandinavians, and so when we went home, we sought out a beer hall, which we went down into. The famous historian of dogma Harnack, who was wearing
[212] all his decorations, hesitated a little, though, before he went down with us. "Nur einen Augenblick!" he said, and this moment he used to make the decorations disappear into his pockets. Over the beer great conviviality reigned. But Harnack

teased two Austrians who were present by comparing Austria with the old house in Andersen's tale: it did not know to which side it should fall, and only for that reason did it remain standing! A rather apt image of the Austro-Hungarian-Slavic state, but one which Harnack would hardly apply with the same merriment now (after 1914).

From Washington we went on via Philadelphia to Boston, where Harvard University gave a celebration for us. President Eliot of Harvard presided and spoke to the various nationalities. The speech to the Scandinavians he addressed to me, and I had to improvise a little speech, which I believe went off quite well. Here in Boston the Congress was definitively dissolved. I now took up my residence for some three weeks at Harvard University, which lies outside the city, in Cambridge, which is separated from Boston only by a river. At first I lived in a boarding-house, later in James's house. In a letter to a young friend I wrote (14 Oct. 1904): "I am now living with my friend Professor James in a large and comfortable house in this splendid university town, — splendid, not in the sense of magnificent, but in the sense of glorious and interesting. It is like a large park, where lecture halls, laboratories, student and professors' residences lie among the trees, which now stand in their autumn splendor. James is an excellent philosopher, especially by his fine psychological sense and his open eye, and he is moreover a lovable personality. Immediately after I had come to America, at the beginning of September, I stayed some days with him at his country estate, and now he has lodged me in his house here in a large bright room with a view of friendly avenues and gardens. Today I gave a lecture for his students. And yesterday I gave a lecture out at a women's university, which is called Wellesley College and lies some miles from here These days are some of the best I have [213] had on my journey. Mrs. James too is extraordinarily charming, and the whole family cannot do enough for me." — The two lectures mentioned here I worked together into an article, which was printed in English in an American periodical and later in Danish in my *mindre Arbejder*, third series, under the title "En filosofisk Bekendelse".¹⁾

¹⁾Both of the two lectures I have mentioned here were given in James's presence. But he has certainly interpreted them far too strongly in the direction of his own ideas when, shortly after

For some days Pierre Janet and the English psychologist Lloyd Morgan (who had in his time written a fine review of my *Psychology* in “*Nature*”) were staying with James at the same time as I. The stay with James was thus of many-sided interest to me. But I was most taken up with James’s gentle and deep personality. I know too that James felt friendship for me. That appeared from his letters to me in the following years. And when he had died, Mrs. James wrote to me: “William had a strong affection for You.” — Already at the time of my visit he was weak; the neurasthenia increased in the following years, besides which he suffered from a heart condition. After having taken a cure in Europe in vain, he died in the year 1910. —

At the end of October I sailed from New York on one of the Cunard Line’s ships, the *Lucania*. Just outside New York we ran into a strong storm, and I had to lie four days in my bunk, where I was well looked after by the English steward, so well that a young South American who shared the cabin with me also felt [214] like staying in his bunk, which, however, he was not allowed to do. When the weather had improved, I came up on deck again, but spent the day by myself in an open hall. I had my food brought up there, since I did not venture to go down into the saloon. Nor was there the same coziness there as on the Danish ship. There were many more passengers, and it had a somewhat uncomfortable effect that warnings had been posted against playing cards with unknown fellow passengers, since the management knew that there were professional gamblers on board. Not that card-playing was a temptation to me; but one did look around with a certain suspicion. I spent the day reading and looking out at the sea, which now no longer had the summery look it had had on the voyage over. In the middle of the Atlantic a wireless telegram came about the tension between Russia and England, occasioned by the Russian fleet in the North Sea having fired in a panic

my departure, he recommends me very warmly (make much of good old Høffding) to a correspondent in Oxford (24 Oct. 1904) on the ground that I was “a good pluralist and irrationalist”. If one will read the essay in which both lectures are worked together, in the third series of my *Mindre Arbejder*, one will see that this does not fit (as far as pluralism is concerned). I am naturally glad that James liked me (I took to him immensely, and so did everybody), and that in his opinion I made a good impression in America. — James was very pleased with an anecdote an American lady had told me, and which I used in my lecture for his students. (It is quoted in *Mindre Arbejder* III p. 26). It was aimed at orthodox theology, but proves nothing for “pluralism”.

on English fishing boats. Every morning a small newspaper was printed on the ship and distributed to the passengers, and one could thus read the latest news in one's bunk. It is said to have been the first time that wireless telegraphy was used in that way. When we came to Liverpool, we heard that the danger of war was over.

Together with the steamship ticket I had received a railway ticket from Liverpool to London, which gave the right to stop at various places on the way. I went at once from Liverpool out to the little town of Chester, partly to rest after the sea voyage, partly because Chester is a historically interesting town, with memories of Roman times and of the English Civil War. It was a pleasant English provincial town, and I spent the day partly reading in the beautiful park, partly walking. In the evening I went on to Stratford on Avon, Shakespeare's birthplace, where I stayed over the next day. It was in a peculiar mood that I walked about here, where one's thoughts could well dwell on the great poet's youth and again on his plain life there after he had left the stage and literature. There are no direct memorials of him, except for his bust in the church, which dates from the [215] time immediately after his death. But the landscape is characteristically English, and walking along the broad river Avon, where it flows through meadows and beneath overhanging willows, I was constantly reminded of the description of Ophelia's death.

In London I had been invited to give a lecture to the Sociological Society, and it had been arranged that I should stay with three of the Society's members, a week in each place, during my stay in London. I went at once, then, out to my first hostess, Lady Welby, in Harrow on the Hill, a few Danish miles from London. Lady Welby was the widow of a landowner. She was very much interested in philosophy and has written on what she called "Significs", i.e. the doctrine of the most exact possible correspondence between word and thought. She held that ordinary language, and in part also the language of science, was full of unclear metaphors and false analogies. I do not deny that for me there was something exaggerated in the old lady's zeal for this cause, — the same impression I have had of one of our natural scientists' doughty battle against false

analogies. The figurative expressions of language are often excellently suited to searching and working thought, which, as it advances, has it in its power to strip off the figurative through definite formations of concepts. I would rather look for the imperfection of language at another point, which Bacon already, and in our day Bergson, have pointed out, namely in this, that by giving the various things and properties each its own special name it comes to emphasize the difference between them too much. — But Lady Welby was a tireless worker. Every morning from 5 to 8 she dictated in bed to her woman secretary, and when she had got up, what had been dictated was copied out fair. Often she then went through it with me, and I often had to admire her energy and acuteness. In one of the later [216] editions of the *Encyclopædia Britannica* she has written the article *Significs*. — But I remember her especially as a solicitous and kind-hearted hostess.

The very morning after my arrival I received a very sad piece of news from home. A young friend of mine, Dr. med. Harald Munch-Petersen, son of Julius Petersen, had met with an accident on a journey in Savoy. He had, it was presumed, fallen from a steep mountain near Aix-les-Bains; but a long time passed before his body was found, and so a sense of dread was added to the great grief that all who knew him felt. I set down here some lines of a letter that I wrote during my stay in London to one of the deceased's sisters.

"I have often thought of how you were faring under this new great sorrow. [Half a year before, her mother had died]. For me too it is a great sorrow, and I cannot at all imagine that I shall not see my dear young friend again. In recent years, especially after he had become Hans's doctor, we had become very close friends, and I had great confidence in him. It is a fine career that has been broken off here; we had every reason to believe that he would have achieved something significant ... There are so many ruins in the world, and it is not easy to see why it must be so."

The news of my young friend's death (or properly, of his disappearance) I received, as I said, on the morning after my arrival. We were sitting by the fire-place in the drawing room. Shortly afterward I got up and went into the library, which had been put at my disposal as a study. A few moments later there was a

soft knock at the door, and my old Lady came in and said that she had been able to see from me that I had received sad news; she only wanted to say that I must take care not to fall ill, and that if there was anything she could do to relieve and strengthen me, she would most gladly do it. I was much moved by the old lady's love and tact, and from that moment I felt at home, as under a mother's care.

Lady Welby's villa was beautifully situated, with a view over grass- and [217] wood-clad hills. A beautiful garden belonged to it, and the district invited walks. There was an excellent philosophical library in the house, so that there was everything I could wish for, both for refreshment and for work. The conversations with Lady Welby and her secretary were lively and interesting. For some days one of my English translators, Miss Ethel Meyer, also stayed at the villa. The distance from London was no greater than that one could easily spend a morning there, attend an afternoon performance at the theater and be home for dinner at 8 o'clock. On the very first evening, when I came up to my room toward dinner time, I found my tailcoat and the rest of my black dress neatly laid out; otherwise I should hardly have thought of what was the custom in a fine English house. As a rule we were only three at table, and I took Lady Welby in. At the end of the meal the ladies would then have me remain seated over the wine, which, however, I had no wish to do. Every morning the lady of the house held prayers, which consisted in a reading from the Bible and from the liturgy; all the household were present on this occasion. The first morning I was asked whether I would go in with them, which I had nothing against. But when, according to Anglican custom, they fell on their knees at a certain point of the liturgy, I could not join in, but remained standing. The next morning the secretary said to me that I would probably rather be excused from going in. As far as I could see, it was a patriarchal custom that the old lady faithfully kept up. One noticed nothing whatever of theology in her way of thinking, although she had a deeply religious mind.

When the time for the lecture to the Sociological Society drew near, I moved in with my next host, Mr. Gooch, a young English historian and politician. He had written a good book on "English democratic ideas in the seventeenth century", and he has later (1913) written an excellent book on "History and Histo-

[218] rians in the 19th Century". He was very well off and could live for his studies and his political interests. When I visited him again some years later, he was a Member of Parliament, belonging to the Liberal Party. He was an upright and warm-hearted man with much knowledge and many-sided interests. His wife, who was of German descent, was also handsome and hospitable. I was excellently off in their house. I can still hear his kind words when he came in to me in the morning: "Now, Mr. Høffding, have You made Yourselves comfortable? Have You a good fire?" Whereupon he — to show me what it was to be "comfortable" — placed me in an armchair by the fireplace and gave me the Times.

The lecture to the Sociological Society dealt with the relation between ethics and sociology and was very well received. There was a long discussion afterward, in which, among others, Professor Westermarck of Helsingfors, who also teaches in London for some months every spring, took part.

With Gooch's help I got reasonably well oriented in London. I visited museums, and I was introduced into a club. When we walked in the street, he led me like a little child every time we had to cross the heavily trafficked streets. — One day I received word from the Danish Minister, Chamberlain Bille, that Queen Alexandra wished to speak with me, and he suggested that I come to him for lunch, after which he would accompany me to Buckingham Palace. When we came to the palace, he handed me over to a footman, who handed me over to another footman, who handed me over to a third footman, who showed me into a hall, where the Queen came a little later. She asked me to sit on a chair beside her sofa and then conversed with me for half an hour or so, very kindly and openly, among other things about the danger of war that had recently existed.

I had received invitations both to Cambridge and to Oxford. And so one morning I left Gooch's pleasant home to drive to the station and from there go [219] to Cambridge. But on the way a heavy fog suddenly came on, brownish and dense, like a veil that settled over all things. The cabman had to get down and lead the horse. One could not see one's hand in front of one. At the street corners stood policemen, who gave the necessary topographical information. I had read of something of the kind in Dickens, but now I experienced it in its most glaring

form. I understood what accidents and crimes could happen in such cases. I arrived too late for the train and had to spend several hours at the station before the next train went. When we came out of the city, it cleared up, and the sun shone gloriously when I came to the old university town, where I was kindly received by Professor Sorley and his wife. I had made Sorley's acquaintance in America and soon felt at home with my new hosts. They lived in a pleasant house with a garden. Sorley is a fine, quiet man. As an ethicist he belongs to an idealist school, and one of his most important writings is a critique of naturalism in ethics. The Sorleys had two sons and a daughter, who were all at home now, but who some years later were each sent to a boarding school of their own. As the youngest son was somewhat dependent and clung a great deal to his elder brother, he wanted to go to the same school as he did; — but in spite of all tears they had to be separated, so that the younger too could learn to become independent. The eldest began his studies at Oxford with distinction, but when the war broke out, he went with it, rose to captain and fell in October 1915, while leading his company forward to the attack. All this still lay in the future, and there seemed to be peace and no danger in the autumn of 1904. I visited the various colleges, which hold so many memories; e.g. Thomas More, Bacon, Locke and Newton studied here, and Erasmus visited his friend More here. For Sorley's students I repeated my lecture on the relation between ethics and sociology. The splendid parks invited walks; they still stood in their autumn splendor.

[220]

German influence has been great in England in the philosophical field in the nineteenth century. Many professors had received their training in Germany, as had Sorley's colleague James Ward, who not infrequently mentions "my old teacher Lotze". Ward is an able psychologist and theorist of knowledge, though, like most English and American philosophers, rather given to theologizing. I also stayed some days with Ward and then traveled to Oxford, where I was to give a lecture to the "Jowett Society". I stayed with Sidney Ball, tutor at St. John's College. He was married and therefore did not live in the college, but in a small house next to it. I was a guest at the Oxford philosophers' annual dinner, and in my reply to a toast I spoke of the strong German influence on present-day English

philosophy and expressed the hope that, just as in its time Hume's influence had worked toward a new and distinctive development of German philosophy, so German philosophy might now call forth a new development of that vigorous philosophizing which has contributed much to giving England so considerable a place in the history of intellectual culture. — In Oxford I had the honor of being created Doctor of Science. Clad in a splendid red and gray silk gown, I was led solemnly before the Vice-Chancellor, who was enthroned on his high seat. After the Public Orator had set out my merits in Latin, and the Vice-Chancellor had obtained the consent of the assembled colleagues and Masters, he declared me Doctor and member of the University and asked me to take a seat at his side. It was my second English doctorate. Some years before I had been made Doctor of Law in absentia at St. Andrews. — My lecture to the Jowett Society dealt with the concept of analogy and its philosophical significance and is printed in "Mind" and in my *mindre Arbejder* (second series). — I insert here a letter I wrote from Oxford to a younger philosopher in Copenhagen, Magister Herdis Krarup; it gives a summary of my experiences in America.

[221] Dear Miss Krarup!

Thank you for your kind letter. It pleased me very much to hear that your doctoral dissertation seems to be well under way. Nor have I ever doubted that it would be. Not least it pleased me to see that you are constantly at work thinking, and that you, as hitherto, unite an interest in the experimental with an interest in the philosophical problems. There are so many experimental psychologists with whom that is not the case. In America they have large and good laboratories, but it does not seem that they get much out of them. Pierre Janet (whose acquaintance it was a great pleasure to me to make in America) once said in his witty way that he was not sure that their famous laboratories really existed! — In America there was a frightful amount of metaphysics in the air alongside the quite specialized experimental investigations that ignored all questions of principle. But on the whole I must say that I received an excellent impression of the intellectual life; there was much interest among old and young, and the metaphysical interest itself was combined with great openness and many-sided

discussion. As I put it in a lecture I gave at the women's university Wellesley College (near Boston): philosophy is in the process of becoming at once more personal and more scientific. I tried to show the connection between these two things in the constant need for supplementation and for new experience.

It will interest you to hear that in America I met a woman colleague, Professor Mary Calkins, professor of philosophy at Wellesley. She read a good paper on comparative psychology at the Congress in St. Louis, and she pressed Ostwald hard in the discussion after his (very thin!) lecture on "Methodology". —

It has been a great joy to me on my journey to come together with American and English students. James, Royce and Münsterberg gave me access to that at Harvard, and here in England I had in Cambridge an interesting evening with a [222] circle of young men (Moral Science Society), with whom I had a lively discussion after my lecture on the relation between sociology and ethics. — (In Cambridge it was also a joy to me to spend some days in James Ward's house). — Yesterday evening I discussed Kant's philosophy here at St. Johns College with some young men, and this evening I am to speak at the Jowett-club on the concept of analogy. You see, I am constantly active. Yet I now long for my Danish friends. Around 16 December I shall be in Copenhagen, and I look forward to seeing you and our common circle again.

Yours devotedly

Harald Høffding.

My last week in England I stayed with the third of my sociological hosts, Dr. Stanton Coit. In his younger days Dr. Coit had worked in the East End of London among the poor population there, as leader of one of the so-called "neighbourhood guilds", where university men seek to spread intellectual culture among the destitute, especially by living among them and acquainting themselves with their conditions. Now he led an "Ethical Society" in Kensington and worked for non-denominational morality. He was a very hard-working man and much absorbed in his work. Through his marriage he had become very rich. His German-born

wife, a gifted and charming lady, once said to me: “Yes, we are socialists, but we live in Hyde Park Gate and keep seven servants!” — One evening a large company had been invited “to meet Professor Høffding”. And Professor Høffding then stood together with host and hostess at the door of the drawing room and shook hands with everyone who came. There was conversation and music, and afterward there were buffets in the rooms upstairs. As so often on such occasions, the best part of the evening came when the guests had gone, and “we” were alone and sat in cozy conversation by the fireplace.

[223] From a letter I wrote while I was staying with Coit I quote the following.

“When I look back on my journey, I must say that it has brought me great profit and in many respects refreshed me and given me new strength, at least a new desire to work on. But now I am, after all, becoming an old man, so I must be diligent if I am to have accomplished what I still want to have done. — I am afraid that I have been spoiled on the journey, especially here in England, where I have gone from hand to hand and have been treated as an old friend wherever I have come. Since my return from Cambridge and Oxford I have been staying with a Dr. Coit, in whose very beautiful and elegant house near Hyde Park I have worked every morning, so as later in the day to visit museums and in the evening either go to the theater or meet people. The greatest impression on me has been made by the Parthenon frieze, of which large pieces are here in the original, and by Raphael’s cartoons. But a modern English painter, Watt, with his grand symbolism, has also occupied me. And then I have found good things by my dear Dutchmen (especially Ruysdael and Hobbema).” —

I took the way home through Holland and stayed some ten days in The Hague and in Amsterdam in order to develop and deepen my knowledge of Dutch painting. In The Hague I performed an inward devotion at Spinoza’s statue, which stands outside the place where he lived in his last years, those years in which we know his daily way of life so well through the account of a worthy clergyman who later lived in the same house. Otherwise it was the museums I frequented, and especially the Rijksmuseum in Amsterdam brought me many happy hours. I spent the mornings out there, and in the evenings I read or was at the French

comedy.

In the middle of December I came home to Strandgade again after a journey rich in content and in enjoyment.

VI

[224] Shortly before I left for America, my youngest son had married; the eldest had already left home earlier; and from that time on I lived alone. Solitude was not disagreeable to me. I had enough to do, and I have always had difficulty in breaking off my work and my train of thought and becoming absorbed in family life and its interests. In my hypochondriac periods this difficulty was especially great. At such times it was mostly those closest to me who suffered for it. With strangers one can, after all, control oneself more easily, or the strange element is a positive help in getting beyond one's entanglement in oneself, the heaviness and the strange sensations of faintness. I have often been ashamed of this. But I have also again and again had reason to feel grateful because those closest to me have borne with me. Now that I had become entirely alone, there was no one for my hypochondria to fall on. It has faithfully followed me into my old age too. — On this I quote a passage from a letter (from 1902) to a young friend, now dead.

“Even if I had not believed that a definite cause lay behind your so often depressed mood, I would still have been able to sympathize with it. For I know from my own experience how vague, dark and foggy moods can get the better of us, and they are often precisely the worst adversaries we can have, — those that take no firm shape, so that we could look them in the eye, but which, like figures of fog, are indeed scattered for the moment when we strike through them, but
[225] only to clump together again. I can have quite terrible attacks of hypochondria, to the astonishment of those closest to me, and I by no means have the evenness and calm that is often ascribed to me. By contrast, I feel all the more glad when I am together with people I am fond of and who can set me going. — Then I have

also had worries and sorrows. No one escapes them. — But now I have come to talk about myself, and that was not the intention.” —

In an autobiography, on the other hand, it is precisely the intention that one should talk about oneself, so that no apology is needed when I dwell a little longer on this subject and in particular bring forward a single experience.

In states of the kind I have mentioned here, it could be as if no thought could arise, no hope endure, no light appear, no work be done. Sometimes such a mood faded away of itself, just as it had also come “of itself”; at other times an external event could act as a diversion; but now and then the bull had to be taken by the horns. I will tell of a small experience from the years I am speaking of here, which was very instructive for me both as a philosopher and as a human being. It was some years after the journey to America that a very severe attack came. I did not know what to turn to; it was as if I were dying of thirst. How it then came about that I took out Shakespeare’s *King Lear*, — whether it had perhaps been lying on the table, — I do not know. But I stood at my desk and read, and read. Before the passion, the sorrows and the clashes I was reading about, the inner fog drew back, and when I came to the mighty ending with the moving scene where the old man stands bent over his daughter’s body, while the few faithful ones close in a circle around him, I burst into heartfelt weeping. I had a feeling as when a storm has raged and the light begins again to dawn through fog and rain. — It is not the only time that the great master’s deep humanity and great art [226] have brought me strength and peace. Another time it was “*Stormen*” that helped me, especially Prospero’s relation to Caliban, — when I saw Prospero, however violently he was torn out of his festive visions by the thought of the dark and bestial power that was not yet overcome, nevertheless hold fast to the clarity of his thought and to his exalted humanity.

When one reads Shakespeare in moods like the one I have indicated here, one benefits from his art without knowing and understanding it. But the main thing is still what he himself has one of his characters say, that above the art that helps nature there stands an art that nature itself has created. It is this deep, creative nature whose saving power one comes to know in such experiences.

Carlyle has said: close your Byron and open your Goethe! A Danish author wanted in his youth to turn it around: close your Goethe, and open your Byron! I would say, finally, and precisely when things are hard: close first your Byron, then your Goethe, and then open your Shakespeare!

Only the human can help us beyond the human, the all too human.

I still lived in the big old house in Strandgade for some years after the journey to America. The rooms were large and comfortable, somewhat low-ceilinged, but appealingly old-fashioned. And a splendid staircase led up to them. For walks I had Kristianshavns Vold, and when I wanted to go farther, Langelinie, having myself rowed across from the end of Strandgade to Nyhavns-Hoved. But soon the apartment became too big for me, and I wanted an apartment that would not be too expensive for me when I retired. I then moved out to Carl Bernhards Vej, into a small apartment where I had difficulty finding room for my books and my large worktable, but where I nevertheless soon felt comfortable and at home.

[227] I had more or less room for the gatherings I held at home now and then with the participants in my laboratory exercises. The pleasant Friday gatherings with Vilhelm Thomsen, Christiansen and Bohr also went on. To Frederiksberg Have and Søndermarken I had only a few minutes. My walks in these years, moreover, often stretched out into the country, to Hvidovre and to Damhussøen and its surroundings.

In political respects the change had taken place that the victorious Left had split. I could not bring myself to join either of the two new parties, and from that time on I have been a political free agent. In elections I voted according to the question most immediately at hand. In many things I could agree with the Radical Left and with its allies, the Social Democrats. What separated me from the Radicals was especially their short-sighted and indefensible position on the question of defense. In the Social Democrats' proposal, complete disarmament, there was at least consistency, and to that extent sense; but in the Radicals' position, or hint of a position, there was absolutely no sense. — But political life

on the whole took such a form that it could not awaken any desire to occupy oneself with it. And gradually I followed so little in this field that I often did not understand at all what set minds in the high Rigsdag in such strong commotion.

I had, besides, enough to do. Once in these years, in answer to an enquête, I gave a description of my working day which fits more or less the whole later part of my life. A morning person I have never been. Often, especially in my youth, I tried to begin my work early in the morning; but it never succeeded. In my student years it was the time from 10–2 at night that was my best time; then I had the most peace of mind. Later, on the other hand, it was the morning hours from 10–2 that became my best working time. The day was then naturally divided by the lectures, which in later years were mostly held from 3 to 4. And I [228] could then still have 5–6 working hours in the evening. One winter (1909–10) I worked for several months 11 hours a day.

My written works rest on a mass of drafts and attempts, which are constantly reworked, and even the continuous fair copy I have often completely reworked. My *Religionsfilosofi* was thus written 4 times, the program on the problems 3 times. When reading scientific literature I like to work pen in hand; it sharpens the attention both to what is right and to what is wrong in the books one reads. And remarks are often born that must be caught on the wing. I have collected large quantities of excerpts from books on philosophy, natural science and the history of religion; unfortunately they are of no use to anyone but myself (and I myself cannot always read my own handwriting).

Besides the propaedeutic course two years out of three, I constantly held laboratory exercises and lectures for larger circles. Some winters I also gave lectures at the Folkeuniversitet and took much pleasure in it. There came, moreover, new editions of my books, which gave much work in keeping them up to date (which I have not succeeded in doing in every detail); translations into foreign languages had to be looked through. Some correspondence was also unavoidable. And amid all this I was occupied with a work on knowledge and its main tasks on the basis of the sketch I had given in my University program of 1902. Before this sketch there were various preparatory studies in papers I had had printed

over the years in the Skrifter of the Royal Danish Academy of Sciences. In the winter of 1909–10 I undertook the final editing of the planned work, which then appeared in the autumn of 1910 under the title “Den menneskelige Tanke, dens Former og dens Opgaver”. (In words of foreign origin it would have run: The Functions of Thought, Its Categories and Its Problems). The winter months in [229] which I put the last touch to this book stand in my memory as a particularly good time. I worked with zeal and without tiring, and with a confidence by which I have unfortunately not always been animated¹⁾.

I go back some years in time. — In the summer of 1906 I lectured at a summer course in Lund for elementary-school teachers, men and women, from all over Sweden. It was a fresh and delightful audience, and I was very glad of this guest appearance, which took place under pleasant circumstances, since I stayed with my friend Professor Axel Herlin and his excellent wife. At a small closing celebration I spoke, after “Der er et yndigt Land” had been sung to applause. It was, after all, the year after the separation of Norway and Sweden, and there was in Sweden some ill feeling over Denmark’s attitude in that matter. I declared that Denmark’s position in this conflict was to be compared with Antigone’s in the conflict between her brothers: she could join in loving, but not in hating! —

That same autumn I represented the University at the 400th anniversary of the University of Aberdeen. I had a hard journey with much seasickness across the North Sea, and a young Englishman who was on board felt very sorry for “the poor old gentleman”, who was so ill. After a good night’s sleep in London I met my friend Otto Jespersen at the station the next morning; he too was going to Aberdeen, where he was to represent the Academy. At the ceremony the representatives of the various countries walked forward in alphabetical order, led by a student as herald, while the national anthem concerned was played. And so Jespersen and I marched forward to the stately “Kong Christian”. In the three minutes each deputation had, I declared that there were two things Danish students especially valued in Scottish thought, the broad Common Sense and the [230] keen sense for problems. I received on this occasion my third English doctorate.

¹⁾[On the content of this book I may refer to the essay on my work as an author, which is reprinted in “Religiøse Tanketyper” (pp. 29–33).]

There were great festivities, both official and private. And on this occasion I also came to know pleasant English home life, since I stayed some two miles outside the town with a colleague, Dr. McIntyre. In the same house stayed the German philologist Diels, whom it was a joy to me to get to know. In Aberdeen I also met the French philosopher Boutroux, whom I was with again some years later in Geneva, and who later again gave guest lectures in Copenhagen. I learned to admire his gift for brilliant characterization of philosophical types, and his open-mindedness and personal amiability have made him dear to me.

Several times I have mentioned how much I love the nature of Jutland. For a number of years I have spent my summer holidays in Jutland. I have mentioned the holiday in 1903. But I must also mention that I lived two summers (1898 and 99) on a farm by Salten Langsø, some five miles south of Silkeborg, in a glorious district with heath, lakes and woods, which truly invited long walks. To Himmelbjerget it was no farther than that one could walk there and back in an afternoon. From 1907 on I have for a number of summers (with the exception of 1909) lived on a farm between Hobro and Aalborg, in a true Jutland district with hills and stream, heather and wood. The excellent family I stayed with as a paying guest later moved to Moesgaard near Aarhus, and I have found the same comfortable home there, while the nature is somewhat different, more idyllic and more akin to that of Zealand.

On 1 September 1908 it was twenty-five years since I had been appointed professor, and on that occasion I was presented with an address from men in various walks of life and from a number of former students, in which I was at the same time asked to sit for my portrait. Since the collection for this purpose [231] had produced a large surplus, they wanted to have me painted twice, so that one picture should be given to the University, the other after my death pass to the National Museum at Frederiksborg. On the occasion of the day I received various

other tokens of kind thoughts. I did not myself celebrate the day, but it did me good to notice that my work had met with understanding. When I began my lectures the day after, I was received with loud applause by older and younger students.

To paint the two portraits I chose Viggo Johansen and Herman Vedel. I confess that I cannot really recognize myself in either of the two pictures, although each of them has surely caught something characteristic. Of portraits of myself I value most the bust which the sculptor Brandstrup made some years before, and which is in the Statens Museum for Kunst. — But I have sufficiently experienced how difficult it is to know one's mental self, and something similar probably holds as regards the bodily self as well.

That I, as mentioned above, worked particularly well in the winter of 1909–10 was perhaps because the previous summer I had made a longer journey which cheered and refreshed me greatly. I had received from the University of Cambridge in England a request to write an essay on “Darwin og Filosofien” for a Festschrift to be published on the occasion of the centenary of Charles Darwin's birth, — and with it an invitation to come over for the celebration and become an honorary doctor. I had also received from Geneva an invitation to take part in a celebration on the occasion of the University's 350 years of existence. And finally I had been asked to open a discussion on the psychology of religion at a psychological congress that was to be held in Geneva a month after the University celebration. I now combined all these various invitations and planned a round trip via Esbjerg to England and from there through France to Switzerland and home through Germany.

In fine summer weather I traveled, then, together with my zoological colleague Jungersen and his wife, two most amiable traveling companions, over to Esbjerg and from there across the North Sea to Harwich. This time the North Sea was comparatively gentle; in any case the lively conversations with the Norwegian meteorologist Mohn and his daughter kept the swell from making me sick.

In Cambridge I stayed, as five years before, with Professor Sorley. On the very first day my host invited me for a row on the river Cam. He himself stood in the stern and sculled us forward with his oar; we others, gentlemen and ladies, sat on comfortable cushions, and so we glided down the river through the splendid grounds belonging to the various colleges. On the banks young people could be seen lying about in conversation or reading. We met other boats with students or with the University's guests. In the brilliant sunshine it was a glorious trip, which has left a vivid picture in my memory. On one of the following days the solemn conferring of doctorates took place. We were 21 who were created at this Darwin commemoration. One by one we stepped forward before the Chancellor, Lord John Rayleigh, who sat in his chair clad in the magnificent chancellor's robe. At his side stood the Public Orator and read out a characterization in Latin of each of us. I was much moved and glad at mine, since in it I could recognize the understanding and kind view of English friends. After this reading I gave the Chancellor my hand, and he admitted me to the number of doctors with a Latin formula in the name of the Trinity. It was a collision between old and new to hear this formula pronounced at a ceremony in Darwin's honor. Otherwise the occasion of the day was celebrated by a speech by Balfour and, on behalf of the foreigners, by Arrhenius, and also in the following days by garden parties in various colleges. A special joy was the time spent with the good and warm-hearted Sorleys. Their happy home was not yet darkened by the sorrow that six years [233] later was to be caused by the fall of their eldest, gifted son.

From Cambridge I went to London, where I first stayed for a day or so with a young Danish friend, the engineer Thomsen, and his wife. Both had often visited me in Copenhagen as quite young people, and I had followed them on their way with interest. Then I stayed some days with Lady Welby, who had grown old but still pursued her studies with zeal, and then with Gooch, who had now become a member of Parliament. Through him I obtained admission to a sitting of Parliament, and although nothing of greater importance took place, I still got an idea of the proceedings in the world's first and most famous parliament, and it was with historical reverence that I looked out over the chamber from my box.

Some days later the journey went on to France. I had a glorious crossing from Dover to Calais. The white cliffs of Dover shone in the sunshine, and the blue sea sparkled. For an ardent reader of Shakespeare poetic memories were awakened here. And some lines of Wergeland's "engelske Lods", which Professor Mohn had enthusiastically reminded me of as we approached the English coast, came to my mind again:

"Det, som skinner vester hist
mellem Sky og Havsens Vover,
Det er England, solbelyst,
Klipperne ved Dover.
Shakespeare cliffens hvide Hvælv
vesterud er Marmorfoden,
hvorfra Sejrens Dronning selv
stolt behersker Kloden."

The deck was full of travelers from every possible country, who were now making the crossing between the two countries to which world culture owes so much. To my bodily well-being there contributed, besides the sunshine and the life around me, the excellent lunch Mrs. Gooch had provided me with.

[234] In Paris I stayed four days. A joy of recognition rested over them; it was forty years since I had been there. The bright, beautiful summer days now were very different from the wintertime in which my stay had fallen the previous time, and cast a new light over the familiar places. And how much had not changed in Paris; the previous time it was under the Empire. And how much had not changed in and for me? — But I enjoyed life in those days, drove around in a cab to look about, was in museums in the mornings and at the theater in the evenings. I visited Professor Léon Brunschvicg and his wife, who some years before had been in Copenhagen and been my guests. To the well-known, much disputed philosopher Henri Bergson I paid a long visit and had an interesting conversation with him. I admired the subtlety and open-mindedness of his thinking. He knew that on various points I took a critical stance toward his philosophy, and we came

at once to the decisive questions. He gave a nervous impression, but above all the impression of a man who lives in his work of thought without any other consideration than how the thoughts can rightly unfold and find their clearest expression. It is quite unjust to think one can dispose of him by shouting fashionable philosopher after him or by making jokes about the vitalism he shares with a number of biologists. — Some years later I published a little book on his philosophy, which was translated into English, and when Bergson had read it, he wrote me a longish letter in which he acknowledged the chivalry of my criticism and made a number of counter-remarks. It pleased me to see that he too kept a good memory of our conversation. When the book was translated into French, the letter was included as an appendix.

In Geneva I took part in the University celebration and received here a new doctorate (the sixth!); this time it was *Docteur ès lettres*, motivated by my book on Rousseau, on the recommendation of the *Société Jean Jacques Rousseau*. It pleased me to meet the philosopher Boutroux here again, this time accompa- [235] nished by his lively and gifted wife, a sister of the mathematician and philosopher Poincaré and a cousin of the President of the French Republic. Some years later I had the pleasure of seeing them both in Copenhagen, where he gave two brilliant lectures at the University, and where I also had them as guests at my home. — On my last day in Geneva this time I was together with the Boutroux at the home of the literary historian Bouvier, chairman of the *Société Jean Jacques Rousseau*. Here I also met the well-known historian Gabriel Monod, a brother-in-law of Bouvier, an exceedingly attractive man, refined and gentle in his manner and his judgment. He pleased me by telling me that in his lectures on the history of culture he had made good use of my book on the history of modern philosophy. — The Monod family, to which he and Bouvier belonged, had connections with Denmark, since the grandfather of these two had been a French Reformed pastor in Copenhagen. And so here too I was given a Danish national dish, namely *rødgrød*, but in a very refined form, as a jelly with cream; it did, however, come from Copenhagen.

That same evening I sailed from Geneva across the Lake of Geneva to Mon-

treux. The weather was rainy, and I kept to the cabin, where I met a Dr. Forel, brother of the well-known psychiatrist. When the next morning I opened my balcony door at the Hotel Suisse in Montreux, the glorious blue Lake of Geneva lay before me. I now had some paradisal days, which were spent on walks partly northward to Clarens, known from Rousseau's "Nouvelle Héloïse", partly southward past Chillon, known from Byron's poem on the prisoner of Chillon. Later I moved up the mountain, to Glion, whose pure, strong air did me good. I here made the acquaintance of an elderly English lady, Mrs. Rufford, a clergyman's widow, with whom it was very pleasant to talk and discuss. She was free and open in her views. Her husband had belonged to the critical school in theology, and she was in high degree free of prejudice. We corresponded for several years afterward.

[236] From Glion I went via Aigle up to Ormont dessus, in the vicinity of the Diablerets glacier, where an American colleague, Professor Leuba, had booked a room for me. I spent a week or so here and was often together with Leuba and his family. Then I went down again via Aigle to Martigny, where I spent the night, so as to make the next day the magnificent trip by mountain railway from Martigny to Chamounix. It is one of the most glorious things I have experienced. The line runs right along the edge of a mountain, and one looks down into deep valleys and across to mountain heights on the other side. There was great enthusiasm among the travelers too. A French father, who was making the trip with wife and children, cried out time after time: "Oh, ça vaut bien l'argent! Ça vaut bien l'argent!" I liked this exclamation better than the Germans' "Famos! Furchtbar schön!"

In Chamounix I met my friend the chemist Karl Meyer with his wife and daughters, and we had a pleasant time with one another, all the while that in this great nature, with Mont Blanc right before us, we received unforgettable impressions. After the Meyer family had left, I put the last touch to the lecture I was to give at the psychological congress in Geneva. And on solitary walks I experienced something of what Kant has said, that the great in nature as it were bends us back into ourselves to find an inner greatness as a counterpart to the

outer. Alas, it was not pure greatness I could find. There was so much that was petty that came out at the same time. But it went through a purgatory, and as the conclusion of the whole movement in my mind there arose the confidence that there was after all a striving to be worthy to behold so mighty a nature, — a striving for kinship, however distant, with what is great in the world of the spirit. —

In Geneva I came to stay with the psychologist Th. Flournoy, who had long since sent me a very kind invitation. He met me at the railway station, and I now spent a good full week in his beautiful and comfortable home in the suburb of Florissant. His wife was a stately and gracious lady, independent in her way [237] of thinking and in her way of taking life, like her husband a descendant of the old strict Calvinists who founded Geneva's freedom and culture. Of orthodox Calvinism there was certainly not much left, but as a heritage there prevailed a consistency of thought that cuts through the half-measures characteristic of Lutheran theology. Théodore Flournoy himself is an excellent psychologist of the experimental school. He has written on visions of colors and figures, but has occupied himself quite especially with somnambulistic phenomena, which he has treated from a scientific point of view in several books and papers. Alongside that and in connection with it he has a keen sense for the involuntary movements of mental life. His religious standpoint is akin to that of James, whose friend he was.

The days were spent with lectures and discussions. I had planned my opening lecture so that with the help of the history of religion I would find out what I called the psychological place of religion, that is, which region of mental life religion most nearly belonged to. In a similar direction went the lecture of the other opener, Leuba, though with a decidedly polemical tendency. In the discussion several theologians spoke, not exactly with great clarity. As not seldom, the Catholic theologians here too were sharper and more consistent than the Protestant ones, and I remember with pleasure a discussion I had with Abbé Pacheu from Paris, author of several works on religious mysticism. At the closing banquet he gave a speech in which he said that he too was "un chercheur comme

Monsieur Høffding". Several years later I received greetings from him through Danish travelers who had met him. It was a shortcoming of both opening lectures that no account was taken of the pathological phenomena that so often accompany religious states of mind. In the discussion the psychopathologists could not get a word in at all for the many theologians.

[238] An interesting debate was provoked by the German-American physiologist Jacques Loeb's lecture on "Tropisms" (roughly the same as reflex movements). Loeb maintained with great sharpness the necessity of seeking purely mechanical explanations of all animal and human movements, in contrast to the current spiritualistic explanations. From my Spinozist standpoint I could support him in the debate from the philosophical side. — I had already met him in America, but now became better acquainted with him in Geneva. When Flournoy one day suggested that I invite some of the participants in the congress to lunch at his house, I chose Loeb and the American psychiatrist Morton Prince, whom I had likewise met in America. On one of the last days of the congress Morton Prince presented to a quite small circle a female patient whom he had cured of double consciousness. After hypnotizing her, Morton Prince could by suggestion call forth her earlier states again, and one thereby gained an interesting insight into the course of the illness and of the cure. It is the lady who in the psychopathological literature is known under the name B. C. A. (A was a very depressed state; it was relieved now and then by B, a very frivolous state; but there appeared now and then, especially under hypnosis, a more harmonious state, C, which Morton Prince cultivated in pure form through constant suggestions). She was a very intelligent lady, who declared that out of gratitude to Prince, and so that others might benefit from her case, she gladly submitted to hypnosis again.

Best of all in this whole stay in Geneva, though, were the summer evenings out in Florissant with my dear host and his family. I felt quite at home with them. I had the same good fortune here as I had had at Harvard, in London, in Cambridge, in Oxford and in Aberdeen. To judge from these experiences, philosophers must be well suited to founding good homes. Yet I am inclined [239] to give the wives the main credit, so that the philosophers' merit becomes that

of winning good wives. Madame Flournoy was indeed a mistress of the house without equal, both by her spiritual superiority and by her at once energetic and gentle management of everything in the house.

A Swedish friend and colleague, Sidney Alrutz from Upsala, was also staying with the Flournoy's. We meant to leave immediately after the close of the congress, but were asked in the kindest way whether we would not stay over the next day, which was a Sunday. It was a very hot day, which we spent in the garden in all sorts of good conversation. The next day we left, each in his own direction. I had no idea that the excellent woman I had come to know was soon to go on the journey from which one does not return. A couple of weeks after my return home to Copenhagen I received a letter from Flournoy in which he told me that his wife, during a stay in the mountains, had caught pneumonia and had died after a short illness. Later he published in her memory a biographical sketch, which contained some of her poems and gave a characterization of her religious standpoint. She was a deeply religious nature and held essentially to Christianity; but she was to such a degree convinced that God could not be the cause of evil that she could not believe that he had created the world. God works constantly to alleviate and prevent the evils that the laws of matter bring with them. But if he were really present in the world, he would have to be victor everywhere! It was her own experiences and her own reflection that had brought her to this stage, which she embraced with great seriousness, without its preventing gentleness and a bright mind from prevailing in her conduct. In his little book Flournoy quotes some sentences from a letter of mine, which I had written immediately after the news of her death; I said in it that there were few people toward whom I felt such a desire and need to open myself and communicate myself as toward her. — I have not lost all connection with the family in Florissant in later years. They have always sent me news of the more important family [240] events. We also have, after all, one beautiful memory in common. —

From Geneva I traveled through Savoy to Grenoble. On the way I stopped at Aix-les-Bains, where five years before my young friend Harald Munch-Petersen had lost his life. His body had been found half a year later and buried in the

town's cemetery, on ground given by the municipality. Danish friends had had a monument designed by Bindesbøll and Jerndorff erected on the grave, which I now wished to visit. It was painful to stand there at the grave of broken hopes. I had the grave put in order and arranged with the gravedigger how it was to be kept up. Then I traveled to Chambéry, the residence of the old dukes of Savoy, which interested me most, however, because Jean Jacques Rousseau had lived there for several years. I drove out to Les Charmettes, a country house outside the town, where he spent the time that in his "Bekendelser" stood before him as an idyll, and where he pursued the studies that made his gospel of nature more than a mere matter of feeling. In Grenoble I met a number of Danish students who had made a journey through Germany and Switzerland, and who were staying there to take part in the vacation courses the University of Grenoble holds every year for foreigners. How diligently they studied I shall leave unsaid; but they enjoyed themselves splendidly, and I enjoyed myself well with them for a couple of days. We made an interesting trip up to the Chartreuse, where the empty monastery buildings stood as memorials of the violent struggle between state and church that had recently raged.

Via Lausanne and Frankfurt I traveled home to Copenhagen, and in the first while felt very tired from the journey and the irregular way of life. My eldest brother invited me to stay some weeks with him at his country house near Frederiksdal, and I recovered so well there that I could begin my work after the vacation with fresh strength.

[241] It was in the following winter (1909–10) that I put the last touch to the above-mentioned rounding-off (not concluding) account of my studies of human thought and its relation to existence and its riddles. That I could now publish this account ("Den menneskelige Tanke" 1910) was naturally a major event for me. I thought that I could speak of "langer Jahre redlich Streben" and moreover add: "Nun, man kommt doch eine Strecke!" — Yes, but how long this stretch is, I naturally can myself have no opinion about.

The following three years (1910–12) take their character for me partly from

interesting lecture journeys to Sweden, Finland and Norway, partly from deaths in my nearest circle. Light and darkness contend sharply in my memory of these years.

In the summer of 1910 I gave a series of lectures on social ethics at the summer course in Stockholm. As in Lund in 1906, I had here a good audience of teachers, men and women, and I felt quite at home among them. And here too I delighted in the full-toned Swedish singing. None of the Nordic peoples sings its national anthem as powerfully and proudly as the Swedes. Prince Eugen of Sweden was president of the course, and I was glad to meet him here again, after I had made his acquaintance some years before in Copenhagen at the home of his friend the painter Viggo Johansen. Together with several of the speakers at the course I spent a beautiful summer evening at his villa by the “inloppet”. — The stay in Stockholm was very pleasant for me, since I stayed with my friends Frants and Hanna v. Schéele. After the close of the lectures I spent some time with them at their beautiful summer residence in Södermanland.

The next year (1911) I accepted an invitation to give lectures in Helsingfors. [242] At the end of March I went via Stockholm to Finland. I lectured every day for a week on “Personlighetsprincipen i Filosofien”. On request the lectures were later printed both in Finnish and in Swedish. The expression “principle of personality” I had often used before without knowing that it was Erik Gustaf Geijer who first used it (1838) to designate the right the individual has to initiative as well as to independent appropriation. It signifies a reaction against Romanticism and the “historical school”, a luminous reaction, which within Danish intellectual life came some years later through Sibbern and Kierkegaard. My lectures aimed to show the psychological possibility and the ethical justification of this principle, its significance for the philosophy of religion, and for the right understanding of the relation between science and life. The little book (*Personlighetsprincipen i Filosofien*, Stockholm 1910) I deliberately did not let appear in Danish, because I think that Swedish and Danish should not be regarded as two entirely different literatures. I have a certain fondness for the little book, because in it I have tried in concentrated form to shed light on a subject that I have come upon here and

there in my various writings in more special contexts. — One evening I also gave a lecture in which I drew a comparison between Kierkegaard and Nietzsche, two thinkers who could illuminate each other both by their mutual contrast and by various points of likeness. The lecture was printed in “Svensk Tidsskrift” and later in Danish (in “Mindre Arbejder”. Third Series).

During the stay in Helsingfors I enjoyed great kindness and hospitality from the Rector, the philologist Heikel, and other colleagues. After the close of the lectures I went to Petrograd, where I stayed some days with my brother, the engineer Theodor Høffding. It was a joy to me to live these days with him and his wife and to renew acquaintance with his sons, as well as to make the acquaintance of his Russian daughters-in-law. (The youngest son and his wife I did not meet, however, as they did not live in Petrograd). — On the journey home I stopped some days in Åbo, where I lectured in the Pedagogical Society. Here too I had an excellent and attentive audience and met interesting people. When on a Sunday afternoon I was to sail from Åbo to Stockholm, and so say farewell to Finland, a number of my listeners had gathered on the shore, and as the ship put out, they sang “Suomi’s Sang”. It was a moving farewell from a country for which I had already beforehand come to feel love, for its nature, for its poetry and for its tragic fate. — The voyage through the sounds of the Åland Islands was very beautiful. There was still ice between the islands, and only a narrow channel had been made for the steamer. The sun shone on the white ice and on the green spruce forests on the islands. In several places people were going from one island to another, and often, as soon as the steamer had passed, a rolling bridge was run out to get across the shipping channel. It was a peculiar winter picture. —

In the spring of 1912 I was invited to lecture in Kristiania. I stayed there two weeks. In the first week I lectured every other day to a larger circle (1100 listeners) in the University’s great festival hall on “aandelig Kultur”. (The lecture is printed in *Mindre Arbejder*. Third Series). In the second week I gave three lectures on questions in the theory of knowledge. In addition I spoke in the Students’ Society and in the Philological Society. It was a joy to me to become

better acquainted with Norwegian colleagues. After the close of the lectures I spent some days up at Voxenkollen, where deep snow still lay, which in the brilliant sunshine and under the blue sky made a splendid sight. —

When I think of the three years 1910–12, it is — when the bright memories prevail — especially the visits to Stockholm, Helsingfors and Kristiania that come to mind. It was a joy to me, now, as earlier in Upsala and in Lund, to take part in [244] working for a community of intellectual life in the Nordic countries.

But these three years have also left memories of a sad kind. Through deaths in my nearest circle I began to learn that to live long is to outlive many with whom one would gladly have gone on living.

My brother Otto Høffding, who lived at Strandegaard on Præstø Bugt, was an able and highly respected farmer. In his later years he held the post of chairman of the United Agricultural Societies of Zealand. In his tenant farm his family felt at home. This was due not only to the many memories that through three generations were now attached to the idyllic place, but also to his and his wife's hospitality and their clear and sound view of life. Since for several years I had lived in the summer near Strandegaard, namely at Vemmetofte Strand and at Strandegaard Dyrehave, I had had the opportunity to grow close to them.

My brother was a handsome and stately man. Not without reason was he called, in the funeral address given by one of his friends, a noble nature. He did not easily open up his innermost self. And yet he was a gentle and loving man, easily moved to tears. He was much loved in his district by high and low. It therefore caused much grief when in the spring of 1910 he suddenly collapsed. After a walk across his fields he was seized with violent pains and had to be taken, sedated with morphine, by automobile to Copenhagen, where some days later he was operated on. It then turned out, as the doctors had probably suspected beforehand, that a cancer had burst the intestine. A few days later he died. It was sad down at his farm to hear the church bell calling to his funeral on the quiet spring day. The gentle chime that so many times in my childhood and later had [245]

been part of the idyll down there now brought the last farewell to one of those closest to me.

A couple of months later my eldest brother, the wholesale merchant Victor Høffding, died. He had continued with great ability and in honorable fashion the business founded by our father (chiefly in seeds and iron) and was highly respected in the commercial world. After the death of his wife, Elisabeth Høffding, some years before, he had wasted away. She had been very ill for several years, and in his care for her he had neglected an abdominal complaint, which now spread more and more. In these years of his infirmity he had a touching need to have his brothers and sisters around him. My sister and I often had to be with him at his comfortable country house near Frederiksdal. He liked best to talk of old days and dwelt on the memories we had in common. After great suffering he died in June 1910. I lost in him a friend who followed me on my course with brotherly interest. I often looked in on him at his office (the corner of Gammel Torv and Nørregade) when I walked to the University. — His children, of whom the son has continued the family's fine tradition in the commercial world, show on every occasion their affection for the old uncle, who is now the eldest of the family, and of whom they know that he was their father's friend.

The only brother I still have left lives in Petrograd, where — as mentioned earlier — I have visited him twice, just as he in the autumn of 1915 stayed for a month or so with me at Carlsberg. Besides him, of my brothers and sisters I have only my sister left. In her gentle nature, which has stood its test through hard times, I find again the best that could be inherited from our mother. She and I are now alone with the old memories from home. She takes part with heartfelt sympathy in everything that concerns me. And gentle as her mind is, she still has her clear and definite view of life, won through experience and independent reflection. — I cannot at all imagine that she should go before me. —

[246] The year after (shortly before my journey to Finland) I received one morning in the spring word by telephone of the death of my friend Christian Bohr. He

had died suddenly the night before. It was not long since he had taken part in one of the pleasant Friday gatherings I have mentioned before, where his life and wit contributed so essentially to what the evenings yielded. He had, to be sure, recently suffered a disappointment, in that one of his works proved not to lead to the result he had expected. But the main thing was that his somewhat heavy constitution could not endure the strenuous work he lived in. He had come home from the laboratory at about ten in the evening, apparently well and cheerful; but then he had a heart attack, which after a couple of hours ended in death. It was a great sorrow for those closest to him and for his friends, and a great loss for Danish science. For my own part I owe him much, and I felt it a joy and an honor to stand close to him. At the wish of his family I gave an address at his funeral in the Crematorium, and I set down here some portions of the characterization of my departed friend that I attempted on that occasion.

“This man was torn away in his full strength. The news struck with violent and overwhelming force. A happy death it was, to be sure; he came straight from his work and lay down on the deathbed of a few hours. To fall asleep thus after the day’s work is a manner of death that many wish for themselves. But here, after all, the poet’s words do not fit: ‘He fell asleep, as the sun goes down at harvest-time.’ For it was not harvest-time, not yet autumn for him. He did not yet belong among the veterans. He stood in the rich summer of his searching genius and his energy for work, in the first rank among Denmark’s men of science, and still had fruitful years of work in prospect.

If it has fallen to my lot to speak here, it is not because I was one of his colleagues in his field. But I have followed him through a long series of years with instruction and admiration. It was a helping hand he gave me, when my work had to seek help from his field, that first brought us into closer connection, and later I have been able to follow his work through the years in the Royal Danish Academy of Sciences. It was a festive evening when he took the floor, absorbed by the new things he had found, by the difficulties he had overcome, and by the new problems that arose before him. And his investigations moved, over that long series of years, along one single definite line. It was his task, in one of the [247]

most central domains of organic life, to trace the boundary between life, and the laws of inorganic nature, — to see whether there was a fixed boundary, and where in that case it lay. And for this the physiology of respiration was quite especially suited. Bohr stands as an independent collaborator in the great period in the history of physiology that was founded by Johannes Müller and his disciples in Germany and by Claude Bernard in France, and whose program was to follow the working of the general forces of nature as far into the processes of organic life as possible. Bohr found a provisional limit to their working in the fact that respiration was not wholly determined by the influence of external conditions. The riddle proved to lie further back than the contending parties had supposed. There was a time when Bohr complained that his position was often misunderstood, as if he wished to return to so-called vitalism. But his meaning was only that a new line of investigation had to be undertaken, chiefly of the influence of the nervous system on the processes in the cells of the lungs. His position here was characteristic of his character as an investigator, and he expressed it clearly and aptly in his last University program. His mastery of thought shows itself in the critical holding fast to the reach of the problems, with reference to the great horizons that open up behind each single line of investigation for the true investigator, — but at the same time in the firm conviction that there is only one way by which progress into the new regions can be achieved, steady, faithful work in [248] the spirit of strict science. His work could have had as its motto Lotze's words: enthusiastic only for the great, but faithful in the small! He stood for us all as an instructive example, not only through the results his research brought, but above all through his whole scientific bearing.

He has done his country honor. If our flag cannot wave victorious in the strife of the world powers, it can wave proudly over many a deed of the spirit, many an exploit of thought, and it is lowered at this bier! —

For those who had the joy of standing close to him outside collegial intercourse as well, his personality presented basic features similar to those that distinguished him as an investigator. His free and energetic mind often played with paradoxes, and he let his wit have its play; his friends could often feel as if they

were in a purgatory before his criticism; but behind it there always lay respect for serious work and a great faithfulness in friendship. He was not one of those who easily let feeling run away with them, and who gave or expected declarations of friendship, but all the more did his hearty glance and his firm handshake tell. Nor was he one of those who talked much about his view of life and its fortunes. In the background, however, there stood for him an outlook that could recall Goethe's great, at once naturalistic and ideal view of life, in which the small and the bitter things faded away against a great horizon. Few knew their Goethe as he did. He perhaps most often quoted Mephistopheles' speeches; but behind them lay a striving like Faust's, only he did not, like Faust, give up the work with retorts, lever and screw (*Hebeln und Schrauben*); it was not by going around the place of scientific work that the way to truth lay for him. —

Now we shall no longer see his bright gaze and clear, spirited brow, which gave his whole powerful figure its stamp, or listen to his instructive exposition or to his wit and his sharp criticism!

He leaves a great void in science at home and abroad, and in the circle of [249] friends and colleagues. But we, to whom he was so much, now turn nonetheless to the one and to those to whom he was most. In his beautiful home he was the soul through his life and his interests, and those for whom he opened it will understand how great the void there must be. He found understanding and love there. In this as in other things he was a happy man. Not least was his joy in the young, able talents that he saw unfolding in scientific works, precisely in such domains as had special interest for him. There had, after all, been every reason to believe that he would have a fine evening of work together with his aspiring sons, and warmed by all the love that surrounded him in his home. It was not to be so.

But from the thought of the suddenness of the loss and of all that the loss contains, we turn back again to the remembered image of his personality and of his figure as an investigator.

Honor and peace be with the memory of Christian Bohr!" —

A year or so later I stood again in the Crematorium to speak at a friend's

coffin. Julius Petersen had been ailing for a number of years, and, odd as he was, and skeptical toward his own science, or at any rate toward his own profession, he would not let himself be examined by any physician. He literally withered away, often in great suffering. But again and again his warm heart could stir and his soulful eyes bear witness that the old friendship still lived in him. Of his death I give an account in the address I gave at his funeral, in which I also attempted a characterization of him. I set down this address here, roughly as it was delivered.

[250] “So our old, dear friend has found rest after the long time of pain. And he had a beautiful death. Toward the morning hours on the day that was to be the day of his death, a greater and greater restlessness came over him, which was first stilled when his faithful nurse asked whether he wanted to get up. He nodded eagerly; speak he could not. He was then carried over to the window and saw the sun shining on the water, a sight he had always been very fond of. His youngest son supported him. The nurse now asked whether she should sing a lullaby he had always been very fond of, and to this he answered eagerly Yes, Yes! So there was singing for the old man, as there was singing for him in his childhood, and when the song was over, he was dead.

As in the hour of his death, so during his whole illness there was a wondrous spiritual clarity about him, together with the advancing decrepitude. A struggle went on between his need for thought and speech and the darkness that the illness, as well as the melancholy which was his companion through life, kept spreading anew over his mind.

And this struggle between light, vigorous work and zest for action on the one side, melancholy, bitterness and passive sinking down on the other side, runs through his whole life, right from the young years. He was a man of strife, and a brave man. It was within him that the strife took place. When we met as comrades in the last years at school, more than half a hundred years ago, it was the oscillation between light and darkness in his mind, between zeal and languor in his activity, that first gave me an understanding of him. One had to hold fast to the fact that both belonged to his nature, and those who became

his friends learned to bear with him in the heavy and dark hours, in contrast to which the real and hearty sympathy and the clear, lively thought worked all the more strongly in the good times. The way in which he then came to meet us with his warm glance, his friendly handshake, made his friends, like himself, forget the hours when the ‘mjeltsjukans svartalf’ that Tegnér has depicted held sway. There was a fire within him that often threatened to consume himself, but that could give light and warmth when the dark mists did not prevent it from becoming a pure and clear flame.

His work came in fits and starts. It could not be otherwise under his changing [251] life of moods. At school he was periodically considered lazy, because for long stretches he neglected everything. But he could then, in a short time, by violent concentration and intense diligence, work his way up to a place among the first. Our old Rector had great goodwill and also a certain understanding of him; but he nonetheless felt toward him like the hen toward the swimming ducklings it has hatched. And his friends often fared the same way.

He finished his University studies with feverish haste and soon after began to practice out in the poor quarters of Nørrebro, and he quickly acquired a large practice. His warm feeling for the needy and the suffering animated his activity, but often made it hard and painful for himself. The want and suffering he saw so much of increased the low spirits that so easily mastered him, and his modest home often seemed to him too luxurious when he returned to it from the wretched rooms in which so many of his patients lived. In other circles too than those of the poor he won a large practice, which returned to him when, after some years' absence as a country doctor, he came back to Nørrebro.

As a physician he worked above all through his warmth of heart and sympathy, through the immediate beneficial impression of his personality, through the mysterious influence that is not the least essential part of the effect the physician produces at the sickbed. Everyone whose physician he has been will have experienced how calming it was merely when he came and sat down. Not everyone discovered that behind this calming presence the strongest inner discord was often stirring in himself.

Something tragic came into his whole position through his slight faith in medicine as a science. He himself had no faith in the remedies he used, and which most of his patients would not do without. What had his heart was medicine as [252] an art, Hippocratism with its great respect for the organism's self-help, which required the physician's activity only to keep hindrances away, to relieve and strengthen, to individualize, to treat each case and each single patient in its own particular way. It is a great ideal for the practitioners of the healing art that he draws at the end of his book on the historical development of the medical art of healing. It seemed to him that many of the practitioners of the more recent medical science did not have sufficient understanding of this ideal, and it aroused in him an antipathy to the new tendencies that became more pronounced with the years. He himself belonged to a period of transition, in which the old art of healing was more and more replaced by a technique built on medical science, and what is tragic in such a period of transition worked strongly in his inmost being and increased the bitterness that the mjeltsjukans svartalf had beforehand so often instilled in his mind.

It was the history of the healing art that he treated in his work as an author and as University teacher of the history of medicine. His considerable literary talent and the eloquence he commanded in his inspired moments made it possible for him to give brilliant and sympathetic portrayals of the heroes of the healing art. Here both his interest in and his sense for personalities and his skeptical attitude toward modern theories and methods found expression.

Those were his happiest years, in which his literary work really flourished and won recognition. It was also a great help to his soul to be able to immerse himself in research and exposition. Then he could more easily overcome the darkness of despondency and subdue the inner unrest. His strength found an outlet in production instead of being wasted in hypochondria and melancholy.

The one who of all understood him best, his wife, saw this clearly. As his and her old friend I must here express my great admiration for this faithful and [253] wise woman, who in her own nature also had her own share to struggle with, but who was wholly absorbed in him and his doings and had a clear eye for the

core of his nature and great faith in it. She held fast to the center about which the strong oscillations took place, always sure that the pendulum would swing back into the old path, and patiently waiting for it. She saw clearly that salvation for him lay in work, and never grew tired, despite all his resistance, of keeping him at it. After her death he began to decline. The long dreadful illness by which she wasted away, the great emptiness the loss caused, and the loss of a young son, on whom he, like the rest of us, set great hopes, wore on his vital strength, and to this was then added the long illness that has now led to his passing. But even now his lively spirit and his warm heart broke forth again and again through the shadows that illness and melancholy caused.

As a relief it is now felt by us all that his sufferings are ended. But then there comes also the wistful thought of what we have lost in him. Not only his children and nearest kin, his friends too feel that here a life has closed which, in its personal singularity, its depth, its faithful endurance in life's inner and outer struggles, must fill a great place in the minds of all who had attached themselves to him and gained an insight into what moved within him. I personally am not among those who have least to be thankful for, and I must be allowed here to thank the friend of my youth, on whose faithful heart I could always rely, and who, tossed about in many ways in the course of life, always preserved the sacred fire within him, the sacred fire of ideal striving, of understanding and of compassion.

And so we all say farewell to our friend. Weary of days as he was, he might well have deserved a gentler evening than the one the wasting and tormenting illness permitted. But a beautiful death was granted him; he went away, after all, greeting the rising spring sun. What moved within him in the last moments no one can say. But I am hardly mistaken, judging by everything, when I believe [254] that it was something like what the poet has expressed in the line: 'Yet the spring of life wells up, as ever it welled!'

Honor and peace be with the memory of Julius Jacob Petersen!"

In March 1913 my seventieth birthday was approaching. I was thinking a little

of being away from town that day. I felt I had had jubilees enough. I had made a whole plan for a solitary excursion to North Zealand, from which I would return home in the evening to drink tea with my son and daughter-in-law in Hellerup. Inquiries were made privately whether I would accept an invitation to a festive dinner; but it was warded off. But then I was surprised and much moved by an invitation from the three children of my eldest brother, the wholesale merchant Aage Høffding and his sisters Mrs. Schierbeck and Mrs. Dyrhauge. They wished to gather family, friends and colleagues in my nephew's beautiful home in Nørre Farimagsgade. I gladly accepted this invitation, and we drew up a list of about 40 participants for this family celebration. Besides some Danish colleagues who were close to me, my Swedish friend Professor Axel Herlin and his wife were also invited, and at the last moment my German friend Professor Ferdinand Tönnies came as well. And to this was added one more thing that made the day a radiant event for me. The Students' Council had obtained permission from the Rector of the University and from the Director of Police to greet me with a torchlight procession, and had then arranged with my nephew that the procession should go to his home, which lay not far from the University.

And so the day dawned that was in so many ways to bring me joy through the overflowing kindness that met me from so many sides. In the morning, having been summoned, I was in audience with the King, who with a few kind words [255] presented me with the Commander's Cross of the First Class. On several occasions it has been a joy and an honor for me to learn that King Christian X followed my activity at and outside the University. Later in the day flowers, congratulations and deputations streamed in, and I had just time for a short rest before I was to drive to my brother's children's celebration for their old uncle. Speeches and songs (among them a fine cantata by Niels Møller) alternated right up to nine o'clock, when the torchlight procession was to come, and I stepped out on the balcony facing Ørstedsparken. It was a splendid sight when the torchlight procession appeared on the other side of the park and moved around it up Nørre Farimagsgade, which was black with people. I was much moved to see this mass of people, which stood quite still and waited. I may say that what stirred in

me was indeed joy and pride at being the object of all this homage, but that the thought nonetheless stirred in me especially that it was as one of the teachers of our old University that it was accorded me, so that it could bear witness to the good relation that prevails between teachers and students when both parties are absorbed in serious striving. Now the long procession came up in front of the house, and after the singing of a fine song the student Skat Hoffmeyer stepped up onto a platform and gave a speech in which he dwelt on my work and my relation to the students, especially to the individuals who had confided in me. The essential content of my reply was that for me these torches cast light back on the happy years in which I had worked at the University and had there met so much fresh youth and so much serious striving. I had especially been gladdened by the trust that so many had shown me by asking my advice on purely personal matters. I hoped that the torches would also cast their light forward, and that our University might always find faithful sons and be the home of a fine collaboration between older and younger in the service of truth. I closed with a cheer for the University. Then the procession filed past amid hurrahs and disappeared [256] on the other side of the park.

When the last torches disappeared my emotion got the upper hand, and I went and sat in a solitary room, where I burst into tears. What had met me on this day was so overwhelming that I could not understand that it really was me it all concerned. I had to think of the many dark hours, the many doubts about myself I had gone through, the sour work I had many times had to do. There must, after all, if I could trust what had met me today, be some for whom I had meant something. I do not let my judgment of my works depend on the judgment of others; but it does warm one to the innermost when signs come that one believes one can rightly interpret as an expression of understanding.

Before and after the birthday there were celebrations in the Students' Society and in the Students' Union, and finally the participants in my laboratory exercises gave a party for me. It was an eventful week. —

A year after 11 March 1913, on 12 March 1914, the chairman of the Board

of the Carlsberg Foundation came out to me and informed me that the Board intended to propose to the Academy that I be chosen to occupy the main building of Old Carlsberg, which under J. C. Jacobsen's will was to be used as a residence for the Danish man or woman whom the said Academy might select for it. This provision was now to take effect, since the testator's son Carl Jacobsen had died.

This came as a complete surprise to me. There had been much discussion in some papers, from what I had heard, and I too had been mentioned. And I had seen myself in Klods-Hans as Diogenes, who in the end, however, for economic reasons preferred his tub to the Carlsberg Honorary Residence. But I had, like all [257] the members of the Academy, been convinced that the choice should and must fall on Vilhelm Thomsen. But then Thomsen's physician had firmly advised him against moving from his present home, which in every respect suited his frail health, out to Carlsberg, which did not suit him so well, besides the fact that the change itself could be risky. And so it was that they turned to me.

I had never seen the house from inside, and the first visit out there on a fine day in early spring was overwhelming. I still harbored some economic misgivings; there had been so much talk of how expensive it was to live in such a residence, — and the Diogenes of "Klods Hans" therefore had to go out and beg once he had got the Honorary Residence! Although I was not badly placed financially, there were nonetheless considerations I had to take into account, especially when I thought of my approaching retirement from the University. These misgivings were overcome, however, and a few days later I wrote to the Board and accepted the offer. The week after (20 March) the matter came before the Academy. I had been asked not to appear in the meeting room until I was called in, and I waited a quarter of an hour or so in a side room. When I had been called in, the President, Vilhelm Thomsen, informed me in a few kind words that the Academy had unanimously chosen me as occupant of the Honorary Residence. In my reply I began by saying that the President knew me so well that he knew it was not in me either to dissemble or to flatter. It was not dissembling when I said that it grieved me that his health did not permit him to accept the offer. And it was not flattery when I said that the Honorary Residence was his due as our country's

foremost man of science, and when I added that, if he could not accept the offer, there was still a great leap before it could be directed to me. Turning then to the Academy, I expressed my heartfelt thanks for the election and added thanks for the many years in which I had had the honor of being a member. It was, I said, of great importance particularly for the philosopher to be able to follow at first hand what goes on in other sciences, by hearing their representatives speak about methods and results within their field. [258]

A couple of months later (11 May) I moved in at Carlsberg. And with this I have reached the point at which I had in mind to close these memoirs. Only a few things more will I mention.

For the time being I continued my University activity in its full scope, with the propaedeutic course for the young students, laboratory exercises for a narrower circle and evening lectures for a wider circle. From a certain quarter in the press there are said to have come, right from my seventieth birthday, frequent hints that I ought now to withdraw — I felt myself still fit for work, and the expressions of sympathy I had received from the students I did not take as a farewell greeting. Still, 72 years stood before me as a fitting limit. And out here in the beautiful natural surroundings, where at any moment one could refresh oneself after the work in the study by a walk in the glorious park or in the antique colonnades, the urge awoke to put the last hand to various planned works and to take up various sketches for working out. I also began to grow tired of the preparatory work that must precede every lecture, although the lecture itself was as a rule a joy to me. I therefore decided at New Year 1915 to submit my application for retirement, to take effect from the following first of September. The rest of the semester was taken up in part by very tiring and painful faculty deliberations about who should be my successor. I will not go further here into these deliberations, any more than into the new deliberations and the competition that became necessary when my first successor died. I do not conceal that my desire for continued University activity dwindled greatly because of a good deal that I experienced on this occasion.

Since I have been accused of voting against Dr. C. N. Starcke on both oc- [259]

casions for reasons other than the merits of the case, I shall explain more fully what my position was in these deliberations. At the first vacancy the choice stood between Dr. Starcke and Dr. Anton Thomsen. I had earlier been close to Dr. Thomsen, but I had had to subject one of his writings to a very sharp criticism, which in turn led to a mocking attack on his part. I nonetheless supported his election because of the talent and independence I found in him. Dr. Starcke had in my view at one time fallen into hasty production, in which the stream of words covered over a lack of sharp grasp of the problems. Later, because of school work and political work, he had had to put philosophy on the shelf. That he had criticized my Etik (a criticism I had answered) naturally played as small a part with me on this occasion as that Thomsen had criticized and mocked my Religionsfilosofi. — After Thomsen's death several applicants came forward, and a competition was held. The works Starcke produced on this occasion had in my eyes very serious defects, and I cannot deny that I was both astonished and indignant at the way in which the discussion of them was conducted in the assessment committee. I held to my view and, together with the Dean, formed a minority in the vote. — Within the majority too, however, misgivings made themselves felt. One of the foreign members said to me: "I cannot vote against the old man." He would have preferred to vote for one of the younger men, but gave it up, presumably under the influence of the deliberations conducted within the majority between the meetings. I myself spoke only in the meetings themselves, and it is untrue when a son of Starcke has spoken in a newspaper of the "activity" I was supposed to have exerted to exclude his father. — The day after the close of the competition I wrote to Professor Alfred Lehmann, who had voted for Starcke, and urgently asked him to use his personal relation to Starcke to dissuade him from publishing anything whatever for the time being. Lehmann answered that he had already put it to Starcke that he must submit to strict work if he was to give satisfaction, especially as regards exercises with older students. He had moreover dissuaded him from publishing "the written work (in the competition), with which everyone thought he had come off very badly." It turned out, unfortunately, that this warning did not help.

When Starcke's appointment was settled, I wished him in friendly words good fortune and success in his new position.

It is possible that I have underrated his latest writings. But in any case it did not happen from such motives as a son of Starcke has attributed to me in "Politiken" (3 July 1926). — What I have set out above I did not wish to put forward in an article of reply, partly because I felt that the tone of the attack ruled out a reply, but partly also because it went against me so soon after Starcke's death to drag up these unpleasant matters. (July 1926) [260]

Now I could live solely and wholly for my studies and my production. Every morning I feel glad at the thought that I have the day at my disposal for work of my own choosing. In the morning hours I work on philosophical subjects, and in the evening I write at my biography, — yes, and now that this is finished, other tasks will no doubt come. Besides, I read what I can manage of general literature. I cannot boast of keeping up in this field, but it may perhaps interest readers of my biography to see what of newer and older literature has especially been nourishment to me in recent years, and I therefore set down here a part of an article that I dated 11 March 1916.

A living and colorful mood of nature I have found in Ludvig Holstein's poems. They enrich feeling through the fresh breath from soil and field, from garden and wood, from life together with nature through the changing of the seasons. One is called out of the study to move about in free and rich nature. It is not nature's great scenes, not heights and expanses, that are brought before us here, but it is the small things, the details, that are presented in their peculiarity, revealing to us a whole world where the dull sense could formerly see nothing. Stuckenberg too leads us out into nature, but only to lead us at once into a series of delicate and deep moods, which in the poet have now sought nourishment in images of nature, now been called forth by them. And to these two poets Sofus Michaëlis joins himself as the poet of thought, for whom the fundamental laws and fundamental forms of existence are the great sources of mood. In mighty images he

[261] sees, when he stands above the strata that a cutting has laid bare, the history of the earth and of mankind pass by.

I confess that, much as I owe to Danish poetry, Swedish poetry has nonetheless for a number of years given me still greater refreshment and rest. Gustaf Fröding's Vermland poems, his images of nature, the clash of humor and bitterness in his mind, the pith of his language, borne up by the dialect of his home district, the strength and depth of his thoughts, sprung as they are from the fortunes of a tossed life, — all this has given me the greatest poetic joys, ever since I bought his poems in Uppsala 14 years ago. And Verner v. Heidenstam leads us into the enigmatic inmost of the human heart, to which no one has the key, not even man himself, for

i människans öden en gåta bor gömt,
som aldrig tyddes, hur lärd och berömd
hun läste sin filosofi.

It does the philosopher good to hear this in the urgent language of poetry, even if he knew it beforehand from his own experience, after he has for his part put honest work into finding out what the riddles are and what they mean.

Selma Lagerlöf, with her incomparable Gösta Berling, forms a transition from lyric poetry to narrative prose. It is a great pleasure to take up anew a single chapter of this book, fresh as nature, by itself, or to follow a single one of its characters through the vicissitudes of his fate. Swedish landscape, Swedish folk poetry and Swedish life of mood meet us here, at once with the strength of reality and with the splendor of imagination. — If I go from Selma Lagerlöf to Danish storytellers, I come, for my part, first upon Henrik Pontoppidan, whose "Muld" is the most Danish book I know. It is not the construction of Pontoppidan's books that I admire, but it is the clear and striking characterization of the individual
[262] scenes and of the characters in the particular situations. His latest book [Torben og Jytte] has, with all its lack of unity in what has so far appeared, greatly engaged me through its individual portrayals, which have enriched me with a series of pictures of life that I will not forget. I wait with suspense for the last

part, to see how the different regions of life here at home may after all prove to form a whole. And I do not deny that I am still waiting for a better fortune for poor Jytte than the one that has so far fallen to her lot. She is drawn so vividly and naturally, with all her wavering and in all her dividedness, for which the author makes her pay dearly, that toward her there must stir the sympathy that what is truly alive involuntarily calls forth, however it may behave¹⁾. And from Pontoppidan himself I still expect many a good account of human beings and human fates. — Andersen-Nexø leads us into a wholly different world from the one in which Pontoppidan moves. We follow in his “Pelle” the proletarian boy, who begins life with two bare hands, and whose labor for a place at life’s table nonetheless leaves him time and strength to spare to see, in great fantasies of the future, possibilities of brighter conditions for his class, and to do a work of organization that leads him through great catastrophes. What one remembers most is probably the childhood on Bornholm and the strike winter in Copenhagen. But there are many who, like Charles Darwin, in their old age like best books that end well, and for me too the idyll with which the book ends stands as something I take joy in imagining, and in whose lasting possibility I hope.

Though it is not the very newest present whose literature I have spoken of here, the forces that have produced the literature I have lived in are nonetheless for a great part still at work. But I cannot close without naming what I owe to books by older French and English authors. Mme Staël-Holstein’s “Corinna”, [263] Dickens’ “David Copperfield” and George Eliot’s “Mill on the Floss” I read again and again and with ever new joy. And then, last of all, the confession that my highest moments are still given me by Shakespeare’s “golden song” and by the great and clear images of fate of the Greek tragedians. In this great art I especially like to immerse myself when the inadequacy of psychological analysis for the understanding of human characters becomes clear to me again and again, both as philosopher and as human being. It is not only intuition that here yields a fullness that thought cannot exhaust; here too the consoling assurance of the sublimity of greatness in its very downfall wins a victory over despondency and

¹⁾[Later note.] The hope was (see the last part) not to be fulfilled. But Pontoppidan is right, with the right of tragedy.

doubt.

When I was little, my family lived in summer at a farm in Valby (which has now been replaced by a four-story building). Here I saw the main building of Old Carlsberg and the beautiful garden with the pergola come into being. Little did I suspect that I would come to live in that splendid house, and it is strange to think back on the days when as a little boy I went about in these parts. I remember especially how I often rode along up to the brewery (in a one-horse carriage, drawn by “the little black one”) to fetch beer for the use of the farm, and then now and then could see a little of the splendor. It is far from the case that I feel like Aladdin when I think of the time when I walked here as a little boy. If there is anything I am not, it is an Aladdin. I pride myself on diligence and honesty, on a certain perseverance that astonishes me now in retrospect when I think of my hypochondria and of the slight interest that for many years (perhaps because of the hypochondria) I believed I could detect for what I myself was absorbed in. I have had the good fortune to bring out what I had at heart, and to point to the paths that, according to my experience and my reflection, one must take for the [264] life of the spirit to unfold freely and healthily. And a greater good fortune the gods cannot bestow. The gods cannot help it that the ability was not greater in the one on whom they bestowed this good fortune. It is also a good fortune for me that I have completed this autobiography. Through the work on it, which has extended over more than a year, I have in several respects learned to know myself better. But above all I have been glad to write it, because during the work I came to live again in the memory of people I have loved.

I do not think much about death. I know that I am best prepared for it when I collect myself around what has made life valuable for me. And I hope to keep the ability for such collectedness. Most of all I would wish the end to come in the middle of an hour of work.

It has been strange to walk out here in the idyllic quiet while the World War, which began shortly after I had come out here, rages throughout Europe. It was a good thing for me when a young friend, Vilhelm Sloman, got me to take part in his fine work of procuring books for prisoners of war. But it is so little that can be done. — On some men of science the war has had the effect that they cannot work in their field. For my part it has rather led to deeper absorption in my philosophical work. Nor have I felt any misgiving about occupying myself with my own individual course of life while millions of people clashed against one another and the whole future of Europe was at stake. Serious work and honest self-reflection keep their value nonetheless, however things go in the world.

Nor had I been one of those who were so optimistic in their view of human nature and in their belief in how gloriously far we had come that the war and its brutality must shake them in their innermost faith. I know from myself and from others the opposition between Prospero and Caliban. Both belong to human nature, and the bright view of life must always prove its right by taking up the fight with the bestial anew. The bestial has many forms. It can spread in peacetime as well as in wartime. I do not give up the hope that the powers of light will assert themselves, even if the victories must always be confirmed through new struggles. [265]

Finished 21 December 1916.

VII

[266] The preceding sections of these memoirs were concluded in December 1916, and I did not then imagine that there would be a continuation. But the years that have passed since have in many outward and inward respects been eventful for me. Here in my idyllic home at Carlsberg, where better than in my earlier dwellings I can follow the fixed course of the sun and the stars and the capricious drifting of the clouds, I have followed the great events of the world with suspense, while I nevertheless found rest in the work that I still thought I had before me, and also once more immersed myself in the thought of what had given life value for me. Of this I feel a need to write down one thing and another. I am just now (January 1922) in the mood that follows the completion of a piece of work, while a new one has not yet been planned. Then one's own experiences naturally press forward again.

Not only through the newspapers did I follow the course of the world's events. Through letters from both of the warring parties I gained an impression of how people understood, and were moved by, what was going on. For my own part, as for the very great majority here at home, my sympathy was unreservedly on the side of the Western Powers. Not only because of the encroachments from Germany that we ourselves had suffered under, but also because of the reactionary and militaristic attitude in the policy of Germany and Austria, we could not make their cause ours. Those were therefore terrible times when the Ger-

[267] mans repeatedly threatened Paris, and when their swelling sense of power and victory found clear expression. They had won so many times; should they not

win this time too, since they had used the time since the last war so well! And then world dominion would be theirs. A German friend of mine who died before the war, the poet Arthur Pfungst in Frankfurt, a radical man who felt himself in decided opposition to Prussian government and the Prussian character, had nevertheless stated, as something that in his eyes was self-evident, that if they again won a war with France, they would not be content as last time, but would take the whole French north coast right up to Havre in order to have free access to the ocean and a better hold on England. Even Danes living in Germany were seized by the idea of power and by the certainty of its victory. My cousin the poet Karl Gjellerup, from his youth “the Germans’ pupil” and for many years at home in the German way of thinking, wrote to me shortly after the outbreak of the war that now Denmark’s day of visitation had come. He addressed an urgent appeal to me to do what I could to influence the mood here at home, which in his opinion was going in a ruinous direction. Our outwardly correct attitude could not help us, since our press was decidedly anti-German. And when the war that has now begun is ended, Germany and Austria will be able to do with Europe as they will. Germany is now taking note of its friends and its enemies, never again to forget them. The sovereignty of small states will soon be over; they must seek attachment to a great power. A friendly attitude on the Danish side could lead to a more liberal government in North Schleswig — though not to a frontier adjustment, which is hardly desired in North Schleswig either, “whose sons from every farm and house have, on the mightiest battlefields of world history, mingled blood with all the German tribes for Germany’s culture!” — Yes, the fine and truly idealistically minded poet had indeed become the Germans’ pupil! How little he knew the spirit in which the Danish South Jutlanders went into the struggle! They thought only that they had the choice between fleeing from their native region, whereby they would ease German immigration, and doing their duty as citizens in the state they had been forced into. And they thought besides that if they did their duty as citizens, it would become morally impossible for the Prussian government to rob them of the land their forefathers had inhabited from time immemorial. And how the Germanized Danish poet confuses German [268]

culture, which all honor, and German militarism, which is a danger to the culture of the world — and in the end to the true German culture itself!

Especially as regards this last point, his thoughts coincided with those of many German authors and scholars. The excellent and liberal-minded educator Rudolph Penzig implored me “im Namen der uns teuren ethischen Kultur der Menschheit” to counteract the false reports about the war that the French and the English press were spreading, and that were leading whole peoples astray. The distinguished philosopher and fine critic Georg Simmel, professor in Strassburg, wrote to me no less urgently, so that I (and through me others up here) might get the right understanding of what was taking place. Germany has not begun the war; every German knows that in advance (*von sich aus*)! Germany has no need of expansion: we have, after all, everything a nation can wish for! Against its opponents’ long-prepared conspiracy Germany stands united, and this unity is the mightiest manifestation of ethical-political energy that world history has yet seen. The Germans are accused of barbarism because in the utmost self-defense they have had to damage some old buildings. But what is that compared with the barbarism France and England show in making it possible, through their alliance with Russia, for the Cossacks to destroy the cities of Kant and Goethe, of Humboldt and Hegel! The Muscovites’ horses are to be allowed to trample the soil where the highest scholarship and the most magnificent organization have seen the light! For a hundred years Germany will not forget this. —

[269] I answered my German colleagues quite briefly that we up here had better access to reports from both sides, and that we used our best judgment to find out who was telling the truth, though well aware that here history would in the end speak the decisive word. To Simmel, with whom I had earlier carried on a philosophical correspondence, I said besides that I looked forward to the time when we could again continue our discussions with free minds. —

Later in the autumn of 1914 I was drawn more directly into the strife of opinions. The correspondent of the “*Vossische Zeitung*” in Copenhagen came out to me and asked me to write an article in his paper in which I would express myself on what we here at home owed to German scholarship. I answered that I could

do this only if I could at the same time express my great astonishment at the manner in which 93 German scholars and artists had recently come forward.

In an appeal addressed “to the civilized world,” these men, for the most part scholars and artists of high rank, had protested against “the lies and calumnies with which the enemies seek to sully Germany’s pure cause in the hard struggle for life forced upon it.” The appeal (which is said to have been composed by the poet Sudermann) sets out 6 propositions: 1) It is not true that Germany is guilty of this war. 2) It is not true that Germany has wantonly violated Belgium’s neutrality. 3) It is not true that the life and property of a single Belgian citizen has been violated by German soldiers, except where the bitterest self-defense required it. 4) It is not true that German troops have raged against Löwen (Louvain) in a brutal manner. 5) It is not true that German warfare has disregarded international law. 6) It is not true that the struggle against so-called German militarism is not a struggle against German culture, as the enemies hypocritically say. — For these 6 propositions the signatories vouched with their names and with their honor.

It was sad to find among the signatories names such as Felix Klein, Nernst and Planck, Harnack and Hermann, Brentano, Liszt and Schmoller, Eduard Meyer [270] and Wilamowitz, Riehl, Wundt and Windelband.

In my article in the “Vossische Zeitung” I spoke from a sincere heart of what we owed to German scholarship. But I added that we up here had been all the more surprised that a number of distinguished scholars could vouch on their honor for things of which they could have only imperfect and one-sided reports. I said further, as I had said to my correspondents, that we up here had better opportunity to test the reports in an impartial manner, but that in the end only history could judge.

On the occasion of this article I received a letter from a German district judge (Landgerichtsrat) in Berlin wholly unknown to me (his name was Eugen Meyer), in which he began by declaring that with people who could express themselves as I had done one could no longer meet in “the temple of the seekers of truth.” Next he states that the question of who had begun the war could be settled neither by “Presslügner” nor by “Gelehrte unserer Zeit,” but must be cleared up with the

help of the state archives.

I answered quite briefly that the content of my article had after all been precisely to dispute the right of “the scholars of our time” to declare what had and had not happened at the beginning of the war and in the conduct of the war, and to maintain that only history could settle this. That must have struck the man, for in a following letter “he regrets his sharpness.” But he declares that the German scholars have only defended their people’s cause. And Germany, he continues, is a national state. Only the most pressing self-defense has compelled it to incorporate elements with foreign languages (among others “140,000 Westjüten und [!] Dänen”). As for militarism, it was (this must be said in German) “eine Teilerscheinung des Pflichtlebens, des reinen Opfers, das reine Sittlichkeit von uns fordest.” For Germany has so many enemies, and in the struggle against [271] them it stands alone. Perhaps it will perish! It is spat upon like Jesus before the Council! (Bespähen werden wir wie Jesus vor dem hohen Rat!). But the day of victory will come again, the day of the German people and of truth!

I did not continue the correspondence. — In Germany itself there were protests against that appeal, and it has since been made known that many of the signatories had given their assent by telegraph and without knowing the wording! When the occasion arose, many of them declared after the war that they regretted their signature, indeed some even that they looked back on this affair with horror, after they had come to know how matters stood with the attack on Belgium and with the conduct of the German troops there. Dr. Hans Weberg (lecturer in international law), who has thrown light on the whole affair in a small pamphlet (*Wider den Aufruf der 93! 1920*), says rightly that the 93 had in fact declared themselves in solidarity with the conduct of the imperial government, and that the document betrays the same spirit of the policy of blood and iron that in 1899 made the German Foreign Office reject the idea of a court of arbitration at The Hague. —

In England and France the conduct of the 93 had a violent effect. A quiet man, hitherto very well disposed toward Germany, Professor Sorley in Cambridge, expressed himself in a letter to me in the following way: Military and industrial

success has changed the national direction of the German people. Some Germans, e.g. Eucken, see this, but hope that a new idealism will develop. But, to judge by the conduct of Eucken and the other professors, this new idealism must be of a strange kind. Arrogance is the most prominent trait of the Germans of our time. It appears, e.g., in their judgments on the philosophy of other countries. If Europe is to be fit to live in, German militarism must be struck down. The future of the small states depends on the victory of the Allies. Finally Sorley says that he does not believe that international intercourse with the Germans will become possible in his lifetime. — My French translator Madame de Quirielle wrote to me on the occasion of the manifesto of the 93 that its only interest was to show [272] that there were not *two* Germanies, a military one and a cultural one, and that one therefore cannot give the military the whole blame for the war. But, she added, even if the intellectuals would not separate their cause from that of the army and the people, they ought nevertheless to have waited until the facts were clearly established.

From letters from French and English friends that I have lying before me, I see that I, as is only natural, did not conceal my interest in the cause of the Western Powers. An English lady, Mrs. Alice Rufford, whose acquaintance I had made at Glion in 1909 and with whom I had since carried on a lively correspondence, was glad that I wished England success in this terrible war. She had feared that I would believe what the German newspapers said about her country. She speaks with admiration of the wounded Belgian soldiers who had come over to England, — “these brave people, who had saved both England and France from a sudden attack for which they were not prepared.” — The correspondence with Mrs. Rufford stopped before the end of the war. My old, wise and liberal-minded friend has probably passed away. On our walks in the mountains above Montreux we had exchanged our opinions and experiences of life (especially when her very orthodox friend was not with us).

The profound philosopher Herbert Bradley wrote to me in March 1915: “Some years ago it became clear to me that war was almost inevitable, but nothing could make my countrymen realize this and prepare for it. It is bitter to think that if

they had prepared for the war, they might perhaps have prevented it.”

Of the sacrifices the war brought, the harvest of young gifted men that it reaped, many of the letters tell. Thus Émile Boutroux writes that he has lost many relatives who have fallen with honor. The Fondation Thiers, a kind of scholarly college of which he was director, he has turned into a hospital, which is run by Madame Boutroux. Sorley tells of the death in battle of his young son [273] in Belgium, after he had, as so often, gone gladly to meet danger. The young captain (20 years old) was leading his men forward to the attack when death struck him. His father says of him: “In soul and body he was among the fairest of the fair, and he understood the secret art of making everyone who came near him glad.” The young man had already won a fine name as a poet and had begun his studies at Oxford in a brilliant manner. A collection of letters from him, especially during a stay in Germany (Schwerin and Jena) before the war, shows his fresh and independent way of thinking. I myself saw him only as a boy in his parents’ pleasant home, where I stayed several times.

For many good Germans the defeat, and what followed it, was a grief of the heart. Thus my friend Ferdinand Tönnies writes (April 1919) that he grieves deeply over the dissolution of his people. He himself, however, suffers less than others, since he had never had an overstrained faith in Bismarck’s German Empire (which, though, in his opinion was the least imperialistic of the great powers). Despite all his sympathy with the working class, he was by no means glad of the revolution, but would rather have seen a calm development.

During the war my spacious and secluded residence at Carlsberg was often the place for gatherings that, because of the circumstances, had to take place quietly.

The famous physiologist Richet had come up here to give a lecture on the war from a French point of view at the “Alliance française.” But since all public lectures by foreigners were forbidden by the government, he was invited to speak here at Carlsberg to a narrow circle. Before the lecture I addressed the following words to him:

“It is a great honor for me to receive you in this house, which was built by a man who was a good Danish patriot and loved France. When I moved in here I found two flags, the Dannebrog and the Tricolor. I hope that the day will come [274] when I shall be able to hoist the Tricolor to celebrate a peace that is truly a peace for all Europe. When the founder of Carlsberg loved France, it was not purely a matter of feeling. On your way in here, Monsieur Richet, you have come along Pasteur’s road and past a bust of Pasteur. Carlsberg’s great industry, whose profits are applied to the good of the sciences, owes an extraordinary amount to the genius of Pasteur.

Our gathering here this evening is entirely private and must not be mentioned in the press. We thought that Monsieur Richet would like to have an opportunity to speak freely about the events of the time to a circle that feels sympathy for his country and for himself. But this gathering also has another purpose. We have heard, to our very great regret, that in France our painful position during this war is not always understood, in which we are obliged to hold back expressions of sympathy and antipathy. Fifty years ago we had to fight alone against the two great powers against which three great powers are now fighting. That has made us cautious. But our heart has not grown cold. We hope that what will be said this evening by representatives of our political, commercial and scholarly life will give our French guest a clear idea of our position and our feelings.

You, Monsieur Richet, do not come to us as a stranger. Our physicians honor you for your scientific works and discoveries. Several of us greeted you on your return journey from Stockholm, where you had received the Nobel Prize. I myself have profited greatly from your psychological writings. And we know that you are not only an eminent scientist, but that your heart beats for all that is great and beautiful. You must have suffered under the events of the time, which went against all that love of mankind could hope for. But you feel always the need to work for your country, this glorious country, which has rendered mankind such great services.”

Some years later Richet recalled this gathering with a few kind words in a [275] letter he wrote to me on the occasion of a preface which I, at the request of the

Flournoy family, had written for a new edition of the early work of our common sick friend Théodore Flournoy.

The misunderstandings of which Denmark's position and mood during the World War were the object in France also gave occasion later to secret gatherings at Carlsberg, where men of all parties met to deliberate on what could be done by private means to bring clarity to the matter. Owing to the course of events it did not become necessary to take any step in that direction.

I came into closer touch with the World War and its effects through taking part in the work of the Danish Red Cross. While in the summer of 1915 I was staying at Moesgaard near Aarhus, the librarian Vilhelm Slomann asked me by telephone for a conversation. As I was just about to drive to Aarhus, I made an appointment with him there, and he now came forward with a request that I be chairman of a committee that was to be formed to procure books for prisoners of war from the various countries. Slomann's idea was that each belligerent country should procure books for its captive countrymen, and that the Book Committee in Copenhagen should be the intermediary through which the books were sent to the prison camps. I readily agreed to the proposal and thereby entered upon an activity that extended through all the war years and brought me into touch with people and conditions that would otherwise have lain far from me. But first and foremost it was a relief after all to help lessen the distress during the great world catastrophe. The spiritual distress could be quite as serious as the material. — It was a great joy to me to come to know Vilhelm Slomann more closely. His warm temperament, great enthusiasm and wealth of initiatives gave the work [276] a swing that led to fine results. We worked well together, even if his zeal and restlessness at times burst the forms that it was the chairman's duty to uphold. When I look back on the activity of the Book Committee, "Bellibria" (as it was called after its telegraphic address), it is not only with joy at having taken part in the fine work, but also with joy at having won a friend.

In the first year we met the great expenses of arranging and dispatching the books out of a capital quietly collected (50,000 kroner). But after that all the aid to prisoners of war, “Bellebria” too, was supported by the state, in recognition that this was an activity that did the country honor and awakened sympathy for it. We no longer needed constantly to make collections. From the very beginning we had obtained permission to use the Red Cross emblem and had come into contact with the International Red Cross in Geneva. Now we became a special department of the Danish Red Cross’s prisoner-of-war work, alongside the departments that worked for correspondence between the prisoners and their home countries, for the sending of clothes and food, for visits to prison camps, etc. On that occasion I was admitted as a member of the central board of the Danish Red Cross.

Because of the geographical situation it was especially the prisoners on both sides of the Eastern Front that we could work for. We procured German books for German prisoners of war in Russia and Russian books for Russian prisoners of war in Germany. Director Vagn Jacobsen showed us the kindness of letting us have splendid premises at Carlsberg for storing books and for an office. At times we might have a collection of several hundred thousand volumes waiting to be sent off. It cannot be denied that Germany provided in a magnificent way for its captive sons, among whom there were many students. All the way to Siberia we sent scholarly and literary works. A few times I personally received requests for particular works for captive philosophers, and I then used what I [277] could spare from my own library. Moving were the letters of thanks we received from prisoners whose spiritual hunger we had been able to relieve. At the beginning of the war there also came many Russian books, which were sent to captive Russians in Germany. But many Russians could not read, and because of the unsettled conditions in Russia the shipments therefore stopped later on. We had, moreover, an envoy skilled in the Russian language, who visited prison camps in Germany to hear the wishes of the Russian prisoners. We attempted something similar in Russia, but it did not succeed. On the other hand we could make use of Danish officers and physicians who accompanied German sisters of the Red

Cross on visits to prison camps in Russia and Siberia. We also got some Turkish books sent to Turkish prisoners in Russia, whereas it was not possible to procure a Tatar translation of the Koran for a captive Russian Tatar in Germany (A Turkish delegate explained to me, moreover, that the Koran must not be translated at all from the holy Arabic language in which it was originally written). On a single occasion we were able to send a splendid English collection of books to English prisoners in Germany; but otherwise it was nearer at hand for England to let its shipments go through Holland, just as it was for France to send its own through French Switzerland.

Our work meant that we received a good many visits from Russian and German envoys, and the festive rooms of Carlsberg were often taken into use. In the spring of 1917 there came a deputation from the German universities with the famous philologist Wilamowitz at its head, to give thanks for the book aid to captive German students. The summer before, ten Russian sisters of the Red Cross came to Copenhagen in order to go from there, accompanied by Danish officers, to visit Russian prisoners in Germany. I visited them at their hotel to talk with them about the book matter. There were several highly cultivated ladies of high station among them, with whom it was of great interest to talk. Despite the seriousness of the times they had not lost their good spirits. I invited them to [278] visit me in the evening at Carlsberg, and when, before I left, I asked how many of the ladies I might then have the pleasure of seeing, one of them answered: *Tout le regiment, Monsieur!* It was a glorious June evening in the season of roses. In their long gray costumes they skipped about in the rose garden, and later, at the supper table, they gave speeches in French and English. It is one of the most beautiful memories I have from the war years; but it is darkened by the thought of how things have gone with the ladies during their country's defeat and dissolution. To one of them a moving story attaches. She was a general's wife, and her husband had fallen in the Russian defeat in East Prussia. She had entered the Red Cross and had joined this expedition in order, if possible, to find traces of her husband. She is said in fact to have reached the battlefield, and nearby she came upon a peasant who, after being questioned by the German officer who accompa-

nied her, produced a locket in which her own picture was found! The body was then found nearby. — The visit of the Russian ladies had a little epilogue. One of them had, during the stay in Germany, written down diary notes about the visit to Copenhagen, and so also about the evening at Carlsberg. These papers were confiscated on the return journey at Warnemünde. The president of the German care for prisoners of war, General Friedrich, when he later visited me, was curious to see the place where the Russian ladies had enjoyed themselves so much, and asked about everything he had read of in the papers (— und wo wurden die Reden gehalten? etc.).

Most (not all) of the German envoys who came up here in connection with the aid to prisoners of war were tactful and chivalrous men. General Friedrich was especially well liked. Of several of these men I have the impression that long before the catastrophe they sensed that their country would succumb. This applies especially to General Friedrich. When he was here for the last time (in the late summer of 1918), he was quiet and dejected. He died before the end came.

In the summer of 1917 a new constitution came into force for the Danish Red Cross. Previously a board in Copenhagen had had the direction, and the branches outside Copenhagen were regarded merely as subsidiaries. Now the branches became more independent and took part in the election of the central board, which no longer co-opted its own members. They were at a loss for a new chairman and turned (after having turned in vain to various others) to me. (From a letter left behind in the chairman's portfolio I came to know the preceding negotiations. — Outgoing chairmen should never leave that kind of letter in their portfolio). It was by a kind of surprise attack that I was taken. But I have not had reason to regret it, and I hope that the Danish Red Cross has not regretted it either. I now combined the special position as chairman of Bellibria with the position of chairman of the Danish Red Cross. Besides the various prisoner-of-war departments, each of which had its own management and its own offices, I now came into relation with the great domestic work. (Nursing, ambulance transport, the Samaritan Society, etc.). Much here was foreign to me, at any rate in the beginning, but an executive committee, which consisted of able men and

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women, lightened the work and the responsibility. I learned much about the practical conditions of life, and I gained much experience of people through the position I had come into. On the whole I look back with pleasure on that time. I came out well from the responsibility, and I have taken part in a significant activity.

In the autumn of 1917 a conference was held in Copenhagen, under the formal direction of the Danish Red Cross, to discuss the treatment of prisoners of war. The two groups of enemies of the Eastern Front met here in the midst of the war. Prince Valdemar, who was honorary president of our prisoner-of-war departments, presided; in his absence I presided. But the negotiations were conducted with superior skill by the then head of department in the Foreign Ministry, Herluf Zahle. With a certain suspense the Danish members of the conference as-
[280] sembled at Amalienborg (in Christian IX's palace) for the first meeting between the enemies. With strict etiquette it had been arranged that the delegates of the belligerent countries (Russians and Rumanians on the one side, Germans, Austrians and Turks on the other) at one and the same moment, at a given signal of a bell, entered the hall through different doors and sat down, each delegation at its own table. A few times there threatened to be a clash, when one party accused another of mistreating prisoners of war; but the chairman always managed to get the negotiations going again. In the small committees things gradually became quite genial. Many cigarettes were smoked in Queen Louise's old sitting room. The negotiations led to a real result, in that certain humane measures were adopted that were to be observed in the treatment of prisoners of war. From what was forbidden one could, moreover, infer how terrible things have often been, as when, e.g., it was forbidden to use degrading punishments (especially by fastening mocking placards on a prisoner who had committed an offense). The rules adopted at the conference have been of importance for later negotiations between the enemy groups of the Western Front.

Although one could negotiate together despite the enmity, one could not, however, celebrate together. The Foreign Ministry, at whose expense the conference was held, proposed to me that the festivities be held at Carlsberg. An

emissary from the ministry then took over the supreme command out here for two days. He saw to everything, and my household helpers and I had nothing to do with any of it, except that I had to dress in full dress, preside at table two days in a row, and give two French speeches. One day there was a festivity for the Germans, the Austrians and the Turks, the next day for the Russians and the Rumanians. It turned out that several of the Russian, Rumanian and Turkish delegates had used my books in their student years (in French translation), and on that occasion many kind words were addressed to me. Later the foreign ministers concerned each gave festivities of their own, so that in this respect too it [281] was a rather strenuous time.

It was, as already said, especially the belligerents of the Eastern Front that the Danish Red Cross had to do with. But we also tried to help French prisoners of war in Germany, by collecting books and in other ways. And in the last year of the war Slomann had the brilliant idea that in the prison camps examinations of a preparatory kind could be held, so that candidates for the preliminary examination, training-college students and future university entrants could have their examinations behind them when they came home after the conclusion of peace. To carry this out Danish examination commissioners were to be sent to Germany and France, with authority from the French and the German government respectively, and to arrange the examinations, at which captive professors and senior masters were to be examiners. Dr. Louis Hammerich had been chosen to travel to Germany, Rector Otto Zahle to travel to France, for this purpose. When the matter seemed to be coming into order, I went to the French minister, M. de Conti, to present Rector Zahle; Dr. Hammerich was already in Berlin. On this visit to the French legation a scene took place which I must describe here, since I have heard that incorrect accounts of it are in circulation.

While Count de Beaucaire, who before the war was French minister here, was a very attractive and sympathetic personality, this can hardly be said of M. Bapst and M. de Conti, who were here during the war. They had evidently been

imbued with suspicion of Denmark, or at any rate of Danes who did not belong to a small, tenacious, hypernational clique that knew how to encapsulate the French ministers and make them unreceptive to whatever did not bear the clique's stamp. Slomann and I once went to Bapst to talk about the book matter, but although a time had been agreed, the minister had forgotten it, and we had to [282] wait over an hour before he came. (The time passed, moreover, very pleasantly and interestingly, since the lively and gifted military attaché Colonel Taylor, who afterwards fell at the Chemin des Dames, entertained us in a captivating manner). When Monsieur Bapst finally came, we did not succeed in interesting him in the book matter. Later, when he saw how eagerly the German side took up the matter, he came rushing out to Carlsberg to ask whether the matter had been put before him; he had forgotten it! With his successor M. de Conti it went with me in the following way. Shortly after his arrival in the early summer of 1918 he invited me to dinner on 14 July, but when I learned that there would be French demonstrations which, in my capacity as chairman of the Danish Red Cross, I could not attend, I sent my regrets. I then waited to pay a call on him until I could present Rector Zahle to him, which for various reasons dragged on until the autumn. As soon as we now came in, he flew at me. "Yes, now you come, now that we have won! Before, I saw nothing of you! We distinguish between true and false friends!" I was undeniably somewhat taken aback at this greeting, but answered that my French and English friends knew where my sympathies had been during the war, and that I had waited to come until I found an occasion. It was a very unpleasant situation, since I must not provoke the testy man more than he had provoked himself, lest he should put obstacles in the way of Rector Zahle's journey¹⁾. When I came home, I wrote a letter to Conti, which for safety's sake I put before Herluf Zahle, the head of department, who corrected some expressions that seemed to him too strong. I stated in this letter, first, that the men

¹⁾Rector Zahle, moreover, got as good as no access to the prison camps guarded by the French themselves. A head of department in the French Ministry of War declared that toward the German prisoners they would indeed show humanité, but not générosité! On the other hand Zahle received a hearty welcome in the German prison camps guarded by American soldiers (with c. 50,000 prisoners) and accomplished much there for the benefit of the prisoners. The corresponding activity for French prisoners in Germany came to nothing.

who without remuneration devoted their time and their strength to the service of the Danish Red Cross do not approach the ministers of the belligerent countries [283] except when they have an offer to make, and that I had therefore waited until the examination matter had been put in order, — and second, that the leaders of the Danish Red Cross were obliged to observe the strictest neutrality in order to be able to carry out their work. To this letter I received no answer. Later he once sent me congratulations on a Danish honor that had been conferred on me. In the meantime he is said, from what has reached my ears, to have said: “Yes, he *had* received the Commander’s Cross of the Legion of Honor; so he had no reason to come!” (I had received this decoration a year before the war, on the grounds of my work as an author).

Of course this conduct on the part of one of France’s representatives has not in any way impaired my admiration for France and my gratitude toward the country that contributed so much to Danish North Schleswig’s being able to come back.

The three Scandinavian Red Cross societies worked together during the war as far as possible, which among other things gave occasion for the chairman of the Norwegian Red Cross, Supreme Court Advocate Heyerdahl, and me to be guests for a week or so in February 1920 of the chairman of the Swedish Red Cross, Prince Carl of Sweden. They were pleasant and lively days that we spent with Prince Carl and Princess Ingeborg in their beautiful home at Djurgården. Our negotiations turned mostly on the possibility of aid in the return of the prisoners of war; but there was also an opportunity to get one’s bearings with regard to the three Red Cross societies’ very different positions within their countries. The Swedish Red Cross stood in the front rank through its rich means, its close relation to the state and its excellent organization. Besides, we also discussed our conduct at a conference which the so-called League of Red Cross Societies (consisting essentially of representatives of the Entente Powers) had convened for the beginning of March 1920 in Geneva. At this conference I represented the [284]

Danish Red Cross and had excellent support in the director of the Serum Institute, Dr. Thorvald Madsen, who represented the Danish government. The yield of this conference was not great, although the speeches (and the dinners) were many. My philosophical colleague at the University of Geneva asked me to give a lecture at the University, which, despite the short notice, I also undertook. I chose a subject I had just treated in Danish, trying to give “an intellectual characterization of the 19th century.” The lecture was given in the great hall of the University, which was quite full. I was in good form, and in the course of the week I had got so much French into my ear and brain that I managed reasonably well to bring it forth on my tongue. A question hour which, on request, I held immediately after the lecture went off very lively, and a good many sensible questions came up. I felt like an old cavalry horse that hears the trumpet.

Both on the way out and on the way home I spent some days in Heidelberg with my niece Ellen and her husband, the engineer Nissen, who lived in a glorious villa on the hillside above the town. There, on the way home, I celebrated my 77th birthday. In the morning I was awakened with song by the young people of the family. — Otherwise it was very dismal and troublesome to travel through Germany at that time. In Hamburg I was stopped on the way home by a general strike, but together with two other travelers I hired a motorcar and then drove through Mecklenburg to Warnemünde, where I caught the Danish ferry.

In February 1921 negotiations were held at Carlsberg between the three chairmen of the Scandinavian Red Cross societies, each accompanied by a member of the board. My assistant was Chief Physician Svendsen of Odense, one of the Danish Red Cross’s most eminent men. The most important matter here was agree-
[285] ments on a common stand at the conference that the International Red Cross was to hold in Geneva in the spring of 1921. At this conference the Danish Red Cross was represented by Chief Physicians Svendsen and Videbech. The negotiations were this time fruitful in several respects.

One of the last acts I had to perform as chairman was the formal direction of a congress for combating venereal diseases, which the “League of Red Cross Societies” had asked the Danish Red Cross to hold. I had, with the full support

of the central board of the Danish Red Cross, made it a condition of our taking on the responsibility for this congress that it should consist exclusively of specialists. I opened and closed the congress, but the meetings were held under the direction of Professor Rasch. At the congress envoys from England, Holland and Germany met with envoys from the four Scandinavian countries. According to the specialists' statements the congress was successful. Apart from the practical yield, it offered the interest that Englishmen and Germans met here both for negotiations and for festive gatherings. The language of the proceedings was English, but a fair amount of German was spoken too. —

In the spring of 1921 the four years for which I had been elected chairman had expired, and at my age (78) I would not accept re-election. I keep many good memories from my Red Cross time, both from abroad and at home, of personalities I came to know and of serious work for the welfare of human beings.

Now that I am to speak of the great, joyful event that the Reunification was for all Danes, I must first look back a little to show my position on the South Jutland question, which has not been spoken of connectedly in the foregoing.

Among my first childhood memories, as I have mentioned in its place, is the mood of 1848, as it was awakened in me by the remarks of my parents and my brothers. I also remember clearly that, on a journey by carriage down into [286] Zealand with my parents, I saw a detachment of troops on the march over to “the war” and heard the bugle calls when it set off after a halt. I knew that the war was against “the Germans,” but otherwise I of course understood nothing of it all. The patriotic feelings awakened early (most strongly awakened when I saw my parents weep after the Eckernförde disaster) held through the years of childhood and youth. When I began to read newspapers, it was not the “internal” politics of the Kingdom that interested me, but the constant effort to obtain a constitution that could make a united whole out of all the Danish and German elements of the realm. The details I naturally could not follow at that time. But I entered in good faith into the National Liberal, “Eider-Danish” standpoint with its strict

adherence to what was then thought to be the correct constitutional view. When I now think back on that time, it stands before me as a barren time, in which many good forces were wasted in attempts to fill a vessel of the Danaids. And now (through Krieger's diaries) the cover has indeed been drawn away from the relations among the National Liberal leaders, so that their petty jealousy and their common helplessness, when the catastrophe came, are no secret. The defeat in 1864 had the effect that one was led from the supposed formal right over to the real right, which lies in a people's inward adherence to its language, its memories and its way of taking life. And this transition was favored in a gratifying way by the growing feeling of Danishness in North Schleswig, just as it also received a natural support from the fact that the internal politics of the Kingdom led to the center of gravity coming more and more to lie in democracy. In the Students' Society the idea then arose of founding an association that was to work, according to its ability and quietly, for the Danish language and culture in North Schleswig. It was the present Prime Minister Neergaard who brought this matter forward at a meeting in the Students' Society in the year 1887, and on his [287] proposal I became chairman of the new association, which got the odd name 4 S (i.e. the Students' Society's South Jutland Society), by analogy with a previously founded North Jutland association named S S (i.e. South Jutland Society), which worked especially for visits by young North Schleswigers to Danish folk high schools. Already just after '64 a secret association named "Danebrog" had been founded, chiefly by old National Liberals. It had good funds at its disposal for the support of national life in North Schleswig. The association 4 S never got many members and had no great income. In the Students' Society the soil for its work was not unreservedly favorable; people feared new conflicts with Germany and a repetition or continuation of '64. It came especially to lack an influx of young forces. Moreover, 4 S did not come forward as agitators and shunned exaggerated patriotic statements and proclamations, whereas in other similar associations, which issued from other groups within the student world, one could even hear a cheer raised for "the third Schleswig war." From 4 S there issued a special association which on Sundays sometimes gathered South Jutland pupils from the

folk high schools and agricultural schools of the surrounding district, arranged museum and theater visits for them, and gatherings with speeches and songs. This association was given, at my proposal, the name Vidar (the silent god of the Æsir), in contrast to other associations, which were rather loud-voiced, although they undeniably did a great work.

My own activity in the service of 4 S was not of importance. But this association commanded some of the best forces that have worked in the service of the national cause. There were men like H. V. Clausen, the quiet but inwardly enthusiastic man, who knew North Schleswig inside and out, was informed about the sentiments and economic position in every district and on every farm over there, and with his statistics and his maps gave a sound basis for work and for hope. There was the historian Mackeprang, himself born over there, author of an account of the condition of Danishness in North Schleswig from '64 on. And there was Niels Hjort, who conceived the idea of a fund that could save the Danish [288] soil over there from German colonization and from the German government's attempts (as in Poland) to drive native, nationally minded men from their farms; in the course of one winter he collected in all quietness ½ million kroner, which was deposited in the Haderslev Bank and served to support farms whose mortgage situation might make it easy for German buyers to get in. The work of these men has made the history of 4 S an honorable one, and it was a joy to me to work with them and win their friendship.

For a number of years we worked together with the association "To Løver," which had issued from the Students' Union and found a better soil there than 4 S found in the Students' Society. The link between the various groups that worked for the national cause in North Schleswig was the Keeper of the Public Records A. D. Jørgensen. It was of interest to me to come into closer relations with this fine historian, whose inner glow did not often break through a certain stiffness and coolness outwardly. After late meetings we often walked together at night to our homes in Frederiksberg, and then his innermost thoughts could sometimes find expression, and they went, both in military-political and in religious respects, in other directions than the National Liberal and conservative

circles that claimed him for their own would have been able to approve. When he spoke in favor of developing the armed forces, it was, he explained to me, because a small people, in his conviction, ought not to withdraw from taking part in the great events of history, but seek attachment to a great power, which, as the geographical conditions were, could be none other than Germany. In religious respects his sympathy was with Catholicism, which, by the way, is clearly noticeable in his portrayal of Steno. — After Jørgensen's death Supreme Court Advocate Nellemann took, with great amiability, ability and expert knowledge, his place as the link between the various South Jutland associations. Clashes now came about not infrequently. On the whole I had, with regard to "To Løver," [289] the impression that here I stood face to face with the National Liberal view that I myself had lived in during my uncritical young days. What I have occasionally experienced after the war (sometimes in a rather insolent form toward me personally) has confirmed me in this. There are, after all, many in our country who have learned nothing and forgotten nothing.

Every year there were larger gatherings, at which the various South Jutland associations here met with men from South Jutland. It was festive to come together with men like Gustav Johannsen, Hanssen-Nørremølle, Jessen, Reimers and many more of the best South Jutland men. Among these I felt especially drawn to Hanssen-Nørremølle. After several years' stay at Danish folk high schools he had studied here at the University and at several German universities, and it was a rich and comprehensive culture that he had acquired. He had, and has, a remarkable ability to see what is essential in a matter and to find the ways by which it can come into its own. When he expressed general points of view, it was always in such a way that one felt how they had grown up out of personal experience and out of an eye for realities, and how they had their significance for him as guiding stars in continued work. In a multitude of practical and local matters in South Jutland he became the understanding leader, and this he became gradually in high politics too, as North Schleswig's representative in the German Reichstag. Of him one can say that he had learned what was to be learned and forgotten what ought to be forgotten. His great enthusiasm for his

people's cause he did not vent in empty phrases and in quixotic attempts, but in manly work on tasks whose necessity sprang from the given conditions. Even when things looked darkest for our cause, it was strengthening to have his clear stand and untiring course before one's eyes.

A little episode from these years I cannot pass over, since it throws light on the Prussian regime in North Schleswig. In the summer of 1889 I made a journey to South Jutland. In Sønderborg I visited Hanssen-Nørremølle, who had [290] then recently married. One Sunday afternoon he drove me round in Sundevad to visit the large farms where he had relatives and friends. Everywhere we were hospitably received, and I got a strong impression of how solid a foundation Danishness was building on here. This glorious land must above all not be lost. A new school system had recently been introduced, according to which in the elementary school too, not only in the higher schools, teaching was to be only in German, with the exception of a few hours of religion. A little girl wept because she did not know "what she should say when she came to school." Besides, there had been eager spying on the German side; there had been talk of a larger visit by Danish students, and the police wanted to know whether the population itself had had anything to do with the matter. On one farm the gendarme had even hidden himself in the bedroom to hear whether husband and wife might not in private talk about the matter.

One day I drove about on Als with some young students I had met in Sønderborg. Old Reimers drove with us. The young people sang Danish songs when we were in a district where Reimers thought there were no spies. It was a splendid trip. Als is indeed like a garden. But the day after we were summoned to the town hall, where the mayor held up to us that we had behaved "in einer Weise, die der Staat schlechterdings nicht vertragen kann," and that he would therefore be obliged to expel us. It was a critical situation. But by paying closer attention to the mayor's statement I realized that what was complained of must have happened the day before our drive, and that it must therefore have been another party that had committed the terrible crime against the Prussian state. Since some of the young people had return tickets stamped with the day of arrival, we

could prove that they had not come until the evening of the day the crime was
[291] supposed to have taken place, and we now played injured innocence. The mayor now asked us to go back to our hotel, where we would be informed in an hour. We waited in some suspense, but then the police clerk came and asked me for a private conversation. He informed me that we did not need to leave, but added that the reason for our summons was that we had been seen together with Herr Reimers. I answered: "Ich kenne Herrn Reimers als einen sehr braven Mann," to which he said: "Ja, so kennen wir ihn auch, aber er ist ein dänischer Agitator." I: "Ja, so nennen Sie ihn; wir haben einen anderen Namen für ihn." — The clerk, who is said to have earlier been on the Danish side, was evidently very embarrassed by the matter. — When I came home to Copenhagen, the story had been improved: I was supposed to have been seen being transported through the town between two gendarmes! —

I also visited Flensburg and was the guest there of the editor Jessen, whose wife, née Fibiger, I had met in her young days in her uncle Johannes Fibiger's vicarage. There was a breath of energy in everything Jessen said. Together with the Jessens and two Danish ladies I visited the Isted grave in the Flensburg churchyard, where we sang "Slumrer sødt i Slesvigs Jord." Jessen was convinced that Germany was heading toward its dissolution, so that we could get Denmark to the Eider (and "we shall see to it that the South Schleswigers become Danish"), — and that the Duke of Cumberland would then become King of Hanover and Duke of Holstein. I did not know whether to laugh or weep on hearing this. Flensburg gave the impression of an overwhelmingly German town. Five years before, Gustav Johannsen had been defeated here in the Reichstag election, and it had proved impossible to keep the Low German-speaking part of the population on the Danish side. — From Flensburg I made a walk to Sankelmark together with H. V. Clausen, who explained to me with expert knowledge how the honorable fight here had been fought. At Bilskov Inn (where in its time the plan for
[292] the battle of Isted had been laid) the innkeeper's wife was Danish-speaking, but could not be got to say anything in Danish, since the Germans had made her believe that it was a language of the rabble she spoke. —

The years went by, and the World War, which had long threatened, drew near, and with it the great suspense as to how our country would fare in the mighty reckoning that must be at hand.

But still in the spring of 1914 all seemed quiet, and we celebrated in this country the 50th anniversary of the brave fight at Dybbøl on 18 April 1864, the last fight on South Jutland's mainland. A commemoration was held at the Royal Theater in the presence of the royal family and the old veterans. After a cantata, rich in thought and weighty in word, by Niels Møller, I gave the address. After having spoken of the course of the war and dwelt on the fight at Dybbøl fifty years ago, I said:

“As after an earthquake new vegetation covers the masses that had collapsed, so has life unfolded in our country in the last half-hundred years. It is a large question whether despondency and the feeling of impotence would so easily have been overcome if the heroic fight had not been fought. We do not boast, but we have shown that we have the right and feel the duty to maintain our place and lead our own life. The work of peace and the memories of war give us the right to it.”

I closed with the following address to the veterans, who filled all the floor space in the theater and now rose:

“And now I speak to our veterans to bring them our thanks.

You did not come home with victory. You came home despondent to a despondent people. One veteran writes: ‘Quietly we marched out, and quietly we marched in. We brought no victory with us, but each of us nevertheless had the conviction of having done his duty.’ Another veteran writes: ‘The troops were not allowed to march into the city by the main streets, but had to steal quietly and unnoticed along the ramparts to their barracks, as if they had not fully done [293] their duty, but had reason to be ashamed and to hide themselves!’

What was neglected then, in the time of despondency, shall today be made good. We salute you, you brave, steadfast and undaunted men! But the best amends you will receive if you have the feeling that the country and the people you fought for were indeed worth striking a blow for. Courage and work will be

required of our people if it is to maintain its place in the ranks of the nations. But there your tenacious fight and your love of the fatherland will stand as testimony to the spirit and the strength that dwell in our people.

What held you up in the time of danger and toil, that was the innermost of our people's soul, love of the land, faithfulness to its memories, the wish that it may keep the freedom to live its own life. What the poet says of memory — that it seems as nothing, yet is a hidden spring — holds also of love of the fatherland. It may often seem to have vanished; it is not always noticed in the busy, scattered course of the day. And yet it stirs in all honest work, in everything in which we live with our whole soul, — so as then to rise with might in the decisive hours.

So we greet the men who half a century ago, in dark and heavy days, fought for Denmark's honor and right! We ask them to keep up their courage with us for a bright and honorable future for our people, such a future as they staked their lives to secure!

Honor to the heroes of '64! Honor to the land they fought for!" —

Four months after this commemoration had been held, the World War then broke out, the war that in its effects was to lead to so joyful an event as the return of South Jutland. But while the war lasted, hope and fear alternated. Possibility stood against possibility. Could not Germany's victory lead to its now, when the motive could not be interpreted as fear, using the opportunity to come into a conciliatory relation with its nearest neighbor to the north? There were Germans who had long and eagerly wished for this. Or were those right who thought that Germany would now use the good opportunity to incorporate into itself the neighbor which had indeed behaved formally correctly during the war, but about whose real sympathies there could nevertheless be no doubt? — If, on the other hand, the Western Powers won, would they then be eager for us to get South Jutland back, and would this eagerness have its ground in the principle of nationality or rather in an arrangement of affairs favorable to these powers at the Eider Canal? A French journalist who, on an official mission, traveled through

Sweden and Denmark during the war and had visited me several times, had declared outright that France did not care at all about the principle of nationality (it wanted, after all, German-speaking Alsace for itself), but that the main thing was that the Kiel Canal should pass out of Germany's dominion. Here at home there were not a few who held fast to a Denmark to the Eider as the goal; that it would require extensive use of military force had nothing deterrent for their way of thinking. There were others who, since the South German Schleswig had originally been colonized from the south and had always been nationally German, wished for the Danevirke line, inspired by the many memories attached to it, and trusting that there was still a "subconscious" Danishness among the population between Flensburg and the Danevirke that could surface after some time of calm and reflection.

All these possibilities stood against one another. But besides, the question naturally came up whether Denmark could accept South Jutland from one of the warring parties without thereby making itself suspect to the other. At a meeting at Carlsberg, to which, by arrangement with colleagues from 4 S, I had invited men of various parties, the question was discussed whether any Danish government whatever could refuse to accept South Jutland, from whichever side [295] it might be offered. The mood was decidedly for accepting an offer in any case, especially after H. V. Clausen had shown statistically that a line could be drawn north of which the population was overwhelmingly Danish. That was the famous Clausen line, which indeed was afterwards also taken as the basis, adopted by the government and the Rigsdag and approved by the victorious Western Powers. For the time being, however, it was only hopes that were in question. Then came the November day when Germany collapsed, and when in its distress it accepted Wilson's 14 Points, among which the self-determination of peoples also had a place. The consequence of this was drawn in Berlin at once as regards North Schleswig and Poland; there were to be no more "Musspreussere." Wilson was a dreamer, but woven into his dreams was a principle American in the best sense, the same on which in his time the brilliant Alexander Hamilton had founded the American constitution of the Union, and which already lay at the basis of

the American Declaration of Independence: that the state must have its ultimate foundation in the free choice of the people. Since now Wilson himself belonged to the Allies who were fighting Germany, a possibility had here come forward that let the return of South Jutland by plebiscite stand as recognized by both of the warring parties. The South Jutland question itself had also long since passed from being a question of constitutional law to being a purely national question, a question of the sentiments of the South Jutland people.

Of course the principle of sentiment would not have been recognized without the victory of the Allies. But America, which proclaimed this principle, itself contributed decisively to the victory. Had America not sent its millions of well-equipped soldiers across the ocean in the greatest haste, Marshal Foch could not [296] have gathered the masses of troops with which in July 1918, to the complete surprise of the Germans, he broke out of the woods of Villers-Cotterets and thereby brought about the decisive turn.

True enough, not all Schleswigers of Danish sentiment came along. That is a sting that remains, even in those who consider the solution accomplished to be the only possible and the only just one. Had the plebiscite boundary been set farther south, such a majority as was desirable would not have been reached. Here we suffer for the sins of our forefathers. They were more taken up with supposed constitutional law than with what is really decisive in the life of a people. Now it was a matter of salvaging the part of the old Danish duchy of Schleswig that had remained Danish and would continue to be so. In a plebiscite the will of the majority must, after all, be decisive. North of the boundary drawn there is a German minority that will strive to preserve its nationality, essentially by using, under the mild Danish rule, the means the Danish Schleswigers used under German pressure. And south of the boundary there is a Danish minority, practiced in living under foreign rule, which now, under the German republican constitution, has better conditions than before. —

I have wished here to set out how the matter stood for me after the many years of observation and work. With deliberate purpose I supported, as far as I could, the work of Hanssen-Nørremølle and H. V. Clausen. Great recognition

these men did not exactly receive for their work. With many here at home it had become an article of faith that Denmark should reach to the Eider, or at any rate to the Danevirke. What one should then do with the hundreds of thousands of Germans one would get along with it, one heard nothing about. For my part it had long been clear to me that all we could and ought to wish for was to get Als and Sundeved along with it. And even here I had, as I expressed it in a statement to the press, had a hope indeed, but not really a faith in the fulfillment of the wish. But there is here at home, in both national and religious respects, a superstition about faith. Accordingly, when the statement to the press had appeared, I [297] received an anonymous letter (from a lady),¹⁾ which began thus: “Poor Professor Høffding, how poor you must be!” — As if hope were not rich when it inspires to serious endeavor (which faith, which easily becomes fatalistic, does not always do).

Before the plebiscite I was chairman of two meetings in the Town Hall, where the main speakers were Hanssen-Nørremølle and Nis Nissen, those two stout leaders of the South Jutlanders. There was an excellent mood at these meetings. Various interruptions from one particular quarter were answered with great quickness, schooled as both speakers were through meetings with Pan-Germans. The morning before the first meeting I received a letter from a lady (this time, however, not anonymous), who wondered that I, who had hitherto had nothing to do with the South Jutland question, should now come forward. This gave me occasion to state in my introductory words that I had now for 33 years seriously occupied myself with this question. — Later I chaired a meeting in Grundtvig’s House, where Nis Nissen also spoke. My introductory words there gave Kloppenborg-Skrumsager (an excellent man, but inclined to confuse himself with Uffe the Meek) occasion to say (in Flensborg Avis) that now I had stood

¹⁾If one could get statistics on anonymous letters, it would surely turn out that they are predominantly written by women. They have more need than men to vent their feelings in this way. When I had been chosen for the “Honorary Residence,” I received an anonymous letter which “in the name of all Danish women” called on me to decline the election, — because I was not a “believer.” One of the anonymous letters I received during the political strife of the eighties had, however, a decidedly masculine tone; I was threatened that I “would get a thrashing some evening, all right.”

there and disowned the fine thoughts I had expressed in my youth, — and that merely to please the Germans! — On the whole that side has denied itself nothing. But I ought not to have mentioned such things here at all, when I see how men like Hanssen-Nørremølle and H. V. Clausen have been treated. And then [298] all this pettiness vanishes before the great experience these years have brought all Danes. Not least for the old, who remember the pain of the separation, it has been a glory to live to have this experience.

When I left the University, I had plans and drafts for various works, which I now meant to use my leisure to carry out. Alongside my activity in the Red Cross it was this that occupied me in the following years. I found at Carlsberg a good place to work, where there were not only glorious rooms and a splendid garden, but where it was as if it lay in the air that work should be done. I gave up the thought of continuing my laboratory teaching, since I was reluctant to put my special work entirely aside a few days a week in order to be able to prepare for the classes. For the same reason I declined an invitation I received in February 1915 from the University of Glasgow to give lectures on the philosophy of religion for two semesters (the so-called Gifford Lectures). I excused myself on the ground of my 72 years and of my wish for full otium. The most weighty reason, however, was that I had in my time published my philosophy of religion, which had been translated into a whole series of foreign languages, English among them, and that I now had more inclination for psychological, epistemological and historical-philosophical subjects. In addition, although in the deed of foundation of the Gifford Trust no dogmatic conditions whatever had been laid down, most Gifford lectures had nevertheless been given in a more so-called “positive” direction than I, from my psychological-historical point of view, could take. Finally I was also doubtful about my English, which could pass tolerably in a single lecture, but could hardly be offered to an audience over several months. — I missed a fee that was almost a small fortune. But then I could sit in peace at Carlsberg, where I was indeed well provided for. —

The works I have completed here at Carlsberg fall into three groups: psychological (Den store Humor. 1916; Oplevelse og Tydning 1918), epistemological (Totalitet som Kategori. 1917; Relation som Kategori. 1921) and historical-philosophical (Spinoza's Ethica. 1918; Om Platon's Parmenider. 1920; Ledende Tanker i det 19. Aarhundrede 1920). Only on the occasion of "den store Humor" will I here make some remarks. [299]

In the book I have sufficiently indicated for a careful reader (especially at the end of ch. 6) that I do not dare to regard myself as a humorist in the sense in which I take the word. I can only say that I wish I were one. And by a reference to an earlier passage in the book I have indicated where the essential hindrance for me has lain, namely in the hypochondria (Acedia) which in Dante is punished by wallowing in the mire of Hell. Nevertheless I believe that it is not without connection with my nature that the subject has had so great an attraction for me. A striving to unite the great and the small in life in the way that lies in the concept of humor has perhaps lain in my nature. My friend from youth Hans Skovgaard writes from his vicarage (March 1915): "Now that you are writing your memoirs, you must regard yourself as something valuable and at the same time have your amusement in finding it comic that such a one as you should really belong to the totality. Humor is for you something genuine and familiar, so that you need not explain it with effort, but can paint it from the bottom of your heart as a totality that is also glad of small things." — In the same letter he himself jests in a humorous way about his legs, worn by hardening of the arteries, and adds: "I now hobble about in wooden shoes here in Kettinge village, or rock along the snowy road in my old carriage and blink at the sun and find that it is a sublime idea heaven has had when it hit upon turning water into the pure white snow and making the whole landscape a residence of honor." The year after, when the book on humor had come out, he writes: "The book is written [300] out of yourself, so that I know you well in the book."

I think I have the right to use my old friend's testimony, even if it goes further than I myself would and could express myself. — Things went downhill, moreover, for this same old friend. For my birthday in 1918 he writes: "I can hardly

hold on to a pen, nor to a thought.” — Skovgaard retired in 1919 and moved to Copenhagen. And in February 1920 he died, while I was at the Red Cross meeting in Geneva. He did not have so good an old age as I. But his faithfulness and his understanding he kept to the last. —

Another friend, whom I count among the old ones, although his friendship is of much later date than Skovgaard’s, Professor Valdemar Vedel, wrote on the occasion of the book on humor, among other things: “There is, after all, a need to keep the multiplicity and the oppositions unresolved, unleveled — a feeling of richness and freedom, a feeling of openness; one wants to let existence play freely.” This significant remark points to a danger that is present in every formation of wholes within mental life, in the sphere of feeling as well as of thought. But I think that the book itself makes all the necessary reservations. Humor itself presupposes precisely that there is a multiplicity that cannot be overcome, and that one must essentially let stand as it is. But in order to be able to assert oneself against it — in order to be able to “let existence play freely” — one must, as in great humor, have a deep and serious background, a stronghold that keeps one from being split. I have even required that humor should take itself humorously, namely by realizing that it is not the only competent way of taking life. —

On the occasion of the book on the leading ideas of the 19th century I had an interesting letter from Georg Brandes, who after some appreciative words stated [301] that in his sphere he had come to a result similar to mine in mine: “Although the world of thought is not foreign to me, I am not at home in it, and my interests and endeavors have had to gather around art, where the century does indeed also stand out with a clear distinctive character, even if perhaps it has not reached the very highest heights there either.” — He closed with the following statement: “The World War has driven a good deal of confidence in what has been achieved out of its entrenchments. We, like the insect, crawl up a wall, fall down when the top edge is reached, and begin all over again. Fortunately you have not (any more than I) lost your zest for work and your resilience.”

In one of the last years in which I lectured at the University, a young woman

student, Agnete Bertram, came out to me after a lecture I had given on Spinoza. She was much taken with Spinoza's thoughts, which for the first time came before her. Quietly her own thoughts had moved in the same direction, but she now found a clear expression for the union of a sense of reality and an ideal view that she was longing for. I offered to go through Spinoza's chief work with her, she using an English translation. Later we read some of my own books, and she also took part in my laboratory classes. She was a great help to me in preparing my works, not least the book on humor, through her apt and independent remarks. Philosophy, however, was not her chief interest; this was concentrated for the time being on Danish literature, which she studied under Vilhelm Andersen. Danish she had chosen as her main subject; her subsidiary subjects were English and gymnastics. But she was a Renaissance nature, with a great need to develop her powers, although she was not yet clear in which direction her gifts lay. From her earliest youth her interest went in an artistic direction, and she sometimes regretted that she had not taken the way of art. I owe her an extraordinary amount, because she opened my eyes to nuances of color and form to which [302] I had hitherto been blind. Both on walks and before works of art she taught me to observe and enjoy quite differently than before. She also developed my sense for poetry, especially while I read together with her some of the English poetical works she had set down for her examination. More and more, however, her interest gathered around gymnastics, especially through Professor Lindhard's lectures, in which he demanded that gymnastics, namely women's gymnastics, be built up on a strictly physiological and anatomical basis. Previously there had been only one kind of gymnastics, the masculine, which was without further ado regarded as applicable to women. Agnete Bertram's need to unite the artistic with the rational could here find satisfaction. She worked out Lindhard's theory, when her examination studies were finished, practically and artistically, and she soon found much support among young women, who with enthusiasm took part in exercises that at once satisfied the need for healthy muscular functions and the need for harmony and plasticity in movement. It was a joy to me to give room in Carlsberg's colonnade hall ("Pompeii") for such exercises, on one

occasion also for a public display. The fresh and perfectly formed movements and the participants' beautiful antique costumes suited well the Greek columns of "Pompeii." And the life that on exercise days filled the otherwise so quiet Honorary Residence, when the young ladies moved about upstairs and down, with jest and laughter, was refreshing for an old professor.

More and more Agnete Bertram has since extended her teaching, so that it takes all her time. She is wholly absorbed in her art, and she is also working on setting forth its theory.

I shall never forget what she has been to me in the years when she could give me a part of her time, and I follow her on her way with its sense for the demands of nature and of harmony, which I owe it to her to have gained.

[303] Now that I, in my eightieth year, conclude these memoirs, it is with conflicting feelings that I look back on what I have set down in this book. Was it worth writing all this down? Have I not talked too much about myself? And on the other hand, have I managed fully to express my gratitude for what life has brought me, for the people I have known and loved, for the world of thought that has opened itself to me, and in which it is an honor to be merely the humblest servant?

Were I to answer these questions, I should never be finished, and the answer might perhaps lead me to discard the whole thing. So I set them aside, trusting that perhaps one or another may yet find interest, and perhaps instruction, in following how I have worked in the face of the problems of life and of thought.

My philosophical development will, I hope, be understood through what I have related of my youth and then of my later studies.¹⁾ I find two decisive points of departure, Søren Kierkegaard's principle of personality and the positivism of Comte and Spencer. Here lie the most significant influences I have received. (I take the occasion to state that Comte in his time worked more strongly on me than Spencer). Through these two influences the task was set me on which I have worked through my principal works (*Psykologi — Etik — Religionsfilosofi — Den menneskelige Tanke*). I myself find less and less any irreconcilable opposition

¹⁾I have given a fuller account of this in the essay on my work as an author, reprinted in *Religiøse Tanketyper* (1927).

between personal striving and scientific thinking.

In recent years my philosophy has several times been made the subject of doctoral dissertations (I know of two French and one German). It is especially my philosophy of religion that has been discussed. And sometimes the authors concerned have tried to construct my development, without my quite being able to recognize myself in it. The most significant attempt has been made by the Swiss [304] Jean de la Harpe, who has undertaken a critical investigation of the relation between my philosophy of religion and my philosophy as a whole. (*La Religion comme conservation de la valeur dans ses rapports avec la philosophie générale* de Harald Høffding. Lausanne et Paris. 1920). In a longish letter to the author I had every reason to thank him for his interest in my writings and for the clear and accurate exposition of my fundamental ideas, while I could not agree with him that there was a “dualism” between my doctrine of the possibility of religion in the sense of faith in the persistence of value and my philosophy as a whole. But in particular I had to object to his construction of my development. I wrote to him as follows: “You confuse the kinship with other philosophers, after my development was essentially complete, with influence from these philosophers during my development itself. I conceive the history of philosophy as a great dialogue, and when I myself attempted to interject a reply into this dialogue, I naturally had to take account of earlier replies in the same direction (especially Spinoza and Kant, from whose influence the authors thought they could derive two opposed tendencies in my philosophy). But it does not follow from this that these earlier replies motivated my reply from the start. As regards Spinoza in particular, I have always stood critical toward him. I saw early that on essential points he ends in a faith. (On this see *Den menneskelige Tanke*. p. 140). My ‘monism’ I have not from Spinoza, but from a purely psychological investigation of how we convince ourselves of reality (see the section in my *Psykologi* on ‘Opfattelsen af det Virkelige’). All science begins with, and is at bottom throughout, only a consistent extension of the practical criterion of reality. My ‘monism’ consists in my assuming lawlike connection as the expression of reality; but my monism is ‘critical’, because the work of finding and carrying through such a

[305] connection has not been completed and probably never will be. As regards my philosophy of religion in particular, you seem to overlook that on my view all scientific study of religion is psychological and historical. My special theory is that all social and individual religion and religiosity, on closer analysis, proves to be a faith in the persistence of value, and that such a faith can in fact persist even if the time of the positive religions should be past In my doctrine of categories (in ‘Den menneskelige Tanke’ 1910) I have sought to show how concepts of value relate to the other categories. Especially the connection between the two concepts totality and value is of great importance here, which I have later developed further in a treatise on the concept of totality (1917).” — This last treatise Dr. la Harpe did not know, since it was only later translated into German. But a connection between totality and value in fact underlies all my writings on ethics from 1876 onward, although only in “Den menneskelige Tanke” have I expressly demonstrated it. I cannot go further here into this question. I fear that this autobiography already contains too much philosophy. —

People in daily life owe more than they suspect to the philosophers’ labor of thought. But it is through many intermediate links and essentially indirectly that the significance of philosophy makes itself felt. Philosophy has, as my old teacher Sibbern puts it, an “intermediary” (mediate) significance for life. Every human being has his philosophy of life, whether he knows it or not. For no one, whatever faith or unbelief he may otherwise have, can do without thoughts that order his experiences, guide his actions and awaken new striving. Such thoughts arise under the influence of all sides of mental life and are determined partly by tradition, partly by one’s own experiences. Through many intermediate links such a philosophy of life stands in interaction with philosophy in the stricter sense. Even in the greatest and strictest philosophers one will be able to demon-

[306] strate the influence of their involuntarily formed philosophy of life, besides the fact that this itself is altered through their work on giving their thoughts scientific form. It has made a strong impression on me to see that even Plato (in the seventh Letter) has declared that there is a difference between his philosophy, accessible to all and scientifically formulated, and “that which his striving really

concerns". Perhaps, though, Plato, vexed at dilettantes' boasting of insight into his fundamental thought, stresses this difference more strongly than is right. But it is true that here we in the end stand before something incommensurable, because it is at once inexhaustible and complex. Here the old saying can be applied, that from the gods we learn to be silent, from men to speak. And the gods are right in the end. —

At bottom it is hard going to live. I sympathize with Schiller's words: "Herb ist des Lebens innerster Kern". There is so much that is heavy and sluggish in us and outside us, and in the struggle to overcome it one cannot always sing. Yet — there are other elements in the drink that life pours out than the bitter ones, and I praise life because I too have had them mixed in. When all is said, it is a strengthening drink that is handed to us, precisely through this mixture. Perhaps there are also elements in the drink that we have not yet been able to distinguish.

In my personal faith I go straight to that which, from all I have been able to understand, underlies all faith, to the assurance that Ingemann has expressed in "Sangen om Livet" thus: "Yet the spring of life wells up where eternally it sprang." All conceptions of gods and of an existence other than the one we know from experience are in the end only symbols of the assurance that the sources of value in existence will never dry up. I do not feel alone in this faith, but in inward communion with all earnest and inward souls, even if many of them cannot find their dogmas again in me. I understand well that many find only in the inherited religious conceptions that on which they can lay their head.

I can best express my relation to such people by setting down here a letter ^[307] I once wrote to a lady I was very fond of, and who was much taken with the religious movement called the Inner Mission. She had had much to struggle with in her life and had shown herself a brave little person. My acquaintance with her came from her being married to a brother of my late wife. Both have long since died. The occasion for the letter was that she had sent me an edifying book that had made a strong impression on her, and with lovable naivety she hoped now that it would have an effect on me that was good in her eyes. — The letter, whose draft I have found among my papers, ran as follows:

“Dear Laura, It is out of your loving disposition, which you have so often shown toward me, that you sent me the book I now send back, and especially that you sent me the good letter that came with it. I confess that the letter was dearer to me than the book. It is not easy for me to explain myself, but since you are fond of me and have confidence in me, you must believe me when I say that if I have come away from so many thoughts that are so much to you and also *have been* so to me, I dare confidently say that it has happened because truth, so far as I could see it, has always been sacred to me, and that I, if I would not deny what is innermost in me, had to go the way I have gone. It is simply so that the ways are different for different people. I do not take life lightly, and I see clearly the dangers that threaten many souls when doubt comes. I never awaken doubt when it is not in the sacred service of truth.

As things have gone, I dare say that life has become greater and richer for me, and that courage and the desire to take it up and work not only for myself but also for others have grown in me.

But, dear Laura, wherever I feel that a sincere mental life is stirring, there is [308] my sympathy. And perhaps in no one have I felt it as in my little sister-in-law in Aarhus, whose striving I have followed through the years. Can we not meet here, even if our striving after truth leads us along different ways? That hope I never give up with regard to those I am fond of.”

[The letter must have been written around 1900].

A philosophy of personality is very well possible without dogmas. This holds especially of the dogma of personal immortality. Very early the conviction dawned on me that there could be much of value in existence even if my personal immortality did not belong to what is valuable, and I have not noticed that my zeal to find, develop and spread values in the world, my work for what is true, beautiful and great, has thereby been weakened. I know dead times; but should not those who have all the rubrics of dogmatics filled in also know them? My position here is expressed in what, according to Johannes Fibiger’s autobiography, I am

supposed once to have said in a conversation with him: if there is a personal immortality, we will of course come to experience it. Whether there is, we know just as little as we know how old we shall become. In any case we cannot form any conception whatsoever of it. On this point I make Wilhelm von Humboldt's words my own: "Human conceptions of immortality I will not form; and others I cannot form." — Modern belief in immortality has, not only outside the Church, gradually become a meager conception, most often built on a slender spiritualism. I better understand the mighty visions of primitive Christianity of judgment and the end of the world. But if they are to hold, the whole of life must be laid out quite differently from how it is now led inside and outside the Church. — A longing or need in the direction of immortality I have never felt. Nor, when it fell to my lot to close the eyes of people I had loved, had I felt the need for a reunion, which for many is the essential motive for believing in an immortality. [309] There is, after all, a tragedy of life. Losses are suffered, an emptiness is left behind that only work and striving forward can remedy. — In the hope of reunion an unsavory coziness often asserts itself. It affects me as when people in the theater chat together at the most moving places in the play. Far better do I understand the great Scholastic Thomas Aquinas when he says that in the other world there will be such glory to behold that one is wholly absorbed in it and cannot think of oneself or look to see whether one has got all one's good friends along up there.

Let us really bring forward the idea of personality, and let us then have testimonies about life and about spiritual need that are really founded on independent experience of life and not on adaptations to old traditions, which yet themselves in the end arose in this way!

There has been no lack even of rather pressing appeals from younger people to raise a storm against Church and theology. But precisely because I adhere to the principle of personality, that is in my eyes not the way to go. What matters, rather, is indirectly, in Socratic fashion, to get people to think for themselves. Besides, the history of religion shows, not least the history of Christianity, that

reinterpretations of the religious traditions are constantly going on, so that the actual and personal faith involuntarily becomes another than the official one. And here it is personal experiences that determine the reinterpretations. Spiritual changes take place slowly when they are to be thorough. Many inconsistencies and half-measures follow from this in particulars; but when life does not stand still, a need to get beyond them will stir again and again.

Nevertheless many things may suggest that a prophet is needed, a great, [310] free human being who can teach us courage and honesty and integrity in our thoughts about life. He will surely not pull his punches. I for my part have, as I once had occasion to say in a polemic concerning great men, only been a poor professor, not a prophet. And big words are ridiculous in the mouths of small men.

Every morning I sit in one of the large rooms at Carlsberg facing three of Thorvaldsen's most beautiful works: Morning, Hebe and Night. "Morning" does not make much impression on me. Of the roses she scatters it holds for me that their time is past. To Hebe I devote my daily cult, hope for a drink from her cup, and promise to be true to her as long as there is life in me. "Night" I look toward as to a woman friend who at last arranges the pillow on my bed. As yet I know only one of the children she carries in her arms, but when the other child's lot becomes mine, I hope to find rest like it.

Finished 15 March 1922.

VIII

More than two years have passed since I wrote what I thought was to be the conclusion of my memoirs. I cannot say that since that time I have lived in the thought of the motherly embrace on which, according to Thorvaldsen's relief, even Death can lean, and which I mentioned in the last words I wrote then. Brighter moods have made themselves felt, productive moods too. One of our authors, who in his somewhat older days believes he has won an infallible religious standpoint, declared last year that "the old man at Carlsberg" must now be full of days, and, as was delicately hinted, of spiritual striving as well. I by no means feel hit by such words. Already when I concluded the preceding section of the memoirs in March 1922, I had in mind a continuation of the works on the theory of knowledge in which I had sought to develop further some points of view in my principal work "Den menneskelige Tanke". And my subject this time was a concept that had long underlain my thoughts on life and science, on religion and poetry, without my having seen it as clearly as it now presented itself to me. It was the concept of analogy, which I now undertook to investigate in earnest, with regard to its significance in the various domains and in the relation between these domains. I had long been aware that, not only in religious conceptions, but also in natural science, in philosophy and in so-called common sense, a confusion of identity and analogy occurs again and again. But of special significance to me now were Niels Bohr's electron physics and Hjelmslev's geometrical investigations. Through these works I got the best possible examples of the role of analogy in science too, where the relation between observation and interpretation is concerned, or where the relation of scientific domains to one another is

concerned. I had long ago been led to the conviction that the relation between the physiological and the psychological conception of human nature could, strictly speaking, only be called analogy. Likewise it was clear to me that the relation between examples of the same concept was a relation of analogy. Finally it was a fundamental idea in my philosophy of religion that all religious conceptions are due to analogies that the human mind is led to form under the influence of its experiences of life. In a treatise on the concept of analogy, which I presented to the Royal Danish Academy of Sciences shortly before my eightieth birthday, I have sought to develop these points of view, besides others I had become aware of. This treatise, which appeared in Danish in 1923 and in German the following year, will form the conclusion of my work in the theory of knowledge. At any rate no ideas have so far turned up that could lead to a continuation of this work. — In June 1923 three hundred years had passed since Pascal's birth, and Xavier Léon, the editor of "*Revue de Métaphysique et de Morale*", asked me on that occasion to write an essay on Pascal and Kierkegaard for the Festschrift his *Revue* was to publish. The subject was not new to me. I had often immersed myself in Pascal, especially once the splendid edition of his works that Brunschwig and others had produced was available. Likewise what is analogous in the positions of the two great religious thinkers had struck me. I had often, when I had to explain Kierkegaard's standpoint to a Frenchman, called him *le Pascal danois*. On renewed investigation the parallels between the two men in their relation to the religious problem increased, and I came through this back once more to [313] my own conception of the relation between religion and human culture, which had developed chiefly under the influence of Kierkegaard. The essay was printed both in Danish (in "*Tilskueren*") and in French. It is perhaps the one of my works with which I have most right to be satisfied from a purely literary point of view (which perhaps does not mean much).¹⁾

In recent years I have also been rather occupied with translation of my works. The essay "*Oplevelse og Tydning*" (the first of the essays in the Danish book of that name) was translated into German by a German man of letters who for some

¹⁾Reprinted 1927 in "*Religiøse Tanketyper*". [Later note].

time was staying in this country. On the other hand I myself translated the analogy treatise and, at the request of the *Societas Spinozana*, the essay published in 1918, “Spinoza’s *Ethica*”. It has especially pleased me that under the title “*La Relativité philosophique*” a French translation of my essays on totality and on relation is now being printed. Here I stand in a debt of gratitude to the French philosopher Emile Meyerson, with whom in recent years, by reason of my works on the theory of knowledge, I have come into lively and constant correspondence.

In general it has been a joy to me in recent years to notice interest in my philosophizing in France and to make the personal acquaintance of excellent French thinkers. In 1906 I made the acquaintance of Emile Boutroux in Aberdeen, where we were both guests at the University jubilee. Afterwards in 1909 I met him and his charming wife (the sister of the mathematician Poincaré) in Geneva, likewise at a University jubilee, and finally he was, accompanied by his wife, in Copenhagen in 1913, invited by the University to give lectures. Later I was in contact with him right up to his death. Even earlier I had come to know Léon Brunschwig (now Professor at the Sorbonne) and continued to be in fruitful contact with him. He has visited me in Copenhagen, and I him in Paris. The closest relation I have come to have with Émile Meyerson, whose works in the theory of knowledge are the most significant to have appeared in recent years. [314] He wrote to me for the first time in the year 1918, when he had found points of contact between his conception and mine. It is owing, as I said, to his interest in my works that two of them can now appear in French. The correspondence with Meyerson in recent years has been and is a great encouragement to me. We have discussed several important points where our views went in somewhat different directions. In my essays of recent years one will find more information about this. Common to us was that we had an eye for the irrational remainder that, however far knowledge advances, is left over, precisely when one applies a strictly rational standard. The great warmth with which Meyerson in his letters speaks of the impression he has got of me through my works has pleased me quite exceedingly.

Meyerson comes from Poland, lived his youth in Germany, but has since lived

in France for over 40 years. In Germany he studied natural science; only in France did he begin to philosophize. His rich knowledge of natural science makes it easy for him to illustrate his ideas in the theory of knowledge by apt examples, which he analyzes in masterly fashion. He finds it interesting that he and I agree to so high a degree in our views, since we have yet come to philosophy from very different sides, he essentially from natural science and its history, I from psychological and ethical-religious problems. He has never been a teacher of philosophy, but has held an official post, from which he retired in 1921 at the age of 63. His health has been weak in recent years, and there is unfortunately not much prospect that he, as he has repeatedly announced, will be able to come to Copenhagen to continue our written discussion through conversation. It would be a very great joy to me to see him here.

[315] With much interest and understanding he expressed himself last year about my essay on Pascal and Kierkegaard. Only he did not quite agree with me when at the end I pointed to Plato's harmonious concept of personality as the point of departure we should hold to. He sympathizes most with "philosophers who, like Kant, have been influenced by the Bible". He feels a spiritual kinship with Deutero-Isaiah. This he himself explains by his being a Jew; but he thinks that those who have come from Christian families will feel something similar toward the New Testament. Our connection with the Greeks is, he thinks, purely intellectual, but our moral nature leads back to Judaea. Yet he remarks in conclusion that the difference between him and me is not great on this point either, since I hold that the Greek spiritual tendency had to be deepened and widened through later spiritual currents, among others Christianity.

The friendship this thorough and spirited scholar has shown toward me has been a good support to me in recent years.

The preparatory work for the essay on Pascal and Kierkegaard renewed for me the problem of my youth, which, however, had not in the meantime been out of my thoughts. Even after I had found and worked through the position on

this problem that I, according to my experience and my understanding, had to take, there was still always occasion to think about what it could be that held most people fast in the established Church. Here I could naturally reach only an indefinite estimate. The main thing for me was that there constantly stirred a need to live in great images, in which the fundamental mood that experience of life and its great contrasts awakened found expression, a need that one did not feel satisfied by what science and art could bring. This need expresses itself in many forms and degrees and can seek expression in many different ways. But for most people there is laid down in the church tradition, into which they are led early, a great poetry of life, beside which all that they can find themselves [316] pales. At the same time there stirs, especially in times like ours, a need to have something to hold on to amid the swell of life, and such a hold was easiest to find in the church's dogmas and the church's cult. Much suggests that cult (especially hymn-singing), even in Protestantism, plays a greater role than preaching.

For me myself the problem had from my youth essentially been determined by the conflict between the ethics of primitive Christianity and modern Christianity's attempt to fuse cultural and social interest with religious ethics. The so-called People's Church meant, from this point of view, a great compromise, which the Church's representatives would not face. In the correspondence between Otto Møller and Skat Rørdam this comes out in a particularly naive way. — Studies in the history of religion show that the same problem makes itself felt within all great positive religions in the relation between a founding time, which constantly stands as the ideal, and later times, in which people have accommodated themselves to the demands of a life constantly advancing. This holds for Buddhism and Mohammedanism as well as for Christianity. This historical consideration, which neither Pascal nor Kierkegaard entered into, made it easier for me to understand what went on within church life.

I had, however, sometimes thought of withdrawing from the People's Church. Especially when a gifted and deeply religiously moved lady was declared by the Supreme Court not entitled to take part in elections to the parish council because she was a Unitarian, I felt it as an inconsistency that on the census list I still

entered myself as belonging to the People's Church, since my standpoint was further from the People's Church's than the Unitarian one. But I could not put up with the ridiculous custom that one had to appear in person before the parish priest to withdraw. — A couple of years ago the question came up again for me [317] in a somewhat different form. The proceedings before the elections of bishops were not edifying, and through the parish councils and the way in which they were elected the road must necessarily be barred for many young, independently inquiring men to become teachers within the Church. Orthodoxy is, according to an observation many have made, stiffer among laymen than among theologians. I then made the decision to withdraw, and informed in writing the parish priest in my parish of this. It went simply enough. On the back of my baptismal certificate it was merely written that I no longer belonged to the People's Church. The step I here took, I took as a Danish citizen, out of dissatisfaction with a Danish institution, not really for religious reasons. —

I cannot refrain from mentioning a small example of how the Church, as someone has put it, drags along the impossible so as not to lose the necessary. A couple of years ago two little girls (aged 12–14) came out to me. I did not know them, but presumably they had heard that at Carlsberg there lived a man who had among other things speculated about religion. On two fine slips of paper with gilt edges they brought a series of questions that the school's religious instruction had raised in them. They were friends; the one was visiting the other during the holidays, and they had now lain awake at night discussing the problems. When I had talked with them a little, I was struck by the seriousness, partly indignation, with which they regarded the doubts that had arisen in them. I shall not go through all the questions here; there were some I did not go into. Most of the questions came from Bible history. How could, e.g., Cain fear that people he met would kill him: there were of course no other people than Adam and Eve! The teacher had merely said to this that it stood in the Bible and so one must believe it. Nor, indeed, has the Church said definitely when the content of the Bible is to be taken literally and when it is poetry. My answer was that the biblical stories were the old legends of the Jewish people, in which one still found so much that

is beautiful that one constantly returned to them. With this answer the younger [318] of my guests was not satisfied, however. We too have old forefathers, she said, so why do we keep to the legends of the Jews instead of using our own? — The elder of the young girls, who seemed to have a poetic mind, while the logical was more developed in the younger, was especially dissatisfied with the story of creation. It was too mechanical for her; things were created from outside. Was it not more beautiful to think that things developed, just as a flower grows, so that one form unfolds from the other? — The conversation showed me how religious instruction can crush both the child's logical sense and its poetic sense, when it is carried on as, on the Church's official presuppositions, it really must be carried on. — I was much taken up with the conversation with the young girls and tried to manage as well as I could on Socratic principles. Later I had several visits from the elder (the younger had come down with a long illness). She told me that they now had got a new teacher who did not take things so heavy-handedly, and besides, she had now realized that many of the questions that had troubled them they must leave alone until they could discuss them on their own.

Now and then the memory of the time when I read with the young students has come up in me, and when Professor Frithiof Brandt a couple of years ago proposed that I give a lecture to his audience, the desire for a repetition was awakened. I used a part of a work I had in hand, and spoke about the relation between natural science and the human sciences. I was well received and had great joy of this attempt. I repeated it the year after and spoke then on "Viden-skab og Livsanskuelse", a lecture that will be printed in "Vor Ungdom". But on other occasions too I came to speak to the young. Two years running I have taken part in the meetings that the association "Norden" held at Hindsgavl for young [319] students or for teachers, men and women, from the Nordic countries. Hindsgavl is one of the most beautiful places in Denmark. The glorious garden goes down to the Little Belt with its wood-wreathed shores, and here it was a joy to me to

move among the young people and get an impression of what occupied them. My subjects at these gatherings were: "Søren Kierkegaard", "Holberg som Populær-filosof" and Troels Lund's book "Bakkehus og Solbjerg". This last subject gave me a welcome opportunity to speak about the poetry of life in which, I believe, the attempts at a concentrated conception of life must in the end issue. Later (in the autumn of 1923) I received from some students a request to give a series of lectures on the philosophy of religion. I then gave lectures on this subject in the garden room at Carlsberg for a circle of some thirty-odd young listeners. One of the hours was used to answer questions put orally by listeners, and the last hour was used to answer written questions (of which one was especially acute and penetrating). After the end of the last hour refreshments were taken and there was strolling in the winter garden. —

The student meeting at Hindsgavl in 1922 was the occasion of an acquaintance that came to be of special significance for me. I fell into conversation with a woman student from Stockholms Högskola, Greta Ellstam, about the mysticism of the Middle Ages, which from different points of view interested us both, in her case both from the religious and from the purely historical side, in mine especially from the psychological side. In the course of our conversations I noticed that she was on the way to Catholicism. I took good care not to intervene directly in what was moving in her mind, but tried by various routes to stress the importance of the step she seemed about to take. Besides the history of religion she also studied the history of literature and spoke with enthusiasm and understanding [320] of poetic works she had immersed herself in. During our continued friendship she has been exceedingly much to me through the two great interests she thus cherished, and which both have deep roots in her personality. We could meet in spirited poetic works, even if we still interpreted them each in our own way. This was so, e.g., with Geijer's little poem "Nathimlen", where the poet speaks of how, of the love that passes through the world, a ray has fallen into his soul. She could well sympathize with my interpretation of this glorious poem as an expression of the often so narrow stream of values of life; the ray we both believed, each for ourselves, that we experienced, but about the stream we were of different faith.

My young friend's religious interest soon carried her over to Catholicism, and she even entertained thoughts of entering a convent. In the following winter she took part with great zeal in the Catholic service in Stockholm. In spite of her bodily weakness she went fasting every morning to Mass. This had to stop when one morning she fainted in the church. I had thought that I should never see or hear anything of her again after her conversion. But then at Christmas 1922 I received a letter from her, in which she tells of the course of her studies, and in which it also shone through that she was beginning to feel the conversion as an unsatisfying step. Her studies in the history of religion had led her to immerse herself in the Indian Upanishads, those remarkable works in which inward mysticism and keen thinking met in so peculiar a manner. By this route thoughts had come into her mind that could not be reconciled with the Church's cult and dogmatics. She also thinks that the study of my *Religionsfilosofi* in the course of the autumn has had an influence on her mind. There was a clear change to be noticed when she visited me at Easter 1923, and especially when she spent her summer holidays at Carlsberg the following summer. After she had taken her degree at Stockholms Högskola in the autumn, she followed my invitation to take up residence at Carlsberg, in order there, as far as her health permits, to [321] continue her studies. I have thus gained in her a dear housemate, whose open sense and fine understanding for what is great and beautiful enrich my life. Under her influence (although she herself has her dark moments) my old tendency to hypochondria has almost vanished. We sometimes pursue common studies. Thus I have gone through Spinoza's *Ethica* with her in Latin (under constant criticism from her side of Spinoza's bad Latin), and since a general philosophical orientation is a part of her plans for the future, I have been able to be of help to her in various ways. Conversely she has, both through her knowledge of the history of religion and through her fine sense of language, been a good help to me in preparing the third edition of my *Religionsfilosofi*. Poetic works too, Swedish and Danish, and from foreign literatures especially Shelley, we have pursued together. — As regards my personal view of life, I feel understood by her as by no one else. —

I have the hope that the stay here at Carlsberg will not be without fruit for her continued development, from which I expect much, although in the nature of things I shall not live to see it. When these lines after my death come to light, they shall bring her a greeting from her old friend with heartfelt thanks for what she has been for him in his last years.¹⁾

In later years I have often called myself an over-jubileed man. It is perhaps a fault that I have never in time withdrawn from a jubilee celebration that could be expected. But I have never had any wish to travel without special reason, and I have not always been able to, even if I wished. When now the 80th birthday approached, and I heard of preparations to celebrate it, I was so childishly [322] glad that people wished to show me kindness that I did not think at all of withdrawing. The Students' Society held a fine gathering, at which I read from my "Erindringer" what concerned my relation to the political and literary movement of the '70s and '80s. A circle of my personal friends held a party that was splendidly opened with a quartet by Mozart and continued with a supper at which many warm words were addressed to me. On the birthday itself I received in the morning a visit from the King. He came from the Lucasstiftelse, where the Queen at that time lay ill, and he brought me flowers and a written greeting from her. He himself congratulated me in his warm and simple way. In the course of the day I had visits from many colleagues and friends. The Rector of the University, Professor Bock, brought me, in an exceedingly warm manner that deeply moved me, a greeting from the University. The chairman of the Carlsberg Foundation, National Archivist Erslev, brought a greeting from the Foundation's board and presented me with a beautiful silver bowl, on which were set both my birthplace on Gammel Torv and the main building at Carlsberg, where I shall probably die. For dinner a few relatives and friends were gathered at my home. It was a special joy to me that Vilhelm Thomsen and his wife could be present.

The University had invited me, on the occasion of my 80th birthday, to give a lecture in the University's ceremonial hall, and I had chosen the 15th of March

¹⁾On 3 October 1924 Greta Ellstam became my wife. [Later note].

for it. It became for me a high point of the festivities, and it was with great emotion that I once more mounted the lectern, after the Rector had again spoken to me in his warm and heartfelt manner. It pleased me especially that in his characterization of my activity at the University he quoted the following closing words of a speech I had given in the year 1897 at the University festival: “He whose position in life entails that he must not only occupy himself with the problems in the quiet of his private chamber, but must also set the young on their way in their striving to find their bearings in the world of thought, will seek in all his conduct to unite the sense for the striving personality with the conviction that the personality must be purified and ennobled through the work of winning the truth and bowing to its demands.”¹⁾ [323]

Shortly after my birthday I wrote to Meyerson that I now felt myself at the end of my production and in future would keep to a receptive attitude. He protested against this in a way very flattering to me. But the only work I have done since is to write, on the basis of notes for use in my laboratory exercises, a treatise on Plato’s books on the State.

[Later (1925), however, came my philosophical testament: “Erkendelsesteori og Livsopfattelse”.]

A couple of days after I had presented the Plato treatise to the Academy, I fell seriously ill. It was a bronchitis that threatened to turn into pneumonia. For some days an intestinal complication was also feared, and there is said to have been talk of an operation. Pain I did not really have, but I lay in a state of exhaustion the like of which I have never known. When I was asked how I was, I am said to have answered: “I am not at all.” My condition was like a zero. Anxiety I did not feel. I was excellently nursed by my physician Einar Hall and later, during convalescence, by Greta Ellstam. When I was on my feet again, a few weeks’ stay in the Jyderup woodlands gave me fresh strength. Out there I experienced

¹⁾The lecture is — under the name of “Filosofiske Synspunkter” — printed in “Religiøse Tanketyper” (1927). [Later note].

so sudden and splendid a breaking-through of spring as I have never seen the like of.

But now I feel myself in earnest an old man. I used to be a brisk walker, but now I prefer to go from bench to bench in the Carlsberg garden or in Søndermarken. [324] Larger works are out of the question; the initiatives are gone. But I busy myself daily with something or other. A special rest it is for me to read Greek, the language I have loved most. This summer I have thus again taken up Herodotus and Sophocles, after Plato had occupied me the previous year.

All around me my old friends and colleagues are dying. Only Vilhelm Thomsen still keeps up, especially with the help of his faithful wife, and I look forward to these two, in whose home I have had such good hours for so many years, moving now in the autumn — if all goes well — out to Valby Bakke into a villa that belongs to the Carlsberg Foundation. I still hope sometimes to meet his mild, loving gaze.¹⁾ — But otherwise it grows empty in the circle of my contemporaries. I sometimes feel like the Greenlander who, on Mylius Eriksen's monument, tells how his comrades die, one after the other. But like him I have kept on writing my diary.

And should these lines be the last I come to write, they shall end with a thanks to life for what it has brought me, thanks that it has made possible for me a work in the service of thought, however modest it may be, thanks for the understanding and the love I have met.

10 July 1924.

¹⁾Vilhelm Thomsen died 12 May 1927. [Later note].

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